The Three Paths of Initiation

Explanations of Rudolf Steiner

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Foreword

Rudolf Steiner's explanations consist solely of quotations and appear between GA numbers, where NNN is the number of the Collected Works edition.

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The Three Paths of Initiation

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The three paths of initiation are as follows: the Indian-Eastern path of yoga, the Christian-Gnostic path up to the 15th century, and the Christian Rosicrucian path since the 15th century. The first is not for Europeans. The second is suitable for people of the middle zone; it is a path we can follow, but the Rosicrucian path, which was taken starting in the 14th century, is more appropriate. Although the Christian-Gnostic path does bring truth to the individual, the student will not be able to consistently follow it within modern life and provide answers to the manifold objections raised by today's science and culture, as he is able to do with the help of the Rosicrucian path.

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In the three paths we have now discussed, the relationship between the student and the teacher is different in each case. In Indian yoga training, the relationship between student and guru is very strict: absolute, complete submission to the guru is an unconditional prerequisite. Since, when following the Indian path, the student is not yet familiar with the higher worlds, it is necessary for him to be guided by his personal guru.

The relationship is different in Christian education. There, the teacher is the guide to the great Guru, Christ Jesus. A personal connection, a personal spiritual bond with Christ Jesus, is absolutely essential for the student. If the student cannot believe with all the strength of his or her soul in Christ Jesus and in what He did and exemplified for humanity, then he or she cannot walk the Christian path.

In Rosicrucian training, the relationship is the freest and most easygoing. The teacher is a faithful friend, a guide within the narrower limits of the student's occult experience. He does not concern himself with the student's daily comings and goings; he trusts him and grants him complete freedom. There is no coercion or command anywhere; only advice is given. But a friendly relationship of trust between teacher and student must exist. Without this, the training would remain within the realm of the Manasic; without this, Budhi could not be implanted at all. The power generated by this relationship of trust is essential to occult training. Without it, the powers lying dormant within the student cannot be awakened.

The specific training you undergo is not the deciding factor. You can develop your soul forces and gain insights into the supersensible world through all three paths. However, it is, of course, advisable to consider, when choosing a path, which side of the mountain you are already standing on at the foot of the mountain you are about to climb.
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We have seen that a person first passes through the stage of seeing and only then reaches the stage of spiritual hearing. While one is at the stage of seeing, one must, of course, first learn how the images relate to the objects. One would be thrust into the stormy sea of astral experiences if one were to surrender to it without further ado. That is why one needs a guide who, upon entry, explains how things are connected and how to find one's way there. This is the basis for the necessity of relying strictly on the guru. In this context, three different paths of development are distinguished:

The Eastern path—also known as the path of yoga—is one in which a single initiated individual living on the physical plane serves as the guide, or guru, to another, and the latter relies completely on the guru in every detail. This is best achieved by completely setting aside one's own self for the duration of the development and surrendering it to the guru. The guru must even provide guidance regarding the initiative to act. The Indian temperament is suited to such a complete dissolution of the self; European culture does not permit such devotion at all.

Christian development replaces the individual guru with the one great guide of humanity, Christ Jesus himself. The sense of belonging to this Christ Jesus—oneness with him—can replace devotion to an individual guru. But one must first be led to him by an earthly teacher. Even then, one is, in a certain sense, dependent on the teacher, the guru, on the physical plane.

One is most independent during Rosicrucian training. The guru is no longer the leader; he is the advisor. He is the one who gives instructions on what one should do inwardly. At the same time, he also ensures that, parallel to the occult training, there is a rigorous training of the mind—without which one cannot undergo such occult training. This is because the mind possesses a quality that other things do not have. For example, when we are on the physical plane, we perceive with our physical senses only what is on the physical plane—nothing else. On the astral plane, astral perceptions apply, and devachanic hearing applies only in Devachan; in short, each plane has its own perceptions. But one thing runs through all the worlds, and that is logical thinking. Logic is the same on all three planes. Thus, one can learn something on the physical plane that is also valid for the higher planes, and the Rosicrucian path follows this method by primarily training the mind on the physical plane using the means of the physical plane. A penetrating mind is already developed through the study of theosophical truths or through direct mental exercises. If one wishes to train the intellect even further, one can study books such as The Philosophy of Freedom and Truth and Science, which are deliberately written in such a way that a mind trained by them can navigate the highest planes with absolute confidence. Even someone who studies these writings and knows nothing at all about Theosophy could thereby find their bearings in the higher worlds. But as I said, the Theosophical teachings also work in the same way. This is the system of Rosicrucian training. One's own sharp thinking is the truest inner guide. The guru is then merely the student's friend, offering advice, for the best guru is cultivated within oneself through one's own reason. Of course, one still needs the guru here as well, because he must provide guidance on how to achieve one's own free development.

Among the European population, the Christian path is the most suitable for those who have developed a greater sense of spirituality. Those who have more or less broken away from the Church, who are more grounded in science, and who have begun to doubt because of science, are best served by following the Rosicrucian path.
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Today, in principle, there is really no objection to someone wishing to rise to the stages of higher knowledge. Certainly, some people speak at length about the dangers and all that confronts occult development—the term used for a person's inner development. Much is said about Hatha Yoga and Raja Yoga, but this is largely of theoretical value. If the matter is handled correctly, and if the person guiding such inner development is genuinely qualified to do so, there is in fact no danger. Everything simply has to be done properly; that is what matters. A lecture such as this one is not intended to give instructions—this should be especially emphasized. Such instructions must be given explicitly from one person to another. Whoever gives them assumes a great responsibility, and whoever receives them must be sure that the chosen guide truly deserves their trust. This trust is absolutely essential.

The occult, or inner, development of a person therefore gradually leads the individual upward to the stages of personal knowledge. I would now like to outline the essentials of inner development, as already said, for information and not as instruction.

When someone has reached the summit of knowledge, when they stand at the top of the mountain, they have an unobstructed view in every direction. This is true of physical existence and also of knowledge. As long as one has not reached the top, as long as one is still on the way, one does not have this clear view. The higher one climbs, the more one learns, yet a large part remains hidden by the mountain. This image of the mountain aptly describes inner development. Anyone wishing to climb the stages of higher knowledge must begin from a point suited to them. People differ on Earth, including in their physical, etheric, and astral constitutions. The outer nature of a Hindu, a person from Western Asia, a European, or an American differs far more than someone unfamiliar with occult matters can imagine. Exercises in inner development that suit a Hindu nature cannot simply be expected of a Western nature. It was therefore a mistake to transfer Oriental Yoga teachings to Europe, and much harm resulted. The much softer body of a Hindu can be developed quite differently from the European organism, made much harder, one might say, by civilization. Human natures differ far more than you can imagine. An anatomist cannot tell you this, but someone who sees clairvoyantly into the inner nature knows how enormously different these constitutions are.

Humanity today can be divided into three types. First, there are still people for whom Oriental Yoga initiation is essentially suitable; then there are those for whom the Christian-Gnostic path is possible; and finally those—and this is true of by far the largest number—for whom the path known since the 14th century as the Rosicrucian path is suitable. Note well: these paths do not lead to different knowledge, for when one reaches the summit, all things are the same. But the paths are, and must be, different.

One can attain many things on the Christian-Gnostic path and reach the highest knowledge. The Rosicrucian path, however, is suitable for modern people because they may find themselves in situations where doubts arise and disturbances occur precisely because they live within modern life; these they must overcome for themselves and for their work in the world. This is possible only through inner training based on the Rosicrucian method, which is the right one for the Western world.
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When humanity had evolved to our present state of consciousness—actually only during our fifth post-Atlantean age—it felt in its soul a longing to enter the spiritual realms once again. I have told you how, among the ancient Indian people, there originally lived a profound longing to recognize the true spiritual reality behind everything surrounding us in the world. From this arose the view that everything around us is a dream, an illusion, and that our sole task is to develop ourselves upward toward the ancient wisdom that created and worked in former times. The students of the ancient Rishis sought to embark on the path that, through Yoga, enabled them to look up into the realms from which they themselves had descended. They strove to rise away from Maya into these spiritual realms.

This is one path a person can take. The most recent path for ascending to wisdom is the Rosicrucian path. It directs people not toward the past but toward the future, toward states they will experience again. It teaches methods for developing from within oneself the wisdom latent within the human being. This is the path given by the founder of the esoteric Rosicrucian movement, known outwardly as Christian Rosenkreutz. It is not an un-Christian path; it is a Christian path adapted to modern conditions, lying between the specifically Christian path and the path of Yoga.

This path had, in part, been prepared long before Christianity. It took on a particular form through the great initiate who, in Paul’s esoteric school in Athens, founded as Dionysius the Areopagite the training from which all later esoteric wisdom and training emerged.

These are the two paths of esoteric training chiefly practicable in the West. Everything connected with our culture and with the life we lead and must lead is elevated and raised to the principle of initiation through Christian and Rosicrucian training. The purely Christian path is somewhat difficult for people today; hence the Rosicrucian path was introduced for those who must live in the present. Anyone wishing to follow the old, purely Christian path amid modern life must be able to withdraw from external life for a time, in order afterward to re-enter it all the more intensively. The Rosicrucian path, however, can be followed by anyone, whatever their profession or sphere of life.
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The Indian-Oriental Yoga Path.

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We are thus confronted with a fact that can help us easily grasp what is meant by "yoga" or "inner training." From what I have said, you will be able to infer that that which once created the world—that which has been active and potent within the world—was, in earlier times, absorbed into our own inner being. What is within me today was once outside of me: this is the fundamental concept of occult training. Before our physical body existed, our etheric body was already present. Our etheric body, in turn, is a structure that was shaped by our astral body. And it is from this premise that yoga training begins. Anyone who engages in yoga training descends into their own etheric body, knowing that within it they can find the very power that, millions of years ago, built them up. The physical body gradually emerged from the foundation of the etheric body.

When the yogi descends, stage by stage, into this etheric body, he penetrates into the times of the past —a period when his original spiritual form was influenced by these forces and entities, giving rise to what lives within us today. Having descended into life in this manner, he can, in the course of his descent, reach that specific point once again. He moves downward from the head into the lower realms —realms that were constructed in the most ancient of times—before returning once more to his head.

This is a description of the occult path to knowledge, albeit a sparse one; further details may be provided within the occult schools. In this way, the student of the wisdom of the mysteries develops the capacity to look back into earlier ages; eventually, the time arrives when he can undertake an occult pilgrimage. He achieves this through a specific practice, by means of which he transcends his personal self, thereby ceasing to be merely the small, confined "I." Only then can he begin his ascent into the universe. He descends once more—carrying the universal force with him—into the sea of the past. Then, by following an upward trajectory, he can gradually retrace the path he has traversed. Slowly and incrementally, the individual learns to descend into the sea of his own formative forces, eventually arriving at a point that lies near the very origin. This must have been the experience of those who first gained the vision to cast their gaze out into the cosmos. At this stage, the student begins to perceive the merging of his own "I" with the great universal "I." And now, he must learn to say to his small, personal "I": "I am not you."

It is a significant moment when he realizes what this implies: I am not you. It is a moment when one begins to grasp that there are forces in nature higher than thought—that beyond thought, there exists something which cannot be expressed in the terms of the present, yet which ensures that when two people speak of the same subject, the words of one may be clear but barren, while the words of the other are imbued with the warm light that the future will bring into being.

When the student has reached a certain stage, he becomes capable of learning in a way that was previously beyond his reach. He experiences something truly extraordinary: in the supersensitive world, he encounters a spiritual being—an individuality with whom he was once connected in the past. It is a profound and significant mystery that certain phases of our existence recur. We ascend consciously from Manas toward higher powers. Long ago, we descended from spiritual realms, and at that time, this same being implanted something within us—something we now encounter once again, at a stage corresponding to that point in the past when we were together. This being is the teacher, the so-called guru. We first met him back then; now, we meet him again, once we are able to consciously grasp what he once planted in our souls—something we had originally received unconsciously. And as we descend further, we encounter the spirits who, eons ago, helped to fashion us. We meet the twelve spirits: the Spirits of Will, the Spirits of Wisdom, the Spirits of Form, the Spirits of Motion, the Spirits of Personality (or Egoism), the Spirits of Fire (or Warmth), the Spirits of Twilight (or Dusk), and so on. All of this reveals itself to our spiritual perception during this descent into the universe—this pilgrimage. And this, in turn, enables us to cast a glance into the future; it allows us to anticipate what is to come "shortly," as the author of the Apocalypse puts it. When the student is ready, then he can learn in an even different way than he has been able to learn up to now. He is experiencing something very special. A spiritual being confronts him in the supersensible world: he meets the individuality that was previously connected to him. This is a great, important mystery, that certain stages of our existence repeat themselves. We consciously rise from Manas to the higher powers. We once descended from spiritual worlds, and at that time, a certain being implanted something within us—something we now encounter once again, at a stage corresponding to that point in the past when this being was with us. This is the teacher, the so-called guru. We met him for the first time back then; now we meet him again, at the moment when we are able to consciously grasp what he once planted in our souls—something we had received unconsciously. And as we descend further, we encounter the spirits who helped shape us eons ago. We meet the twelve spirits: the Spirits of Will, the Spirits of Wisdom, the Spirits of Form, the Spirits of Movement, the Spirits of Personality or Egoism, the Spirits of Fire or Warmth, the Spirits of Twilight, and so on. All of this reveals itself to our spiritual perception during this descent into the universe—on this pilgrimage. And this alone enables us to cast a glance into the future; it allows us to foresee what is to come "shortly," as the author of the Apocalypse puts it.
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The Eastern path of yoga involves a series of stages for which one must first prepare. The seven stages can be practiced concurrently, but the individual must place himself strictly under the guidance of a so-called guru. The guru is fully aware of the state of the disciple's inner development. The Indian path leads directly into the astral world. At the beginning, the student is very helpless there; hence the strict submission to the guru, because the student lacks the ability to correct his own errors when faced with facts that contradict one another sharply.

The first stage is Yama, which means "abstention." In the physical world, the physical world corrects the student in all his perceptions and assertions; reality corrects him. But this is no longer the case in the astral world. There, impressions rush toward him in images and colors, in forms and shapes that are in constant, undulating flux and ceaseless motion. Added to this is the fact that what one's own soul thinks and wills also becomes entities, and the student is not yet able to distinguish between his own astral and that of others. That is why, in the astral world, he must have inner guidance in order to stand firm. For how does this world appear? In the case of a plant, for example, it rises like a purple flame. The qualities of things dissolve into colors, standing out from the things themselves; the astral space is filled with colors, qualities, and tones undulating back and forth. These colors and tones must flow toward the astral beings and fill them. An elemental spirit, for instance, may then appear to you in a brilliant yellow color. To be able to distinguish and know what it is, certainty is necessary. At moments when these elemental spirits seek to guide you toward something, powerful forces arise within the human nature: the person's own soul expresses itself through them, and thus they drive him toward wherever the soul desires. To properly guide the helpless disciple, he must live within the Guru's soul and see through the Guru's eyes—hence the necessity of the Guru's strict authority. In everything he undertakes—for example, even when buying a house—the disciple must consult the guru. — In practicing the yamas, one must practice abstention. One must abstain from: killing, stealing, lying, desire, the consumption of intoxicating beverages, and debauchery. These requirements are much harder for Europeans to fulfill than they appear, for under current conditions of time, life, and culture in Europe, it is hardly possible to know whether the disciple can meet these conditions. For example, he kills with every breath if he does not regulate his breathing. He has his assets deposited somewhere in a bank or invested in some company: how can he know what happens to them? The concept of "refraining" must be interpreted very strictly by the student, for the point is that absolutely no one should be harmed by us. The only way to partially comply with these conditions is to become increasingly free of needs.

The second stage, Niyama, requires observance of the symbols of worship. Indian training strictly demands that the student participate in ceremonies and submit to ritual. In doing so, what one experiences inwardly must be reflected in the external ceremony. An example of such a ritual is found in the Catholic Mass, which, with its four parts, is the expression of what also took place in the ancient mysteries. It consists of the Gospel (the Proclamation), the sacrifice of the lower self, the transformation into the higher self, and Communion: union with the Divine. What truly happens on the astral plane takes place there in image on the physical plane. It is significant that one contemplates this in image. You take in the image, and one night the astral world can then take in the student, and it becomes a force within him. First, contemplate in images that which is to take place on the higher planes.

The third stage, asana, is correct body posture. Today's European, steeped in modern culture, has hardly any idea of the importance of correct body posture. Enormous currents constantly flow through the world and through the human body, and these etheric currents have a significant influence on

human beings. This was known in ancient India, as was the extent to which the student's development depends on correct body posture. Animals are positioned horizontally relative to the Earth's axis, while plants are positioned vertically. If we draw a line from the flower through the root, we reach the center of the Earth. In the plant, we see a reflection of what is revealed to us in the structure of the human being, only in the opposite direction; what corresponds to the human head is located at the bottom in the root, while the reproductive organs are modestly turned toward the sun. The horizontal position of the animal and the upright position of humans and plants form a cross, hence Plato's words: The world soul is crucified upon the world body. — Just as these lines run through the cosmos, so do the currents flow through all organs. The Indian yoga student had to position his limbs in a specific direction so that the world currents could work within him; this is not possible for the European human being.

Fourth: Pranayama. This is the teaching of proper breathing. Through the process of breathing, humans are actually constantly killing. We inhale oxygen, mix it with blood, and exhale carbon dioxide, which is toxic to humans and animals. We would die if plants did not breathe in the carbon dioxide, retain the carbon, and exhale the oxygen again. This cycle is of paramount importance and is what makes the existence of humans and animals possible in the first place.

Human, Animal::	Plant:
inhales oxygen,	inhales carbon dioxide,
exhales carbon dioxide	and builds carbon to build its body.

Pranayama, the rhythmic breathing process, is intended to gradually overcome the process of death. Human beings will expand not only their consciousness but their entire lives. Carbon is present in the blood; when it combines with the inhaled oxygen, it burns to form carbon dioxide, which is then excreted; the plant separates the components; it exhales oxygen, and the human being inhales it. Thus the cycle begins anew. In the future, the human being will complete this cycle within himself. When the human being is able to build his own body from carbon, he will have attained his future state. Carbon, or coal, corresponds to what occult literature called the Philosopher's Stone, lapis philosophorum. Anyone familiar with Rosicrucianism knows the meaning of the saying that humans will build a transparent body out of carbon, just as a diamond forms from coal. This will happen.

In the future, humans will be able to transform their blue blood through the lymph glands—which will then play a very important role—and thereby shape their bodies, just as they do now with usable red blood. In the future, the pineal gland will serve as an internal mechanism for the process of converting spent blood into usable blood.

Closely linked to this is the rhythmic regulation of breathing. The breathing process therefore holds the key to the future transformation of the human organism. At the very moment when a person works his way down into his lower bodies, he ascends to higher planes.

Fifth: Pratyahara, which means right living. A person must become capable of living purely within the soul; he must be able to hold within himself thoughts that are entirely independent of the external world. The ideal of meditation is to be able to become blind and deaf to one's surroundings.

Sixth: Dharana, concentration of the mind, complete mastery of one's inner world of imagination, so that a person experiences only those impressions that he chooses. If one can then select just one image from a series of images and dwell in it for a long, long time, this process—in which one remains at rest with one's entire consciousness—is called Dhyana.

Seventh: Once this has been achieved, one must also let go of this one thought, yet remain conscious with one’s entire soul. One retains the form of imagination, but without any content. With this, the student has reached the highest stage, samadhi—complete absorption in a single thought. Now the spiritual world can flow into him.
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First of all, it must be understood that yoga—or initiation—is not a tumultuous event, but rather a gradual process of training, a deeply intimate transformation. People often imagine that it consists of a series of external rituals and ascetic practices. None of this is the case. Everything must unfold within the depths of the soul.

Let us first discuss the practical rules of this training. It has often been said that the beginning of initiation is dangerous and that anyone who undertakes it exposes themselves to serious risks. There is some truth to this, and we shall attempt to explain it from a scientific perspective.

Initiation, or Yoga, is a coming-to-birth of the higher soul which lies latent in every human being. The astral body is faced with dangers analogous to those attending physical birth; there is travail before the divine soul comes forth from the desire-nature of man. The difference is that the birth of Spirit is a much longer process than that of physical birth.

Let us take another comparison. The higher soul is closely linked with the animal soul. By their fusion the passions are tempered, spiritualised and dominated according to the strength of man's intelligence and will. This fusion is of benefit to man but he pays for it by the loss of clairvoyance. Imagine to yourself a green liquid, produced by a combination of blue and yellow elements. If you succeed in separating them, the yellow will descend and the blue will rise to the surface. Something analogous happens when, through Yoga, the animal-soul is separated from the higher soul. The latter acquires clairvoyant vision; the former is left to its own devices if it has not been purified by the self and it is then given over to its passions and desires. This often happens in the case of mediums. The ‘Guardian of the Threshold’ protects man from this danger.

The first condition requisite for the Initiate is that his character shall be strong and that he shall be master of his passions. Yoga must be preceded by a rigorous discipline and the attainment of certain qualities, the first of which is inner calm. Ordinary ‘morality’ is not enough, for this relates merely to man's conduct in the outer world. Yoga is related to the inner man.

If it is said that compassion suffices, our answer will be: compassion is good and necessary but has nothing directly to do with occult training. Compassion without wisdom is weak and powerless.

The task of the occultist, of the true Initiate, is to change the direction of his life's current. The actions of man today are impelled and determined by his feelings—that is to say, by impulses from the outer world. Actions determined by space and time have no significance. Space and time must be transcended.

How can we achieve this?

(1) Control of thought. We must be able to concentrate our thought upon a single object and hold it there.

(2) Control of actions. Our attitude to all actions, be they trivial or significant, must be to dominate, regulate and hold them under the control of the will. They must be the outcome of inner initiative.

(3) Equilibrium of soul. There must be moderation in sorrow and in joy. Goethe has said that the soul who loves is, till death, equally happy, equally sad. The occultist must bear the deepest joy and the deepest sorrow with the same equanimity of soul.

(4) Optimism—the attitude which looks for the good in everything. Even in crime and in seeming absurdity there is some element of good. A Persian legend says that Christ once passed by the corpse of a dog and that His disciples turned from it in disgust. But the Christ said: 'Lo! the teeth are beautiful.'

(5) Confidence. The mind must be open to every new phenomenon. We must never allow our judgments to be determined by the past.

(6) Inner balance, which is the result of these preparatory measures. Man is then ripe for the inner training of the soul. He is ready to set his feet upon the path.

(7) Meditation. We must be able to make ourselves blind and deaf to the outer world and our memories of it, to the point where even the shot of a gun does not disturb. This is the prelude to meditation. When this inner void has been created, man is able to receive the prompting of his inner being. The soul must then be awakened in its very depths by certain ideas able to impel it towards its source.

In the book Light on the Path, there are four sentences which may be employed in meditation and inner concentration. They are very ancient and have been used for centuries by Initiates. Their meaning is profound and many-sided.

"Before the eyes can see, they must be incapable of tears."

"Before the ear can hear, it must have lost it's sensitiveness."

"Before the voice can speak in the presence of the masters, it must have lost the power to wound."

"Before the soul can stand in the presence of the masters, its feet must be washed in the blood of the heart."

These four sentences have magical power. But we must bring them to life within us, we must love them as a mother loves her child.

The first exercise has the power to develop the etheric body, particularly its upper part, which corresponds to the head.

This, the first stage of training, has power to develop the etheric body and particularly its upper part which corresponds to the head.

Having trained the upper part of the etheric body, the disciple must begin to control the systems of breathing and blood, the lungs and the heart. In remote ages of earthly evolution, man lived in the waters and breathed through gills like fish. Sacred literature indicates the time when he began to breathe the airs of heaven. Genesis says "God breathed into his nostrils the breath of life." The disciple must purify and bring about changes in his breathing system. All development proceeds from chaos to harmony, from lack of rhythm to rhythm (eurhythmy). Rhythm must be brought into the instincts.

In ancient times, the various degrees of Initiation were called by particular names:

First degree: The Raven (he who remains at the threshold). The raven appears in all mythologies. In the Edda, he whispers into the ear of Wotan what he sees afar off.

Second degree: the hidden Scholar, or the Occultist.

Third degree: the Warrior (struggle and strife).

Fourth degree:

the Initiate bears the name of his people—he is a “Persian” or a “Greek” because his soul has grown to a point where it includes the soul of his people.

Sixth degree: the Initiate is a Sun-Hero, or Sun-Messenger, because his progress is as harmonious and, rhythmic as that of the Sun. The Sun represents the vivifying movement and rhythm of the planetary system. The legend of Icarus is a legend of Initiation. Icarus has attempted to reach the Sun-sphere prematurely, without adequate preparation, and is cast down.

Seventh degree: the Initiate is a ‘Father,’ because he has power to make disciples of men and to be the protector of all; he is the Father of the new being, the ‘twice-born’ in the risen soul.

The new rhythm of breathing produces a change in the blood. Man is purified to the point of himself being able to generate blood without the aid of plant-nourishment. Prolonged meditation changes the nature of the blood. Man begins to exhale less carbon; he retains a certain amount and uses it for building up his body. The air he exhales is pure. He gradually becomes able to live on the forces contained in his own breath. He accomplishes an alchemical transmutation.

What are the higher stages of Yoga?

(1) The Initiate finds calm within his soul. Astral vision—where everything is a symbolic image of reality is acquired. This astral vision which arises during the sleeping state, is still incomplete.

(2) Dreams cease to be chaotic. Man understands the relation between dream-symbolism and reality; he gains control of the astral world. And then the inner astral light awakens in the soul who perceives other souls in their real being.

(3) Continuity of consciousness is set up between the waking state and the sleeping state. Astral life is reflected in dreams but in deep sleep, pure sounds arise. The soul experiences the inner words issuing from all beings as a mighty harmony. This harmony is a manifestation of reality.

It was called by Plato and Pythagoras, the harmony of the spheres. This is not a poetic metaphor but a reality experienced by the soul as a vibration emanating from the soul of the world.

Goethe, who was initiated between the periods of his life at Leipzig and Strasburg, knew of the harmony of the spheres. He expressed it at the beginning of Faust in words spoken by the Archangel Raphael:

“The Sun makes music as of old
Amid the sister-spheres of heaven.
On its predestined circle rolls
With roar of thunder.”

In deep sleep, the Initiate hears these sounds as if they were the notes of trumpets and the rolling of thunder.
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The Indian yogi exhaled less polluted air. The polluted air exhaled by humans is restored by plants, which release oxygen and absorb carbon. Animals and humans thus owe their lives to plants. In coal, the plants then return the carbon to humans. The plant, for its part, is structured in such a way that it is built up with the help of carbon. This process forms a complete and wondrous unity. Just as humans were once plants, so too will they become plants again in the distant future in a certain sense—namely, with full self-consciousness. Then human beings will produce within themselves what plants still provide for them today, and they will consciously build their etheric bodies from carbon. This is the purpose of the regulation of the respiratory process. Carbon is the philosopher's stone. The more a person breathes in pursuit of wisdom, the purer and more useful the air around them becomes. Chemistry will soon address this question. Anyone who has breathed rhythmically for some time gains mastery over their astral senses. Europeans must be very cautious with breathing exercises and should not begin them until later, after receiving appropriate instruction.

The second stage of Eastern training consists of blocking out external impressions for a time, concentrating, and allowing one's soul to be filled with the Eternal. There are certain timeless images and sayings for these exercises. Such sayings of wisdom can be found in the Bhagavad Gita, as well as in Egyptian books of wisdom and in Christian writings, particularly in the Gospel of John. Once a person has progressed far enough to establish inner stillness within themselves, new powers come alive within them through deep immersion in such sayings. However, they must not merely understand these sayings; a love for them must awaken within them. The same applies to magical symbols such as the pentagram and so on. One can meditate on them.

At a certain advanced stage of development, the student reaches the point where the following experience occurs: even when the consciousness is completely empty, the function of thinking—without any mental content—remains intact. Through meditation, the student learns to be conscious and to practice this function by refraining from giving any content to his thoughts. This is a beginning, and the spiritual world can then begin to flow into him. The process of inspiration begins.

This is followed by the stage of intuition, which, however, can only be attained after a sufficiently long period of occult training. Ultimately, the student lives consciously in the higher worlds. The Eastern initiate must unconditionally submit to the guru's strict discipline if he wishes to undergo the secret training. He must organize his life accordingly and do many things that he will only come to understand later. Once he has thus aligned himself with the guru, the astral body begins to change; the astral sense organs, which form lotus flowers, develop. Michelangelo depicted the two-petaled lotus flower as two horns in his Moses. At first, two rays of light become noticeable there, which grow ever wider and then begin to move. The sixteen-petaled lotus flower is like a wheel with sixteen spokes; it is located at the larynx and rotates to the right. The two-petaled lotus enables us to develop our will; the sixteen-petaled lotus, to penetrate into the thoughts of others; the twelve-petaled lotus, to recognize our emotional life; and the four-petaled lotus is connected with the regenerative and productive powers of the human being.
GA094

GA095
I have already told you that in Eastern spiritual training, there is strict submission to the guru. I will now describe the nature of the instructions the teacher gives within an Eastern training program. Understandably, one cannot give instructions publicly, but only outline the path. The things given as instructions by the teacher can be divided into eight groups:

1. Yama
2. Niyama
3. Asana

4. Pranayama
5. Pratyahara
6. Dharana
7. Dhyana
8. Samadhi

1. Yama encompasses everything we call “restraints,” which are incumbent upon those who wish to undergo yoga training; and this is expressed more specifically in the precepts: “Do not lie. Do not kill. Do not steal. Do not engage in sexual misconduct. Do not covet.”

The precept “Do not kill” is a very strict one and applies to all beings. No living being may be killed or even harmed, and the more strictly this is followed, the further it leads. Whether this can actually be put into practice in our culture is another matter. Any killing—even that of a bug—hinders occult development. Whether one must do so, however, is another question.

“Do not lie” is a commandment that will make more sense to you in light of what I have told you about the astral plane. On the astral plane, lying is the same as killing; every lie is a murder; so it actually falls under the same category as killing.

“Do not steal”—this, too, must be carried out in the strictest sense. A European might say, “We do not steal.”—But the Eastern yogi does not view the matter so simply. In the regions where these exercises were first spread by the great teachers of humanity, conditions were much simpler; there, the concept of stealing could be easily defined. But a yoga teacher will not concede that a European does not steal; he takes this very seriously. For example, if I appropriate another person’s labor—if I gain an advantage that is legally permitted but which constitutes the exploitation of another—the yoga teacher calls that stealing. In our society, things are so complicated that many people violate this prohibition without the slightest awareness of it. Suppose you have a fortune and you deposit it in a bank. You do nothing with it; you do not exploit anyone. But then the banker goes and engages in speculation, thereby exploiting other people with your money. Even in this case, you are responsible in the occult sense—it weighs on your karma. You can see from this that this precept requires deep study in the context of occult development.

The situation is just as complicated when it comes to “not straying.” A retiree, for example, whose capital has been invested by a bank—without his knowledge—in distilleries, is just as guilty as a manufacturer who produces spirits. Ignorance does not alter karma. There is only one thing that can provide a clear direction in these cases of omission, and that is: striving for freedom from desire. To the extent that one strives for freedom from desire, one can never harm anyone else.

It is particularly difficult to practice “desiring nothing.” It means striving for complete freedom from need, approaching nothing in the world with any desire, but doing only what the outside world demands of us. Yes, I must even suppress my own sense of well-being when I do someone a favor; it is not this feeling, but the sight of the suffering person that must move me to help. Likewise, when I have to make an expense myself, for example, I must not think: “I want this, I wish for this, I desire this,” but rather I must tell myself: “You need this to sustain your body or for the needs of your mind; everyone else needs it too; you do not desire it, but you are merely considering how best to get through life.” — Within the teachings of yoga, the concept of yama, as mentioned, is defined extremely strictly and cannot simply be transplanted to Europe.

2. Niyama. This means, among other things, adherence to religious customs. In India, where these rules are primarily practiced, a problem has been resolved that causes European culture great difficulty. It is easy to say: “I am beyond dogma; I adhere only to inner truth and attach no importance to outward forms.” — The more a European can transcend religious customs, the more exalted he considers himself to be. The Hindu thinks the opposite and holds fast to the rituals of his religion; no one is

allowed to tamper with them. But in the Hindu religion, everyone is completely free to form their own opinion about them. There are ancient sacred rites that have a very profound meaning. An uneducated person will form a very basic conception of them; a more educated person will form a different, better conception, but neither will say that the other's conception is wrong. The wise man follows the same customs as the less educated. There are no dogmas, only rites. In this way, deeply religious customs can be observed by both the wise and the unwise; both can be united in the rite. Thus, the rites serve as a unifying force for the people; no one's opinion is restricted by conforming to a strict ritual.

The Christian Church has followed the opposite principle; it has imposed opinions, not customs, on the people, and the result is that in modern times, a lack of structure has become the norm in our social life. This marks the beginning of the complete disregard for all customs that would unite people; all forms that symbolically express higher truths are gradually being abolished. This is a great detriment to the overall development of humanity, especially to occult development in the Eastern sense.

Many among the European population today believe they have moved beyond dogma, but it is precisely the freethinkers and materialists who are the worst dogmatic fanatics. Materialist dogma is even more oppressive than any other. While many no longer believe in the infallibility of the Pope, they do believe in the infallibility of the university professor. Even the most liberal person, despite claims to the contrary, is subject to the dogmas of materialism. What dogmas, for example, weigh upon the lawyer, the physician, and so on? Every university professor teaches his or her dogma. Or again: How heavily does the dogma of the infallibility of public opinion—of the daily newspaper—weigh upon a person! The Eastern yoga teacher urges us not to step outside the forms that serve as a link between the wise and the unwise, for these ancient sacred forms are the images of the highest truths. Without forms, there is no culture; it is an illusion to believe the opposite. Let us suppose, for example, that someone were to found a colony, entirely formless, without laws, without rites, and without religious customs. To those who see through things, it is clear that such a colony can survive quite well for a time, because people still live according to the old forms they brought with them. But as soon as they lose these, the colony will perish, for without forms, no such colony can survive in the long run. All culture must be born out of form. The inner life must be expressed outwardly through forms. Modern culture has lost these forms; it must regain them. It must learn once again to express outwardly what lives within the soul. In the long run, form is essential to human coexistence. The ancient sages knew this, and that is why they held fast to the practice of religious customs,

3. Asanam refers to assuming a certain physical posture during meditation. This is much more important for Easterners than for Europeans, because the European body is no longer as sensitive to certain subtle currents. The Eastern body is even more refined; it easily perceives currents that flow from east to west, from north to south, and from high to low; for spiritual currents flow throughout the universe. For this reason, churches, for example, were built facing a specific direction. That is why the yoga teacher has the yogi assume a specific posture; the student must position his hands and feet in a certain way so that the currents can flow through the body in an orderly manner. If the Hindu were not to bring his body into this harmony, he would completely jeopardize the fruits of his meditation.

4. Pranayama is breathing, or yogic breathing. It is a very essential and extensive component of Eastern yoga training. It is almost entirely absent from Christian training, but features more prominently in Rosicrucian training.

What does breathing mean for occult development? The significance of breathing lies in the principles of "Do not kill" and "Do not harm life." The occult teacher says: You are constantly and slowly killing your surroundings through your breathing. — Why? We inhale, hold our breath, oxygenate our blood, and then exhale. What happens during this process? We inhale oxygen-rich air, combine it with carbon within us, and exhale carbon dioxide; yet no human or animal can live on that. We inhale oxygen and exhale carbon dioxide—a toxin—so with every breath we are constantly killing other beings. Bit by bit, we are killing our entire surroundings. We inhale life-giving air and exhale air that we ourselves

can no longer use. The occult teacher is determined to change this. If it depended only on humans and animals, all the oxygen would soon be used up and all living things would die out. We owe it to the plants that we do not destroy the Earth, for they undergo exactly the opposite process. They assimilate carbon dioxide, separate the carbon from the oxygen, and use the former to build their bodies. They release the oxygen back into the atmosphere, and humans and animals breathe it in. In this way, plants renew the air we breathe; without them, all life would have been destroyed long ago. We owe our lives to them. Thus, plants, animals, and humans complement one another.

However, this process will change in the future, and since the person engaged in occult development begins what others will one day go through in the future, he must wean himself from killing through the breath. This is pranayama, the science of breathing. Our modern materialistic age always needs open windows and places fresh air at the forefront as a remedy. For the Indian yogi, the opposite is true. He locks himself in a cave and breathes his own air as much as possible. The yogi has mastered the art of polluting the air as little as possible because he has learned to make the most of the air. How does he do this? This secret was always known in the European secret schools; it was called the attainment of the Philosopher's Stone. If one wishes to find the Philosopher's Stone, one must discover the secret of breathing.

At the turn of the 18th to the 19th century, some of this information began to seep through. Much was written about the Philosopher's Stone in public publications, but it is clear that the authors themselves did not understand much about it, even though everything came from reliable sources. In 1796, an article about the Philosopher's Stone appeared in a Thuringian government newspaper, in which, among other things, the following was stated: The Philosopher's Stone is something one simply must know about, for every person has seen it. It is something that all people handle almost every day for a certain period of time, something that can be found everywhere—only people do not realize that it is the Philosopher's Stone. - This is a mysterious hint: the Philosopher's Stone is said to be found everywhere. But this peculiar turn of phrase is literally true.

Here's how it works: When a plant builds its body, it absorbs carbon dioxide and retains the carbon, which it uses to construct its body. Humans and animals then eat the plant, thereby reabsorbing the carbon and releasing it again as carbon dioxide in their breath. This is how the carbon cycle works. In the future, things will be different. Then, humans will learn to expand their own being more and more, and what they now leave to the plant, they will one day be able to accomplish themselves. Just as human beings have progressed through the mineral and plant kingdoms, so too will they retrace their steps. They themselves will become plants, absorb the plant existence into themselves, and undergo the entire process within themselves: They will retain the carbon and consciously use it to build their bodies, just as plants do unconsciously today. He will then produce the necessary oxygen himself within his own organs, combine it with carbon to form carbon dioxide, and subsequently store the carbon within himself once more. In this way, he will be able to continue building his own physical structure. This is a grand, forward-looking vision of the future. Then he will no longer kill anything else.

As is well known, carbon and diamond are the same substance. Diamond is crystallized, transparent carbon. So you need not think that people will later walk around as black figures; rather, their bodies will consist of transparent—and indeed soft—carbon. Then they will have found the Philosopher's Stone. They will transform their own bodies into the Philosopher's Stone.

The person who is developing occult abilities must anticipate this process as much as possible; that is, he must deprive his breath of its ability to kill. He must control it in such a way that the exhaled air becomes usable again, so that he can inhale it again and again. And how does this happen? By introducing rhythm into the breathing process. The teacher provides instructions for this. Inhaling, holding the breath, and exhaling—there must be rhythm in these actions, even if only for a short time. With every rhythmically exhaled breath, the air is improved, very slowly but surely. One might ask:

What difference does that make?—Here the saying applies: “Constant dripping wears away the stone.” Every breath is such a drop. The chemist cannot yet prove this, because his methods are too crude to detect the subtle substances, but the occultist knows that this indeed makes the breath life-giving and causes it to contain more oxygen than under ordinary circumstances. At the same time, however, the breath is purified by something else as well—namely, meditation. This, too, contributes—albeit only very slightly—to the reintegration of the plant nature into human nature, so that the human being comes to the point of non-killing.

5. Pratyahara. The next is pratyahara; this means the restraint of sensory perception. A person who leads an everyday life in the modern sense receives an impression here one moment, there the next, and so on constantly; he allows everything to affect him. The occult teacher now tells the student: “You must hold onto a sensory impression for so many minutes and must not shift to another one except of your own free will.”

6. After practicing this for a while, one must be able to become deaf and blind to every external sensory impression; one must learn to disregard all external sensory impressions entirely and retain only what remains as a mental image after the sensory impression itself has been eliminated. When one lives in this way solely within ideas, strictly controls one’s thinking, and links one idea to another solely of one’s own free will, that is the sixth state: Dharana.

7. Dhyanam. Now there are concepts that Europeans are reluctant to admit do not stem from sensory impressions at all, but rather must be formed by human beings themselves—for example, mathematical or geometric concepts. A triangle or a circle are mental concepts. What I draw on the blackboard is, after all, nothing more than a series of chalk marks. Now there is a range of concepts in which the occult student must practice diligently. These are symbolic signs that are consciously associated with certain things—for example, the hexagram, a sign that is explained in occultism; likewise, the pentagram. The student keeps his mind sharply focused on such things that do not exist in the sensory world. The same applies to other concepts, such as the “lion,” which one can only conceive of. The student must also direct his attention to such concepts. Finally, there are also moral concepts, such as the one in Light on the Path: Before the eye can see, it must wean itself from tears. — This, too, cannot be experienced externally, but only within oneself. This meditation on concepts that have no sensory counterpart is called dhyana.



Der Schüler hält seinen Geist scharf auf solche Dinge gerichtet, die es in der Sinnenwelt nicht gibt. Ebenso ist es mit einer anderen Vorstellung, zum Beispiel die Gattung «Löwe», die man auch nur denken kann. Auch auf solche Vorstellungen muß der Schüler seine Aufmerksamkeit richten. Schließlich gibt es auch moralische Vorstellungen, wie zum Beispiel in «Licht auf den Weg»: Bevor das Auge sehen kann, muß es der Tränen sich entwöhnen. - Das kann man auch nicht außen erleben, sondern nur in sich erfahren. Dieses Meditieren über Vorstellungen, die kein sinnliches Gegenstück haben, nennt man Dhyanam.

8. Samadhi. And now comes the most difficult part: samadhi. One immerses oneself for a long, long time in a mental image that has no sensory counterpart; one allows the mind, so to speak, to rest in it and fills the soul completely with it. Then one lets go of this concept and has nothing left in one’s consciousness, but one must not fall asleep—which would happen immediately to an ordinary person; one must remain conscious. In this state, the mysteries of the higher worlds begin to reveal themselves. This state is described as follows: There remains a thinking that has no thoughts; one thinks because one is conscious, but one has no thoughts. In this way, the spiritual powers can allow their content to flow into this thinking. As long as one fills it oneself, they cannot enter. The longer one maintains the activity of thinking in consciousness without the content of thought, the more the supersensible world reveals itself.

These eight areas form the basis of the teacher's instructions in Eastern yoga training.
GA095

GA097
Firstly, the Eastern yoga way. The human soul is able to develop to the point where it becomes like an eye that has direct vision of the spirit, of the eternal which is beyond time. The way taken by people of the East for this development differs from the way of the European because their natural disposition and organization are different. A Hindu differs from a European not only in external appearance, for his brain and soul are also built differently. It is evident, therefore, that if they are truly to reach the goal, Hindus must take a different way from that of Europeans. It actually goes so far that a European may possibly ruin himself both morally and physically by taking the Eastern path of development. The isolation and withdrawal of the soul required for the yoga way is practically impossible in our European civilization. One would have to step completely aside from ordinary life here, and indeed from our whole civilization, devoting oneself entirely to one's personal inner development.

Someone who follows this route needs a spiritual guide or guru who pilots him safely through all the chaos. Without such a guru it is impossible to follow this way. It also needs a complete transformation of human nature, a transformation laid down for one by the guru. Such a guru altogether has unlimited power over his pupil. It then is no longer of no concern what the individual does in his life in other respects. It is no longer enough to be a decent, good person of the ordinary kind, simply the kind of person society tends to consider an example.

It has to be possible to keep soul and body quite distinct and separate, they must no longer interpenetrate the way they did before. Passions and animal instincts should no longer have a place in the human soul, for the soul is inhibited and prevented by them from penetrating the mists of the physical world and looking into the higher world of the spirit. However, when soul and body are cleanly separated, the latter may well bring its passions and drives into play at the same time as the soul is in that higher life. It is therefore possible for the soul to develop to a higher level and gain vision in the spirit, whilst the body falls subject to all kinds of bad qualities and perhaps becomes corrupted because its passions and drives are no longer guided towards better things by the soul's insight, which had been possible when soul and body were still interpenetrating. This shows the tremendous importance of proper guidance on this difficult path. One must in that case strictly obey the guru, even if it goes against the grain. The guru is permitted to involve himself in the pupil's most intimate affairs of the heart and give him rules on how to conduct his life. Certain relationships may be forbidden as being an impediment to the development that is in progress. Preconditions for this way of development are firstly the ability to prevent the lower drives to good effect, then regular practice of certain ways of doing things, firmly establishing particular qualities and developing additional faculties that still lie dormant or do not yet exist.

Such preparations for development are: firstly to get out of the habit of letting one's thoughts dart about. This would seem to be an easy condition, but it is in fact difficult. We are driven and put under pressure by external impressions. For at least five minutes a day the individual should have complete control of the way his thoughts run. One exercise one might try, for instance, is to concentrate the mind on a single idea. Nothing else should be linked with this idea, however many things want to come in of their own accord, only the thoughts I myself connect with it, freely deciding to do so. Such exercises should be done with a variety of objects. After some time, the individuaPs thinking will be controlled and this is outwardly apparent in a more precise choice of words, among other things.

Secondly, taking initiative in one's actions. Some people are quite incapable of this, for they may have been forced into an occupation from early on, and this occupies most of their active life. Most of the things we do are dictated from outside. Someone seeking to gain initiation should therefore be deeply

concerned to do something regularly, always at the same time of the day, something they have decided on themselves, even if it is something quite insignificant.

Thirdly, the pupil should overcome mood swings, being on top of the world one minute and down in the dumps the next. It means we should not give ourselves without will to pleasure and pain but keep our inner equilibrium even in the bitterest pain and greatest pleasures. This certainly will not make us insensitive and lacking in response; quite the contrary, our inner responses become all the more subtle and intensive.

Fourthly, a Persian legend about Christ Jesus should live in the pupil's heart. It is this. One day Jesus walked in the countryside with his disciples. A half decomposed dog lay by the wayside, a horrible sight. The disciples turned away, feeling shocked. Christ Jesus looked at the cadaver with loving eyes, however, commenting: ‘Look what beautiful teeth this dead animal has!’ The quintessence of this is to find hidden beauty even in ugly things, and altogether always look for the positive aspect, for something to which one can say yes. The life of even the worst of evildoers has moments of light and we can meet these with understanding.

Fifthly, we must seek to gain complete freedom from prejudice, The past should never determine the way we judge the present. We should not reject something new just because we have not come across it before. New insights should be taken in an unbiased way if one wants to be an initiate.

Sixth, developing harmony of soul. This will really arise from all the other things, as if of its own accord.

These qualities are absolutely essential preconditions for anyone who is to be initiated the yoga way.

The actual yoga way involves a number of stages that must be kept clearly distinct.

Firstly the yoga pupil must not kill, lie, steal, live to excess or be covetous. The more one ceases to live at the cost of others, the closer does one come to what is meant by the requirement that one should not steal. For this is not, of course, the stealing that is a punishable crime, but more subtle forms of it. As to the other requirements, each individual will immediately know what they involve.

Secondly it is highly desirable to acknowledge certain symbolic acts for one's own. One must have a feeling for it and come to understand that a rite is really just giving symbolic expression to something much more profound.

Thirdly the assumption of specific body positions, for the position into which one brings the body for the exercises to gain higher wisdom is far from immaterial. As far as possible it should be placed in the direction in which the spiritual streams move in the world.

Fourthly, pranayama, the regulation of one's breathing, is of great importance. It has to do with the requirement not to kill, for man's breath is capable of killing many things in the world around him. Yoga breathing aims gradually to free the breath from its deadly effect on other life forms. Above all, yoga pupils should no longer release so much deadly carbon dioxide. This is possible, for we know that individuals who have been deeply initiated can spend decades in caves where the air is stale and this does not ruin them physically.

The fifth stage relates to suppressing the evolution of certain sensual ideals. We must no longer let every sensual idea influence us but need to take individual ones and concentrate all our attention on them. The rest of our thoughts should also be made to progress in a specific, regulated way.

The sixth stage is that as he progresses the pupil must concentrate on, say, an impression of light, or, put in a better way, to concentrate on the image such an impression has left in the soul. This is an even higher stage. Even more valuable is meditation based on an idea that is no longer part of the world we perceive through the senses. It is essential for the human being to give himself to the contemplation of such ideas if he is to progress.

The seventh stage is very hard. It consists in the individual banishing every idea of any kind from his conscious mind whilst remaining wholly awake. He then comes closer to the state of intuitive conception. Now at last the soil is prepared and the contents of a world that has been unknown to us so far can come to us.

A guru is absolutely essential during the whole of this preparation for the yoga way. It is solely and exclusively due to him that these inner developments take the right course and benefit the pupil.
GA097

GA097
Yama is the first stage of Indian yoga training. It signifies ‘restraint’; or ‘forbearance’. To an Indian this means not to lie, not to kill, not to steal, no dissoluteness, no desires. To enter more deeply into what this means to an Indian, we must consider it in its whole context. Thus we may be vegetarians, but we still have not got out of the habit of killing things. Our life is in fact impossible without this. We actually kill as we breathe, for we exhale carbon dioxide. If the earth's green plant cover did not continually take up the carbon dioxide and give off oxygen, humans and animals would be unable to live. It is part of the yoga exercises to get out of the killing habit. Indians take this very seriously. Many of the connections we have in our life would also come under the heading of stealing for them. Each of us must accept money in some way. Many conditions are involved in our getting this money. When we buy a coat we have no way of knowing if human blood has not been shed for it. People do not give much thought to the fact that they are in a social context and partly responsible for what they do. If we take these things seriously, we must feel responsible for the things that happen because of us.

You help other people most by having few wants. Someone who reduces his wants helps others more than a philanthropist does. Thus if we do not write unnecessary letters this may save some people the effort of having to climb stairs. It is quite wrong to think that you help people by making more demands, thus providing more work. You do not in the least add to the things people need by making work for them. In Europe the situation is so complex nowadays that it is getting more and more difficult to meet the requirements of the Eastern yoga path. This can of course be followed in the proper, strict way in a country where there are no banks and where the cultural situation is clearly apparent.

The 2nd stage is niyana, observance of ritual. The Indian yoga way certainly demands ritual, so that the teachings may be linked with religious rites. It is strictly required that everyone taking the yoga way observes a ritual. Things should be enacted before their eyes. Just as in the case of art it matters that it comes to real expression in objects, so in the case of initiation it is important to have things presented in rituals.

The 3rd stage is asana, body positions assumed to be in accord with specific currents in the cosmos. When people still had a feeling for such things, they would always put the main altar at the eastern end of their religious buildings. Indians are so subtly organized that it matters in which direction they face. The current that goes from north to south is indeed different from the one that goes from east to west. Body positions are important for yoga initiation because the Oriental body is much softer, and taking a particular position leaves much more of an imprint. A European wanting to take the Oriental yoga way would have to do all these things as well.

The 4th is pranayama, bringing rhythm into the breathing process. We can best understand this if we consider that under present-day conditions, the human breath kills things. The teacher instructs the pupil to regulate his breathing according to certain rules he gives him, at least for a time. If we were to examine the breath we would find that the air exhaled by a yoga pupil has quite a different composition, quite a different carbon dioxide content, than the breath of ordinary people. It is therefore true that by regulating the breath the pupil influences the future evolution of the earth. Constant dropping wears the stone. You don't see results from one day to the next. But it all adds up and will have definite significance over long periods of time.

At a particular time, Rosicrucian teachers also get their pupils to bring rhythm into their breathing. What does the breathing process bring about? The physical human being cannot be thought of without the plants. We inhale oxygen which combines with carbon in the lung, and we exhale carbon dioxide. The plant does exactly the opposite. There is a continuous cycle between human beings on the one hand and plants on the other. In far distant times human beings will develop an organ of their own which will take care of the function plants perform today. They will be able to process the carbon dioxide in themselves. Human beings will have an organ able to separate the carbon from the oxygen and make it part of themselves. The principles we take in with our food today to build up our bodies will then be something we consciously do within ourselves. We'll thus change carbon dioxide into oxygen again. This process is indeed helped by making the breathing process rhythmical. This was taught extensively in 14th century Rosicrucian schools. Some of these secrets were betrayed, so that they appeared in the popular literature. In an 18th century work reference is made to the philosopher's stone.149 The statement is literally true. The author himself probably did not know what this was really about. The whole human being must change if he is to achieve what the plant does for him now. His physical body will then be carbon, but not black coal, nor hard diamond, which after all is only a symbol for the philosopher's stone. The philosopher's stone is meant to be a body which is transparent, with the other organs integrated within it. It will consist of a mass of gel-like carbon, rather like the white of an egg. Man is following a course where he will one day develop into this marvellous glory. The rhythmic breathing which leads to this is called ‘alchemy’. The philosopher's stone is the lapis philosophorum. The man who wrote this did not actually know what it was he was writing.

The 5th stage on the yoga path is pratyahara. It consists in being able to suppress external sensory impressions. We have to know the things that are truly our soul world and leave aside everything that has come to us from outside. Most of the things people think have come to them from outside. When someone is able to give himself up consciously to his inner thoughts and make himself blind and deaf to the world around him, though he is inwardly awake; if he is able to have a thought without reflecting on external things, his sleep will be filled with dreams and he'll be practising pratyahara.

At the 6th stage one needs not only to blot out completely anything the eyes see and the ears hear but also suppress inner ideas rising from the soul itself. Having removed everything from the soul that has come to it from life, one then holds one idea, which the guru has given, in one's inner soul. These may be ideas like those given in the first four rules in Light on the Path. The best soul contents are those a special teacher is able to give us.

Such a soul content is allowed to act for some time before one lets go of it, without losing conscious awareness. One then has the function of the life in mind and spirit, without the thinking content. When this 7th stage has been reached the world of the spirit enters into us. This condition is called samadhi.
GA097

GA054
In other cultures—and they do exist—the human being is in a position to cultivate the inner life more and to withdraw from the influences of external life. Such cultures offer a soil where inner life in the higher sense can thrive. In the Oriental culture there exists what is called Yoga. Those who live according to the rules of this teaching are called yogis. A yogi is one who strives for higher spiritual

knowledge, but only after he has sought for himself a master of the super-sensible. No one is able to proceed without the guidance of a master, or guru. When the yogi has found such a guru, he must spend a considerable part of the day, regularly, not irregularly, living totally within his soul. All the forces that the yogi needs to develop are already within his soul. They exist there as truly as electricity exists in the glass rod before it is brought forth through friction. In order to call forth the forces of the soul, methods of spiritual science must be used which are the results of observations made over millennia. This is very difficult in our time, which demands a certain splintering of each individual struggling for existence. One cannot arrive at a total inward composure; one cannot even arrive at the concept of such composure. People are not sufficiently aware of the deep solitude the yogi must seek. One must repeat the same matter rhythmically with immense regularity, if only for a brief time each day, in total separation from all usual concerns. It is indispensable that all life usually surrounding the yogi cease to exist and that his senses become unreceptive to all impressions of the world around him. He must be able to make himself deaf and dumb to his surroundings during the time which he prescribes for himself. He must be able to concentrate to such a degree—and he must acquire practice in this concentration—that a cannon could be fired next to him without disturbing his attention to his inner life. He must also become free of all memory impressions, particularly those of everyday life.

Now consider how extraordinarily difficult it is to create these prerequisites in our culture, how little people have any concept of such isolation, of such spiritual solitude. All of this must be achieved under one condition: namely, that one must never, in any way, lose harmony—that is, complete equilibrium—with the outside world. And this is extraordinarily easy to achieve when one is so deeply immersed in one's inner self. The person who delves deeper and deeper into his inner self must, at the same time, establish harmony with the outside world all the more clearly. Nothing that smacks of alienation or detachment from practical external life must arise within them; otherwise, they will go astray, and their higher life may, to a certain extent, become indistinguishable from madness.

Another thing that a person must then learn—and which can only be mentioned here in passing—is to consciously regulate something that is otherwise governed by a natural process of which they are unaware. This is, first and foremost, the respiratory system. If a person wishes to evolve to a higher level, their breathing must become commensurate with the great processes of evolution. They must inhale, hold their breath, and exhale in a precisely prescribed manner. When a person brings spiritual control to their breathing, they spiritualize their breath, their life-giving air. In this way, they ascend from Hatha Yoga to Raja Yoga, the royal yoga.

Then comes the highest stage: the exercises in meditation and contemplation centered on one's own inner life. When a person has prepared and trained themselves in this way, when they have advanced to the point of bringing rhythm to their life, then they are fully ready to lead an inner life. There are three stages of meditation. It can be organically integrated into the rhythmic breathing process. First, one must take the sensory world as the starting point, so that a person can detach themselves from the external world and the multitude of its external impressions. Taking full control of one's own attention helps them in their higher development. Once they are able to master their attention in this way, they must be able to immerse themselves completely in the object of their attention, allowing nothing else in; only that one thought must live within them. It is best if the teacher assigns him very specific tasks tailored to his individuality. Once he has reached this stage, a cannon could be fired right next to him without distracting him. Then he must let go of the object of his contemplation itself, yet maintain the activity. This is what brings him into the highest worlds.

If a person has progressed this far—having thoroughly contemplated the object, but then let it go and lives solely in the act—then he reaches the state known in occultism as that of Dhyana. And he can let go of this state immediately; then his inner eye is awakened.

He learns to exercise the powers of his thinking on external objects. However, he does not yet get very far in this; he arrives at a world that appears to be a kind of skeletal framework for the higher world.

He must now develop a feeling of very special intensity from the object itself, again while excluding everything else. Thus, he must be able to feel something very specific when he holds a crystal in his hand; he must feel something when he holds an octahedron in his hand. He develops a feeling that one can have toward the inanimate world. We then compare the lifeless rock with the living, blood-filled being and tell ourselves: That has sensuality, but the water-clear rock is devoid of desire. If I am able to feel how the stone has allowed its desire to die away, how it has become pure and chaste, and if I know how to immerse myself in this feeling so that the world around me fades away and I allow only this feeling to live within me—be it the feeling from the crystal, from the animal, or from the human being — and if I can then let go of the object, return in the same way as before, and enter the state of dhyana, then I realize that the feeling is not merely a feeling, but that it begins to grow bright, that the feeling begins to become a manifestation of light. Thus appears what is perceived as a thought-form, but which should more accurately be called a feeling-form.

These are a few concepts I wanted to share with you today. There have always been teachers who provided guidance to individuals and assigned tasks suited to their individuality. Every person has their own name in the spiritual world; there, they are even more individual than in the physical world, and this unique individuality must be carefully taken into account, especially on the higher levels, where higher development is concerned. Therefore, only a teacher can provide what is necessary.

What I have presented today are the first steps toward what is called “recognizing the self.” When a person learns to sense the objects around them and those objects take on colors that then crystallize into images, they see their emotional world unfolding around them. One must face oneself as an objective observer; then one crosses the threshold where one perceives oneself with all that one is and is not yet. The first guardian of the threshold stands there before us, showing us: “This is you!” — Everyone must learn to know themselves, for through self-knowledge one comes to knowledge of the world. However, no one should mistake self-knowledge for knowledge of God. That is why it was written at the gate of the Temple of Delphi: “Know thyself!” — And once one has passed through the gateway of self-knowledge, one enters the innermost sanctuary of the world, where divine forces reign and spiritual insights are bestowed. When one’s own inner being feels connected to the inner being of the world—where only then can one speak in the true sense of inner development—and when a person approaches this knowledge with dignity and not in a frivolous or base manner, then it will be granted to him. And he will be given that through which his humanity can be developed more and more, and he will become an ever more worthy member in the course of human development. But no one should seek to ascend to higher knowledge merely for their own sake. A person should develop themselves, increase their powers, and gather knowledge—that is, increase their powers—solely to become a servant of the entire universe.

In this way, we become servants within the whole of the world, and it is in this sense alone that the journey toward higher knowledge should take place.
GA054

GA082
As we look back on human evolution, we do not, in fact, always find the same disposition of soul that man has to-day. He cultivates the scientific spirit as, in a sense, a most lofty thing. If we look back at the ancient Orient—not necessarily so far back as the most ancient Indian times, but to times more recent—we found much of what had been handed down as cognitive principles still retained. The path to knowledge was named quite differently then. In those ancient times—even the history of language can support this—man did not think of himself as he does to-day. Modern man has, on the one hand, his consciousness of self firmly established within him, and, on the other hand, a grasp, through observation, of what is mechanistic. But the man of the Orient, for example, could not have this feeling of himself. (As I have said, the history of language can prove this.) He felt himself, in the first place, as a breathing human being. To him, man was a breather. In self-contemplation he focussed his attention chiefly upon the respiratory process. He even related immortality to the respiratory process: death

came to him as a kind of expiration of his soul. Man a breather! Why did man in this former disposition of soul feel the human being as a breathing being? Because he did actually feel life in the respiratory process (which did not proceed so unconsciously as it does to-day). He felt the vibrations of life, life's rhythm, in his breathing; he felt breathing as one feels hunger and thirst to-day. But this was a continuous feeling in the waking state. When he looked with his eyes, he knew: the process of breathing now enters right into my head and into my eyes. He felt his perceptions permeated by the flow of the breath. It was just the same when the will stirred. He stretched out his hand and felt this movement as if it were something linked up with the respiratory movements. An expansion of the breath through the whole body was felt as an inner life-process. He even felt the more theoretical perception of the outer world through the senses to be ensouled with breath, just as he felt the breath ensouling the movements of the will. Man felt himself a breathing being, and because he could have said: “My breath is modified in this and that way when I see through my eyes, hear through my ears and receive through the effects of heat”—because in his sensations of all kinds he “saw” differentiated, modified, refined respiratory processes—because of all this the path of knowledge was for him a systematic training of the respiratory process. And this systematic training was for those earlier epochs in the evolution of man's cognition what university study is for us to-day. We study in a different way now. But in those times, when one sought religious satisfaction or wished to acquire knowledge, one “studied” by systematically modifying the respiratory process; in other words, by developing what was later called Yoga Breathing, Yoga Training. And what did one develop? If we investigate what was attained by one who practised Yoga Breathing in order to reach higher stages of cognition, we find something striking. Those who came to be “savants” through Yoga exercises—the word “savant” is not quite appropriate to these earlier conditions, but perhaps one can use it—required as long for this as we do for a university course. In the knowledge so acquired they had grasped in the disposition of their souls what, in a later age—the Graeco-Roman, for example—was regarded as a world of ideas and present of itself in the soul, thus making Yoga unnecessary.

This is really a very interesting thing—that what men had to strive for in earlier epochs through all kinds of exercises is present of itself in later epochs of evolution. It has then no longer the same significance as before. When Socrates, when Plato were alive, their philosophies had no longer the same significance as they would have had for the ancient pupils or teachers of Yoga, had they reached Socratic or Platonic truths. By this Yoga-breathing the pupil did not acquire exactly the same inner organisation as Plato, Aristotle or Scotus Erigena, but he came to the same disposition of soul [*Seelenverfassung*]. Thus we find systematic breathing exercises practised in ancient times, and we see that this cognitive path led to a certain vivid world of ideas.

One really gains a correct idea of what lived later in Parmenides and Anaxagoras if one says to oneself: What was given to men in this age as something self-understood, had been achieved in still earlier times through Yoga. It was always through exercises that men strove for the higher knowledge required by their own age. Thus in the perception of the world in later epochs, men were no longer aware of their breathing in self-contemplation, but they perceived as the Greeks perceived (I have given more details of this in my *Riddles of Philosophy*). At that time one did not construct for oneself isolated thoughts about the world, for ideas and sense-experiences were one. One saw one's thoughts outside, as one saw red or blue and heard C sharp, G or B natural. Thoughts were in the world outside. Without knowing this, nobody understands the Greek view of the world. But the Greeks perceived only spirit permeated with sense-perceptions, or sense-perceptions permeated by spirit, and no longer differentiations in the process of breathing.
GA082

GA211
If we go back to times when ancient Eastern views set the tone for civilization, it was precisely the case that people perceived nature as animated in their everyday lives, but had a very weak, almost nonexistent sense of self—and certainly not this sense of self based on the conviction “I am”—though individual people who had been trained in the mystery schools were led to experience this “I am.”

However, they did not experience this “I am” in the way we take it for granted today; rather, at the very moment when their breathing process enabled them to say “I am” at all—out of inner conviction and inner experience—they experienced something that even people today do not truly experience at first.

Think back to your childhood: You can think back only so far, and then it stops. You were once a baby, and you don’t know what your inner life was like as a baby. Your memory simply stops there. You were certainly already there, crawling around on the floor, being cherished by your mother or father. You may have squirmed or moved your hands, but what you experienced internally at that time is something you are not aware of in your ordinary consciousness. Nevertheless, it was a more active, more intense soul life than what came later. For this more intense soul life, for example, shaped your brain plastically and permeated the rest of your body, shaping it plastically as well. An intense soul life existed, and the ancient Indian felt himself transported into this very soul life at the very moment he said to himself, “I am.”

Just imagine very vividly what that was like. When he said to himself, “I am,” he did not feel as though he were in the present moment; he felt transported back to his infancy, he felt just as he had felt in his infancy, and from that place he spoke to his entire later life. He didn’t feel at all that he was now—but that had only been drawn into this inner being after it had previously lived in the spiritual-soul world. That is to say, by first transporting himself back to his infancy through his breathing process, this ancient Indian yogi became aware of the time before his earthly existence. It seemed to him like a memory. Just as when a person today remembers something they experienced ten years ago, so it was like the emergence of a memory at the very moment when the “I Am” shot through the soul—when, in that ancient Indian era, a person strengthened himself inwardly through breathing exercises and “killed off” the external world around him, but in doing so brought to life not what was now his external world, but rather what had been the external world before the human being had descended into the physical world of the Earth.

Back then—if I may describe it using a modern term, which of course sounds infinitely philistine when applied to those bygone days—the study of yoga truly lifted one out of one’s present earthly existence and elevated one into the spiritual-soul realm. So it was thanks to the study of yoga in those days that one was lifted up into the spiritual and soul worlds. People had a somewhat different consciousness than we do today. But precisely when one was a yoga scholar in the sense of that time, one could think —other people could not do so, other people could only dream—but one could think one’s way into the supersensible world from which one had descended into earthly existence.

Humanity was living out of step with the times, in an era when it needed more than just to have the spiritual-soul world presented to it in images, now that nature had been stripped of its soul for the sake of observation. Humanity needed the historical mystery of Golgotha. The ancient yoga student of the Indian era had taken in the breath, held it back, as it were, within his own body, in order to feel within that breath: “The divine ‘I’ impulse lives within you.” — As a yoga student, the human being experienced God within himself through the process of breathing. Later times came. Human beings no longer experienced the divine impulse within themselves through the process of breathing. But they had learned to think, and they said: Through the breath, the soul entered into human beings. — The ancient yoga practitioner lived this through. Later generations said: And God breathed the breath of life into human beings, and they became souls. — The ancient yoga student experienced this; later generations merely stated it. And by stating this in ancient Hebrew times, people were already experiencing—in a certain abstract sense—what they had previously experienced concretely. But people did not look inward in ancient Hebrew times; they did so, however, in ancient Greek times. One thing always takes place in one part of the world, another in another part. People no longer experienced God within themselves as the ancient yoga student did; instead, they experienced, in symbolic form, the presence of God within the human being. And this experience—in symbolic form—of God’s presence within the human being was certainly present in ancient Greek drama. But this drama now became a world-historical event. This drama became the Mystery of Golgotha. Consequently, however,

the image was now set aside. The image became a mere image, just as the process of breathing was described only in thought. The entire constitution of the human soul changed.

All faith—everything associated with the word “faith”—actually dates back to very ancient times in human development. It dates back to those times when the process of breathing played a much greater role in human life than is the case today. People, with their current state of mind, do not really pay attention to their breathing. They inhale and exhale, but they do not perceive any particular experience in the process.

The religious beliefs of earlier times have always emphasized the importance of breathing. One need only recall—as I have already pointed out in recent days—that in the Old Testament, the very creation of humankind is linked to the breathing in of the breath, and one need only recall what I have explained about that striving, which existed in ancient India, for example, to attain higher knowledge by regulating the breathing process in a specific way. This endeavor made sense in an era when people paid much more attention to their breathing. I have said that this endeavor took place in an era when human beings perceived around them not only the lifeless nature we perceive today, but also saw spiritual and soul forces at work in all natural phenomena and facts; an era in which they perceived spiritual and soul activity in every spring, every cloud, the river, and the wind. During this time, people strove to make their breathing more and more conscious: to regulate inhalation, holding the breath, and exhalation. And through this regulation of the breathing process, what might be called self-consciousness was brought about—the experience of the “I,” of “I am.” But it was a time when the perception and experience of breathing played a certain role in human life. People today, from their ordinary state of consciousness, cannot really imagine what that was like. I would like to give you an idea of what that was like.

Isn’t it true that the breathing process consists of inhaling, holding one’s breath, and exhaling? This breathing process is initially governed by human nature. The yoga scholars I mentioned regulated it differently. Just as today, those who study develop a way of thinking that is different from everyday thinking, so too, in times when breathing played a special role in life, people developed a different way of breathing than in ordinary life. But for now, let’s set aside yogic breathing—that developed form of breathing—and consider ordinary breathing instead. I can best illustrate this for you schematically.

If we assume that this represents the human chest, we can say: We distinguish between the inhalation process, the process of holding one’s breath—which I will not illustrate specifically—and the exhalation process. In earlier times, when a person inhaled, they experienced it as if, with the inhalation—that is, with the air drawn in from the external world—what was spiritual in the beings and events of the external world were also entering within. So in what I have indicated here in red as the inhalation current, people experienced, let us say, gnomes, nymphs—all that was spiritual and soulful in the surrounding nature. And as they exhaled (blue)—that is, as they sent the exhaled air outward—these beings became invisible again during exhalation. They were, so to speak, lost in the surrounding nature. One breathed in and knew: there is something spiritual and soulful out there in nature, for one sensed the effect of this spiritual and soulful aspect in the act of inhaling. In doing so, one felt connected to the spiritual and soul elements of the external natural world. This had—though this is only a relative comparison—a certain intoxicating effect on people in those ancient times. They became intoxicated by the spiritual and soul elements of their surroundings. And as they exhaled, they came down to earth. So they lived in a state of both intoxication and sobering up. And in this alternation between intoxication and sobering up, there was an interaction with the spiritual and soul aspects of the outside world. But there was something else as well. As people inhaled—as they, so to speak, became intoxicated by the spiritual and soul aspects—they felt these aspects gently rising into their heads through the flow of breath, filling them from within, uniting with their own physical being. So that what the human being sensed there can be expressed something like this: I breathe in the spiritual-soul aspects of the environment. They fill my head. I feel it, I perceive it. Then



the breath is held. And as he exhales, the human being would say: I give back my perception of the spiritual-soul aspects.

But this was intimately connected with life. Take just one very simple example: Here is some chalk. When you pick up this chalk today, you look at it, reach out, and pick it up. That is not how people in ancient times did it. We have the thought as we look at the chalk, and then we pick it up. That was not the case for people in ancient times; instead, they looked at it, inhaled what radiated spiritually from the chalk, exhaled, and only as they exhaled did they take hold of the chalk, so that for them, inhaling was equivalent to observing, and exhaling was equivalent to acting. This was at a time when human beings actually lived in a kind of rhythmic interaction with their environment. This rhythmic interaction has indeed been preserved for later times, but without the living, contemplative consciousness of the old days. Just imagine, for example, how grain was threshed by hand in the countryside during our youth: look, strike, look, strike—in rhythmic activity. This rhythmic activity corresponded to a certain breathing process.

Inhaling = Observing

Exhaling = Doing

Regarding a later stage in human development, we can say: This experience of inhalation faded from human perception, and human beings perceived—or perceive—only what rises from the breath into their head. In ancient times, then, human beings perceived how what they inhaled—which was intoxicating to them—continued on into the head and there combined with sensory impressions. This was no longer the case later on. Later, human beings lost awareness of what takes place in their chest region. They no longer perceive this upward flow of the breath because sensory impressions become stronger. These impressions overshadow what rises with the breath. When you see or hear today, the process of breathing is present within the act of seeing and also within the act of hearing. In ancient times, breathing was strongly present in hearing and seeing; in modern people, seeing and hearing are so intense that the breath is completely muffled. So we can say that what was once perceived by the ancients in the breathing process within themselves—that intoxicating sensation flowing through the head—no longer exists, so that they would say: “Ah, the nymphs!” Ah, the gnomes! Nymphs swirling in the head like this, gnomes hammering in the head like this, undines undulating in the head like this! — Today, this hammering, undulating, and swirling is drowned out by what comes from seeing and hearing, and what now fills the head.

There was, then, a time when human beings were more keenly aware of this flow of breath rising into their heads. This gave way to a time when human beings still perceived things in a confused manner, when they still sensed something of the aftereffects of the gnomic hammering, the undine-like undulating, and the nymph-like swirling—as they still perceived something of the connection between these aftereffects and their perceptions of sound, light, and color. But then everything they had still perceived of the breathing process was lost. And among those people who still retained a trace of awareness that breathing had once brought the spiritual-soul aspect of the world into human beings, what now remained—what had become established through sensory perception in connection with breathing—was called “Sophia.” But breathing was no longer perceived. Thus, the spiritual content of breathing was killed off—or rather, numbed—by sensory perception.

This was felt particularly by the Greeks. The Greeks had no concept of science as we understand it today. If someone had told the Greeks about the kind of science taught in our universities today, it would have seemed to them as if someone were constantly piercing their brains with tiny pins. They would not have understood at all that this could give a person any satisfaction. If they had been asked to take in the kind of science we have today, they would have said: “That makes the brain sore; that wounds the brain; that stings.”—For they still wanted to perceive something of that blissful expansion of the intoxicating breath into which what is heard and seen pours forth as it flows in. So among the

Greeks there was a perception of an inner life within the head—an inner life such as I am now describing to you. And this inner life, they called it Sophia. And those who loved to develop this Sophia within themselves, who had a special inclination to surrender to this Sophia, called themselves philosophers. The word “philosophy” certainly points to an inner experience. That dreadfully pedantic approach to philosophy—where one simply “crams” philosophy, as they say in student life—that familiarization with this discipline—was unknown in Greece. But the inner experience of “I love Sophia”—that is what finds expression in the word “philosophy.”

But just as the head receives sensory perceptions, so too does the rest of the body receive what flows out as exhaled air. In the organism of the limbs and metabolism, just as sensory perceptions—what is heard and what is seen—flow into the head through the intoxicating effect of the inhaled air, so too do the physical sensations and experiences flow together with the exhaled air. The sobering quality of the exhaled air—which extinguishes perception—flowed together with the physical sensations aroused by walking and working. Activity, the act of doing, was linked to exhalation. And as a person was active, as they did something, they felt, in a sense, how their spiritual-soul aspect was flowing away from them. So that when they did anything, when they worked on anything, they felt as if they were allowing their spiritual-soul aspect to flow into things. I take in the spiritual-soul aspect: it intoxicates my head; it connects with what I have seen and heard. I do something; I exhale. The spiritual-soul aspect departs. It goes into what I am hammering, it goes into what I am grasping, it goes into everything I am working on. I release the spiritual-psychic from within me. I transfer it, for example, by churning milk, by doing something outwardly; I let the spiritual-psychic flow into things. — That was the feeling, that was the sensation. So that is how it was in ancient times.

But this awareness of the exhalation process, this awareness of disillusionment, simply ceased, and only a trace of it remained in the Greek era. In the Greek era, people still felt as if, through their actions, they were imparting something spiritual to things. But then everything that was present in the exhalation process was dulled by the bodily sensation, by the feeling of exertion and fatigue during work. Just as the inhalation process was dulled by the head, so too was the exhalation process dulled by the rest of the organism. This spiritual exhalation process was dulled by the bodily sensation—that is, by the feeling of exertion, of becoming heated, and so on—by what was alive within the person, so that he felt his own strength, which he applied by being active, by doing something. He no longer felt the exhalation process within himself as fatigue; he felt a force at work within him; he felt his body permeated with energy, with strength.

This power that lived within a person was Pistis—faith, the sense of the divine, the divine power that drives one to work: Pistis, faith.

Sophia = the spiritual content of breathing, dulled by sensory perception

Pistis (faith) = the spiritual process of exhalation, inhibited by bodily sensations

Thus, wisdom and faith converged within the human being. Wisdom flowed to the head, while faith lived throughout the whole person. Wisdom was merely the content of the idea. And faith was the power of that content. The two belonged together. Hence the sole Gnostic text preserved from antiquity: the Pistis Sophia text. Thus, in Sophia one found a rarefaction of the inhalation, and in faith a condensation of the exhalation. Then wisdom became further rarefied. And in this further dilution, wisdom became science. And then the inner power condensed further. Human beings could feel only their bodies: the awareness of what faith—Pistis—actually is slipped away from them. And so it came to pass that, because people could no longer sense the connection, they separated what—as mere content of faith—was meant to rise subjectively from within, so to speak, from that which is connected to external sensory perception. First there was Sophia, then Scientia—ordinary science, which is a diluted Sophia. One could also say: Originally, Sophia was a true spiritual being whom human beings felt as an inhabitant of their own minds. Today, all that remains of this spiritual being is a ghost. For

science is the ghost of wisdom. This is something that should actually pass through the soul of modern humanity like a kind of meditation—that science is the ghost of wisdom. And similarly, on the other side, faith—which is commonly called that today; here one has not really grasped a specific distinction in the words—the faith that lives today is not the inwardly experienced faith of antiquity, Pistis, but rather it is the subjective that is closely linked to egoism. It is the condensed faith of ancient times. In the faith that had not yet become condensed, people still sensed the objective Divine within the human being. Today, faith is found only subjectively, rising, as it were, like smoke from the body. So one could say that just as science is the specter of wisdom, so today's faith is the solidified remnant of former faith, the lump of former faith.

In the era I have been speaking to you about—those days when people sought to attain higher insights by regulating their breathing, the era when the ancient Eastern system of yoga was truly in its heyday—for what is referred to today as "yoga practice" is, in many cases, merely a secondary matter— there was indeed a consciousness present: When you inhale, when you direct the inhaled air into your head, you can grasp the mysteries of the universe in the reflection of that universe, in the specific configuration of the nervous system within your head. You need only relate to the inhalation process in the appropriate manner.

I am not speaking now of what later existed in a decadent form, but of the original. And the original was this: People used to say to themselves: When you inhale and shape your breath so that you send it up into this inner vault of the head, which is an imprint of the entire universe, but in such a way that you imbue the breath with a sound that lies between "a" and "o" or between "a" and "u"—that is, when you infuse the breath with "a-u"—then you shape it so that, just as the hand is suited to feel something externally, the sound becomes suited to feel the mystery of the universe within. And one brings it into consciousness by continuing this breathing process in such a way that it culminates in a state of absolute devotion toward what one has perceived there. So when one has what one attains by inhaling, by sending out the breath and probing with it through "a-u," when one then enters this devotional mood, becomes devoted to the world, and pours out what one has explored there into absolute devotion, then allows the breathing process to culminate in "m," then in such a breathing process—which takes shape inwardly as "aum"—one has captured—from the replica, from the nervous replica of the universe within—the mystery of the universe. And one has brought it to life, so that it can become conscious in the air exhaled in the sound "m." In what I have now explained, you have an indication of what once formed the basis of the original yoga training.

This yogi said to himself: "The secret of the entire universe lies within my head." I can perceive it by inhaling. As I inhale, the secret of the universe is revealed through me. I grasp it—this secret of the universe. But I can only retain it—otherwise it remains in the unconscious—if I then live my life in absolute, devotional surrender to the universe. And so it is realized by shaping the process of inhalation into the Word of the Universe—that which creatively ripples through and weaves through the world—and by grasping it and exhaling it in absolute devotion to the universe: Inhalation is the revelation of the World Word; exhalation is the inner condensation of the World Word, the affirmation of the World Word. Thus is summarized humanity's exploration of the World Word and humanity's articulation of the World Word, through the realization that: Inhalation is revelation, exhalation is confession, and "aum" is the synthesis of revelation and confession—the enlivening of the mystery of the universe within oneself, the affirmation of this mystery of the universe within oneself.

For us today, in our present era, the tone has shifted even further upward. The tone finds its expression in real, concrete thoughts, not in intellectualistic ones. So that we can say: Inhalation becomes thought, and exhalation becomes the volitional living out of that thought. That is to say, we break down what was once inhalation as revelation and exhalation as confession into exercises of thought and will, and thereby receive—also in thought, but in the thought cultivated through meditation—the revelation, and in the exercises of will, which are carried out on the other side, the confession of what has been revealed.

For modern humanity, it is as follows: What was previously experienced in the mere process of breathing—and what was formed into a vowel sound during inhalation and a consonant sound during exhalation—now finds expression in a more spiritual way in the inwardly contemplated thought, which is, however, permeated by the will in devotional surrender to the universe. Thus, the process is the same, only made more spiritual and internalized. But here, too, the process consists in perceiving the inner experience of the universe in its mysteries and in professing one's commitment to this universe, to the spiritual foundation of this universe.

We can also consider the following thoughts. We can say: Human beings are born out of light, and their inner being—the innermost part of their head—is the result of light. The entire nervous system is, after all, the result of light. Light is conveyed not only through the eye, but also through the other senses. The eye is merely the sense through which light is conveyed in the most primary sense. We cannot say that blind people are completely cut off from light. Light is at work within them; it is only their conscious perception of light that is absent.

And sound actually lives within the entire organism. Sound lives within us. Sound does not live only in the ear; the ear is merely an organ of perception for sound. When we experience a sound, we experience it with our entire organism. We always experience a symphony with our entire organism. When we listen to a piece of music, the inner process is actually as follows: We attune our entire breathing process to a very specific rhythm, to very specific musical processes that are precisely brought about by the composition. These formations within our air-filled interior resonate with the structures of the brain; the way they are reflected back from there gives us the musical impression. In fact, there is always within us a process of probing the light through sound.

Keep in mind that within us there is a constant process of exploring light through sound. The world of sound within us—the resonant organism—is actually a sensory organ for light. Light is, in fact, always the external aspect; sound is, in fact, always the internal aspect.

Thoughts — Inhalation: Revelation

Will — Exhalation: Confession



Palpate Light by Sound -> The External Through Sound -> The Internal

Palpate the thoughts of the world through human will.

The inner world probes the outer world. In fact, we can only truly grasp our own nature in the right way when we perceive ourselves as a unique being, set apart from the harmony of the world's spheres. This being feels its way in the light, and in the configurations of the light, sound recognizes the nature of the world. It is only in our epoch that we actually have a "feeling out" of the world's thoughts through the human will (see diagram). We feel out the world's thoughts with our will. Here, the will takes the place of sound. Thought, on the other hand, takes the place of light. As I said, these things are very difficult to express in intellectual, abstract terms. But what I have tried to present to you in a pictorial way will draw you into these matters if you reflect on them a little, if you realize that humanity's innermost being in the world is truly such that the human being has, within his head, an image of the entire cosmos. The human being is, in fact, with regard to his head, an image of the entire cosmos.



As the human embryo develops in the womb, it is initially formed as a reflection of the cosmos. The first point is that, indeed, within the mother's womb, the human being is formed as a reflection of the cosmos. At first, the human being is, in essence, a brain—a reflection of the cosmos. You can study the cosmos by studying the human embryo in its earliest stages. Only later does something emerge that is no longer a reflection of the cosmos, but rather—to put it this way—if you have the Earth here, with the human being upon it, then—as a part of the embryo is taken—what is added are the forces that, parallel to the surface, circle the Earth in rhythms. The chest organism is formed, which is actually created from currents that circle around the Earth. You can, if you like, still see these currents reflected in the ribs. Last of all comes the effect of the Earth organism itself. Here, the currents are sent up from below: you can see in the two legs a very precise expression of how these currents flow. So that I can depict the human being as currents emanating from the Earth, as currents circling the Earth, which are connected to his chest organism, and at the top as the head, the image of the entire universe.

What takes place in the mind is, in fact, always a reflection of the entire universe, throughout one's entire life. Because human beings possess a mental organization, they carry within themselves a reflection of the entire universe. They need only perceive it. They would not perceive it if they were not organized for this purpose by the Earth. In fact, the Earth perceives the universe through human beings: the chest organism serves as the mediator. Inhalation is brought about by the cosmos; exhalation is brought about by the Earth. The cosmos gives us pure oxygen; the Earth causes this oxygen to combine with carbon, thus forming the deadly exhaled air. But it is through the formation of this dead air that understanding arises.

Understanding is always connected to what is dying within us. We actually die through our understanding; we live through the cosmos. But we would live very quickly if we were simply surrendered to the cosmos. The cosmos provides us with the most life while we are still in our embryonic state; then the Earth's atmosphere gradually takes over, and later what flows up from the Earth. Through this process, the life that the cosmos gives to our organism is mediated until the amount of life the cosmos gives us is precisely exhausted. The cosmos animates us; the Earth kills us as physical organisms and also as etheric organisms. However, it is the case that the cosmos primarily influences our etheric organism, while our Earth primarily influences our physical organism.

When you consider all of this and say to yourself: Once upon a time, a regulated breathing process was practiced to cultivate higher knowledge—a process carried out for the purpose of exploring the mysteries of the universe within the human being—then you will come to understand how, in the days of humanity's earliest aspirations, people felt inwardly how they were connected to the entire universe, and how they sought to experience the Word of the Universe through the process of inhalation, and to offer a sacrifice to the Word of the Universe through the process of exhalation; how, through yogic breathing, they sought to place their consciousness within the cosmic process. Unconsciously, of course, they are always already within this cosmic process. From the external description given today of this yogic breathing, one gains no real insight into what was actually intended by it. But one does gain such real insight by striving to attain it through today's anthroposophical spiritual science. People have no documents describing how things were originally. In the times from which we have documents on this subject, these things no longer existed in their original form. One must arrive at the true mysteries of humanity's origins on Earth without documents; otherwise, one must do without them. So anyone who seeks to understand these things solely through external documents that have survived from earlier times will not arrive at them; rather, only those who can look back to states far more primordial than those attested to by external documents will arrive at them. The mystery of the Eastern "Aum" prayer—if I may call it that—I might just as well say: the "Aum" formula of knowledge, for both were contained within it—can only be grasped if one truly understands the connection between the human being and the world in the act of inhaling and exhaling. If one knows that, just as the air—which otherwise produces no specific tones at all—is shaped into specific tones as soon as one has

strings tuned to different pitches, so too the inhaled air, which one sends through the brain with the Aum sound, inwardly expresses the entire mystery of the world—if one knows this, then one understands humanity's connection to the universe. One begins to sense how one actually came to be. Since the human being lived in the spiritual-soul world before conception, he was, after all, in the spiritual world. But as he now descends, he passes through the entire configuration of the cosmos in the ether, absorbing the ether. At this moment, he takes in all the mysteries of the universe and gradually imprints them upon his brain. And the very young child is actually still gradually imprinting upon its brain what the soul has experienced of the total mystery of the universe. And later on, one rediscovers this mystery when one strives—in ancient times through the air one breathed, and now through thought—to experience this mystery of the universe anew within oneself.

The power of thought—which is, after all, nothing more than a diluted form of the breath's power—also takes shape when it is truly channeled through the brain. Modern humans do not do this. Modern humans do not actually channel the power of thought through the brain; rather, they hear everywhere the words spoken in their language—words in which thoughts also dwell—and then they channel through themselves what they inwardly parrot from their national heritage. And in doing so, they gain no inner insights whatsoever; at most, they write books about how we have only language and cannot gain any insight through it. He then writes a critique of language because he has no idea what the power of thought encounters, since he knows only what is, so to speak, recorded in the words. Modern man is, after all, merely a sounding board for words.

One must be clear that it is a profound truth that a human being is "human" through the divine breath, through the air they breathe in. For through this—through this inhaled air—they discover the entire world within themselves; they discover how they are a microcosm.

Yoga achieved much while the old instinctive clairvoyance could still come to its aid, while the last possessors of instinctive clairvoyance were still practising yoga. But it is a long time since the modern Oriental, the Indian—about whom many Westerners weave such fantastic ideas to-day—has attained any real vision of the eternal essence of the human soul when he engages in his exercises. He lives for the most part in illusions, in that he has a fleeting experience belonging to some elemental reality of earthly life, and then reads into the experience something from his sacred books. Real and fundamental knowledge of the divine nature of the human soul has been possible for humanity only in two ways: either as primeval humanity attained it, or as man can again attain it to-day, in a much more spiritual way, through Intuitive cognition, through cognition which, rising to Imaginative knowledge, and then to knowledge through Inspiration, finally becomes Intuition.

Now during earthly life the thinking part of the soul has poured itself into the human nervous system; it has built up this plastic structure and in it no longer has a separate existence. In the rhythmic system it is only partially absorbed. We can say of this is that there remains here some possibility of independent thought-activity. But the really eternal element of the human soul is hidden in the metabolic system, in the system which, for earthly life, has the most material function of all. Outwardly it is indeed the most material, but just because of this, the spiritual remains separate from it. The spiritual is drawn into, absorbed by the other material parts of the organism, by the brain and the rhythmic system, and is no longer there independently. In the crude materiality, the spiritual is present in itself. But to use it, a man must be able to see, to perceive, by means of the crude outer materiality. This was a possibility in primeval humanity and, although it is not a condition to be striven after, it may still occur to-day in pathological states. It is known by very few, for example, that the secret of Nietzsche's style in Thus Spake Zarathustra lies in the fact that he imbibed certain poisonous substances which brought into play within him a particular rhythm, which is the distinctive style of this work. In Nietzsche, it was a definitely material substratum that was really doing the thinking. This, needless to say, is a pathological condition, although in a certain respect again there is a kind of grandeur in it. If we are to understand these things we must no longer have false ideas, either about them, or about Intuition and the like, which lie at the opposite pole. We must understand what it means that Nietzsche should have imbibed

certain poisons—a procedure not to be imitated—which substances work in such a way that they lead to an etherisation, an etherealised mode of experience in the human organism. This irradiates the thinking and produces what we find in Thus Spake Zarathustra. Intuition, on the other hand, is able to perceive the spirit-and-soul as such, separated from matter. Nothing of a material nature is at work in Intuition as described in the books Knowledge of the Higher Worlds and Its Attainment or in An Outline of Occult Science. Here we have two opposite poles of spiritual knowledge.
GA211

GA305
If we want to gain clarity about ourselves today by stepping back from the general consciousness of our time, what do we do? We reflect; we engage our intellect. Even if we want to gain clarity about nature, what do we do? We conduct experiments and engage our intellect in those experiments. Intellectual activity everywhere. In ancient times, people sought to reach the spirit and the soul in a completely different way. They sought—and I want to highlight two examples from the many I could cite—to reach the spirit and the soul in ancient times, in the East, through the so-called yoga method. Yoga—the very mention of the name today evokes a slight sense of horror in many people, for historically we are actually familiar only with the later yoga methods, which are largely based on the egoism of people who want to possess something powerful in the external world. The older yoga methods—which today can really only be discovered through spiritual science, not through external science—were paths that human beings took toward the spirit. What were they based on? They were based on the fact that, out of a certain instinct, people said to themselves: We cannot reach the spirit through mere thinking alone. We must do something that reveals within us an activity, an inner dynamism, far more than mere thinking. We can stand somewhere apart from the world, playing the role of a spectator, while thinking takes place within us. We do not bring about any change within ourselves that is perceptible to us.

Jogi was seeking a much more real process within himself than we seek today when we want to understand the spirit. When we ask ourselves, based on our current physiological knowledge: What happens when we intellectualize? — Well, something happens in our nervous system, in our brain, and in those parts of the rest of the organism that are connected to the brain via the nerves. But what happens there in the nerves could never occur if a much more perceptible activity were not intertwined with the processes of our brain. From birth to death, we breathe in, hold our breath, and breathe out ceaselessly. When we inhale, the air we breathe flows throughout our entire organism. The breath is driven through the spinal canal into the brain. We do not breathe only with our lungs; we also breathe with our brain. Our brain is constantly in motion. Breathing—inhaling, holding our breath, and exhaling—ripples through and animates our brain. This takes place—entirely unconsciously for us today. The yogi said: “Something is happening within the human being; I want to become conscious of it.” So he did not breathe in the usual, unconscious way, but rather he breathed in an unusual, abnormal manner; he inhaled differently, held his breath differently, and exhaled differently. Through this, he became aware of the breathing process. And what remains entirely unconscious to us took place fully within his consciousness as he recognized and felt it. And so he gradually sensed how, in the brain, breathing was connected to what underlies the material activity of thinking and intellectualization. He sought this connection between thinking and breathing, and he finally sensed how the thought—which is something abstract for us—moves through the entire body on the waves of the breath. There, the thought was not only in the brain, not only in the lungs, not only in the heart—there, the thought was in every fingertip. There, by actually feeling the breath pulsing through oneself, one experienced how the spirit is creative through the breath in human beings: “And God breathed into man the breath of life, and he became a soul.” He did not breathe the breath into us only at the beginning; rather, He continues to breathe it into us as we breathe. And it is in the process of breathing—not in thinking, not in the intellectual process—that we become soul. We feel our being by sensing the thought pulsing through our entire body on the waves of the breath. You see, now the thought—the spirit—was no longer regarded as something intellectual, as something abstract and separate; now one sensed it, felt it

throughout the entire body; now one felt oneself as a human being, a creature of the spirit. You see, one had the active spirit.

In the 20th century, we can no longer approach the spirit in the same way it was done centuries or even millennia ago in ancient India. Nor can we do so in the same way it was done before the reality of the Mystery of Golgotha. We are living in the evolution of Christianity. But we can understand spirit and soul if we look back to this older way, if we perceive, in particular, how very different the path to spirit and soul is for the spiritual person compared to the merely intellectual person.

If we want to gain clarity about ourselves today by stepping back from the general consciousness of our time, what do we do? We reflect; we engage our intellect. Even if we want to gain clarity about nature, what do we do? We conduct experiments and engage our intellect in those experiments. Intellectual activity everywhere. In ancient times, people sought to reach the spirit and the soul in a completely different way. They sought—and I want to highlight two examples from the many I could cite—to reach the spirit and the soul in ancient times, in the East, through the so-called yoga method. Yoga—the very mention of the name today evokes a slight sense of horror in many people, for historically we are actually familiar only with the later yoga methods, which are largely based on the egoism of people who want to possess something powerful in the external world. The older yoga methods—which today can really only be discovered through spiritual science, not through external science—were paths that human beings took toward the spirit. What were they based on? They were based on the fact that, out of a certain instinct, people said to themselves: We cannot reach the spirit through mere thinking alone. We must do something that reveals within us an activity, an inner dynamism, far more than mere thinking. We can stand somewhere apart from the world, playing the role of a spectator, while thinking takes place within us. We do not bring about any change within ourselves that is perceptible to us.

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throughout the entire body; now one felt oneself as a human being, a creature of the spirit. You see, one had the active spirit.

What I am expressing here may seem trivial; yet it is profound in terms of inner experience. Once one experiences that all thinking that takes place in the intellectual realm is unreal—a mere image—then one experiences in the soul the same thing one physically experiences as a sense of powerlessness. Powerlessness in the face of reality. True knowledge does not arise from the resolve: “I can think, and therefore I can reflect on all things”; true knowledge arises from saying to oneself: “And if I were to reflect on all things using the mental images I possess, I would be nothing more than a powerless being.” The yogi sought his true self in the breath. We modern people must lose our sense of self in a powerlessness that we feel in the face of the mental image, the intellectualistic. Then we must be able to say to ourselves: Now we do not turn inward, as the yogi did, toward the breath process; now we turn outward, look at every plant, look at every animal, look at every human being, and live with the external world.

In my book *How Does One Gain Insight into the Higher Worlds?*, I have described how to do this—how to look at the plant not merely from the outside, but to follow each of its processes, so that thinking emerges entirely from the realm of mere imagery and participates in the real life of the external world. One immerses oneself in the plant, so that one feels how gravity draws down into the root toward the earth, how the flowering force unfolds upward. One experiences the blooming and the fruiting firsthand. One plunges completely into the external world. There, there one is carried away by the external world. One awakens again as if from a faint. But one no longer has abstract thoughts; one has imaginations. One has images. And in these images that one receives, one no longer sees any knowledge from the standpoint of materialism. One says: Knowledge must take place in abstract, logical terms. Yes, but what if the world is not such that it yields to the abstract concepts of logic!—If the world were a work of art, for example, then we would have to perceive it artistically, not logically; then logic would merely be there to discipline us. But we would understand nothing of the world through logic.

So we must immerse ourselves in things. Where the yogi has turned inward, we turn outward, striving to connect with all things, and thus attain the same in deed, only in a more soulful, more spiritual way. By allowing our concepts, ideas—that which represents mere intellectuality—to be permeated by reality, we feel once again how creative the spirit within us is.

To what I had to say yesterday about older paths to spiritual insight, I would like to add today, as a further example, the path that has been taken through asceticism in the broadest sense of the word. This brings me to a description of a path that we are even less able to follow in our present age than the one I described yesterday. In our time, in our civilization, different attitudes and habits prevail among people than in those times when people once sought higher spiritual insight through asceticism. And so, just as we must replace the path of yoga today with something more spiritual and soulful, we as modern people must also replace the path of asceticism with another. But we can more easily understand what is meant by the modern path into spiritual life if we base our concepts on what was actually intended by a method such as asceticism.

Asceticism essentially consists of certain exercises. These exercises, however, can also extend to the emotional and spiritual realms. But I want now, above all, to consider how such exercises were performed in order to, in a certain way, shut the body out of the whole of human experience for certain periods of time. And it is precisely through this shutting out of the body that an experience in the spiritual world is brought about. Such exercises consisted in training the body in a certain way so that, through the suffering, pain, and mortification it endured, it became capable of learning to endure pain without, so to speak, becoming overly agitated in the soul; so that it learned to endure physical suffering without sinking into that physical suffering with its whole soul. Through this mortification, through this striving for a certain endurance on the part of the human body, it was anticipated that as

the body became increasingly numbed, so to speak, the spiritual within it would rise up, free itself, and lead to a certain direct perception, to a direct experience. It is simply a fact—even though these methods are not recommended today—that to the same extent that the human organism is physically numbed, it allows the human being to take in the spiritual-soul being within themselves. The spiritual becomes—and this is simply a fact—perceptible when the physical is suppressed in its activity.

I would like to use a comparison to clarify what I actually want to say. Let's consider the human eye. The human eye exists to serve as a mediator for the perception of light. By what means alone can the human eye make light perceptible to a person? By this—and I'll put it somewhat figuratively—that it wants nothing for itself. The moment the eye itself wants something internally, let's say, at the moment when the organic activity—the life activity—within the eye itself becomes too vigorous; when, for example, the lens or the vitreous body becomes opaque or hardens; when, in other words, the eye moves from selflessness into selfishness—then the eye is no longer a servant of the human being. The eye must not claim to be something for its own sake. This is, of course, meant in a relative sense, but everything that is to be expressed must, after all, be expressed in a somewhat absolute way. Life itself renders it relative. Thus we can say: The eye owes its transparency to light to the fact that it separates itself from the human being, that it is selfless.

If we want to look into the spiritual world—and by "looking" I mean, of course, in a soul-spiritual sense—then we must, so to speak, turn our entire organism into an eye. We do not need to make our entire organism physically transparent, as is the case with the eye, but we must make it transparent in a soul-spiritual sense—transparent in a soul-spiritual sense. It must no longer be an obstacle to our communion with the world.

Now, I certainly won't say that our physical organism, as we exist in life, is in any way sick—just as the eye would be sick if it claimed a life of its own. Just as we exist in ordinary life, our entire organism is already fine; it is already completely normal. It must be opaque. We will see in the subsequent lectures how our organism cannot be an eye in ordinary life, how it must be opaque. We find rest for our ordinary soul life within our organism precisely because it is opaque, because we do not always have the entire spiritual world of the cosmos before us when we look around. So for everyday life, it is indeed correct, it is indeed normal, that our organism is opaque. But one cannot perceive the spiritual world through it, just as one cannot perceive light through a severely diseased eye. And because our organism is purified through suffering, through pain, through trials it overcomes, it becomes transparent. And this indeed opens up the possibility—just as the eye, when it becomes completely clear within itself, gains the ability to perceive the world of light around it—so too does the entire organism gain the ability to perceive the spiritual world around it when we make the organism transparent in this way.

What I have just described is precisely what, in earlier times—from which the most important religious views originate, views that have been passed down to our time through tradition rather than through the independent discoveries of present-day humanity—led to the physical asceticism that I have just attempted to illustrate.

We cannot emulate this asceticism today. In earlier times, it was a common attitude among people that when one sought knowledge, when one wanted to hear about what went on in the supersensible, spiritual worlds, one turned to solitary individuals—those who had withdrawn from the world. It was a common belief that one could learn nothing from people who were caught up in everyday life, that what needed to be known about the spiritual worlds could only be attained in solitude, and that a person had to become someone other than the ordinary person in order to possess knowledge and insight.

Given our current worldview, we would no longer be able to think that way today. We strive to believe only in those people who can stand on their own two feet in life, who can lend a helping hand to others,

who are of value in life, who can work and act, and who know how life works. That solitude which in earlier times was regarded as a prerequisite for higher knowledge no longer serves as our guiding principle today. Today, if we want to believe in human beings, we need to see before us the active human being—the person who does not withdraw from life but who, on the contrary, throws himself into it. Therefore, it is impossible for us to develop the same attitude toward the kind of knowledge that once led people to the ascetic in order to learn from him how things work in the divine-spiritual world.

Well, for these reasons, we must today—without rendering our bodies physically incapable of action through asceticism—strive for transparency from within the soul and spirit themselves. We can do this. We can do so because we have acquired precise concepts and ideas through our centuries-long development of the natural sciences. We can train our thinking in accordance with this scientific development. What I am saying here is not directed against the intellectual. The intellectual should be the basis in everything; precise thinking should be the foundation. But what must be built upon this intellectuality, upon this precise thinking, is that which then leads into the spiritual world.

Well, we initially achieve the same thing that the ancient ascetic achieved through mortification and the numbing of the physical organism by, in a sense, taking our own spiritual development into our own hands—for example, by asking ourselves at a certain point in our lives: What habits do you have? What are your particular idiosyncrasies? What are your bad habits? What are your sympathies and antipathies?—And after one has written all this down clearly before one's soul, one tries, to begin with, to create a mental image—in a simple, perhaps very simple way—of what one would be like if one were to develop a different kind of antipathy, a different kind of sympathy, or a different element of one's psychological life.

We must not take such things lightly, for it sometimes takes many years to do from within what life otherwise does. Let's take an honest look at ourselves. We'll say to ourselves: We weren't like this 10 years ago. The inner substance of the soul—and its inner formation as well—have become quite different. But what caused this to happen? Life. Quite unconsciously, we have surrendered ourselves to life. We have thrown ourselves into the stream of life. If we can now do for ourselves what life otherwise does, we can look—I would say—at what we are meant to become in 10 years, and resolve to do so, set our minds to it, and then work toward it with iron will to truly bring it to fruition. So let us condense the whole of life—which is otherwise vast and works upon us—into the smallness of our own "I"; let us concentrate the power that is otherwise spread out like an ocean of life into the will of our own "I"; let us advance ourselves, let us make something of ourselves—then what the ancient ascetic accomplished from the outside will be accomplished from within. He weakened the body so that the will and insight might rise strongly from the weak body and the weak body might become transparent to the spiritual world. We must strengthen the will, strengthen the power of thought, so that they become stronger than the body, which carries on with its own affairs; then we compel the body to become transparent to the world of the spirit. We are doing exactly the opposite of what the ancient ascetic did.

You see, I have described these things in my book *How Does One Attain Insights into the Higher Worlds?*. People have often regarded something that was entirely different as "ancient asceticism," viewing it as if it were ancient asceticism in a new form. Anyone who reads carefully will find that everything is something entirely different from what this old asceticism was. But one cannot practice this new asceticism—through which one does not withdraw from life and retreat into a hermitage, but rather remains firmly rooted in the fullness of life—without looking beyond the present moment and into the future.

Just think about it: you have to imagine what kind of person you might want to be in 10 years. So one must take into account the whole person, from birth to death. It is easy for a person to live only in the moment. What is at stake is learning to live over time, throughout one's entire life. Then the spiritual

world becomes transparent to us, and we do indeed see—when our body becomes transparent in this way—a spiritual world all around us.

Everything that is described, for example, in my *Outline of Esoteric Science* is based solely on such knowledge, within which the human body is as transparent as the eye is to light.
GA305

The Christian-Gnostic Path

GA094
Christian initiation has always consisted of seven stages. Four of these correspond to the four stations of Calvary. They are as follows:

First: The Washing of the Feet
Second: The Scourging
Third: The Crowning with Thorns
Fourth: The Carrying of the Cross
Fifth: The Mystical Death
Sixth: The Burial
Seventh: The Resurrection

The washing of feet is a preparatory exercise of a purely moral nature. It refers to the scene in which Christ washes the disciples' feet before the Passover (Gospel of John 13). "Truly, truly, I say to you: A servant is not greater than his master, nor is an apostle greater than the one who sent him." Theology gives this act a purely moral interpretation and sees in it merely an example of profound humility and the Master's absolute submission to his disciples and to his mission. The Rosicrucians also see this in it, but in a much deeper sense that encompasses the evolution of all beings in nature. It is an allusion to the law that the higher is the product of the lower. The plant might say to the stone: "I am above you, for I have life, which you do not have; but without you I could not exist, for from you I draw the sap that nourishes me." —- And the animal might say to the plant: "I am above you, for I have sensations, passions, and impulses of will that you do not have, but without the food you give me—without your leaves, grasses, and fruits—I could not live." And man would have to say to the plants: "I am above you, but I owe you the oxygen I breathe." He would have to say to the animals: "I have a soul that you do not have, but we are brothers and companions, and we are advancing together in the general course of evolution." — The esoteric meaning of the washing of the feet is therefore that Jesus Christ, the Messiah, the Son of God, could not exist without the Apostles.

The student who has meditated on this subject for months, and sometimes for years, experiences the vision of the washing of the feet on the astral plane while asleep. He can then ascend to the second degree of Christian initiation:

The Scourging: At this stage, the individual learns to withstand the scourge of life. Life brings us suffering of every kind: physical and moral, intellectual and spiritual. In this phase, the student experiences life as a terrible and unceasing ordeal. He must endure it with complete equanimity of soul and stoic courage. He must no longer know fear, whether physical or moral. Once he has become fearless, he sees the scene of the scourging in a dream. In the course of another vision, he sees himself being scourged in place of Christ. This event is accompanied by certain physical symptoms and, through an intensification of the entire sensory faculty, extends to the whole sense of life and love.

An example of this hyper-acute sensibility, transferred into intellectual life, can be found in Goethe's life. After extensive osteological studies of the human skeleton and the skeletons of animals, as well as comparative observations, Goethe concluded that the intermaxillary bone must exist in humans. Before

him, it had been denied that the intermaxillary bone could be found in the human upper jaw. He himself recounts that he leaped for joy and fell into a kind of ecstasy when he discovered that this bone does indeed exist in the human jaw, still visible through a suture. He himself calls it one of the most wondrous events of his life. Goethe experienced the same feeling during his trip to Italy, when, upon seeing the remains of a sheep's skull, that other idea came to him—one that was even more wondrous for human evolution—an idea that could be called both esoteric and Darwinian: namely, that the human brain, the center of reason—with the cerebellum situated before it, the center of volitional movements—is a blossom and an unfolding of the spinal cord, just as the blossom is an unfolding and synthesis of the root and the stem. How did Goethe make these wondrous discoveries, which alone would secure his immortality? Certainly through his superior intellect, but also through his lively and profound sympathy with all beings and with all of nature. This sensitivity is a refinement and expansion of the forces of life and love. It corresponds to the second degree of Christian initiation and is the result of the trial of scourging. Human beings acquire a feeling of love for all beings that allows them to live within nature.

The Crowning with Thorns: Here, a person must learn to defy the world—morally and intellectually—and to endure contempt when what is most precious to him is attacked. He must be able to remain upright when everything is pressing him down; to say "yes" when the whole world says "no." This is what must be learned before moving on. A new aspect now presents itself: the power of discernment—or rather, the ability to instantly distinguish between three forces that are always intertwined in human beings: will, feeling, and thought. One must learn to separate or unite them at will. As long as, for example, an external event fills us with such enthusiasm that it sweeps us off our feet, we are not mature, for this enthusiasm, triggered by the event, does not come from within us and can even exert a shattering influence over us that we cannot control. The student's enthusiasm should find its origin solely in the depths of the mystical life. One must therefore remain dispassionate toward every event, whatever its nature. Only in this way does one attain freedom. This separation between feeling, intellect, and will brings about a transformation in the brain characterized by the crowning with thorns. For this transformation to take place safely, it is necessary that the powers of the personality be sufficiently trained and perfectly balanced. If this is not the case, or if the student has a poor guide, this change can trigger madness. Madness, in fact, is based on nothing other than this split, which takes place outside the will, without the unity being able to be restored through inner willpower. In contrast, the student practices making this split disappear whenever he wishes. A flash of his will restores the bond between the organs and functions of his soul, whereas in the case of the insane person, the rift may become irreparable and cause damage to the central nervous system.

During the stage known in Christian initiation as the Crowning with Thorns, a terrifying phenomenon occurs, known as the "Keeper of the Threshold," which could also be called the appearance of the doppelganger. The human spirit, formed from one's currents of will, desires, and intellectual faculties, then appears to the initiate as an image in the dream state. And this image is sometimes repulsive and terrifying, for it is the result of the person's good and bad qualities and their karma; it is the pictorial personification of all this on the astral plane. This is the evil ferryman in the Egyptian Book of the Dead. The person must defeat him in order to find their higher self. The Keeper of the Threshold, a phenomenon of clairvoyant vision dating back to the earliest times, is the true origin of all the myths about the hero's struggle with the monster—Perseus and Heracles with the Hydra, Saint George and Siegfried with the dragon.

The premature onset of clairvoyance and the sudden appearance of the doppelganger or the Keeper of the Threshold can drive to madness those who have not followed all the preparations and taken all the precautions required of the student.

The bearing of the cross, in turn, symbolically refers to a spiritual virtue. This virtue, which consists in carrying the world, as it were, within one's consciousness—just as Atlas carried the world on his

shoulders—could be called: the feeling of becoming one with the earth and with all that it holds within itself. In Eastern initiation, this is called: the end of the sense of separation.

People, especially modern people, generally identify with their bodies. In his Ethics, Spinoza identifies the first fundamental idea of a human being: the idea of the body in action. The student must cultivate within himself the idea that, in the totality of things, his body is no more important than any other body —be it that of an animal, a table, or a piece of marble. The self does not end at the skin: it is one with the whole of life in the world, just as our hand is one with the entirety of our physicality. What would the hand be on its own? A scrap! What would the human body be without the earth on which it stands, without the air it breathes? It would die, for it is only a tiny particle of this earth and its atmosphere. For this reason, the student must immerse himself in every being and become one with the spirit of the earth.

Feeling at one with all beings does not mean despising one's body, but rather carrying it as an external object, just as Christ carried his cross. The spirit should carry the body just as the hand holds the hammer. Then the disciple becomes aware of the occult powers that lie dormant within his body. In this way, during the course of his meditation, he can bring about the stigmata on his skin. This is the sign that he is ready for the fifth stage, where the following is revealed to him in a sudden flash of enlightenment:

Mystical death: While subjected to the greatest suffering, the disciple says to himself: "I realize that the entire sensory world is merely an illusion." He truly feels as if he is dying and sinking into darkness. But then he sees the darkness tear apart and a new light appear: the astral light shines forth. This is the tearing of the veil in the temple. This light has nothing in common with the light of the sun. It bursts forth from beyond things and beyond humanity. The sensation it causes bears no resemblance to that of external light. To get an idea of this, let us use the following comparison: Imagine moving away from a noisy city and entering a dense forest. Gradually, the sounds fade away, and the silence becomes complete. Finally, one begins to perceive what lies beyond the silence—to cross the zero point where every external sound has died away. Sound returns to the inner ear from the other side of life. This is what the experience feels like for the soul as it enters the astral world. It comes into contact with the inner nature of the things it knows—just as one enters a growing sequence of negative numbers beyond zero.

One must have lost everything in order to regain everything, even one's own existence. But at the moment when one loses everything, it seems as though one dies to oneself and begins to live outside of oneself. This is the mystical death. Once one has gone through it, the time has come for:

Burial: At that moment, a person is overcome by the feeling that their own body has become foreign to them and that they are completely one with the planet. They have merged with the Earth and find themselves once again part of the planet's life.

The Resurrection: It is an indescribable feeling that cannot possibly be described except as "in the innermost part of the sanctuary." For at this final stage, all words fail, and every comparison falls short. Having reached this stage, one receives the gift of healing. However, it must be added that the one who receives it also simultaneously receives the opposite ability: to cause illness, for the negative always accompanies the positive. Hence the great responsibility associated with this ability, which can be characterized as follows: the creative word flows from the soul in fire.
GA094

GA094
Today I would like to speak further about Christian initiation and the Earth's interior. It should be noted that Christian initiation was undergone by all those who were to teach Christianity from an occult depth

—for example, the priests of the first Christian centuries. These initiations persisted for a long time but were gradually altered somewhat, and only in certain narrow circles were these rigorous exercises still undertaken. One should not assume that the rigors of these exercises can be expected of everyone; yet whoever submits to them will also attain a high level of knowledge along the Christian path. In this regard, Christ is, as it were, the primordial guru for all Christian disciples on this path. Angelus Silesius once said:

Will Christ be born a thousand times in Bethlehem
And not in you: you will remain lost forever.

Something like this stems from inner experiences. Similarly, in the Gospel of John, it says: “But Jesus went out of the temple.”

This is an astral experience and refers to the astral body stepping out of the physical body. In Christian initiation, the strict guru of the East is replaced by the requirement of Christian humility—submitting not to a single individual, but to Christ Jesus.

The first stage is the washing of the feet. One reaches it by spending months trying to live according to the following ideas: The plant cannot live without the mineral kingdom beneath it. If it could speak, it would have to say: “You, mineral kingdom, you are indeed lower than I, but I owe my higher existence to you.” And when a person looks around at life, he must admit to himself: If I have advanced far in the spiritual realm, it is because others have worked on my behalf. We must therefore bow down in humility and gratitude to those who stand below us. “Whoever wants to be first will be last in the Kingdom of Heaven,” says a passage from the Gospel. This practice ultimately leads to the inner vision of the washing of the feet. Christ washes the apostles’ feet to offer them the tribute of His gratitude. Whoever lives in accordance with these ideas of humility will notice that the image of the washing of the feet appears to them in the form of an astral vision. Through this, what is described in the Gospel of John becomes a personal experience.

Then one can move on to the second stage. The student must absolutely learn to endure all suffering and all obstacles in life with dignity and remain calm, even when everything is crashing down on him. And once again, an image of the flagellation appears in a dream on the astral plane. Not only does the student see the image, but he feels burning pain throughout his entire body, even in his fingernails and hair.

Once this has been achieved, one moves on to the third stage. Here, the student must not only endure pain, but must also be able to calmly accept scorn and ridicule. In a dream experience, the crowning with thorns manifests as a peculiar, temporary headache.

Reaching the fourth stage is very difficult. The initiate must develop a sense that his own body has exactly the same value to him as the things around him; he must learn to regard it as something foreign; he must come to feel: It is not I who go there, but I who carry my body there. The student then no longer lives within his body, but carries it like an object, like the wood of the cross. These exercises lead to the vision in which the student sees himself crucified. And outwardly, this stage of initiation even manifests itself through the appearance of the so-called stigmata. The student then receives, corresponding to the wounds of the crucifixion, actual stigmata at the relevant places on his body, which may appear temporarily. These inner and outer experiences arise after appropriate contemplation.

The fifth stage is the mystical death. Now the student truly becomes clairvoyant on the astral plane. The previous experiences were merely initial symptoms. For a moment, the student experiences a sensation as if everything were disappearing, as if he were facing nothingness. This darkness is the antithesis of the general darkness that fell over the entire land at the time of Christ's death. Then the darkness splits; this represents the tearing of the curtain in the temple and Christ's descent into hell. This, too, is experienced at this stage. Whoever does not advance that far does not yet truly know what evil is. The student of the fifth stage descends into these depths of existence. This is the descent into hell.

At the sixth stage, the burial, he perceives the entire Earth as his body, and his own body as a part of it. He becomes one with the entire Earth. The student is then as if placed within the entire Earth, covered and buried within it; he himself now becomes one with the planetary spirit.

The seventh stage, the Resurrection, cannot be described in further detail, for no soul whose thinking is still bound to the brain can comprehend all that it signifies in terms of greatness and sublimity. When the secret student passes through these seven stages, Christianity comes alive within him. He experiences the Gospel of John as reality.
GA094

GA094
Through Indian yoga training, one reaches the same level of occult development as through the Christian-Gnostic path. Even today, there are people who follow the Christian-Gnostic path. This path is divided into seven stages.

First: The washing of the feet. The student must cultivate a very specific feeling over a long period of time, and this feeling must live within the soul: the law must become clear to him that no one can rise without another being pushed down. For every initiate, there are a certain number of sinners. When one attains greater knowledge and insight, it is therefore his first duty to stoop down and lift the others up. As it is with human beings, so it is in nature. The plant should speak to the earth: "O lifeless earth, in humility—this must be the student's fundamental attitude—I bow down to you, for to you I owe my existence." Christ himself sets an example for us in the washing of the feet, by revealing to us the feeling of innermost humility contained therein. If the student cultivates this feeling within himself, two experiences arise in him: an outer symptom and an inner astral experience. The outer symptom is this: the student has the very distinct sensation of water washing over his feet; he perceives the state of having his feet washed. Innerly, the Christian student experiences the image of this as a real vision.

Second: The scourging. Pain and torment assail a person, seeking to crush him. He must tell himself: You must learn to endure all of this with dignity. Once this has been practiced long enough, two symptoms reappear. The external one: stabbing pains throughout the entire body, as if resulting from a scourging. This is proof that the practice has penetrated into the etheric body. The inner, astral experience is the image of the scourging.

Third: The Crowning with Thorns. The student must learn to endure the scorn and mockery heaped upon his innermost being. Headaches lasting for weeks are the outward symptom of this; inwardly, it is the astral image of one's own crowning with thorns.

Fourth: The Carrying of the Cross and the Crucifixion. One's own body becomes something foreign. It becomes like a piece of wood, like the cross that Christ bore. The personal must disappear completely. The disciple must become free from his body, completely free. Internally, he experiences the image of

the crucifixion; externally, the stigmata appear at the sites of Christ's wounds. The wound in the side appears on the right side of the chest.

Fifth: Mystical death. This is a sublime experience, a very high stage; the experience is extremely significant. The realization dawns: the perception of things was all an illusion. Terrible darkness pours into the room; the whole world sinks into it. One comes to know only one thing: the true form of all evil, of all the torments and sufferings of this world. This is the descent into hell. Once one has gone through this exhaustively, the moment comes when the curtain is torn apart. One now sees a new form of the world; one sees the world from the other side.

Sixth: Burial. Everything in the world becomes, for the disciple, as if it were part of his own body. He becomes one with the earth; the whole earth becomes the body he possesses. One is laid into the earth, and the earth covers one over.

Seventh: Resurrection and Ascension. This ascension cannot be described in human language, and its glory can scarcely be imagined.
GA094

GA095
Now we will discuss, as far as possible, Christian training, and it will become clear how it differs from Eastern training. This Christian training can take place under the guidance of a teacher who knows what needs to be done and who can always correct any mistakes at every step. But the great Guru is Christ Jesus himself. Therefore, a firm faith in the real existence of Christ Jesus and in the fact that he truly lived is necessary. Without this faith, it is impossible to feel connected to him. Furthermore, one must understand that from this great Guru comes a text that itself provides the guidance for this training, and that is the Gospel of John. This can also be experienced inwardly, not merely believed in outwardly; and for those who have truly internalized it, there is no longer any need to prove the existence of Christ Jesus, because they have found Him.

This training involves not merely reading the Gospel of John over and over again, but meditating on it. The Gospel of John begins with the words: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and God was the Word..." These verses, when properly understood, are material for meditation, and they must be absorbed in a state similar to dhyana. Whoever, early in the morning—before other impressions have entered his soul—excludes everything else from his thoughts and lives solely within these sentences for five minutes, and does so continuously, for years, with absolute patience and perseverance, will experience that these words are not merely something one must understand; but will experience that they possess an occult power; indeed, through them one will undergo an inner, occult transformation of the soul. In a certain sense, one becomes clairvoyant through these words, so that one can see astral manifestations of everything written in the Gospel of John.

Following the teacher's instructions, the student first allows the first five sentences of the first chapter to sink into the soul for seven days. The following week, the same is done with the second chapter, and so on with each individual chapter up to the twelfth chapter. You will see what a magnificent, awe-inspiring experience this is: how you are introduced to the events in Palestine, where Jesus Christ lived, as they are recorded in the Akashic Records, and how you then actually experience everything that happened at that time. And then, when you reach the thirteenth chapter, you experience the individual stages of Christian initiation.

The first station is the so-called washing of the feet. First, one must understand what this great scene signifies. Christ Jesus bends down to those who are lower than he is. Throughout the world, this humility toward those who stand below us—and at whose expense we develop to a higher level—should be present. If a plant could think, it would have to thank the stone for providing the soil in which it can lead a higher life, and the animal would have to bow to the plant and say, “I owe my very existence to you”—and so too should human beings toward the rest of nature. And those who stand higher in human society must bow down to those working beneath them and say to themselves: If these diligent hands did not perform the menial work for me, I could not stand where I stand.—No one could develop to a higher level unless the ground beneath him were prepared. And so it is all the way up to Christ Jesus himself, who bends down in humility toward the apostles and says: You are my foundation; in you I fulfill the saying: ‘But whoever wants to be first must be last, and whoever wants to be Lord must be the servant of all.’ The washing of the feet signifies the willingness to serve gladly, the bending down in utter humility. This must become the general sentiment for those developing in the occult.

Once the student has been thoroughly imbued with this humility, he has experienced the first stage of Christian initiation. He recognizes that he is ready by two signs, one external and one internal. The external sign of this is that they feel as if their feet are being washed by water. The internal sign is an astral vision that occurs without fail: they see themselves washing the feet of a number of people. This image appears in their dreams as an astral vision, and everyone has the same vision. When they experience this, they have truly internalized this entire chapter.

Next comes the scourging. Once one has reached this point, one must, while reading about the scourging and allowing its impact to sink in, cultivate a different feeling. One must learn to stand firm in the face of life’s lashes. One tells oneself: I will stand firm in all suffering and pain, in everything that comes my way. —- The outward sign of this is that one feels, as it were, a pain in specific points all over the body. The inner sign is that one sees oneself being scourged in a dream vision.

The third station is the Crowning with Thorns. Another feeling must be added: One learns to endure steadfastly, even when one is showered with scorn and ridicule because of the most sacred thing one possesses. The external symptom of this is that one feels a pressing headache. The internal symptom is: One sees oneself astral-body crowned with the crown of thorns.

Then one can proceed to the fourth station: the Crucifixion. A new, very specific feeling must be cultivated here. It is based on overcoming the notion that one’s own body is the most important thing; it must become as indifferent to one as a piece of wood. We then carry our body through life and view it objectively; it has become for us the wood of the cross. In doing so, one need not despise it, any more than one would any tool. Readiness for this stage is indicated by an external symptom: during meditation, red spots resembling stigmata appear precisely at the places known as the sites of the sacred stigmata—namely, on the hands and feet and on the right side at the level of the heart. The internal symptom is that the student has a vision of hanging on the cross themselves.

The fifth stage is mystical death. It consists in a person experiencing the futility of earthly things, in fact dying to all earthly things for a time.

From this point on, only sparse descriptions of the Christian initiation can be provided. The individual experiences, as an astral vision, that darkness reigns everywhere and that the earthly world has sunk into oblivion. A black veil spreads out like a curtain before what is to come. During this state, the individual comes to know all that is evil and bad in the world. This is the descent into hell, the journey

through hell. Then the individual experiences the curtain being torn asunder, and the devachanic world emerges. This is the tearing of the temple curtain.

This is followed by the sixth stage: burial. Just as in the fourth stage one's own body becomes an object, so here one must develop the feeling that not only is one's own body an object, but that one perceives everything else that surrounds us on Earth as belonging to oneself just as much as one's own body. Thus, one's own body extends beyond the skin. One is no longer a separate being; one is united with the entire planet Earth. The Earth has become our body; one is buried in the Earth.

The seventh stage, the Resurrection, cannot be described in words. Therefore, in occultism, it is said: The seventh state can be conceived only by one whose soul has become completely free from the brain. One could describe it to such a person. That is why it can only be mentioned here. The Christian occult teacher provides guidance on how to experience it.

Once a person has gone through this seventh stage, Christianity has become an inner experience of his soul. He is then completely united with Christ Jesus; Christ Jesus is within him.
GA095

GA097
The Christian way is laid down in a text that is little understood outside occult circles. The gospel of John gives a complete outline of the right way of Christian initiation.

John's gospel is one of the most profound texts in the world, but one has to be able to read it in the right way, that is, one should not think that just reading it is enough and the right thing to do. It is a book for life. Above all you have to understand that even the first words are not written just for people to read or for philosophical speculation. They are written for meditation. We have to have them the proper way, however, not in the usual translation. The first verses of John's gospel must be created out of the substance of the language so that one has not only the meaning of the sentences but also their sound quality. The sound quality or value still matters for genuine occult life.

To meditate, we enter deeply into particular formulas, sentences or even words. But meditation as an important means of inner development is not a matter of entering into something we are given by our occult teacher in a philosophical or intellectual way. It is a matter of entering into the actual sound qualities. If you were to think about a sentence your teacher has given you, you could only develop thoughts about it that you already have. You are, however, to have something new. That is the important point. Sentences given for meditation open up the gates to the world of the spirit for you. They are based on experience gained over hundreds of years. Every letter, every turn of phrase is known to have an effect on the soul. You therefore need to meditate those first sentences to the letter. Correctly translated they are:

In the origin was the word, and the word was with god, and a god was the word.

This was in the origin with god.

All things have come into being through it, and except by this, nothing of what has arisen has come into being.

In it was life, and the life was the light of humanity. And the light shone into the darkness, but the darkness did not grasp it.

There came to be a human being, sent by god, his name John.

He came to bear witness that he might bear witness to the light and that through him all might believe.

He was not the light but a witness of the light.

For the true light that enlightens all human beings was to enter into the world.

It was in the world, and the world came into being through it, but the world did not recognize it.

Into individual human beings (all the way to the I-human beings) it came, but the individual human beings (the I-human beings) did not receive it.

Those however who did receive it were able to reveal themselves through it to be god's children.

Those who put their trust in its name have come into being not out of the blood, not out of the will of the flesh, not out of the will of man, but out of god.

And the word came to be flesh and dwelt among us and we have heard its teaching, the teaching of the one son of the father, full of loving devotion and truth.

If we had more time together I could tell you many things about these first sentences. Hundreds and hundreds of people have gone through the things I am now telling you about this Christian initiation. It has become practical experience for thousands. Let me just briefly indicate some stages of Christian initiation.

The pupils would first of all be told: For weeks, months, years you must set some time aside every morning when you let these first lines of John's gospel come alive in your soul. Turn your attention away from everything that is going on around you during this time. You must turn blind and deaf to everything around you, and these words should arise in your soul as though you were hearing them, day by day, over and over again.

This exercise will first of all have a particular effect on the soul. Its magic brings it about that such a person suddenly finds his dreams becoming regular, assuming regular forms. And then a moment will come when the individual knows that he is not in a dream world. Instead he'll know that he has a new reality around him—imaginative astral reality. Just as in ordinary conscious awareness we see tree and shrub around us, so we now see the things experienced in yonder world. Initially like dream images, and then more and more in a living vision seen in the waking state, the pupil will see the first twelve chapters of John's gospel before him.

After this experience the teacher of Christian initiation will say to his pupil: ‘You must now prepare for the experience of the 13th chapter. Imagine a plant. This grows out of the mineral world. If it were able to think and have inner responses it would have to say to the mineral world: “I grow out of you. You may be a lower world than I am, but I could not possibly live without you.” And it would have to bend down to the mineral world in gratitude and say: “I thank you, stone! I owe to you my whole existence.”’ An animal would have to speak in the same way to the plant. And man would have to bend down to the lower worlds of nature and have the same inner response. And everyone who has advanced

more on the social scale should bend down before those who are below him and say: ‘Without you I could not have life.’

The pupil has to practice giving himself up to this completely and do so for weeks and months. Then two symptoms will arise, which are the same for everyone. He will first of all experience both the external and the inner symptom as a particular fact. He will see himself as the thirteenth, who washes the feet of the twelve. In washing their feet, Christ Jesus sought to make this great truth apparent to the twelve. This wondrous inner experience comes to the human being in the process of initiation. It also goes as far as external symptoms. He will experience something that feels as if he was dipping his feet in water. Nobody needs to be afraid of this; it will soon pass.

When the pupil has gone this far, the teacher will come and say: ‘Now you must enter into another sphere of inner responsiveness. In life pain and suffering come to us from all directions. You must enter into a condition where you meet all the suffering and all the pain that are coming from all directions in this world as an upright human being, so that they cannot harm you. You must stay with these things for weeks and months.’ Then a time comes when an astral symptom shows itself. He'll see himself in a vision of the scourging, with a sensation rather like it felt all over the body, which will pass; but the result will be that the pupil lets this feeling enter into the whole of his body. With this he has reached a level of maturity where he is able to land upright as life plies its scourge.

For the third stage he is given the instruction: ‘You must now enter into an inner feeling of how things would be with you if you not only had to bear pain and suffering but had scorn and derision poured over all that is most sacred to you. You must be able to stand up, using the powers of your inmost soul, and have a centre in you that enables you to stand erect.’ A new vision will then come, where the pupil sees himself wearing the crown of thorns. The external symptom of this is a kind of headache. This indicates, right down into the limbs, that this great experience has come.

Then comes the fourth station. The earthly body must become an outside thing for the pupil. Most people feel it is their I. The body has to be like a piece of wood, something external. The pupil must learn to say not ‘I am walking through this door’, but ‘I carry the body through this door.’ His body must be very much an object to him. Having lived into this for weeks and months, the pupil will have a vision, an astral experience where he sees himself crucified. That is the fourth station. Stigmata will appear for a brief period during meditation as an external symptom on the hands, feet and in the right side—not the left, as is generally thought. They indicate that this degree of development has also entered into the flesh.

The stages that follow cannot be discussed, for we do not have words for them. The fifth stage is the mystic death, where the pupil will first truly have the experience of a black curtain between him and reality. He will feel lost in a way, utterly isolated, as it were, until insight is gained. It is as if the world of the flesh has vanished, and something like an impenetrable black curtain lies before the eye of the soul. This is a moment everyone must go through on this way to initiation. You encounter all the truly great suffering and pain that may rest deep down in the soul, and all the evil there is in the world. This is the descent into hell. Then it seems to the pupil as if the veil tears apart and he looks into the other world.

There follows the entombment, an experience where one feels at one with the planets, and the seventh level, of which we cannot speak, for the individual has to separate his thinking from his brain to have even an inkling of it. This is ascension into heaven.

My aim in giving you this description of Christian initiation was to help you understand what it is about. It is a way full of renunciation. It may be followed quietly, attracting no notice, and there are people among you who have gone through all this. It happens between the lines in life, as it were, and the more serious it is the less will it be visible on the outside.
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In modern theology, clear distinction is made between the first three gospels and the gospel of John. The first three are called the synoptic gospels, whilst the latter is often said to be a composition for teaching purposes and of no historical value. What matters is, however, that everything said relating to the Christ in the gospels is a profound symbol which at the same time is an important historical fact. In reality the first three gospels differ from the gospel of John because they were written by disciples who were less profoundly initiated, whereas the gospel of John was written by the most deeply initiated disciple.

The gospel of John actually makes no direct mention of John, only referring to him as the disciple whom Jesus loved. This is a key word for the one who was most deeply initiated. To indicate that some disciples were the most intimate initiates it would be said that the master loved them.

The disciple who wrote down the gospel of John first of all described something he had himself experienced. Chapters 1 to 12 are experiences in the astral world, chapter 13 and those that follow experiences at the devachanic level. This is highly significant and characteristic of the whole of it. John described experiences on the astral level because he took the view that it is only possible to understand what Christ Jesus accomplished on this earth if one considers it in the light of the spirit. The things the master did and said could only be understood if one put oneself in a higher state of consciousness. Inner development can enable human beings to gain true vision in the astral world. This is only achieved by doing specific meditations. The individual must close himself off from the outside world. He must let eternal truths arise in his soul. A new world then opens up all around him.

John's higher development begins with the 13th chapter. Every word in the gospel of John can be understood if we take it as John's living experience. He then became conscious in his I, and this was no longer an image consciousness. He consciously became the disciple whom the Lord loved.

The experiences John described from the 13th chapter onwards refer to the devachanic level. John indicated this by saying he had been raised from the dead. John was Lazarus raised from the dead. We can understand therefore why it is only now that mention is made of the disciple whom the Lord loved. This is the secret at the centre of the gospel, that the writer was Lazarus raised from the dead.

John then went through experiences with the Christ in the world of the spirit. The second part in particular does not merely tell what has happened on some particular level but describes the things every human being can inwardly experience. The way in which one can inwardly know oneself to be at the level John spoke of is the following. From a certain point in his development the individual no longer feels separate from all things. He enters wholly into the things that are around him. This is to expand one's self into a universe. John felt himself to be part of the whole world around him. This comes to expression in the devachanic image of the washing of the feet.46 John experienced this in the world of the spirit, though it was at the same time also a historical event.

A higher realm of nature always develops at the cost of a lower one. If there were no mineral world, the plant world would not be able to take nourishment from it. The plant world is pushed lower down so

that a yet higher realm, the animal world, may develop, and so on. The human world also depends on the other realms. A more highly developed form needs the one that is less developed. There could be no higher caste if there were not also a lower one. Just as there has to be a mineral world so that the plant world may exist, so did the apostles have to exist for Christ Jesus to be there. No one can be a saint without pushing others lower down. It says in chapter 13, verse 16: ‘The servant is no greater than his lord.’ The Christ has evolved on the basis of the apostles and is therefore able to call them the lords out of whose community he has arisen. He washes their feet to indicate that he is lower than they are in so far as he owes his existence to them. This is something we must all experience in our own bodies. Anyone who has not had this experience has no true perception of the path of Christian mysticism.

Jesus also said: ‘He that eats bread with me has lifted up his heel against me.’ He felt himself to be in the community of the whole earth. He felt that the whole of humanity was resting upon him, that he was under its heel.

Having experienced all this at the devachanic level, John was able to understand the words of the vine and its branches that followed.48 They refer to the community of the whole Christian congregation.

We are now in the fifth root race of our earth existence. This has seven sub-races, the ancient Indian, the ancient Persian, the Egypto-Babylonic-Chaldean, the Graeco-Roman-Semitic, the Germanic, the Slavonic and the seventh sub-race. The last three sub-races of the fourth root race, which was the Atlantean one, were particularly important. From the third from last, the ancient Semitic race, has come the fifth root race. This sub-race dwelt in the region where Ireland is today. It migrated from there, letting itself be guided to the Gobi desert or Shamo. This is the region where the present, the fifth root race originated. Three sub-races of the Atlanteans, seven sub-races of the Aryan root race and two of the sixth root race, belong together in some respect. When humanity has gone through all these races it will have reached a point where a great part of humanity will have achieved what it is meant to achieve.

The twelve apostles are symbols of those twelve sub-races. Jesus has evolved from the twelve apostles. In the washing of the feet he bows before the races to whom he must bring salvation.

In the parable of the vine, the Christ feels himself to be connected with all races; he provides them with the spiritual life blood.

Many different images also come into this in the higher world. We are told of Judas Iscariot's betrayal. He represents one of the races, the race which is now bringing everything down on to the material level, our own fifth sub-race, which is materialistic. In the process of evolution in which humanity first lived in direct spiritual perception and then had to be taken into the physical world it was perfectly natural for the representative of this fifth sub-race to be the betrayer. Judas Iscariot represented the race that descends deeper than any other. The gospel of John continues to be valid beyond space and time for the very reason that it must be seen in symbolic terms. The act of Judas forms an organic part of the Christ's mission. Judas went through a form of martyrdom. He was the traitor and in a sense also a martyr. He brought about the sacrifice of the Christ.

The sequence of parables served to take the apostles up into the inner nature of Christianity. At the Christ's sacrificial death everything that had in earlier times been mystery rite appeared before the world as a historical event. In the mysteries, the pupils went through what here has become the three days of Lazarus' symbolic death. With the Christ this was to appear in the great historical level. From then on a human being was to be redeemed if he believed, without having gained direct vision in the mysteries. Everyone was to have that experience when the spirit of truth came. It would tell of the

element brought into world history with the Christian events. ‘He will proclaim to you the things that are to come.’

John was speaking out of this spirit of truth. The historical betrayal of the Christ was to happen in the future in the race of which Judas was the representative.

The events that follow are exemplary of the Christian mystic's inner experience. Then the Christ was given a slap in the face. This was the second important event after the washing of the feet. It is something everyone must receive who inwardly seeks to go through the life of Christ. It has to be borne with complete inner composure that the people to whom one is giving the best one has, will not acknowledge this. The scourging also follows. In moral terms it means that we bear the pain the world causes us and do so calmly. Together with the slap on the face this is the second stage the Christian mystic must go through.

It is something pupils of Christian mysticism have really and truly been going through since that time. The ability to bear the pain calmly is learned in the pupil's own body. He really gets a feeling as if he is pierced with needles.

The next, third stage is the wearing of the crown of thorns. It is to accept humiliation calmly. It is the human I which is humiliated. The forebrain, which developed during the last period of ancient Atlantis, senses the crown of thorns. Genuinely painful experiences develop in this mystical soul state and have to be overcome.

The fourth stage is the crucifixion. It is a mystical experience which signifies that one's own body has become as foreign to one as an outside object. The human being then bears the burden of the cross. His soul has grown independent. It is only tied to the body the way the body of Christ was nailed to the cross. This is an inner experience for the mystic. He now knows himself to be living in a spiritual body. A blood trial goes hand in hand with this. The wounds of the Christ truly appear on hands and feet when the Christian mystic has gone through this. There is a physical aspect to everything that is of the spirit.

When the human being has reached this point, death on the cross ensues. This is a spiritual experience. Goethe brought it to expression in the following words:

So long as you don't have it,
this word: ‘Die and become!’
you're but a miserable guest
here on this earth.51

Jakob Boehme said: ‘If you don't die before your death comes, you will perish when you die.’52 The Christian mystic must go through the whole of death. Otherwise he cannot enter into a higher life.

The sixth event is the entombment. This is mystic realization of community with the earth organism. The pupil unites with the planet earth, becoming a planetary spirit. Everything around him then becomes his body.

The seventh stage is the higher life, the resurrection, given to man.

These are the seven stages of Christian mystic development: the washing of the feet, the slap on the face and the scourging, the crown of thorns, the crucifixion, death, entombment and resurrection. It is an inner development with external symbols.

John wrote about it in a way that has truly given us a basic work for mystics. The sentences must become the subject of meditation as we read them. This gives us the meditation we need to go through these events. The gospel of John is a book of miracles for it brings about miracles in the soul. It has been written for every human being and everyone can gain inward experience of the gospel of John.
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The gospels exist not only to teach, they are also books of life. The stories told in them are not just external events but inner human experiences. Christian yoga consists in entering wholly into the gospels in a living way, making this the whole life of one's own soul.

Four things are absolutely necessary for Christian yoga to be at all possible. The first is simplicity. This is a Christian virtue. You have to understand that we have many experiences in life that make us lose our lack of bias. Almost every human being is biased. The only unbiased answers to questions come from children. But they are childish, because the children lack knowledge. We must learn to be wise and unbiased in the life of experience, as unbiased as children. This is called simplicity in Christian terms.

The second virtue we have to acquire is that as a Christian mystic we have to rid ourselves of something many people have, and that is inner satisfaction in religious exercises. We must devote ourselves to those exercises not for personal satisfaction but because the training we follow demands it. All pleasure in religious exercises must cease.

The third virtue is even more difficult. It calls for absolute refusal to ascribe anything whatsoever to our own skills and efficiency. Instead we must learn to ascribe it all to the divine power, the merit of God who works through us. Without this you cannot be a Christian mystic.

The fourth virtue to be achieved is patient acceptance of whatever may come upon us. All cares, all fear must be put aside, and we must be prepared to meet what comes, be it good or ill.

If we do not develop these virtues up to a certain level we cannot hope to be Christian mystics. This preparation then enables us to go through the seven stages on the road of the Christian mystic.9

The first stage is the washing of the feet. It is putting the words ‘to be lord you must be the servant of all’10 into practice. We must understand that we do not owe anything we are to our own self. We have to take account of everything other people and the world around us have made of us and reflect on this deeply. We are then able to see that we are connected with the whole of our environment. Having gained strength through the four virtues—simplicity, refusal to feel satisfaction at religious exercises, refusal to ascribe skills to ourselves and patient acceptance of whatever comes—we also gain strength to do the ‘washing of the feet’, as it is called, which is to look in gratitude on everything given to us from outside, everything that has raised us higher, and bow down before it. We must transform everything we feel into nothing but gratitude to those who have given it all to us. And so we must kneel before those because of whom we are, what we are. Christ Jesus knelt before his disciples for without them he could not have been what he had become. Christ Jesus had the disciples as a precondition just as a plant has the mineral world and an animal the plant world as a precondition. He, the Lord, became

the servant of all. If we thus learn to lower ourselves and develop a feeling of profound gratitude, then much that exists by way of outer social form drops away and we can go through the next stage.

To do without strength from outside we must have strength inside. When we have come to be the last, we go to the father. This is called ‘the way to the father’, and we are then intimately bound up with this original strength and power. It can only be found through personal experience. We must learn to bear all pain. That is the second stage, the scourging, the second stage in Christian mysticism. The self then is sustained by itself.

To bear contempt is a yet higher stage, the third stage. One must learn to bear finding no regard among people at all. All the strength one needs must be found in the higher life. That is to wear the crown of thorns. We must learn to stand erect when the world despises us and casts derision on us.

When a person has got to this point his own body has become alien to him. He has lowered himself has learned to bear pain, to bear contempt. Now the body is something he no longer lives in; his soul floats around it. This is the crucifixion, the fourth stage. It is followed by the stage where one's own body has become wholly object, as if one were tied to an alien piece of wood. Then being apart has ceased for us. It is the mystic death on the cross—the fifth stage.

The sixth stage is reached when the human being has become one with all that exists on earth, embracing it all with his feeling, experiencing the whole earth as his body. That is the entombment. The individual has then reached the point known as ‘being at one with the planet’ in initiation science. He then feels himself to be no longer apart. Man can only exist on this earth. A few hundred miles away from it and he must die, shrivel up as a hand shrivels up when it is cut off the body. The earth is then the body of the human being. We must be entombed in it. Through this condition man gains the conscious awareness of the earth. There follows the seventh stage, the resurrection. The individual has become one who is raised from the dead. This condition can only be understood by someone whose thinking no longer depends on the physical brain as its instrument.

Human beings can go through these seven stages by bringing the gospel of John, from the 13th chapter onwards, to life in themselves again and again—the washing of the feet, the path of wanting to serve, bowing down in humility before all; second stage the scourging; third stage the crown of thorns; fourth stage the crucifixion; fifth stage the mystic death on the cross; sixth stage the entombment; seventh stage the resurrection. These are the seven stages of the inner Christian mystery that have been outwardly presented on the plan of world history.

Christian monks lived through these experiences over and over again in the gospel of John, for the whole of their lives. This was the source of the strength they needed.
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The second way is the Christian gnostic one. The main difference here, compared to the one that went before, is that it is not necessary for every individual pupil to have his own guru. This is no longer required because of the existence of a great, sublime individual, Christ Jesus, who is there to be the pupil's goal and to point the way. The way that has to be followed is given in detail in holy writ, in the Bible, above all in the gospel of John. Deep down this does indeed give direct instructions for training as a mystic.

Along this way, the guide is there more to advise than to be an authoritative guru in the usual sense. The guidance concerning initiation is of the highest authority, that of Jesus Christ. John's gospel gives such guidance. It is not a book for study but a book for life in the true sense of the word. The first few sentences of the gospel have special mystic powers and are tremendously important for setting out on this path of initiation. A pupil of the Christian mysteries needs to take a meditative approach to those few sentences, for instance letting them and nothing else live in his soul at a particular time every morning. After some time the profound meaning of these sentences will be clear to him intuitively, and it is only then that the moment has come when one can begin further study of John's gospel so that it will truly bear fruit.

In the course of one's study, the images of the gospel will gradually slip quietly into our dreams, so that we have real inner experience of the events described. This inner experience then continues through all further stages of development which I am not going to describe in detail here and now.

When the pupil has progressed to the washing of the feet, a symbolic act in which one humbly confesses one's dependence and the fact that one has grown and developed on the basis of something lower, at a lower level than our own, certain symptoms will show themselves also externally—a strange feeling of water running by one's feet. The inner symptom relating to this is an imaginative vision of the washing of the feet. In Christian mystic development, the washing of the feet marks the first stage.

The second station is the scourging, which is also something one enters into in one's feelings. It means that in spite of the great and frequent pair and troubles we have to bear in life we will always stand up straight and not grow faint-hearted. Again we have both an outer and an inner symptoms—a strange physical stabbing sensation and the mental image of our own scourging.

Stage three is the crown of thorns. This means that though it is painful to have our most sacred feelings and convictions derided and have scorn poured on them, we must not lose our inner firmness, our equilibrium. Symptoms are headaches, and vision of one's own person wearing the crown of thorns.

Fourthly bearing the cross (crucifixion). Here the pupil is to gain living experience that the body is really an indifferent object compared to the soul and its importance. When we are truly aware of this we'll also be able to use the body merely as an instrument for higher things, and weUl truly control it. Symptoms are the Christ's stigmata appearing as reddened areas on hands and feet. This blood trial only occurs for brief moments during the meditation, however. Inner vision of being crucified oneself.

Fifth, the mystic death. Here the pupil has a strange experience. It is as if the whole world around him is covered by a veil, and he senses the essence that lies behind the veil. When he feels himself thus to be in utter darkness, the veil will suddenly tear and he looks through it into a new, wondrous world. He now learns to judge the depths of the human soul by a completely different standard. This mystic death is like a descent into hell.

The pupil is now someone who has been awakened and can progress to the sixth stage, the entombment. Here he feels the whole outer environment to be his body. His individual nature expands, encompassing the whole world. The body feels itself to be one with the earth, and individual consciousness expands to become earth consciousness.

The seventh stage cannot be described to any degree, for it is beyond all powers of imagination based on the senses. Individuals who have finally come free of this world by unceasing practice may just be able to grasp it in their thoughts. This stage involves entering into perfect divinity and glory, and we do not have the words to describe it.

This Christian way is difficult, for it demands great inner humility and giving up of self. Anyone who has gone through it, however, will have achieved man's goal and dignity. True Christianity will have come to life in him in a very real way.
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The path of Christian gnosis is also in seven stages. This method is designed for a somewhat less subtle body and above all for the world of sentience and feeling. The Christian teacher has to guide the pupil's world of sentience and feeling. The seven stages of Christian initiation are 1) the washing of the feet, 2) the scourging, 3) the crown of thorns, 4) the crucifixion, 5) the mystic death on the cross, 6) the entombment, 7) the ascension to heaven.

It is best to consider these 7 stages by describing the way the teacher works with the pupil. The teacher will say, for instance: ‘Look at the plant. It roots and grows in the world of minerals. Addressing itself to the mineral world it would have to say: “It is to you that I owe my existence, and I am only able to live because of you. Thank you!”’ In the same way the animal should say to the plant world: ‘I owe my existence to you and am only able to live thanks to you.’ Looking at the natural world around him and at the human beings who are at a lower level, a similar feeling should live in his soul. It is never possible to develop and reach a higher level unless there are also lower levels. Because of this, people who are socially at a higher level must also go down to those who are below them and give thanks to them. Christ Jesus suggested this when at the washing of the feet he bent down to his disciples and washed their feet. Someone who is at the first stage of Christian initiation must fill his heart and mind with such a feeling of gratitude to all that is below him. Two symptoms will indicate what he has achieved. He will have an astral vision where he sees himself in the washing of the feet situation. This happens to everyone who goes through this in the right way. Secondly he will have a feeling as if water were washing around his feet.

At the 2nd stage the pupil must learn to bear all the pain and suffering that life brings and which is always present all around him. He must stand up straight, even when he has to suffer the greatest pain. The symptoms will be an astral vision where he sees himself being scourged and he will feel something like needle pricks in different places on his body.

At the 3rd stage the pupil gains the ability to bear it when scorn and derision are poured on things that are most sacred to us. The teacher says to the pupil: ‘If you are able to bear mockery and derision of what is most sacred to you and stand up for it nevertheless, you will be able to wear the crown of thorns.’ The pupil will experience a particular kind of headache when he has reached this level.

At the 4th stage he must learn to consider the body as something wholly external to himself carrying it around the way we carry around an instrument, a hammer or some other tool. In some schools the pupils learn to speak of their body like this: ‘My body goes through the door’—and the like. In his astral vision the pupil then sees himself nailed to the cross. He has Christ's stigmata on his hands and feet and on the right side of the body. Red stigmata appear at the moment of meditation and concentration.

The 5th stage is the mystic death. Here the individual feels as if a veil was placed between him and the rest of the world, like a black curtain. He then comes to know inwardly all the badness there can be in the world. Descent into hell—that is the mystic death. A vision will then show the curtain being torn apart.

At the 6th stage one has a feeling as if everything else were one's own body. You are united with the earth. That is the entombment.

The 7th stage, resurrection, cannot be put into words. Someone who goes through those feelings in his soul gains insight into the world of the spirit.
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We will describe the purely Christian way. It is prescribed as to method in the most profound Christian book least understood by the representatives of Christian theology, the Gospel of St. John, and as to contents, in the Apocalypse or Secret Revelation.

The Gospel of St. John is a miraculous book: one must live it, not merely read it. One can live it if one understands that its utterances are precepts for the inner life, and that one must observe them in the right way. The Christian path demands of its disciple that he considers the St. John Gospel a book of meditation. A fundamental assumption, which is more or less absent in the Rosicrucian training, is that one possesses the most steadfast belief in the personality of Christ Jesus. The pupil must at least find it possible to believe that the most lofty Being, the Leader of the Fire-Spirits of the Sun evolution, was physically incorporated as Jesus of Nazareth; that Christ Jesus was not merely the “Simple Man of Nazareth,” not an individual like Socrates, Plato or Pythagoras. One must see his fundamental difference from all others. If one would undergo a purely Christian training one must be sure that in him lived a God-man of a unique nature, otherwise one has not the right basic feeling that enters the soul and awakens it. Therefore one must have an actual belief in the first words of the beginning of St. John's Gospel: “In the beginning was the Logos and the Logos was with God and a God was the Logos “to the words” And the Logos became flesh and dwelt among us.” Thus the same Spirit who was the ruler of the Fire-Spirits, who was linked with the transforming of the Earth, whom we also call the Spirit of the Earth, has actually dwelt among us in a garment of flesh, he was actually in a physical body. That must be recognised! If one cannot do this then it is better to undertake another method of training. One, however, who has accepted this basic condition and calls before his soul in meditation every morning through weeks and months the Gospel words down to the passage “full of grace and truth,” and moreover in such a way that he not only understands them, but lives within them, will experience them as an awakening force in the soul. For these are not ordinary words, but awakening forces which call forth other forces in the soul. The pupil must only have the patience to bring them before his soul continuously, every day, then they become the forces which the Christian training needs, aroused through the awakening of quite definite feelings. The Christian path is more an inner one, whereas in Rosicrucian training the experiences are kindled by the outer world.

The Christian path is pursued by an awakening of the feelings. There are seven stages of feeling which must be aroused. In addition are other exercises which are only given personally to the pupil, and suited to his special character. It is, however, indispensable to experience the 13th Chapter of St. John's Gospel, so to experience it as I will now describe. The teacher says to the pupil: You must develop quite definite feelings. Imagine the following: the plant grows from the soil, but is of a higher order than the mineral soil from which it grows. Nevertheless the plant needs it, the higher could not exist without the lower, and if the plant could think, it would have to say to the earth: It is true that I am higher than thou, yet without thee I cannot live. And it must incline itself to the earth in gratitude. Likewise must the animal bear itself to the plant, for it could not exist without plant life, and even so must the human being bear himself with regard to the animal. And if man has ascended higher, he must say to himself: I could never stand where I do without the lower. He must bow thankfully before them, for they have made it possible for him to exist. No creature in the world could subsist without the lower, to which it must feel gratitude. So even Christ, the very highest, could not exist without the twelve, and the feeling of his inclination to them in gratitude is powerfully portrayed in this 13th chapter. He, the highest of all, washes his disciples' feet.

If this is thought of in full wakefulness as a basic feeling in the human soul, if the pupil lives for weeks and months in reflection and contemplation which deepen this fundamental feeling—the gratitude with which the higher should look down to the lower to which it really owes its existence, then one awakens

the first basic feeling. The pupil will have entered deeply enough into the experience when certain symptoms appear, an external symptom and an inner vision. The external symptom is that one feels the feet to be laved by water; in an inner vision one sees oneself as the Christ washing the feet of the twelve. This is the first stage, that of the Washing of the Feet. The event in the 13th Chapter of St. John's Gospel is not only an historical event, it can be experienced by all. It is an external symptomatic expression of the fact that the pupil has raised himself thus far in his life of feeling, nor does this sign fail to appear when he has progressed to this point in the enhancement of his feeling-life.

The second stage, the Scourging, is passed through if one deepens oneself in the following: How would it fare with you if the sufferings and blows of life broke in on you from every side? You should stand upright, you should make yourself strong to meet all the sorrows that life offers, and should bear them. This is the second fundamental feeling which must be experienced. The outer feeling of it is an irritation on the whole surface of the body, and a more inner expression is a vision in which one sees oneself scourged, at first in dream, and then in vision.

Then comes the third, which is the Crowning with Thorns. Here week-long, month-long one must live in the feeling: How would it fare with you, if you must not only undergo the sorrows and sufferings of life, but if even the holiest, your spiritual being, should be subjected to scorn and derision? And again, there must be no lamenting, it must be clear to the pupil that he must stand upright in spite of all. His inwardly developed strength must make him able to stand erect despite mockery and scorn. Whatever threatens to overthrow his soul he must stand erect! Then in an inner astral vision he sees himself with the crown of thorns and is sensible of an external pain on the head. This is the sign that he has advanced far enough in his life of feeling to be able to make this experience.

The fourth is the Crucifixion. Here the pupil must again develop a quite definite feeling. Today man identifies his body with his ego. One who would go through the Christian initiation must accustom himself to carry his body through the world as if it were a foreign object, a table, for instance. His body must become foreign to him, he bears it in and out of the doorway as something external, not himself. When a man has advanced far enough in this fundamental feeling, there is revealed to him what is called the “Ordeal of the Blood.” Certain reddenings of the skin appear on certain places in such a way that he can call forth the wounds of Christ, on the hands, the feet and on the right side of the breast. When the pupil by his depth of feeling is able to develop in himself the Blood Ordeal, the external symptom, then appears likewise the inner, the astral, in which he sees himself crucified.

The fifth is the Mystic Death. The pupil raises himself ever higher to the feeling: I belong to the whole world; I am as little an independent being as the finger on my hand. He feels himself embedded in the whole world, as if a part of it. Then he experiences the feeling that all around him grows dark, as if a black darkness envelops him, like a pall that becomes dense around him. During this time, the pupil of the Christian initiation learns to know all the sorrow and all the pain, all the evil and wickedness that attaches itself to mortal man. That is the Descent into Hell; each one must live through it. Then something comes to pass as if the veil were torn asunder, and the pupil sees into the spiritual worlds. This is called the Rending of the Veil.

The sixth is the Burial and Resurrection. When the pupil has advanced so far he must say: I have already accustomed myself to look on my body as something foreign, but now I see everything in the world as standing as near to me as my own body, which indeed is only taken from these substances. Every blossom, every stone, is as near to me as my body. Then the pupil is buried in the earthly planet. This stage is significantly linked with a new life, with the feeling of being united to the deepest Soul of the planet, with the soul of the Christ, who says, “those who eat my bread tread me underfoot.”

The seventh, the Ascension, cannot be described; one must have a soul that is no longer dependent on thinking through the instrument of the brain. In order to be sensible of what the pupil undergoes in what is called the Ascension, it is necessary to have a soul which can live through this feeling.

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In other lectures, I have often described the initial stages through which we ascend to the vision of the Christ-Essence itself. There, the student must live out what is laid out for us in the Gospel of John. Let me briefly outline here, in this context, how a person can develop upward into the spiritual world—where the light of Christ has been kindled since the event at Golgotha—if that person resolves to pass through a certain range of feelings.

The first is that a person says to himself: I am looking at the plant. It grows out of the mineral soil; it grows and blooms. But if the plant could develop consciousness like a human being, it would have to look down at the mineral kingdom, at the mineral earth from which it grows, and say: "You, stone, are a lower being among the beings of nature today than I am, but without you, lower kingdom, I cannot exist!" And likewise, if the animal were to approach the plant and could sense how the plant forms the foundation of its existence, it would have to say to itself: "I, as an animal, am a higher being than you, plant, but without you, plant, I could not exist!" And in humility, the animal would have to bow down to the plant and say: "To you, lower plant, I owe my existence!"—And in the human realm, it would have to be this way: Everyone who has climbed higher on the ladder of existence must look down in a spiritual sense upon those below him and say: "You may indeed belong to a lower world, but just as the plant must bow to the stone and the animal to the plant, so must the human being on a higher level say: 'To you, who are lower, I owe my existence!'"

Then, when a person, over the course of weeks and months—perhaps even years—under the guidance of a suitable teacher, fully immerses himself in such feelings of universal humility, he reaches the point where he understands the meaning of the "washing of the feet." For before him lies a direct spiritual vision of what Christ did when, as the higher being, he bowed down before the Twelve and washed their feet. And the full significance of this event then dawns upon the student as a vision, so that he knows that this event of the washing of the feet actually took place. The path of knowledge leads him to the point where he needs no further proof; rather, he now looks directly into the spiritual world and sees Christ in the scene of the washing of the feet.

Then such a person can be guided by the teacher to have the strength to say: I will steadfastly endure all the suffering and pain that may come my way in this world, and I will not complain. I will steel myself so that such sufferings and pains are no longer pains and sufferings for me, but rather I will know: these are necessities in the world! When the person has then become sufficiently steadfast in soul, the feeling of "scourging" springs forth from this observation within his soul, and the person spiritually feels the scourging within himself. But this opens their spiritual eye, enabling them to behold for themselves the scourging as it is described in the Gospel of John.

Then a person is guided to develop that strength which is one level higher, where he is not merely able to endure the suffering and pain of the entire world, but can say to himself: I have something most sacred for which I devote my entire being. Let the whole world shower me with scorn and mockery—this is my most sacred cause. Scorn and mockery from all sides will not deter me from this most sacred cause, even if I stand alone. I stand up for it! There, within himself, a person spiritually experiences the "Crowning with Thorns." And without any historical document, his mind's eye conveys to him the scene in the Gospel of John that is described as the Crowning with Thorns.

And when, under appropriate guidance, a person comes to view his physical existence in a completely different way than he did before—when he learns to regard his own body as something he wears on the outside; when it has become a natural feeling and a natural sensation for him to say: "I carry my physical body through the world like an external tool!"—then they have reached the fourth stage of Christian initiation, known as "bearing the cross." This does not mean they have become weak ascetics; rather, we learn to handle what we have as a physical instrument much more effectively than

before. When you have learned to regard the body as something you carry, then you have reached the fourth stage of Christian initiation, which is called “bearing the cross.” And then you gain the insight to spiritually behold that scene in which Christ carries his cross on his back, just as you have learned, through your heightened soul power, to carry your body as if it were a piece of wood.

But then something occurs that can be regarded as a fifth stage of Christian initiation, what is called the “mystical death.” Through our inner maturation, everything around us—the entire physical, sensory world—appears to us as if it had been wiped out. Darkness surrounds us. And then a moment occurs as if this darkness were torn apart in the middle like a curtain, and we see beyond this physical world, into the spiritual world. During this moment, however, something else occurs. We have now come to know everything that is sin and evil in its true form; that is to say, at this stage we have come to know what the “descent into hell” is.

And then we learn not only to regard our body as something foreign, but also to view everything else as belonging to us just as much as our body—to regard everything on earth as belonging to us, just as was once done in ancient clairvoyance. And we also learn to regard the sufferings of other people as belonging to us, as part of a great organism. Then, however, we are united with the earth to the extent that we recognize this. Then we experience “being laid into the earth,” the “burial.” And by being united with the earth, we have also risen from it. For in this way we have tasted what it means: The earth is becoming a new sun!

Through this fourth, fifth, and sixth degree of Christian initiation, however, we have attained what enables us to see the event of Golgotha with our own eyes, to immerse ourselves in the event of Golgotha. We no longer need a certificate. The certificate served to guide us up the rungs.

Then comes the seventh stage, which is called the “Ascension”—in other words, the revival in the spiritual world. This is the stage of which it is rightly said that it cannot be expressed with a word taken from our language, that it can be imagined only by those who have become capable of thinking without the instrument of the brain. The wonders of the Resurrection can be conceived only by those who no longer depend on the instrument of the physical brain for their thinking.
GA112

GA103
This method of initiation works exclusively with feelings; specifically, I will describe to you seven emotional experiences—seven stages of feeling—which, when lived through, truly influence the astral body in such a way that it develops its organs during the night. Let us consider how the Christian disciple must live in order to pass through these stages.

The first stage is what is called the “foot-washing.” Here, the teacher tells the student: Look at the plant. It is rooted in the soil; the mineral soil is a lower being than the plant. If the plant could reflect on its nature, it would have to say to the soil: ‘Though I am the higher being, without you I could not exist; for it is from you, the soil, that I draw most of my nourishment.’ And if the plant could translate this into feelings, it would have to bow down to the stone and say: ‘To you I bow, you lower being, stone, for I owe my existence to you.’ — — And if we ascend to the animal, the animal would likewise have to relate to the plant and say: “Although I am higher than the plant, I owe my existence to the lower kingdom.” — And if we continue ascending in this way and come to the human being, then everyone who stands somewhat higher on the social ladder would have to bow down to the lower level and say: “I owe my existence to the lower level!” — And so it continues upward all the way to Christ Jesus. The Twelve who surround him are one level lower than he is; but just as the plant develops out of the stone, so Christ Jesus grows out of the Twelve. He bends down toward the Twelve and says: “I owe my existence to you.”

Once the teacher had explained this to the student, he told him: “For weeks on end, you must surrender yourself to this cosmic feeling—just as the higher must bow to the lower; and once you have thoroughly developed this within yourself, you will experience an inner and an outer symptom.” — But these are not the essential point; they merely indicate that the person in question has practiced sufficiently. When the physical body had been sufficiently influenced by the soul, this manifested to him in the external symptom of a sensation as if water were washing over his feet. This is a very real sensation. And another real sensation is that, in a powerful vision in the astral realm, they see before them the washing of the feet—the bending down of the higher self toward the lower self. There, in the astral realm, the person experiences what is described as a historical fact in the Gospel of John.

The second step involves telling the student: You must develop yet another feeling within yourself. You must imagine what it would be like if all the pain and suffering in the world were to come at you—feel what it would be like if you were exposed to the onslaught of every possible obstacle—and you must put yourself in the mindset that you must stand tall, even if all the misery in the world were to come at you! Then, once the student has practiced this sufficiently, two symptoms arise again: one is a feeling as if he were being struck from all sides, and the second is that he sees the “flagellation” before him in an astral vision. — I am recounting something that hundreds of people have experienced, through which they have attained the ability to ascend into the spiritual worlds.

Third, the student had to imagine that the most sacred thing he possesses—the thing he defends with his whole being—is being showered with scorn and derision. He had to tell himself: “No matter what may come, I must stand firm and defend what is sacred to me!” — Once he had become accustomed to this, he felt something like stinging sensations in his head, and he experienced the “Crowning with Thorns” as an astral vision. Again, it must be said: It is not the symptoms that matter, but they occur as a consequence of the exercises. And care is also taken to ensure that there can be no question of suggestion or autosuggestion.

The fourth point is that the student’s own body must become as foreign to him, in his perception, as an external object—for example, a piece of wood—and that he must not refer to his body as “I.” This must become such a feeling for him that he says: I carry my body around with me, just as I carry my coat around with me! He no longer associates his “I” with his body. Then something occurs that is called the “blood test.” What in many cases can be a pathological condition is, in this case—because everything pathological must be eliminated—a consequence of the meditation. So-called bloodstains appear on the feet, hands, and right side of the chest; and as an inner symptom, he sees the “crucifixion” in an astral vision.

We can only briefly describe the fifth, sixth, and seventh levels of emotion.

The fifth stage consists of what is called the “mystical death.” Through the feelings that the student is led to experience at this stage, he experiences something that appears to him as if, in an instant, a black curtain were drawn over everything physically visible and as if everything were vanishing. This moment is significant for another reason as well—something one must experience if one truly wishes to attain Christian initiation in the truest sense of the word. One then experiences the ability to plunge down into the very depths of evil, pain, sorrow, and suffering. And one can fully experience all the evil that dwells at the bottom of the human soul when one descends into hell. This is the “descent into hell.” Once one has experienced this, it is as if the black curtain were torn apart —and one sees into the spiritual world.

The sixth is what is called the “Burial and Resurrection.” This is the stage where the student feels at one with the entire earthly body; he feels as if he were placed within and is one with the entire Earth. His life has expanded into planetary life.

The seventh sensation cannot be described in words. Only someone capable of thinking without the physical brain as an instrument could describe it; and there is no language for that, because our language has terms only for the physical plane. Therefore, one can only point to this level. It transcends everything else that human beings can otherwise conceive of. It is called the "Ascension" or complete absorption into the spiritual world.
GA103

GA284
Unter den verschiedenen Arten der Einweihung brauchen wir nur die drei hervorragendsten zu erwähnen. Man weiß, worum es sich handelt, wenn man den Jogaweg, den christlich-gnostischen Weg und den Rosenkreuzerpfad erwähnt. Den Jogaweg kennen Sie alle aus der Literatur. Der christlich-gnostische Weg ist der, der in der christlichen Esoterik gelehrt worden ist - in der ersten Zeit, wo das Christentum verbreitet worden ist - durch Dionjsius Areopagita. Die Gelehrsamkeit redet von ihm wie von einem Pseudo-Dionysius, der im 6. Jahrhundert gelebt und alle großen Bücher geschrieben haben soll. Die christliche Tradition weist das in die Zeit des Apostels Paulus zurück. Die Gelehrsamkeit fragt nur: Wann wurden diese Papierrollen geschrieben?, aber die christliche Esoterik weiß, daß dieser Dionysius Areopagita ein Schüler des Apostels Paulus war und von seinem Meister besonders beauftragt war, die esoterische Schule des Christentums zu begründen. Für unzählige Menschen ist diese chrisdiche Esoterik Wahrheit geworden. Heute kann man sich kaum eine Vorstellung machen von den Quellen, aus denen manches Wort eines christlichen Lehrers zu uns kam. Diese Quelle war die christliche Initiation. Diese christliche Initiation schaut heute für den, der materialistisch denkt, wie ein Phantasiegebilde aus. Direktes, unmittelbares Leben aber war sie für den damaligen Menschen. Wir unterscheiden darin sieben Stufen, welche jeder, der die christliche Initiation erreichen wollte, durchmachen mußte. Nur die sieben Namen dafür lassen Sie mich nennen:

1. die Fußwaschung
2. die Geißelung
3. die Dornenkrönung
4. die Kreuzigung
5. der mystische Tod
6. die Grablegung und Auferstehung
7. die Himmelfahrt der Seele.

Das sind die sieben wahren Stufen, die durchgemacht werden mußten in den Lehrstätten, wo die christliche Initiation zu Hause war. Wenigstens zwei dieser Stationen, die erste und die vierte, will ich Ihnen zum Verständnis charakterisieren.

Wenn der christliche Zögling so weit war, daß das, was man im gewöhnlichen Leben Moral nennt, geläutert und schon zu einer höheren Stufe erhoben war, wenn man es als selbstverständlich bei ihm finden konnte, daß er nicht mehr abirren würde von dieser höheren Moral, dann wurde er von seinem Meister der christlichen Initiation empfangen, und er sollte nun etwas in sich durchleben, das ich Ihnen nur in der Form eines Dialoges schildern kann, obwohl sich das nie in einem Dialog abgespielt hat.

Nachdem der Schüler so in Zucht genommen worden war, wurde ihm von dem Lehrer gesagt:

Sieh dir einmal die Pflanzenwelt an. Sie sproßt auf dem mineralischen Reich. Wäre das Mineralreich nicht, die Pflanze könnte nicht gedeihen, obwohl sie auf höherer Stufe steht. Könnte die Pflanze denken, so müßte sie sagen: Du stehst zwar in der Reihe der Naturreiche tiefer als ich, aber ich könnte ohne dich nicht sein. In Demut neige ich mich vor dir! - Und dann wurde der Schüler dazu geführt, diese Demut bei allen Naturreichen zu erkennen. Das Tier müßte sich zur Pflanze und der Mensch sich wiederum zum Tier in Demut herunterneigen und sagen: Ohne euch könnte ich nicht sein! Und der Mensch, der auf einer höheren Stufe steht, müßte sich in Demut neigen vor denen, die noch nicht so weit sind; denn keiner kann höher stehen ohne die anderen. Versteht der Mensch diese Stufenleiter, so

blickt er in Demut hinunter zu den Niederstehenden. Dadurch lernte der Schüler begreifen, was es heißt im dreizehnten Kapitel des Johannes-Evangeliums, daß der Höchste, obwohl die zwölf niedriger sind als er, sich vor ihnen in Demut beugt und ihnen die Füße wäscht. - Wer so [zur höheren Moral] herauferzogen ist im Sinne des esoterischen Christentums, der versteht erst das Innere des Johannes-Evangeliums. Das Johannes-Evangelium ist ein Initiationsbuch über die Methoden der Einweihung, die Apokalypse über den Inhalt der Einweihung.

Wenn der Schüler so weit war, daß ihm diese Demut selbstverständlich geworden war, dann wurde das dreizehnte Kapitel des Johannes-EvangeHums für seine Seele zur Wahrheit. Dann konnte ihn der Lehrer dahin bringen, daß ganz bestimmte Gefühle auftraten. Der Schüler konnte fühlen und erkennen, daß er jetzt die Möglichkeit habe, zu einer höheren Stufe aufzusteigen. Er fühlte - und das war eine gemeinsame Empfindung aller, welche die christliche Initiation empfangen hatten -, wie wenn seine Füße im Wasser ständen, wie wenn die Geisteswasser an ihn heranschlügen. Und das innere Symptom, das als ein Bild jedesmal auftrat, war, daß der Schüler, wenn er so weit war, ganz von innen heraus, durch eine innere Kraft, das Bild vor sich hatte, welches das dreizehnte Kapitel des Johannes-Evangeliums anführt. Das ist nicht bloß ein äußerlich-historisches, sondern ein geistiges Bild, das ein jeder haben kann: auf dem astralen Plan sieht er vor sich ausgebreitet das Bild der Fußwaschung.

Nur um uns zu verständigen, will ich die vierte Stufe - die Kreuzigung - auch noch anführen. Wenn die dritte Stufe vorüber war, wurde dem Schüler klargemacht, daß er seinen Körper nicht mehr zu sich zu rechnen hat. Er mußte seinen Körper empfinden wie einen Gegenstand, wie etwas außer sich selbst. Der gewöhnliche Mensch meint, sein Körper sei sein Ich. Wer die vierte Stufe der christlichen Initiation erreichen will, muß es aber dahin bringen, daß sein Körper ihm nicht wertvoller ist als irgendein Stuhl oder Tisch um ihn herum. Der gewöhnliche Mensch sagt: Ich gehe zur Türe hinein. Dem Initiierten aber ist es selbstverständlich zu sagen: Ich trage meinen Körper zur Tür hinein. - Dann treten wiederum zwei Symptome auf: Das willkürliche Hervorbringen der sogenannten Blutsprobe ist der symptomatische Ausdruck für die vierte Initiationsstufe. Genau an den Stellen seines Körpers, die man die Wundmale nennt, ist er imstande, die Rötung seiner Haut durch die innere Kraft seiner Spiritualität hervorzubringen. An den Handflächen, an den Füßen und an der rechten Seite der Brust treten die Wundmale auf. Dies wird begleitet von dem inneren Symptom, daß der Schüler auf dem astralen Plan sich selber als am Kreuz befindlich schaut.

Man spreche nicht von Gefahren dieser Entwickelung. Worauf es dabei ankommt, ist der Grad der inneren Entwickelung, und dann spricht man nicht mehr von Gefahren dabei. Wer das aber ohne den Rat eines Lehrers machen will, der ist gewiß in Gefahr dabei. Wer aber geduldig, demütig sich der Führerschaft überläßt, wird nur dadurch, daß er seine Märtyrerschaft durchmacht, ein desto dienstbareres Glied der menschlichen Entwickelung sein. Allerdings soll er das nicht eher auf sich nehmen, als bis er die Verpflichtung dazu in sich fühlt.

Es war die christliche Initiation auch die Grundlage und Quelle des äußeren christlichen Lebens. Diese christliche Initiation mußte in die etwas andere Form der Rosenkreuzereinweihung übergeleitet werden etwa zwei Jahrhunderte vor dem Herabstieg des Geistes auf den materiellen Plan.
GA284

The Christian-Rosicrucian Path.

GA094
Today we will focus on the initiation stages of the so-called Rosicrucian, Western occult training. Nothing stated here is to be understood as general rules for life, but can only serve as the task of one who voluntarily submits to this training and thereby initially sets himself apart from the general populace, so that he may later pass on what he has attained. Once he has decided to become a student,

there should be no further possibility for him to criticize this training, the nature of its guidelines, or the conduct of the occult teacher. He must place his trust in the teacher's experience. If this is not possible for him, and if he harbors even a trace of distrust or dissatisfaction toward his teacher, then it is better to sever the bond between himself and the teacher. For only an affection based on trust and recognizing the teacher's authority can establish the proper relationship between the student and the teacher—a relationship that is meant to be beneficial to the student. The student retains the free will at all times to abandon occult training. However, if one wishes to undergo it, one must also be clear that the relevant rules are given based on a firmly established truth in the spirit of the most advanced individualities—those whom we must regard as the great teachers of humanity—and that one can make progress only by following the rules. One must also be clear that this path, with its instructions, has already been tested and successfully followed by many hundreds of people.

Since the Rosicrucian path identifies study as its first stage, one might think that this training is not for everyone. However, that is not correct; it is available to everyone, even the simplest of people. For this study refers to popular theosophy—everything you hear and read here in these lectures and in my writings or those of other spiritual scientists; that in itself constitutes such a study. It is the elementary occult teaching given to humankind. Through it, he is to become free from the prejudices of life, from the suggestion of science, which completely dominates modern man and has already caused much harm, blocking his unbiased view of the outside world—the path to freedom from prejudice that he must find in order to form a clear judgment. In the West, free thinking is no longer the norm; instead, everything is suggestion—dogma established through power and authority. This suggestive influence extends even into the simplest concepts: the suggestion from scholars, the suggestion from science, and the suggestion that emanates from the individual. Our modern life is dominated by the family and by the relationship between the sexes. The Theosophist, however, should delve deeper into preparatory, logical thinking free from sensuality. He should immerse himself in such lines of thought as much as possible. To this end—to cultivate such a way of thinking—I wrote the two treatises Truth and Science and Philosophy of Freedom, so that one might immerse oneself in such trains of thought. What matters here is not so much understanding the content in question as living within these trains of thought. Free, sharp, rational thinking is necessary because it grants the student a certain degree of independence, but this thinking is also a sure guide to the higher worlds. New and different things confront us in the various worlds; but what remains the same in all worlds is thinking. Everywhere there are different perceptions, different experiences, but logic is the same in all worlds. This changes only on the budhi plane. A remarkable transformation now takes place in the student. His thoughts expand, encompassing other spheres of existence. The thoughts that a person usually forms here are not mental in nature; they relate only to the physical plane. They are merely shadows of mental reality. Now he is approaching that reality.

After study comes, secondly, the imagination. Everyone must go through this stage at some point. Human beings gradually free themselves from the dry, sensory perception of things. They try to see in them only the expression of something that lies behind them and begin to view the world in the Goethean sense, according to the words: "Everything transitory is but a parable." The student must systematically cultivate this deeper way of thinking. Things must become parables and symbols to him. When we look at a rose, it is for us the symbol of a certain form of beauty; the autumn crocus, the image of a subtle, melancholic self-containment.

And so every thing has an underlying meaning. For in reality, things are parables. The entire sensory world is an illusion; the spiritual world is the reality. There must be—and we must strive to achieve—an interaction between human beings and the spiritual world. We must keep our mental images and our inner life fluid; we must not form rigid shapes. It has already been pointed out in Lucifer-Gnosis that

through sustained, loving contemplation, the qualities are released from things and then flood and flow through space. For example, something like a flame seems to rise from a plant; behind this lies the spiritual. Human beings must now find their way within these flowing, surging sensations of color and taste, which have no counterpart here on the physical plane; only then are they ready for instruction in the occult scriptures to begin.

Third, we must learn to read the occult script. This helps us to correctly string together the manifold phenomena like pearls on a string. The occult script is not arbitrarily devised, but represents the currents that flow through the world. Something that plays a major role in spiritual reality is two spirals rolled into one another, forming a vortex. At the root of the nose lies the seed of the two-petaled lotus flower, which will develop in the future into a higher organ of perception. The sign of the vortex also corresponds to this ethereal organ. It resembles the sign of Cancer, in which the Sun stood at the dawn of the Atlantean race. We still have this and the other signs of the constellations in the calendar. A very important occult symbol is the caduceus with the serpent. It is the archetype of the consonant S. Anyone familiar with occult writing can evoke the relevant symbols as thought-forms; in certain cases, they then have power over others. In the Gospel of John 8:3–11, the story of Christ and the woman caught in adultery is recounted: Christ wrote symbols of the occult script on the ground with his finger to generate the correct thought-forms among the accusing crowd and to prompt them to perform the action that was right at that moment. “Let him who is without sin cast the first stone at her.” He entrusts her guilt to karma, the balancing justice. Christ meant to say: every deed carries its own reward. “Go and sin no more.” Moses receives instruction in seeing these occult signs during his conversation with God (Exodus 3 and 4). There, Moses becomes acquainted with the occult script and is endowed with the power that enables him to fulfill his mission. The fact that he had to throw down a staff that turned into a serpent signifies that he learned the occult script.

If we imagine a vortex and picture its two parts as red and blue, hold on to this image, and apply it to our own heart or to someone else’s, we can see the two ethereal currents that underlie the red and blue blood.

A fourth is the rhythm of life. All higher life is based on it. Nature and the cosmos are governed entirely by rhythmic laws. The orbits of the stars, every flower, even the innermost life of animals—all follow an exact rhythm. Could you imagine a violet blooming in August instead of March? Rhythm is present everywhere in nature. But the closer we get to human beings, the more that rhythm turns into chaos. The weekly schedule of our schoolchildren is a true blessing. Human beings should establish a certain rhythm for themselves, creating a new cosmos. This is achieved through daily repetitive actions, meditations at a specific time of day, and also through regulating the breathing process.



The fifth is the correspondence between the macrocosm and the microcosm. When a person finds within himself something that corresponds to a fact in the macrocosm, only then does he truly come to know himself. How can a person know when the Sun separated from the Earth? They can discover this by delving into the innermost part of their eye. Another significant moment is when a person began to say “I” to themselves. This occurred in Atlantis, during the time of the Proto-Semites, when a specific point in the physical head aligned with another in the etheric head. The Earth was still shrouded in dense mist, and certain conditions outside and within the human being corresponded with one another. An important exercise consists of the student concentrating on a specific point between the eyebrows while surrendering to an image given to him by his teacher.

At a sixth stage, that of contemplation, the student steps outside of himself and expands his consciousness to encompass the entire world. The Higher Self is outside of us; we must seek it in all beings, for we are everything. It also speaks through Jupiter and Venus. There are theosophists who wish to seek the Divine only within themselves. In truth, however, it is the lower personality that speaks through them. One such person once went about saying repeatedly, “I am Atman, I am Atman.” That was also the only thing he knew. Brooding within oneself leads nowhere. We are everything, and we must immerse ourselves in all beings. Immersion in one’s own inner self is merely a detour toward that end.

When one has reached the point where one can empathize with all beings, one has arrived at the seventh level: divinity. The entire essence of the world takes on a spiritual character. Everything a person sees around them becomes an expression of something higher. Just as tears are not merely salty drops of a certain chemical composition, but an expression of soul experience, so too is the Earth’s vegetation an expression of the Earth soul, which is a reality. Some flowers appear to us as joyfully gazing eyes, others as tears of the Earth Spirit, which weeps over the great sadness that reigns in the cosmos. It is true what Goethe has the Earth Spirit say:

In the torrents of life, in the storm of deeds
I surge back and forth,
Weaving to and fro
Birth and grave,
An eternal sea,
A shifting weave,
A blazing life:
Thus, at the whirring loom of time,
I weave a living garment for the Deity.

This is how we came to know the framework of Rosicrucian training
GA094

GA095
The essence of Rosicrucian training can be described as true self-knowledge. To achieve this, one must distinguish between two things; and as a Rosicrucian student, one must not merely distinguish between them in theory, but also in practice—that is, apply them to one’s daily life. There are two kinds of self-knowledge: lower self-knowledge—which the Rosicrucian student calls “self-reflection”—through which one is to overcome the lower self; and higher self-knowledge, born of self-renunciation.

What, then, is lower self-knowledge? It is the knowledge of our everyday self—of what we already are, of what we carry within us—as they say, a glimpse into our own inner life. One must realize, however, that this alone cannot lead to the higher self, for when a person looks within, they find only what they are; yet it is precisely this that they must transcend in order to overcome the self of ordinary life. But how? Most people are convinced that their own qualities are the very best, and they find those who do not share them unappealing. Anyone who has moved beyond this view—not just in theory, but in their feelings—is already on the path to true self-knowledge. One can move beyond this self-reflection through a specific method that can always be applied whenever one finds five minutes of time. One must start from the following principle: All the qualities you possess are one-sided; you must recognize in what ways your traits are one-sided, and you must seek to harmonize them. — This is a principle that is most suitable not only in theory but also in practice. Anyone who is diligent must examine whether they are being so in the wrong area. Quickness is also one-sided; I must complement it with careful deliberation. Every quality has its opposite; one must acquire it and then seek to

harmonize the contrasting qualities—for example: haste with deliberation, being quick yet thoughtful, being thoughtful yet not sluggish. Then one begins to work beyond oneself. This is not part of meditation; it must be achieved separately.

This harmonization consists, in particular, of paying attention to small details. For example, someone who has a tendency not to let others finish speaking must pay close attention to this and resolve for a period of six weeks: From now on, you will remain completely silent in the presence of others for as long as possible. — Then one should get into the habit of speaking neither too loudly nor too softly. Such things, which people usually do not even consider, are part of this intimate inner self-development, and the more insignificant the traits one addresses, the better. If one manages not only to acquire certain moral, intellectual, or emotional qualities but also to break any external habit, this is particularly effective. It is less a matter of exploring one's inner self in the ordinary sense than of perfecting the qualities one has not yet sufficiently developed, and of supplementing what one already possesses with an opposing quality. Self-knowledge is one of the most difficult things for a person, and it is precisely those who believe they know themselves best who are most easily deceived. They think too much about themselves. The constant fixation on oneself and the constant use of the word "I"—I think, I believe, I consider this to be right—one should break this habit even in one's way of speaking. Above all, one must rid oneself of the notion that one's own opinion matters more than that of other people. Let's take, for example, a very intelligent person. If he displays his intelligence in a group of people who are at a much lower level, it is very out of place: after all, he is displaying it only for his own sake. He should, however, act in accordance with the spirit of the others. Agitators, in particular, violate this rule very easily.

To this must be added what is known in occult terms as patience. Most people who want to achieve something cannot wait because they believe they are already ready to receive everything. This patience stems from strict self-discipline. This, too, is connected with self-knowledge.

Higher self-knowledge begins only when we start to say: Our higher self does not lie at all in what constitutes our everyday self. It is found throughout the entire world outside—up among the stars, in the sun and the moon, in stone, in animals: everywhere is the same essence that is within us. —When someone says, "I want to cultivate my higher self and withdraw; I want nothing to do with anything material," they completely fail to recognize that it is precisely this Self that is everywhere outside, and that their own higher self is only a small part of this great Self out there. Certain "spiritual" healing methods make this mistake, which can be very disastrous; they instill in the sick person the idea that nothing material exists, and thus there are no illnesses either. This is based on a false self-understanding and is, as already noted, very dangerous. While such a healing method bears a Christian name, it is actually anti-Christian.

Christianity is a worldview that sees a revelation of the Divine in everything. In every material thing, we are under an illusion if we do not regard it as an expression of the Divine. If we deny the external world, we deny the Divine; if we negate the matter in which God has revealed Himself, then we negate God. It is not a matter of looking within ourselves, but rather we must seek to recognize the Great Self that shines within us. The lower self says: I am standing here and freezing. — The higher self, on the other hand, says: I am also the cold, for I live as the one Self in the cold and make myself cold. — The lower self says: I am here; I am in the eye that sees the sun. — The higher self, on the other hand, says: I am in the sun and see into your eyes through the sunbeam.

To truly step outside of oneself means self-renunciation. Therefore, the Rosicrucian training is aimed at bringing the lower self out of the human being. In the Theosophical Movement, the very worst mistake was made at the outset by saying: "One must turn away from the external and look within oneself." — That is a great illusion. One finds only one's lower self, the fourth principle, the lower "I," which imagines itself to be divine but is not divine at all. One must step outside oneself to recognize the divine. "Know thyself" also means "overcome thyself."

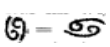
The areas covered by Rosicrucian training are as follows, and they must go hand in hand with the development of the six qualities already mentioned: control of thought, initiative in action, serenity, impartiality or positivity, faith, and inner balance.

The training itself consists of the following:

1. Study. Without study, today's European cannot come to understand things for himself. He must first try to bring forth within himself the thoughts of all humanity. He must learn to think in terms of the world system. He must tell himself: If others have thought this, then it must be human, and I want to try and see how one can live with it. - One need not swear to it as if it were a dogma, but one must get to know it through study. The student must learn about the evolution of the suns and planets, the Earth, and humanity. These ideas, handed down to us for study, purify our spirit. Clinging to these rigorous lines of thought, we climb our way up to forming strictly logical thoughts ourselves. This study, in turn, purifies our thoughts, so that we learn to think strictly logically. When we study a very difficult book, for example, it matters less to grasp the content than to follow the author's train of thought and learn to think along with him. That is why one must not consider a book too difficult; that would simply mean one is too lazy to think. The best books are precisely those that one must study over and over again, those that one does not understand right away, those that one must think through sentence by sentence. In study, it is not so much the "what" that matters as the "how." Through the great truths —such as the laws of the planets—we develop broad lines of thought, and that is the essence of the matter. There is also a great deal of selfishness involved when someone says, "I want more moral teachings and none about planetary systems." — True wisdom leads to a moral life.

2. The second is imagination, the acquisition of imaginative insight. What is it, and how does one attain it? One arrives at it in the following way: One walks through the world and observes it strictly according to Goethe's principle, "Everything transitory is but a parable." For Goethe was a Rosicrucian, and he can introduce us to the life of the soul. Every thing must become a parable in multiple ways. Let's suppose I walk past a fall crocus: through its shape and color, it is a symbol of mourning to me. Another flower, the windflower, is a symbol of need; a red flower that boldly raises its petals upward can be a sign of cheerfulness to me, and so on. A brightly colored animal can be a metaphor for coquetry. Often the metaphors are already expressed in the names themselves—for example, weeping willow, forget-me-not, and so on. The more one thinks in this way—that external things become symbols of moral qualities—the more easily one can rise to this imaginative insight. Such allegories can also be found in people. For example, one can study a person's temperament by observing their gait. Just observe the dragging, slow stride of the melancholic, the firm, determined stride of the choleric, and the light, almost tiptoeing stride of the sanguine.

Once you have practiced this for a while, you move on to the exercises for actual imagination. For example, you hold up a natural plant, look at it closely, immerse yourself completely in it, draw forth the innermost part of your soul, and place it, so to speak, into the plant, as described in my essays "How Does One Attain Knowledge of the Higher Worlds?" This brings about imagination. Through this, one attains astral vision. After some time, one actually notices a small flame emerging from the plant; this is the astral significance of what is growing. Another example: One places a seed in front of oneself and then sees the entire plant—as it will actually be later on—appear in one's mind's eye. These are exercises for imagination to which the Rosicrucians devote a great deal of attention.



3. The third is what is called the study of occult script. For there is indeed an occult script through which one can penetrate more deeply into things. Let me give you an example so that you can see what I actually mean: With the downfall of ancient Atlantis, a new culture—the ancient Indian culture—began. The symbol of such a stage of development—where one cultural epoch ends and another begins —is the vortex. Such vortices also exist in nature: stellar nebulae, such as the Orion Nebula, for

example, and so on. There, too, one world perishes, and a new one emerges. At the dawn of the ancient Indian culture, the Sun was in Cancer; during the Persian culture, the Sun was in Gemini; during the Egyptian culture, in Taurus; and during the Greco-Roman culture, in Aries. Since Cancer is the astronomical sign, it was also the sign marking the dawn of the ancient Indian culture.

Another example is the letter M. Every letter has an occult origin. Thus, M is the sign of wisdom. It originated from the shape of the upper lip and is also the symbol for ocean waves; therefore, wisdom is symbolized by water. These signs always allude to meaningful things. Numerous such symbols are taught in Rosicrucian training.

4. Bringing Rhythm to Life. Transitioning from a chaotic to a rhythmic life. Children have the advantage of going to school; adults, unfortunately, often lack a schedule. One must try to set aside certain hours of the day for meditation. Regulating the breath does not play as significant a role as it does for Eastern practitioners, but it is also part of the training, and the Rosicrucian knows that simply by meditating, the quality of the air one breathes improves.

5. The Correspondence Between the Microcosm and the Macrocosm. This refers to the connection between the great world and the small world, or between the human being and the external world. You know that the human being developed gradually; its individual constitutional elements formed in the course of evolution. On the ancient Sun, the human being did not yet have an astral body. For this reason, certain organs could not yet develop. One such organ is, for example, the liver. A being that has only an etheric body does not have a liver, not even in embryonic form. Although the liver is not possible without the etheric body, it is created only by the astral body. Similarly, a being can never have warm blood unless it arose at the time when the “I” developed.

Although higher animals are also warm-blooded, they diverged from humans when humans developed the “I.” Thus, every organ of the human body, even the smallest, belongs to one of its essential components. The liver corresponds to the astral body, and the blood to the “I.” And when a person now objectively directs his attention to himself, as if to an object—for example, by concentrating on the point at the root of the nose and associating it with a specific word given to him by the occult teacher—he is led to that which corresponds to this point, and he comes to know it. In this way, the person who concentrates on this point under specific guidance will come to know the nature of the “I.” Another exercise, performed much later, focuses on the interior of the eye; through this, one comes to know the inner nature of light and the sun. One comes to know the nature of the astral body by concentrating on the liver using specific words.

True self-development occurs when one is led out of oneself through every organ to which one directs one’s attention. This method has become particularly effective in recent times because humanity has become so materialistic. In this way, through the material, one arrives at the source of the material—at the creative forces that formed these organs.

6. Dwelling or immersing oneself in the macrocosm. This is the same as what has been described as dhyana, or spiritual contemplation. It occurs as follows: One immerses oneself in the organ of contemplation—for example, the interior of the eye. After concentrating on this for a while, one lets go of the image of the external organ, so that one thinks only of what the eye has pointed to: the light. Through this, one reaches the Creator of the organ and emerges into the macrocosm. Then one feels the body growing ever larger, as large as the entire Earth—indeed, it even grows beyond the Earth—and all things are within it. One then lives within all things.

7. The seventh state corresponds to the Eastern concept of samadhi; in Rosicrucian training, it is called godliness. One lets go of the final thought, but retains the power of thought. The content of thought ceases, but the activity of thought remains. Through this, one rests in the divine-spiritual world.

These stages of Rosicrucian training are more inward in nature and require a subtle cultivation of the higher life of the soul. In our materialistic age, widespread superficiality is a major obstacle to the necessary internalization of the entire life of the soul; it must be overcome. This training is tailored to Europeans; it requires a certain amount of soul energy, but it is not difficult. Anyone who is truly serious can carry it out. Yet Goethe's saying applies here as well: "It is easy, yet the easy is difficult."
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The third way is the Rosicrucian one. It is really just a modification of the other two. It developed in the 14th century, when the adepts were able to foresee that civilization would become very different in the centuries ahead.

This is the most suitable way for modern people. It is also the most appropriate for Europeans. This does not mean to say that one of the other ways will not also lead to the goal. But the Rosicrucian system is compatible with our whole civilization and culture. It has not so far been laid down in books or manuscripts, but has been passed from generation to generation by oral tradition. A more detailed description is given in Lucifer-Gnosis under the title 'How to gain knowledge of the higher worlds'.146

This is a very different view of the role of a guru. He is no longer absolute authority for the pupil but more a friend and adviser. The only authority lies in the individual's own free decision.

Evolution is in seven stages: 1) study, 2) imagination, 3) insight into occult scripture, 4) making life rhythmic, 5) looking for relationships between macrocosm and microcosm, 6) contemplation, 7) experiencing godliness.

Study is thus required as a first step, though this is not the scholarly type of study but working with thoughts relating to the world and to human life, the origin of the heavenly bodies, and so on, and other ways of training one's thinking. Thinking is able to give us new living experiences—I am referring to logical thinking with a definite goal. It provides secure guidance througJi all worlds, for thinking has to be equally consistent in all of them.

Secondly we have to gain the faculty of imagination. This is a matter of relating to the world around us not only in theory and in our thoughts but in moral terms. We must learn to discover the aspect of every thing that gives its moral background. To develop this kind of imagination we may, for instance, put the image of a plant clearly before our mind's eye. Or we may have a small seed grain before us and develop images of how it gradually sprouts, producing a stem and finally a complete plant with its fruit. After some practice one can really see how a plant emerges and grows from such a seed. This does, however, call for considerable occult powers. With lesser means it is possible to perceive the astral body of the plant as a small flame emerging from the seed.

Thirdly to learn occult script. This means to learn signs that have to do with the cosmic process.

Step 4 is to make life rhythmical. Our breathing needs to be regulated, changing the relative proportions of exhaled carbon dioxide and inhaled oxygen in a specific way. It is altogether most necessary to bring rhythm into life in our restless age. All processes follow one another in a great rhythm, and as far as possible this should also be made part of one's life. Thus we should arrange to have a meditation process at a given hour, or to review our past life at the same time every night. This releases great powers in the soul.

Step 5 is to look for correspondences between microcosm and macrocosm. Goethe put this most beautifully in the following verse:

Were not the eye like to the sun,
The sun it never could behold;
Were not in us the god's own power,
How could we take delight in things divine?

Entering intensely into our organs teaches us about the parts of the macrocosm that relate to them. Thus study of the eye teaches us about light, exploration of the lung about the composition of the air, and so on. Using a similar way we should finally also gain self knowledge.

Entering into the small world within us we thus gradually also have the great world revealed to us. Such comparative studies will ultimately lead to the state of godliness, the result of all the work that has gone before and above all of the deep, calm contemplation that is the sixth stage.

With all this, the individual must be imbued with specific good qualities, these being self confidence, self control and being present in mind and spirit.

The pupil has to work unceasingly on this inner development. For although the divine principle is indeed latent in us, it does not reveal itself without work and the right kind of development. To follow this way one does not have to leave one's human and social environment to devote oneself to personal development in solitude. Nor does it ask that we despise matter, merely that we grow beyond it, overcoming it to reach something higher.

Our guiding principle should be that self knowledge is world knowledge.

The three ways I have described take the individual to being a pupil at a higher level. It is only from this that a true initiate can then give us the key to the secret of the world, so that we may gain insight into the deeper connections in the life of the world and in human life. That highest level then means one is able to receive intuitions from higher worlds. It is a state of lucidity in spirit and of divine light.
GA097

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The third kind of initiation is the Rosicrucian way. It has been known in Europe from the 14th century. It is above all concerned to strengthen and empower the inner will. Where the Oriental school puts the emphasis on thinking, and the Christian school on feeling, the Rosicrucian way aims to develop the will. The stages of this way are 1) study, 2) Imagination, 3) learning the occult script, 4) bringing rhythm into life, 5) coming to understand the correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm, 6) contemplation of or entering into the macrocosm, 7) godliness.

For study, the pupil must have the patience to gain certain ideas concerning the world. He must first of all accept the teaching he is given. Thus he must, for example, devotedly study the teachings of elementary theosophy. He must try and enter as deeply into these as he can. Patient acquisition of ideas is essential for anyone who wants to reach higher levels. This calls for a specific way of training one's thinking, getting used to living and being active in the pure thinking element. Books such as The Philosophy of Spiritual Activity and Truth and Knowledge150 have been written for those who want to achieve Rosicrucian initiation and train their minds. It is a matter of overcoming the difficulties, which many find insurmountable, of following one's thoughts and perceiving how one thought of necessity arises from another. Oriental training required strict submission to the guru. For gnostic Christian training the pupil must put the Christ at the centre of all endeavour. In Rosicrucian Christian training the teacher is by his side, his friend and counsellor.

We are more apt to take a tumble when we come to the higher regions. It is therefore important to gain inner certainty. In everyday situations life itself puts us right. It will sometimes correct our errors in terrible ways. Such correction is not given when we ascend to the higher worlds. This is why in

Oriental training one must see with one's guru's eyes and feel through him. The European teacher is a counsellor. One needs the guidance of another when ascending into the higher worlds. In the astral world, perceptions are entirely different from those we have in the physical world; and in the devachanic world, too, a new world of perceptions opens up for us. The three worlds differ completely in the impressions to be gained. But one thing is the same for all of them, and that is logical thinking. This can be a reliable guide on the astral and devachanic planes. When study has taught us to think logically, we can also manage on the astral and devachanic planes. The logic of the physical plan no longer applies on the buddhi plan, however.

The 2nd stage of Rosicrucian training is Imagination. European pupils should take their time over this, for it is easy to take a tumble. Man must learn to develop a moral relationship to things. All that is transient should be seen as a simile for something that is eternal. If we look at the natural world in this way, the autumn crocus, for instance, becomes the image for us of a solitary spirit seeking to rise upwards in a melancholy way. The violet will be a symbol of something that has its existence in undemanding, calm beauty. Every stone makes us think—it is a simile for something that lies behind it. Our world thus grows richer. Things tells us of their inmost nature. One flower will then be the tear through which the earth gives expression to its pain, another the expression of joy. Looking at a grain of rice, for example, we may observe a small flame arising from it. The small flame becomes an image of what will later be the haulm growing from the grain.

At the 3rd stage a whole world of the spirit arises from all that is. The spiritual reality, the spiritual content of all things floats above them. The whole astral world becomes visible. You then find yourself as if in the waves of the ocean, feeling as if you were floating in the sea. You see the colour of a tulip lifted out of it, as it were, and realize that this is the garment of a spiritual entity. At this third stage the pupil learns the occult script. We must learn this if we truly want to live in the astral world. Thus many things are based on a spiral in this world:



We see such a spiral in the Orion nebula and in the configuration of life forms. Human and animal embryos are spiral in form at an early stage. One part is an image of the physical aspect, the other part, which winds into it, of the astral. The beginning of a new stage in human history is also symbolized by a double spiral. It is the sign of Cancer in the zodiac. When ancient Atlantis had perished and the post-Atlantean period began, with the ancient Indian race, the sun rose in the sign of Cancer at the beginning of spring. Learning the occult script we gain our orientation in the astral world.

The 4th stage consists in learning the rhythm of life. The pupil is instructed to regulate his breathing in a particular way. In nature, everything goes in rhythms. Every plant will rhythmically flower at the same time. Rhythm may also be seen in the animal world. Thus an animal is only fertile at certain times of the year. In man, however, rhythm becomes chaos. Man must create a new rhythm for his life. Many people only have rhythms that are imposed on them. Generally speaking, people do not have rhythms chosen of their own free will. The Rosicrucian must see to it that his life becomes rhythmical. Rhythm is given to the breathing process according to special instructions given by the teacher.

The 5th stage is getting to know the correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm. A bond exists between human beings and all things around them in this world. Ordinarily this only shows itself as love between the two sexes, the feeling that the one person finds in the other exactly what is familiar and related to him, what belongs to him. Many things are due to this mysterious relationship between world and man. An example is Paracelsus' discovery of the relationships that exist between certain plants and man. Having this ability he also came to know how other substances relate to man. He called someone suffering from cholera an Arsenicus, because arsenic will evoke exactly the symptoms in a healthy person which one also sees in a case of cholera.152 One can have a personal relationship, a loving relationship with all things, one that is wholly of the spirit. This must be practised. You achieve

it by following specific directions. If you think of the point that lies between the eyebrows and above the root of the nose in relation to a particular word, insight into a quite specific process in the world will come to you after some time. Thinking of the inner eye you gain knowledge of the sun's nature, of the processes that occurred when sun and earth were still one heavenly body. Another exercise makes it possible to know the moon in its spiritual aspect, or the condition of the earth 18 million years ago.

You then enter deeply into the correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm. Concentration on the point between the eyebrows and above the root of the nose you are able to penetrate into the time when the I entered into the human being. The human being then grows into the macrocosm in his conscious mind. He has to practise this for some time, growing into all things, be they far or near.

The 7th stage is that of godliness, when one grows beyond the limited bodily shell and is able to live with the macrocosm.

Pupils are instructed according to their occult status. When a pupil has gone through these stages as a real experience, he has reached the summit of insight into higher worlds.
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What does Rosicrucian training consist in? You will meet high ideals in it. Anyone wishing to take up this training must turn to someone who has the requisite knowledge. Even as he takes the first steps the pupil will realize what really matters. Rosicrucian training completely transforms the human being. It is only by gaining the faculties for the higher world that he can be a citizen of it.

Seven elements, activities, are part of Rosicrucian occult training: 1) proper study; 2) acquiring imagination; 3) learning the occult script; 4) finding the philosopher's stone; 5) gaining knowledge of man himself, the small world or microcosm; 6) gaining knowledge of the macrocosm; 7) knowing godliness. The sequence may vary, with a teacher perhaps taking 5) as the fourth step, for instance, to suit the pupil's individual nature.

You will ask if genuine Rosicrucianism still exists today. Yes, it does, and it will achieve its greatest significance in the future. The Rosicrucian brothers also have signs of identification. Not many of them are able to present themselves in public; some work entirely in secret. Anyone who seeks them will find them; and if someone does not find them he may assume that the time is not yet right for him. It [the meeting] will inevitably happen, however. It may often seem to be pure chance. It may happen, for instance, that you have to sit in a railway waiting room for 3 hours because snow is blocking the line. A stranger approaches you seemingly quite by chance. You have found your teacher. This is just one instance which I mention to you.

1) Proper study. What does this involve? You will be taken into worlds of which ordinary people have no idea. It will be necessary to gain your bearings in those worlds. It is not for people who are divorced from reality, lacking a firm basis to their thinking. Absolute certainty in one's thinking is a precondition. The individual has to look around, endeavouring to look about him with sound eyes, and must also be able to shut off his senses. This is something not everyone appreciates, not even the greatest philosophers. Eduard von Hartmann, for example, said over and over again: ‘Something coming from the senses is always present when we think; thinking without anything relating to the senses is impossible.’166 It is unbelievably arrogant to say that thinking without anything relating to the senses is impossible. Methods of developing a way of thinking free from sensory elements are now presented in the spiritual scientific literature and in lectures.

People who are found to be suitable are guided towards deeper knowledge. The elementary part of this knowledge is in fact open to many people. The way of study presented today, leaving aside the sense-related aspects of the world, consists in training one's thoughts. These then have nothing to do with the

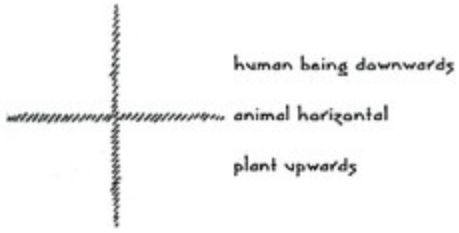
world we perceive around us through the senses. Wanting to enter even more deeply, one must put one's mind to more powerful thought training. I have endeavoured to give directions for such a way of thinking in the two books The Philosophy of Spiritual Activity - A Philosophy of Freedom and Truth and Knowledge. It is like this—when he begins to study these books at some depth, the reader will find that one thought follows another in a sequence that is determined by necessity. All people seeking to gain higher things are thus given the means for genuine growth in the spirit.

2) Developing powers of imagination. Here the way ideas are formed differs from ordinary thinking. Think of Goethe's words ‘All things corruptible are but a parable’. When you see someone with a smiling or worried face you'll not say ‘a crease is developing in that face’, or ‘a tear runs down his cheek’. What you'll say is that this shows a cheerful and this a sorrowful soul. The outer reveals the inner aspect; it is a simile, a likeness of what lives in the soul. Anyone will accept this in the case of human beings. Everyone knows the difference between a human head and a picture of it. A geologist may describe the earth for you, concerning himself only with its purely physical structure. People do not know that the earth's body is the body of a living entity, and that particular plants reflect the happy and the sad earth spirit. Goethe knew to tell of this; he knew how to see the earth as a body and knew what lived in it. In his Faust, he made the earth spirit say:

In life like a flood, in deeds like a storm
I surge to and fro,
Up and down I flow!
Birth and the grave,
an eternal wave,
Turning, returning,
A life ever burning.
And thus I work at Time's whirring wheel,
God's living garment I weave and reveal.

Everything on earth is a likeness of what is happening in the inner earth. People walk about on the earth's body. From my body, the earth may say, grows the seed that gives human beings their bread. The words in John's gospel, ‘He who eats my bread has lifted up his heel against me’, speak of one of the most profound mysteries in the way we look at the world.

Imagination is gained by seeing everything as a likeness. It is, however, necessary to learn logical thinking first. But in Rosicrucian training no one will choose a different image. Each feels that everything is in the image of the eternal. Here I must use dialogue to speak of something that lies behind an image that was taught in medieval temples and then in the Rosicrucian schools. The teacher would say to the pupil: ‘Look at the plant putting its root down in the soil and turning its flower, the seat of its organs of fertilization, to the light of the sun. The calyx is given a chaste kiss by the sunbeam and a new entity comes into existence.’ Even Darwin said that the root of a plant may be compared with the head.167 Man is an inverted plant. His organs of reproduction are turned towards the centre of the earth in shame. The animal is between man and plant. These three realms of nature are shown in the image of a cross: human , animal and plant orientation



Plato said: ‘The world's soul has been crucified on the cross of the world's body.

The Rosicrucian teacher would then ask his pupil to compare matter as it exists in flesh with the chaste matter of a plant, telling him that a time would come when human beings would be cleansed of their passions and desires, maturing to a stage and shining out towards the sun of the spirit where they will be as chaste and without desire as the chaste plant. With this ideal they will cleanse their flesh, so that fertilization becomes chaste and pure. Medieval schooling represented this ideal in the holy grail. The chalice is a sacred symbol of what human sensuality must become if it is to be like the calyx of a plant. It will then receive the kiss of the white dove—the chalice is shown with the dove above it. To make the world thus spiritual, seeing man's environment in such images, raises him to the point of vision in astral images. Imagination is developed out of heart and mind and out of feeling.

3) Learning the occult script. The occult script reflects the inner currents in nature. One such sign is the vortex. If you were able to see the whole of the Orion nebula you would have two sixes intertwined. You see a world that is dying and one that is becoming in the nebula. Things are like this everywhere. When a plant sheds a new fruit, nothing from the old plant passes on to the new one. Nothing but powers cause a new plant to develop. And once again you would only see the vortex swirling inwards and out. In the same way you might see an old civilization spiralling into itself and a new one snaking out. This spiritual process can help us understand such a sign that is part of the script.



800 years before Christ was born the sun entered into the sign of the Ram or lamb. Every spring it moves on a distance. The spring equinox is now in the constellation of the Fishes. At that earlier time people thought the Ram brought all that was good, new strength and power in spring. They even connected the redeemer with this. In early Christian times, the cross and the lamb were their symbol for this. Before the sun was in the sign of the Ram in spring, it was in the sign of the Bull. The Egyptians venerated the sacred bull Apis at that time, the Persians the Mythras bull. After the Flood, the sun was in the sign of Cancer. Cancer was given this occult sign: spiral and sign of Cancer.



And so there are many such lines, and also colours. And so one learns the signs that take us into the forces and powers of nature. One learns to develop the will in the occult script.

4) Finding the philosopher's stone. This was felt to be a secret in the 18th century. Someone then also published something about it. It is something everyone knows. The philosopher's stone is at the same time the noblest thing man can attain to, can make of his organism in order to achieve higher development.

Let me give you a story from Vedanta philosophy for this. People once wanted to see if man could also live without eyes. After a year the individual concerned said: ‘Yes, I have lived, but as a blind person? He then tried to live without ears and a year later reported: 'Yes I have lived without ears, but as a deaf person.’ The voice was taken away and he lived as a mute person. Then his breath was to be taken away as well and that proved impossible. He could not live without breathing. Our breathing gives us the air we need to live. ‘And god breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul.’ We take in oxygen with every breath and release carbon dioxide. In the plant, the cycle goes the other way round. The plant uses carbon to build its body. This is why we find fossilized plants in coal after thousands of years. Man has carbon in him; he breathes in oxygen, and the carbon dioxide which is produced is removed. Animals do the same. The Rosicrucian school teaches a special way of breathing, so that the person learns the process which the plant carries out in itself. One day man will be able to transform his carbon himself; he himself will transform the blue blood that is streaming back into red blood. Now he takes in plant nature; one day he himself will do what the plant does today. The

Rosicrucian says: ‘Today your body is made of flesh; one day you will create it yourself through the breath. Plant nature will appear in you, but you'll not sleep the way plants do but will be clairvoyant with it.’

This is the ideal man is moving towards—to build his body of carbon. Ordinary coal is the philosopher's stone. When man's body has become star-like it will not be black coal but transparent carbon, clear as water. These are not just chemical processes but sublime ideals. The Rosicrucian goes through it in stages, and later the whole of humanity will ascend to this level.

5) Knowing the human being as microcosm. In all the rest of nature, the world is spread out; man is an extract of it. Everything is spread out in the world in letters, and man is the word. In the early 19th century Oken and Schelling presented the basic ideas of this, which were quite correct. They sought to gain understanding of the essence that lies in an organ. Oken got a bit grotesque when he said the tongue was a cuttlefish. Goethe said: ‘The eye is created by the light for the light.’ We only come to recognize the true nature of light when we find the principle in man that corresponds to light.

The teacher gives his pupil a leitmotiv, asking him to concentrate on a point, the organ that lies behind the root of the nose, and he comes to know the nature of dream consciousness in addition to his wide-awake conscious awareness. The human being gets to know the whole world when he deeply considers the spleen, liver and other things. When he has expanded his conscious awareness by thus entering into himself—it is dangerous to go broody—he will become one with the whole world.

6) Coming to know the macrocosm. Having perceived what I have just described, he will also perceive the creator behind all creation.

7) Getting to know godliness. At the 7th stage the individual reaches a point that calls forth universal feeling from the depths of the human soul and something he only has a right to know at this stage—the feeling of blessedness. It is only by gaining insight into macrocosm that he learns to enter into universal feeling. Entering into every individual thing in a clear and living way is godliness. There he discovers the soul that lies at rest behind nature. Someone once said to me: ‘I never thought a stone would feel anything if I split it.’ The spirit of the mineral world feels the greatest voluptuousness when a stone is split, a feeling of bliss. It may seem to us that the marble quarry is going through martyrdom; yet for the spirit of the stone is it the greatest bliss. Now you might ask why people are not told such details. Someone once said it would be most useful for people to know them. My reply was: 'People would want to gain things for themselves from this, and this secret must only be used in utterly selfless service to humanity.’

The Rosicrucians knew this secret, as do those who now walk this earth and serve human progress. They tell the things that will serve progress, they who know how the ‘chymical wedding’ may proceed.
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We are going to discuss some aspects of the Rosicrucian method. It is one of the ways of gaining insight into and access to the higher worlds. The term ‘Rosicrucian’ may sound strange and peculiar to some of you. One has heard of the Rosicrucians as a secret brotherhood which first appeared under that name in about the 14th century. Anything one finds in encyclopaedias and the current literature about them is of no account. A number of highly influential people have represented a quite specific spiritual stream as Rosicrucians. It is only too easy to flail into the most serious error when seeking to discover the greatest truths, as may be seen from many publications on the Rosicrucians. They were one of the closest secret brotherhoods and had to go through severe trials and tests. Anyone wishing to become a member of the order had to go through many things. The aspirant had to go through specific occult training to gain self-knowledge. Ignorance may, however, make the sublime appear in caricature. And that is also how Rosicrucianism was completely misunderstood and distorted to become caricature.

What has been written about Rosicrucianism is utter charlatanism. Someone who is able to judge it rightly will see the kernel of truth in it. But it has always been difficult to find out about Rosicrucianism, as you can see from the fact that Helmont, Leibniz and others were unable to do so. Rosicrucian initiation is said go back to a book written in the early 17th century which says, among other things, that the Rosicrucians were involved in alchemy and also other things such as higher education. That's what is says in the Fama Fraternitatis.

Even there you'll find nothing about genuine Rosicrucianism, for the secrets of the Rosicrucians were passed on by the oral tradition. Things that are outwardly given the name ‘Rosicrucian’ are hardly suitable for getting at the essence of the Rosicrucians. Today we'll consider the methods used by the genuine Rosicrucians, in so far as this is possible on a public occasion. The theosophical movement initially started in the Oriental way. The truth can be found anywhere if one knows how to look for it and is sufficiently mature. People had a different way of thinking things at the time when the ancient Indians received the teaching of the holy Rishis, a different way of feeling and using their will, of seeing and perceiving. The things they did in those days can no longer be done today. The methods used in the past can no longer be used today. Nothing in the world is absolute; humanity is in a continuous process of evolution. People now have a very different, more subtle structure to their brains, and even the way the blood is formed is different. Because of this, all truth must be transformed today, and initiation methods must be such that they are suitable for present-day Europeans. These are the reasons why there had to be Rosicrucianism, a completely different way of initiation. The Rosicrucian stream is in the care of great teachers who have always stayed in the background.

Rosicrucian initiation is in seven stages. These provide a standard method that makes it possible for Europeans to go through the trials they have to go through. The stages do not necessarily have to be consecutive, for the teacher would choose what was best for the individual nature of the pupil.

The seven stages are study, imagination, inspired insight or reading the occult script, preparing the philosopher's stone, correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm, entering into the macrocosm in a living way, and the 7th or highest stage which is godliness.

Study meant developing concepts and ideas that made a person able to form a sound, comprehensive idea of essential relationships. For the Rosicrucians, study involved everything we have in theosophy today, having taken away the Oriental garb. Theosophy today offers Rosicrucian wisdom. We have also spoken about the elementary Rosicrucian teaching in public lectures.158 The main point is to gain a sum of concepts relating to the world that form a complete whole, in a strictly established, firm set of ideas. A system of thinking is created that is entirely sensible. A Rosicrucian had to be a sober, thinking individual. These teachings are truths accessible to the simplest hearts as well as intellectual minds. What is the aim of such study? It leads to insight into higher worlds—the astral world and then the spiritual or devachanic world—that are invisibly all around us.

Man has the same number of abilities to perceive as there are worlds around him. To begin with, these abilities are of course undeveloped. For someone born blind, gaining sight is like a new birth. In the same way, the appearance of yet another world is always like a new birth for the human being. The astral world—we call it that for specific reasons—is around us, and so is the spiritual or devachanic world. It would be arrogance for someone who does not know the higher worlds to insist that they do no exist. The astral world and the devachanic world both differ tremendously from the physical world we are able to see around us. We gain completely new impressions in the astral and again in the devachanic world. Yet although our perceptions in these worlds differ greatly from those we have in the physical world, the logic is always the same. Thinking is the same in all three worlds; it only changes in worlds that lie beyond. Having learned to think in one of these three worlds, the laws of this are the same also in the higher ones. The problem is, however, that in the physical world human errors are corrected from experience. In those other worlds there is no such easy correction, and we therefore need a solid standard of objectivity. You will be completely unsupported if you enter those worlds

without this objectivity. This is why a guru was needed for initiation in earlier times. The guru had to be the ultimate authority in the soul of an individual who was being initiated into Indian yoga wisdom. In Rosicrucian training, the guru-pupil relationship is replaced by the support gained from trained thinking. The pupil must be his own guide. Because of this, study is an important part of training. Fundamental truths of theosophy have been written in Truth and Knowledge and The Philosophy of Spiritual Activity for both the simplest hearts and people who aim higher. Reading those books it is necessary to be completely given up to inner work, letting one thought evolve from another.

The 2nd stage of the Rosicrucian path was imagination. A comprehensive method meant that one was then able to take the first step into the higher worlds. Experiencing imagination we perceive the deeper meaning of Goethe's words ‘All things corruptible are but a parable’.

Looking at a plant we can experience in its form and essential nature how true it is that the spirit of the earth, as it were, reveals itself in it when it is sad and when it is cheerful. It is a great truth that man is part of the earth just as a finger is part of the human body. Man is only part of the whole but he has the illusion of living a separate life. The finger is protected from such illusion because it cannot walk about on the human body. If you feel yourself to be an integral part of the earth, you have a feeling not only for the poetry but for the truth of Goethe's words of the earth spirit.160 When human beings enter into the things which the earth spirit produces on its surface, many a plant will be the earth spirit's tears for them, and many a plant its smile.

Something else was brought to the pupil's awareness by all possible means. He would be told: ‘Look at the calyx with its organs of fertilization, chastely held up to the sun. The sun ray kisses the inner calyx. The plant innocently holds out its organs of fertilization to cosmic space. Think of this transformed and taken to a higher level. Consider the animal first, and the human being, and see how the human being veils the principle which the plant holds out to the sun. And then say to yourself: “One day man must reach a higher level where anything base will have gone from his organs. At this higher level he will offer to the sun the principle which today is the calyx of the plant. All drives and instincts will then have been purified, the human individuality will have overcome its natural desires.”’ In Rosicrucian wisdom this transformation was called the grail, the sacred chalice.

When a person has lived for some time with such ideas, he will be ready to move on to even higher experiences. The physical eye only sees the seed of the plant. When the soul has been prepared, it will be able to penetrate to the image that arises for it from the seed grain. A flame form will arise from the seed for that soul. The individual thus learns to see the spiritual aspect that is behind things; he comes to know that everything physical has been born from a world of the spirit.

The 3rd stage is called reading the occult script in Rosicrucian training. The cosmic powers active in the world are revealed in certain currents and in colour and sound combinations. This occult script is written into the structure of the world. An example is the spiral we see as two intertwined vortices in the Orion nebula far out in the cosmos. At the microcosmic level, the incorporation of the human seed takes a corresponding form. The image of a double spiral is the sign of cancer in the zodiac. In occult script, it shows the transition from one stage of evolution to another. The sun's spring equinox was in fact in the sign of cancer when a new period of human evolution started in ancient India after the end of Atlantis.

Another sign in occult script is the triangle. This, too, is written into the macrocosm. At the microcosmic level the figure of the equilateral triangle with its centre marked is the symbol of balance restored between the three powers of soul. Harmonization of thinking, feeling and will gives rise to the higher power of love.

This 3rd stage, where conscious awareness of inspiration was gained, was followed by the development of rhythm in life and in breathing. In the language of the Rosicrucians this is called

preparing the philosopher's stone. Later on it will be a stage in the evolution of humanity as a whole. Today people need oxygen to breathe. They exhale carbon dioxide, which is a poison. It is the other way round with plants, for they breathe in carbon dioxide and release oxygen. In the distant future man will consciously use the carbon which today is taken in with the food to build his physical body and no longer exhale it. The human body will then consist of an entirely different substance than it does today. It will be a soft, transparent form of carbon. Man's body will then have become the philosopher's stone. The symbol for this is the crystal clear diamond, which is also carbon.

The whole process was prepared for by bringing rhythm into our breathing and altogether into all vital processes. These are regulated from outside in plants and animals. But this no longer happens for modern man. He must create the rhythm for himself which nature gives to all its life forms. Strict adherence to such a rhythm was an important part of Rosicrucian training.

At the 5th stage of Rosicrucian training the pupil would have living experience of the correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm. Paracelsus said: ‘Everything that exists around us in space is related to us.’ The individual letters are in the world,161 and man is the word. Man has everything that exists out there in the world in him on a small scale, in its essence. To know yourself so that you might know the world, that was the task set for this stage.

At the next, the 6th stage, the pupil had to enter into the macrocosm in a living way. Here the human being had to leave himself behind, abandoning all that was his own. He then truly came to know the macrocosm.

The highest stage that could be reached by a Rosicrucian was that of godliness. Here the initiate grew to unite with the whole universe, he knew the summit of human evolution which humanity is to reach in the far distant future. The Rosicrucian pupils would make every endeavour to prepare for this evolution.

A lower, passive nature lives in man and also an active element. If he develops in the way I have described he will overcome his lower nature and be reborn through the spirit. This aspect of human evolution has been put into words by Goethe:

So long as you don't have it,
this word: ‘Die and become!’
you're but a miserable guest
here on this earth.

The symbol for ‘to die’ is the cross, the symbol for a new birth are the roses. The human physical body is the cross. Everything connected with powers of growth is the passive element in us. This means above all the milk. In the blood, on the other hand, the human being develops an active element as he seeks to attain to higher things. That is the secret of the white and the red rose. Our higher nature seeks to find the balance between the white and the red rose. In Goethe's poem The Secrets the thirteenth is the image of someone who has reached this exalted level. We may therefore take the words spoken by this thirteenth as a guide for all Rosicrucian endeavour:

All power pushes forward far and wide
To live and work both here and there;
the stream that is the world, however, hems us in,
builds obstacles all round and carries us away.
Caught in this inner storm and outer strife
the mind does hear a word that's hard to understand:
Man needs to overcome and free himself

of the great power binding all creation.
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Let me say once again that I can only give an outline, and no more.

Study is not the kind of learning we generally know. Instead one has to discover that there is a way of thinking that is still fluid and real, keeping out all sensory perceptions of the world around us. Western philosophers deny the existence of such a way of thinking. They say it is only possible to think if the thought still has a residue of sensory perception in it. Those gentlemen do not know that other people have been able to do this, and they do not wish to believe it because they themselves are unable to think in this way. Man must learn to forget everything, to leave everything aside that influences the senses from the outside, yet without being an empty vessel. This is possible if one enters wholly into a pure thought content that has no sensual connection, as given by the spiritual scientist, and reflects on the thoughts that evolve. I have shown this way in my books, writing them in such a way that one element arises from another, as in a living being, so that one thought follows organically from another. You give yourself selflessly to the thought, and an inner separation results. Anyone who wishes to move to a higher level must read things written out of the science of the spirit in this way. Anyone who does not wish to reach a higher level may read them like an ordinary book. The former is the case because higher perception takes the human being into other worlds. You are now living on the physical plan—plan, not plane, for like the plan of a house it has nothing to do with being level. You thus come to different plans, into different worlds. At first you live here in the physical world, then you enter into the astral, imaginative world. It is a world we may describe as follows. Imagine a plant, green, with a red flower. You do special exercises that enable you not only to see what the senses see but to perceive how a cold flame form arises from the plant, is it were. You perceive floating colours. You thus perceive spiritual entities that you cannot perceive with the ordinary senses. Everything evaporates from the surface of things and becomes the expression of purely astral events. This world is much more real than our sense-perceptible world, for the world of the senses has been created out of that world of the spirit. This physical world has condensed out of the astral world. Matter is condensed spirit to the true occultist, and we can dissolve it again. The whole of our sense-perceptible world is condensed astral reality.

Behind this astral world is yet another world which may best be described by showing you how human beings come to gain living experience of it. When someone does the exercises I have described in my books, his dreams will first of all become regular. Try and enter into the nature of dreams. What is a dream? Let me give you some examples. They are taken from life, for I do not speak of other things.

Someone has dreamt he has caught a tree frog and then finds he has taken hold of a corner of his bed covers. The dream symbolized the occurrence. Another example is someone dreaming that he's in a dark, musty hole of a cellar full of spiders' webs. He wakes up with a headache. Some dreams may involve high drama. A student is standing at the door of the lecture theatre. Another one comes in jostles him, and a duel is fought with pistols. The shot rings out—and the chair next to the bed has fallen over. This minor incident has come to symbolic expression in the whole dramatic story of the dream. A farmer's wife dreams she's going to town and entering a church where the priest's sermon is of sublime things. Just when it gets really sublime, the priest begins to change. It looks as if he is growing wings and then he suddenly begins to crow. At that moment the farmer's wife wakes up and the cock is crowing outside. The cock's crow has been transformed and taken symbolic form in the dream.

Dreams are thus highly creative. Everything is chaotic in them. But life is given to this world and everything becomes harmonious and regular if you gain the certainty, up to a point, that this represents a reality. This is how it first shows itself, and later one takes things perceived in the world of dreams across into everyday life. Something develops which we may call ‘continuity of conscious awareness’.

Human beings also have dreamless sleep. The Rosicrucian pupil next learns to perceive entities and events around himself in a sleep state. The revelations of the spirit world sound forth from the darkness of dreamless sleep. In the Pythagorean schools this was called the world of the music of the spheres. The world of the spirit sounds forth. If you really want to hear something about the devachan, this must be such that it is described to you as a world of sound. Goethe, who had this degree of Rosicrucian initiation, knew of this: ‘The sun proclaims its old devotion in rival song with brother spheres.’ That is either nonsense or a higher truth. The physical sun does not resound, but the spirit of the sun is a real, resounding entity. And Goethe stayed with the metaphor; in part 2 of Faust, he wrote: ‘Resounding now for ears of spirit the new day is already being born.’ He wrote like that because the music of the spheres of which the Pythagoreans spoke was a reality to him. I can only refer to these things briefly. All things will speak to us, a new revelation will come forth.

Those are the stages the Rosicrucian pupil can reach by means of exercises. The worlds are always completely different, and someone who only knows the physical world can have no idea of the things one can learn in other worlds. One thing is the same for all worlds, however, and that is logical thinking. Our perceptions are entirely different in the astral, in the devachanic world, but the laws of thinking are the same in all three worlds. A Rosicrucian pupil must therefore first learn this way of thinking, so that he may keep to the proper path and not lose his way.

The 2nd stage consists in gaining imaginative perception. I can only tell you a few things that should explain what is meant by this. When you see a tear rolling down a cheek, you conclude that the soul is filled with sadness. When you see a cheerful face you conclude that the soul is cheerful. You draw these conclusions in relation to people. When you want to ascend to imaginative perception you must do this in relation to the whole world. The life of plants, animals and stones should express the physiognomy of the world soul for you. Some things must be like our cheerfulness, other things like tears wept by the earth spirit. This must become very real to the person. And much can be experienced in this way. The secret of the holy grail, the ideal of medieval Rosicrucian pupils, is connected with this.

Let us take an example. The Rosicrucian pupil would meet his teacher who would give him an exercise to do. I am going to put this in the form of a dialogue, though it has never been spoken dialogue. But what it conveys was practised and became living experience. It is entirely true and absolutely correct in every detail. The pupil would come to his teacher who would say to him: ‘Look at the plant. It extends its root into the soil, it grows upwards, opening its calyx at the top, and in there are its organs of fertilization and reproduction. Chastely and nobly and in purity it lets the sun's ray kiss it; the light, the sacred lance of love, which penetrates the calyx as a sunbeam and calls forth the potential that lies in the plant's organs of fertilization. You would have the wrong idea if in comparing the plant with a human being you were to think that the root is the head and the flower the lower part. Man is an inverted plant.’

The occultist thus sees the inverted plant in man and the inverted human being in the plant, with the animal between the two. ‘Look at the plant. It is the arm of the cross that goes down, the animal is the horizontal arm, and man the vertical arm.’ That is the original significance of the cross. It is the symbol for plant, animal and man as three realms of nature. Plato therefore wrote that the world's soul was crucified on the world's body. And the teacher would go on to say to the pupil: ‘Look at the human being, the human being in the flesh. What is this human flesh? Compare it with the matter contained in a plant. Plant matter is chaste and pure. Human flesh is full of passion and desire. Man is higher up on

the evolutional scale, but this also means that he has taken in passion and desire.' And the occult pupil would begin to intuit a future human being whose flesh would be pure and chaste again, like the chaste calyx of a flower which holds out its organs of fertilization to the sunbeam's sacred lance of love. Then his productive powers would reach out to the spirit just as today the plant reaches out to the lance of love, to the light. Those who sought to achieve this went through a transformation of the flesh. And so the pupil was presented with the great ideal of the human being who one day will be as pure and chaste as the plant. This ideal is called the holy grail. It is one of the images that speak to the heart and the whole soul. The pupil was able to rise higher not through thoughts but through images that influence the whole soul, captivating heart, mind and soul. Only then can imaginative perception be achieved.

The 3rd level involves learning the occult script. Something exists in this world which in occult life is called the vortex. It is to be found everywhere in nature and in the world of the spirit. Imagine you are looking up to the Orion nebula, which is a distinctive spiral. If you were a seer you would see that a vortex emerges like a figure 6, with a second vortex that is darker. The two intertwine. This also occurs in the world of the spirit.

We live in the age that follows the great Atlantean flood. Before that, our earliest ancestors were human beings of a very different kind. People imagine today that in those times human beings were just as they are now. But the physical conditions were completely different then. Atlantis was always in darkness, enveloped in masses of dense fog. It is important for you to know this. Old German mythology holds memories of Niflheim [land of mist] and Nibelungs [creatures of the mist]. Under those conditions the human constitution was very different. The Atlanteans also had a completely different culture. You might get an idea of this if I were to give you details of the way people heard articulated sounds in all things at that time. There were no moral laws. If someone wanted to know how to relate to a neighbour, he could not appeal to some authority or other; he would listen to the waves and then he would know.

It was a culture of which no trace seems to remain. It perished. When did this happen? We can see that in the heavens. About 8 centuries before the Christ was born the sun rose in the Ram. It takes about 2160 years to move through a sign of the zodiac. The sun moved into the sign of the Ram, or the Lamb, about 800 years before Christ. People felt the new constellation had brought them the new fruitfulness of spring, something new and good. We see from this that they felt the Lamb or the Ram to be important. Many things point to this, among them the legend of the Argonauts, in which the golden fleece plays such a role. The Christ himself is called the Lamb of God. The lamb was the symbol for offering veneration. Before that, the sun had been in the sign of the Bull, hence the veneration of the bull in Egyptian and Persian culture. Even earlier the sun passed through the sign of the Twins. In accord with this, duality played a great role in the Persian teachings of Ormuzd and Ahriman. Traces of this still persisted in ancient Germanic culture. Before that, the sun was passing through Cancer. This was the period that followed the Atlantean flood. A vortex had occurred in the realm of the spirit.

This constellation with the occult sign of Cancer can still be seen in the calendar today. Many such signs are known to man. In reality this is nothing but a recreation of primal forces of nature. If you train your heart and mind to understand the occult signs you will steel your will with this occult script. You get to know the ways of the spirits that are behind nature. A faint echo remains in symbolic signs such as the pentagram and hexagram. One occult sign you often read about is the swastika. The strange explanations given for it are quite unbelievable. In reality it is nothing but the sign for the astral sense organs, the wheels or lotus flowers, several of which are potentially present in the astral body—in the heart, the larynx, between the eyebrows. Astral vision begins when the last named of these wheels begins to turn. The swastika is the sign for this astral organ of perception.

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Someone has dreamt he has caught a tree frog and then finds he has taken hold of a corner of his bed covers. The dream symbolized the occurrence. Another example is someone dreaming that he's in a dark, musty hole of a cellar full of spiders' webs. He wakes up with a headache. Some dreams may involve high drama. A student is standing at the door of the lecture theatre. Another one comes in jostles him, and a duel is fought with pistols. The shot rings out—and the chair next to the bed has fallen over. This minor incident has come to symbolic expression in the whole dramatic story of the dream. A farmer's wife dreams she's going to town and entering a church where the priest's sermon is of sublime things. Just when it gets really sublime, the priest begins to change. It looks as if he is growing wings and then he suddenly begins to crow. At that moment the farmer's wife wakes up and the cock is crowing outside. The cock's crow has been transformed and taken symbolic form in the dream.

Dreams are thus highly creative. Everything is chaotic in them. But life is given to this world and everything becomes harmonious and regular if you gain the certainty, up to a point, that this represents a reality. This is how it first shows itself, and later one takes things perceived in the world of dreams across into everyday life. Something develops which we may call ‘continuity of conscious awareness’.

Human beings also have dreamless sleep. The Rosicrucian pupil next learns to perceive entities and events around himself in a sleep state. The revelations of the spirit world sound forth from the darkness of dreamless sleep. In the Pythagorean schools this was called the world of the music of the spheres. The world of the spirit sounds forth. If you really want to hear something about the devachan, this must be such that it is described to you as a world of sound. Goethe, who had this degree of Rosicrucian initiation, knew of this: ‘The sun proclaims its old devotion in rival song with brother spheres.’ That is either nonsense or a higher truth. The physical sun does not resound, but the spirit of the sun is a real, resounding entity. And Goethe stayed with the metaphor; in part 2 of Faust, he wrote: ‘Resounding now for ears of spirit the new day is already being born.’ He wrote like that because the music of the spheres of which the Pythagoreans spoke was a reality to him. I can only refer to these things briefly. All things will speak to us, a new revelation will come forth.

Those are the stages the Rosicrucian pupil can reach by means of exercises. The worlds are always completely different, and someone who only knows the physical world can have no idea of the things one can learn in other worlds. One thing is the same for all worlds, however, and that is logical thinking. Our perceptions are entirely different in the astral, in the devachanic world, but the laws of thinking are the same in all three worlds. A Rosicrucian pupil must therefore first learn this way of thinking, so that he may keep to the proper path and not lose his way.

The 2nd stage consists in gaining imaginative perception. I can only tell you a few things that should explain what is meant by this. When you see a tear rolling down a cheek, you conclude that the soul is filled with sadness. When you see a cheerful face you conclude that the soul is cheerful. You draw these conclusions in relation to people. When you want to ascend to imaginative perception you must do this in relation to the whole world. The life of plants, animals and stones should express the physiognomy of the world soul for you. Some things must be like our cheerfulness, other things like tears wept by the earth spirit. This must become very real to the person. And much can be experienced in this way. The secret of the holy grail, the ideal of medieval Rosicrucian pupils, is connected with this.

Let us take an example. The Rosicrucian pupil would meet his teacher who would give him an exercise to do. I am going to put this in the form of a dialogue, though it has never been spoken dialogue. But what it conveys was practised and became living experience. It is entirely true and absolutely correct in every detail. The pupil would come to his teacher who would say to him: ‘Look at the plant. It extends its root into the soil, it grows upwards, opening its calyx at the top, and in there are its organs of fertilization and reproduction. Chastely and nobly and in purity it lets the sun's ray kiss it; the light, the sacred lance of love, which penetrates the calyx as a sunbeam and calls forth the potential that lies in the plant's organs of fertilization. You would have the wrong idea if in comparing the plant with a human being you were to think that the root is the head and the flower the lower part. Man is an inverted plant.’

The occultist thus sees the inverted plant in man and the inverted human being in the plant, with the animal between the two. ‘Look at the plant. It is the arm of the cross that goes down, the animal is the horizontal arm, and man the vertical arm.’ That is the original significance of the cross. It is the symbol for plant, animal and man as three realms of nature. Plato therefore wrote that the world's soul was crucified on the world's body. And the teacher would go on to say to the pupil: ‘Look at the human being, the human being in the flesh. What is this human flesh? Compare it with the matter contained in a plant. Plant matter is chaste and pure. Human flesh is full of passion and desire. Man is higher up on the evolutional scale, but this also means that he has taken in passion and desire.’ And the occult pupil would begin to intuit a future human being whose flesh would be pure and chaste again, like the chaste calyx of a flower which holds out its organs of fertilization to the sunbeam's sacred lance of love. Then his productive powers would reach out to the spirit just as today the plant reaches out to the lance of love, to the light. Those who sought to achieve this went through a transformation of the flesh. And so the pupil was presented with the great ideal of the human being who one day will be as pure and chaste

as the plant. This ideal is called the holy grail. It is one of the images that speak to the heart and the whole soul. The pupil was able to rise higher not through thoughts but through images that influence the whole soul, captivating heart, mind and soul. Only then can imaginative perception be achieved.

The 3rd level involves learning the occult script. Something exists in this world which in occult life is called the vortex. It is to be found everywhere in nature and in the world of the spirit. Imagine you are looking up to the Orion nebula, which is a distinctive spiral. If you were a seer you would see that a vortex emerges like a figure 6, with a second vortex that is darker. The two intertwine. This also occurs in the world of the spirit.

We live in the age that follows the great Atlantean flood. Before that, our earliest ancestors were human beings of a very different kind. People imagine today that in those times human beings were just as they are now. But the physical conditions were completely different then. Atlantis was always in darkness, enveloped in masses of dense fog. It is important for you to know this. Old German mythology holds memories of Niflheim [land of mist] and Nibelungs [creatures of the mist]. Under those conditions the human constitution was very different. The Atlanteans also had a completely different culture. You might get an idea of this if I were to give you details of the way people heard articulated sounds in all things at that time. There were no moral laws. If someone wanted to know how to relate to a neighbour, he could not appeal to some authority or other; he would listen to the waves and then he would know.

It was a culture of which no trace seems to remain. It perished. When did this happen? We can see that in the heavens. About 8 centuries before the Christ was born the sun rose in the Ram. It takes about 2160 years to move through a sign of the zodiac. The sun moved into the sign of the Ram, or the Lamb, about 800 years before Christ. People felt the new constellation had brought them the new fruitfulness of spring, something new and good. We see from this that they felt the Lamb or the Ram to be important. Many things point to this, among them the legend of the Argonauts, in which the golden fleece plays such a role. The Christ himself is called the Lamb of God. The lamb was the symbol for offering veneration. Before that, the sun had been in the sign of the Bull, hence the veneration of the bull in Egyptian and Persian culture. Even earlier the sun passed through the sign of the Twins. In accord with this, duality played a great role in the Persian teachings of Ormuzd and Ahriman. Traces of this still persisted in ancient Germanic culture. Before that, the sun was passing through Cancer. This was the period that followed the Atlantean flood. A vortex had occurred in the realm of the spirit.

This constellation with the occult sign of Cancer can still be seen in the calendar today. Many such signs are known to man. In reality this is nothing but a recreation of primal forces of nature. If you train your heart and mind to understand the occult signs you will steel your will with this occult script. You get to know the ways of the spirits that are behind nature. A faint echo remains in symbolic signs such as the pentagram and hexagram. One occult sign you often read about is the swastika.178 The strange explanations given for it are quite unbelievable. In reality it is nothing but the sign for the astral sense organs, the wheels or lotus flowers, several of which are potentially present in the astral body—in the heart, the larynx, between the eyebrows. Astral vision begins when the last named of these wheels begins to turn. The swastika is the sign for this astral organ of perception.



The 4th level is called preparing the philosopher's stone. This is a reality. At the end of the 18th century someone who had got hold of something, but not exactly the right idea, put quite a good description of the philosopher's stone in a journal. He actually did not know himself how good it was. At that time a number of things from the occult school were wrongly made public, and so someone also described the philosopher's stone. This is actually something familiar to everyone, and many people handle it daily without having an idea. To help you see what this is about, follow me in a brief line of thought. Consider human breathing. We inhale oxygen, which changes our blue blood to red, and we exhale

carbon dioxide, which means we are all the time exhaling poisonous matter. Plants on the other hand take up the carbon dioxide exhaled by humans and animals and retain the carbon to build up their bodies. They release the oxygen, so that humans can inhale it again. This is a cycle. Occultists attached great importance to this process. If you dig up a plant form that has become coal today you can see that the plant built up its body of carbon. Humans take in oxygen, changing blue blood into red; plants take in carbon dioxide and return the oxygen which humans then take in again.

Let us try and see what happens when the breathing process is regulated in a particular way in Rosicrucian training. The way in which it is done can only be passed on from person to person, but it is possible to speak of the effect. ‘A steady drip will hollow the stone’, as the saying goes. And that applies with the process I am now describing. The occult pupil is instructed by his teacher on doing his breathing exercises out of the spirit. It is an instruction, therefore, to regulate his breathing process in a particular way and this makes it possible for the human mind to expand a little as time goes on. It is something of which human beings normally know nothing and has to do with something that happens in the plant. The plant now becomes at one with him. Normally human beings exhale carbon dioxide and take in oxygen. The pupil must bring this to mind consciously. In his breathing he consciously experiences the change from carbon to oxygen, blue blood to red blood. He learns to do something in himself that is normally left to the plant. He will then be able to build up his own body. He learns to do so by means of regular breathing. This, then, is a real process in which the human being learns to purify his flesh also at the physical level. The alchemy of the human body lies in this. The human being is transformed into the vehicle for a pure, chaste incarnation that may be compared to a plant. The pupil is aware of something sublime, light and bright. He knows he only had to go through the flesh. That is the transformation of coal into diamond. You'll now understand the significance of bringing rhythm into the breathing in Rosicrucian training and know what was meant by the philosopher's stone. The regulated breathing process is the way to the philosopher's stone.

I am only touching on things lightly, but you'll understand that something profound lies behind the search for the philosopher's stone, something connected with the transformation of the whole of mankind, so that human beings will be different from the way they are today—they and the whole earth. That is how great and strong and firm, morally great, the powers of soul must be if man is to make the flesh, too, part of the process of redemption. We also have to redeem everything that exists around us, all creation.

The 5th level is to enter deeply into the relationship between microcosm and macrocosm. A great occultist of medieval times, someone we must first learn to read, used a beautiful image to show the relationship between macrocosm and microcosm. Paracelsus said: You see there the individual letters. Man is the word made up of the letters. And so we have to see man spread out in the whole of nature, and man himself as a compendium of nature. Paracelsus referred to a cholera patient as Arsenicus, for example, for the powers active in him are the same as those active in arsenic.

But there is more. When someone concentrates really hard on a particular part inside him, the point between the eyebrows—this, of course, is only a reference point—he will have a particular experience in which he is taken into the inner events of the great world. These correspond to the part which in the human microcosm lies between the eyes. And so the correspondence between macrocosm and microcosm has to be experienced bit by bit. Entering deeply into his inner life, the pupil must get to know the outside world.

At the 6th and 7th levels the Rosicrucian pupil comes to be at one with the whole world. He gains true knowledge of the outside world. And his feelings and his whole soul become one with the outside world to the same degree. This is the condition known as godliness. The earth's body is then his body. And the pupil achieves the stage known as being at one with the universe. It is a long road along one particular path. Those who have gone through it become messengers of the spiritual world, speaking from real experience.

It is a road anyone can follow today—certainly in principle. It will take a long time for some, and a shorter time for others. One of the best theosophists, the late Subba Row, said about the time needed, which people ask about so often: ‘It is true that one person needed 70 incarnations, another 7 incarnations, someone else again 70 years or perhaps 7 years; there have been people who achieved it in 7 months, and some in just 7 days, depending on their karma from former lives on earth.’ Setting out on the road one must be patient and persevere, knowing that one will be exposed to great dangers unless one has first gone through character training. Let me give you an analogy. Take a green liquid produced by mixing blue and yellow. You can separate the blue from the yellow by using a chemical agent. Before that, the individual properties of the two solutions were not apparent. Now they show those properties. And that is how it is with the human being. High and low qualities are mixed. The lower ones are prevented from taking full effect because the higher ones have been added. If you now separate the two by doing the exercises you may find that someone who until now was more or less bearable grows malicious and cunning and also shows a whole lot of other bad characteristics. This is something you have to understand. The danger can definitely be prevented by doing specific preliminary exercises that establish a particular inner morality full of character.

The pupil must first learn to keep strict control of his thoughts. He must practise making one thought the focus of his inner life for a long period, the more intensely so the better. He must stick with it and let all thoughts follow from it. This exercise must be done for at least five minutes every day. The more the better, but one should not overdo it.

2) It is necessary to be able to take initiative in one's actions. This is done by the pupil doing one particular thing on his own initiative every day. It may be something quite small and insignificant, for instance watering one's flowers. After a time one takes up another initiative.

3) One has to gain mastery over pleasure and pain. There must be no more of being on top of the world one moment and down in the dumps the next. This mastery will make you more subtly receptive, but you yourself must be the master, not your inner responses.

4) There is need to be positive. A Persian legend about Christ Jesus will show you what is meant. The Christ was walking with some of his disciples. A dead, partly decomposed dog was lying by the roadside. The disciples turned away and said: ‘How horrible that creature is!’ The Christ stopped, however, and said: ‘Look how beautiful the animal's teeth are!’ You can look for and find something beautiful in the ugliest things, something great in the smallest of things. One must always look for the positive side.

5) One has to learn to be completely unbiased towards anything new. Absence of bias to the highest degree. People tend to say: ‘I've never heard of this before, seen this before; I don't believe it!’ We have to learn in the widest possible sense never to say something is impossible. There should be a place in our hearts where one allows it to be possible, say, that the church tower is at an angle if someone says it is at an angle. We should at least consider it to be possible if we hear such a thing.

The 6th level consists in bringing the 5 qualities into harmony.

The pupil will then have developed such inner strength that he will be protected from anything occult training might otherwise do to him. It would be wrong to set limits to occult training and say: ‘All I want is the ethical value.’ Anyone wishing to enter into the higher worlds must follow the indicated route. The road to the most sublime insights is also the way of greatest compassion. We must gain such compassion from insight, not with phrases. When someone has broken a leg all the people standing around full of compassion will be of no use, only the one individual who knows what to do and does it properly. Merely to preach theosophy is like standing in front of the stove and saying: ‘It is your duty to get the room warm.’ And it is the same if you tell people to practise brotherly love. Just as you have

to put wood in the stove and put a match to it, so you have to give people what they need if their souls are to unite in one great brotherhood, and that is insight. True insight is the fuel for the great brotherly union among human beings. Today we have the age of materialism, and because of this people have gone their separate ways.
GA097

GA099
This passing through states of humility and deep devotion represents the nature of the Christian initiation, and he who earnestly goes through it experiences his resurrection in the spiritual worlds. Today it is not possible for all to undertake this path, and so the existence of another method leading to the higher worlds has become a necessity. That is the Rosicrucian method.

Here again I must refer to seven stages which will give a picture of the content of this training. Much of it has already been described in Lucifer-Gnosis,1 much can only be given from teacher to pupil within the school, and yet an idea must be formed of what the training provides. It has seven stages, though not consecutive, it is a question of the pupil's own individuality. The teacher prescribes what seems to him adapted to his pupil, and much else forms a part that cannot be made public.

The seven stages are the following:

Study
Imaginative knowledge
Inspired knowledge, or reading the Occult Script
Preparation of the Philosopher's Stone
Correspondence between Macrocosm and Microcosm
Living into the Macrocosm
Divine Bliss

Study in the Rosicrucian sense is the ability to immerse oneself in a content of thought not taken from physical reality but from the higher worlds. This is called the life in pure thought. Modern philosophers for the most part deny this; they say that every thinking must have a certain vestige remaining from sense perception. This, however, is not the case, for no one, for example, can see a true circle; a circle must be seen in the mind; on the blackboard it is only a collection of tiny particles of chalk. One can only attain to a real circle if one leaves aside all examples, all actual things. Thus thinking in Mathematics is a super-sensible activity. But one must also learn to think supersensibly in other fields. Initiates have always exercised this kind of thinking in regard to the being of man. Rosicrucian theosophy is such super-sensible knowledge, and its study, with which we are now occupied, is the first stage of the Rosicrucian training itself. I am not bringing forward Rosicrucian theosophy for any external reason, but because it is the first stage of the Rosicrucian Initiation.

People think often enough that it is unnecessary to talk about the principles of man's being, or the evolution of humanity or the different planetary evolutions, they would rather acquire beautiful feelings, they do not want to study earnestly. Nevertheless, however many beautiful feelings one acquires in one's soul it is impossible to rise into the spiritual worlds by that alone. Rosicrucian theosophy does not try to arouse the feelings, but through the stupendous facts of the spiritual worlds to let the feelings themselves begin to resound. The Rosicrucian feels it a kind of impertinence to take people by storm with feelings. He leads them along the path of mankind's evolution in the belief that feelings will then arise of themselves. He calls up before them the planet journeying in universal space, knowing that when the soul experiences this fact it will be powerfully gripped in feeling. It is only an empty phrase to say one should address oneself direct to the feelings, that is just indolence. Rosicrucian theosophy lets the facts speak, and if these thoughts flow into the feeling nature and overpower it, then that is the right way. Only what the human being feels of his own accord can fill him with bliss or blessedness. The Rosicrucian lets the facts in the cosmos speak, for that is the most

impersonal kind of teaching. It is a matter of indifference who stands before you; you must not be affected by a personality, but by what he tells you of the facts of world-becoming. Thus in the Rosicrucian training that direct veneration for the teacher is struck out, he does not claim it nor require it. He wishes to speak to the pupil of what exists, quite apart from himself.

One who will press forward into the higher worlds must accustom himself to the kind of thinking in which one thought proceeds from another. A thinking of this nature is developed in my Philosophy of Spiritual Activity and Truth and Science. These books are not written in such a way that one can take a thought and put it in another place; much more are they written as an organism arises, one thought grows out of another. These books have nothing at all to do with the one who wrote them; he gave himself up to what the thoughts themselves worked out in him, how they linked themselves one to another.

Study, then, for one desiring to make a somewhat elementary approach means acquiring a certain knowledge of the elementary facts of spiritual science itself, whereas for one who wishes to go further it means an inner meditation in a thought-structure which lets one thought grow out of another, out of itself.

The second stage is Imaginative Knowledge, the knowledge which unites with what is given to the pupil in the study-stage. The study is the basis, it must be perfected through individual imaginative knowledge. If you think over various things that I have touched upon in the last lectures, you will find traces—in the echo for instance—of what were everyday occurrences on Saturn. It is possible to look on all around us as a physiognomy of an inner spiritual element. People walk over the earth and it is a conglomeration of rocks and stones to them, but men must learn to grasp that all surrounding them is the true physical expression for the Spirit of the Earth. Just as the body is ensouled, so is the earth planet the external expression for an indwelling spirit. When men look on the earth as possessing body and soul as man does, then only they have an idea of what Goethe meant when he said “All things corruptible are but a semblance.” When you see tears run down the human countenance you do not examine by the laws of physics how quickly or how slowly the tears roll down; they express to you the inner sadness of the soul, just as the smiling cheek is the expression for the soul's inner joy. The pupil must educate himself to see in each single flower in the meadow he crosses, the outer expression of a living being, the expression of the Spirit dwelling in the Earth. Some flowers seem to be tears, others are the joyful expression of the earth's Spirit. Every stone, every plant, every flower, all is for him the outer expression of the indwelling Earth Spirit, its physiognomy that speaks to him. And everything “corruptible” or transitory becomes a “semblance” of an eternal, expressing itself through it.

Feelings like these had to be attained by the disciple of the Grail, and by the Rosicrucian. The teacher would say: Behold the flower chalice which receives the ray of the sun, the sun calls forth the pure productive forces which slumber in the plant and hence the sun's ray was called the “holy lance of love.” Look now at man; he stands higher than the plant, he has the same organs within him, but all that the plant harbours in itself, perfectly pure and chaste, is in him steeped in lust and impure desire. The future of human evolution consists in this: man will again be chaste and pure, and speak forth his likeness into the world through another organ which will be the transformed organ of generation. Chaste and pure without desire, without passion, man's generative organ will be; and as the calyx of the blossom turns upward to the holy love lance, it will turn to the spiritual ray of wisdom, and fructified by this will bring forth its own image. This organ will be the larynx. The Grail pupil was shown: the plant on its lower stage has this pure chalice, man has lost it; he has degenerated to impure desires. Out of the spiritualised sun ray he must let this chalice come again, in chastity he must develop that which forms the Holy Grail of the future.

Thus the pupil looks up to the great Ideal. What comes to pass in the slow evolution of the whole human race is experienced earlier by the initiate. He shows us mankind's evolution in pictures and these pictures work quite differently from the abstract thoughts which have been produced by the

modern materialistic age. If you picture evolution in such lofty and powerful pictures as the Grail, then the effect is different from that of ordinary knowledge, which is unable to exercise any deep influence on your organism. Imaginative knowledge works down on the etheric body and thence on to the blood and this is the medium which acts formatively on the organism. Man will become increasingly more able to work on his organism through his etheric body. All imaginative knowledge based on truth is at the same time healing and health giving, it makes the blood healthy in its circulation. The best educator is imaginative knowledge, if man is only strong and devoted enough for it to be able to work on him.

The third stage is Reading in the Occult Script, that is, not only seeing isolated pictures but letting the relationship of these pictures work upon one. This becomes what is called occult script. One begins to coordinate the lines of force which stream creatively through the world forming them into definite figures and colour-forms through the imagination. One learns to discover an inner connection which is expressed in these figures and this acts as spiritual tone, as the sphere-harmony, for the figures are founded on true cosmic proportions. Our script is a last decadent relic of this old occult writing and is modeled on it.

One comes to the fourth, Preparing the Philosopher's Stone, through exercises of the breathing process. If man breathes as ordained by nature he needs the plant-world for his breathing. If the plant were not there he could not live, for it gives him oxygen and assimilates the carbon which he himself breathes out. The plant builds its own organism from this and gives back oxygen, thus through the plant world oxygen is continually renewed for man. Humanity could not exist by itself; eliminate the plant world and mankind would in a short time die out. So you see the cycle: you breathe in oxygen which the plant breathes out, you breathe out carbon which the plant inhales and from which it builds up its own bodily nature. Thus the plant belongs to me, it is the instrument by which my life is sustained. You may see in the coal how the plant builds its body from carbon, for coal is nothing else than the dead remains of plants.

Rosicrucian training guides the pupil through a definitely regulated breathing process to form that organ that can within himself effect the transformation of carbon into oxygen. What is today done by the plant externally, will later on, through a future organ which the pupil is already developing through his training, be effected in man himself This is slowly being prepared. Through the regulated breathing process man will bear in himself the instrument for the preparation of oxygen; he will have become akin to the plant, whereas now he is of a mineral nature. He will retain the carbon in himself and build his body from it, and hence his body will later on be more plant-like, then he can turn towards the holy love lance. The whole of humanity will then possess a consciousness like that gained by the initiate today when he raises himself into the higher worlds. This is called the transmutation of human substance into that substance of which carbon itself is the basis. This is the Alchemy which leads man to build up his own body as does the plant today. One calls this the preparation of the “Philosopher's Stone” and carbon is its outer symbol. But it is not the Philosopher's Stone until the pupil can create it himself through his regulated breathing process. The teaching can only be given from teacher to pupil, it is wrapped in deep secrecy, and only after he is completely purified and made ready can the pupil receive this mystery. If it were to be made public today, then men in their egoism would gratify their lowest needs through the misuse of this highest mystery.

The fifth is the Correspondence of Microcosm and Macrocosm. When we survey the path of human evolution we see that what lies within man today has gradually entered from without—for instance, the glands were an external growth on the Sun, like our modern fungi; all that today lies within the human skin was once outside. The human body is, as it were, pieced together from what was spread outside it, each separate member of your physical body, etheric body and astral body was somewhere outside in the universe. This is the macrocosm in the microcosm. Your very soul was outside in the Godhead. Whatever is within us corresponds to something which is outside, and we must learn to know the true correspondences in ourselves.

You know the spot on the brow just above the root of the nose; it expresses the fact that a certain something which was formerly outside has drawn into man. If you penetrate this organ in meditation, sink yourself into it, this denotes more than a mere brooding in this point, you learn to know then the part of the outer world which corresponds to it. The larynx, too, you get to know and the forces which build it. Thus you learn about the macrocosm through sinking yourself into your own body.

This is no mere brooding within yourself! You should not say: God is within and I will seek Him. You would only find the puny human being whom you yourself magnify into God! One who only speaks of this inward brooding never comes to real knowledge. To reach this by the path of Rosicrucian Theosophy is less comfortable and demands real work. The universe is full of beautiful and marvelous things, one must be absorbed in these, one must seek God in his individual expressions, then one can find him in oneself and then only does one learn to know God as One. The world is like a great book. We find its letters in created things, we must read these from beginning to end, and then we learn to read the book microcosm and the book macrocosm from beginning to end. This is no longer a mere understanding, it lives over into feeling, it fuses the human being with the whole universe and he feels all things to be the expression of the divine Spirit of the Earth. If a man has reached this point, he voluntarily performs all his deeds in accordance with the will of the whole cosmos and this is what is known as Divine Bliss.

When we are able to think thus, we are treading the Rosicrucian path. The Christian school is based more on the development of inner feelings, in the Rosicrucian school all that is spread out in physical reality as the divine nature of the earth is allowed to work upon us and reverberate in us as feeling. These are two ways which are open to all. If you think in the manner of modern thought then you can take the Rosicrucian path, no matter how scientific you may be. Modern science is an assistance if you do not merely study cosmic evolution, reading the letters, as it were, but carry your research into what is concealed behind, just as in a book one does not consider the letters but reads the meaning by their aid. You must seek the spirit behind science, then science becomes to you but the letter for the spirit.

What has been said is not meant to be a comprehensive account of the Rosicrucian training, it is only meant to serve as an indication of what can be found in it. It is a path for present day man, it makes him capable of working into the future. These are only the elementary stages, to give some idea of the way. We can thus realise how through the Rosicrucian method one may oneself penetrate into the higher mysteries.

Spiritual Science is necessary to humanity for its further progress. What is to take place for the transforming of mankind must be brought about through men themselves. He who accepts the truth in his present incarnation will mould for himself in later incarnations the outer form for the deeper truths.
GA099

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The attainment of a supersensible state of consciousness can only proceed from everyday waking consciousness. In this consciousness the soul lives before its elevation. Through the training the soul acquires a means of lifting itself out of everyday consciousness. The training that is under consideration here offers among the first means those that still may be designated as functions of everyday consciousness. The most important means are just those that consist of quiet activities of the soul. They involve the opening of the soul to quite definite thoughts. These thoughts exercise, by their very nature, an awakening power upon certain hidden faculties of the human soul. They are to be distinguished from the visualizations of everyday waking life, which have the task of depicting outer things. The more truly they do this, the truer they are, and it is part of their nature to be true in this sense. The visualizations, however, to which the soul must open itself for the purpose of spiritual training have no such task. They are so constructed that they do not depict anything external but have in themselves the peculiarity of effecting an awakening in the soul. The best visualizations for this purpose are emblematic or symbolical. Nevertheless, other visualizations may also be employed, for it

is not a question of what they contain, but solely a question of the soul's directing its powers in such a way that it has nothing else in mind but the visualized image under consideration. While the powers of everyday soul-life are distributed in many directions—the visualized mental representations changing very rapidly—in spiritual training everything depends upon the concentration of the entire soul-life upon one visualization. This visualization must, by means of free will, be placed at the center of consciousness. Symbolic visualized images are, therefore, better than those that represent outer objects or processes, for the latter have a point of attachment to the outer world, making the soul less dependent upon itself than when it employs symbolic visualizations that are formed through the soul's own energy. The essential is not what is visualized; what is essential is the fact that the visualization, through the way it is visualized, liberates the soul from dependence on the physical.

We understand what it means to immerse ourselves in a visualized image if we consider, first of all, the concept of memory. If, for instance, we look at a tree and then away from it so that we can no longer see it, we are then able to re-awaken the visualization of the tree in the soul by recollecting it. This visualization of the tree, which we have when the eye no longer beholds the latter, is a memory of the tree. Now let us imagine that we preserve this memory in the soul; we permit the soul, as it were, to rest upon the visualized memory picture; and at the same time we endeavor to exclude all other visualizations. Then the soul is immersed in the visualized memory picture of the tree. We then have to do with the soul's immersion in a visualized picture or image; yet this visualization is the image of an object perceived by the senses. But if we undertake this with a visualized image formed in the consciousness by an act of independent will, we shall then be able by degrees to attain the effect upon which everything depends.

We shall now endeavor to describe an example of inner immersion in a symbolic visualization. Such a visualization must first be fashioned in the soul. This may happen in the following way. We visualize a plant as it roots in the earth, as leaf by leaf sprouts forth, as its blossom unfolds, and now we think of a human being beside this plant. We make the thought alive in the soul of how he has characteristics and faculties which, when compared with those of the plant, may be considered more perfect than the latter. We contemplate how, according to his feelings and his will, he is able to move about hither and thither, while the plant is chained to the earth. Furthermore we say that the human being is indeed more perfect than the plant, but he also shows peculiarities that are not to be found in the plant. Just because of their nonexistence in the plant the latter may appear to me in a certain sense more perfect than the human being who is filled with desire and passion and follows them in his conduct. I may speak of his being led astray by his desires and passions. I see that the plant follows the pure laws of growth from leaf to leaf, that it opens its blossom passionlessly to the chaste rays of the sun. Furthermore, I may say to myself that the human being has a greater perfection than the plant, but he has purchased this perfection at the price of permitting instincts, desires, and passions to enter into his nature besides the forces of the plant, which appear pure to us. I now visualize how the green sap flows through the plant and that it is an expression of the pure, passionless laws of growth. I then visualize how the red blood flows through the human veins and how it is the expression of the instincts, desires, and passions. All this I permit to arise in my soul as vivid thought. Then I visualize further how the human being is capable of evolution; how he may purify and cleanse his instincts and passions through his higher soul powers. I visualize how, as a result of this, something base in these instincts and desires is destroyed and how the latter are reborn upon a higher plane. Then the blood may be conceived of as the expression of the purified and cleansed instincts and passions. In my thoughts I look now, for example, upon the rose and say, In the red rose petal I see the color of the green plant sap transformed into red, and the red rose, like the green leaf, follows the pure, passionless laws of growth. The red of the rose may now become the symbol of a blood that is the expression of purified instincts and passions that have stripped off all that is base, and in their purity resemble the forces active in the red rose. I now seek not merely to imbue my intellect with such thoughts but to bring them to life in my feelings. I may have a feeling of bliss when I think of the purity and passionlessness of the growing plant; I can produce within myself the feeling of how certain higher perfections must be purchased through the acquirement of instincts and desires. This can then transform the feeling of bliss, which I have felt previously, into a grave feeling; and then a feeling of liberating joy may stir in me when I surrender

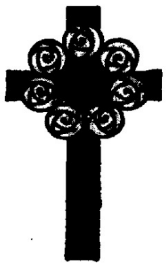
myself to the thought of the red blood which, like the red sap of the rose, may become the bearer of inwardly pure experiences. It is of importance that we do not without feeling confront the thoughts that serve to construct such a symbolic visualization. After we have pondered on such thoughts and feelings for a time, we are to transform them into the following symbolic visualization. We visualize a black cross. Let this be the symbol of the destroyed base elements of instincts and passions, and at the center, where the arms of the cross intersect, let us visualize seven red, radiant roses arranged in a circle. Let these roses be the symbol of a blood that is the expression of purified, cleansed passions and instincts.1 Such a symbolic visualization should be called forth in the soul in the way illustrated above through a visualized memory image. Such a visualization has a soul-awakening power if we surrender ourselves to it in inward meditation. We must seek to exclude all other thoughts during meditation. Only the characterized symbol is to hover in spirit before the soul as intensely as possible.—It is not without significance that this symbol is not simply given here as an awakening visualized picture, but that it has first been constructed by means of certain thoughts about plant and man. For the effect of such a symbol depends upon the fact of its having been constructed in the way described before it is employed in inner meditation. If we visualize the symbol without first having fashioned it in our own souls, it remains cold and much less effective than when it has received, through preparation, its soul-illuminating power. During meditation, however, we should not call forth in the soul all the preparatory thoughts, but merely let the visualized picture hover vividly before our inner eye, at the same time letting the feeling hold sway that has appeared as a result of the preparatory thoughts. Thus the symbol becomes a token alongside the feeling-experience, and its effectiveness lies in the dwelling of the soul in this inner experience. The longer we are able to dwell in it without the intervention of other, disturbing, thoughts, the more effective is the entire process. It is well, nevertheless, for us, outside the period dedicated to the actual meditation itself, to repeat the construction of the symbol by means of thoughts and feelings of the above described kind, so that the experience may not fade away. The more patience we exercise in this renewal, the more significant is the symbol for the soul. (In my book, Knowledge of the Higher Worlds and Its Attainment, other examples of means for inner meditation are given. Especially effective are the meditations characterized there about the growth and decay of the plant, about the slumbering creative forces in the plant seed, about the forms of crystals, and so forth. In the present book, the nature of meditation was to be described by a single example.)

Such a symbol, as is described here, portrays no outer thing or being that is brought forth by nature. But just because of this it has an awakening power for certain purely soul faculties. To be sure, someone might raise an objection. He might say, It is true, the symbol as a whole is certainly not produced by nature, but all its details are, nevertheless, borrowed from nature—the black color, the red roses, and the other details. All this is perceived by the senses. Anyone who may be disturbed by such an objection should consider that it is not the pictures of sense-perceptions that lead to the awakening of the higher soul faculties, but that this effect is produced only by the manner of combining these details, and this combination does not picture anything that is present in the sense world.

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The development of the human being is represented in the symbol associated with the profoundly significant Rosicrucian maxim: the black cross with red roses. One perceives this symbol as something living—a realm in which the spiritual forces that fashioned the human being—born as he was out of the Divine—continue to live and weave. Furthermore, one realizes that the further development of the soul is possible through the exertion of one’s own powers. One understands that not only must one’s blood become as pure as the red sap of the roses, but the black cross, too, must undergo a transformation; this occurs as one purifies one’s own nature—the "sheaths" or vestures of the self—and transcends the merely personal by surrendering to something infinitely greater. In this state, one dies into the Christ, and before the soul’s vision, the dark, black cross is transfigured into a luminous, radiant cross. The red roses expand into an infinite circle as the soul becomes increasingly attuned to the macrocosm, until it perceives itself as that very circle. Within this all-encompassing macrocosm, the human being experiences a new mode of existence.

Then, in a mysterious way, the colors of the symbol transform: the roses appear green, the cross white. The soul can only intuit its full significance by sensing the power that flows toward it. Beholding this sacred symbol as it radiates from higher spiritual realms, the soul recognizes it. Stern and powerful, it presents itself as a call to constant labor, so that the great ideal—which every single human being can realize upon being reborn in the Holy Spirit—may one day be attained.
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The process of effective meditation was illustrated here by a symbol, as an example. In spiritual training the most manifold pictures of this kind can be employed and they can be constructed in the most varied manner. Also certain sentences, formulae, even single words, upon which to meditate may be given. In every case these means to inner meditation have the objective of liberating the soul from sense-perception and of arousing it to an activity in which the impression upon the physical senses is meaningless and the development of the inner slumbering soul faculties becomes the essential. It may also be a matter of meditation upon mere feelings and sensations. This shows itself to be especially effective. Let us take, for example, the feeling of joy. In the normal course of life the soul may experience joy if an outer stimulus for it is present. If a soul with normal feelings perceives how a human being performs an action that is inspired by kindness of heart, this soul will feel pleased and happy about it. But this soul may then meditate on an action of this sort. It may say to itself, an action performed through goodness of heart is one in which the performer does not follow his own interest, but the interest of his fellow-man, and such an action may be designated morally good. The contemplating soul, however, may now free itself from the mental picture of the special case in the outer world that has given it joy or pleasure, and it may form the comprehensive idea of kindness of heart. It may perhaps think how kindness of heart arises by the one soul absorbing, so to speak, the interests of the other soul and making them its own, and it may now feel joy about this moral idea of kindness of heart. This is not the joy in this or that process in the sense world, but the joy in an idea as such. If we attempt to keep alive such joy in the soul for a certain length of time, then this is meditation on inner feeling, on inner sensation. The idea is not then the awakening factor of the inner soul faculties, but the holding sway, for a certain length of time, of the feeling within the soul that is not aroused through a mere single external impression.—Since supersensible knowledge is able to penetrate more deeply into the nature of things than ordinary thinking, it is able through its experiences to indicate feelings that act in a still higher degree upon the unfolding of the soul faculties, when they are employed in inner meditation. Although this is necessary for higher degrees of training, we should remember the fact that energetic meditation on such feelings and sensations, as for example have been characterized in the observation of kindness of heart, is able to lead very far.—Since human beings are varied in character, so are the effective means of training varied for the individual man.—In regard to the duration of meditation we have to consider that the effect is all the stronger, the more tranquilly and deliberately this meditation is carried out. But any excess in this direction should be avoided. A certain inner discretion that results through the exercises themselves may teach the pupil to keep within due bounds.

Such exercises in inner meditation will in general have to be carried on for a long time before the student himself is able to perceive any results. What belongs unconditionally to spiritual training is patience and perseverance. Whoever does not call up both of these within his soul and does not, in all

tranquility, continuously carry out his exercises, so that patience and perseverance form the fundamental mood of the soul, cannot achieve much.

It will have become evident from the preceding exposition that meditation is a means of acquiring knowledge about higher worlds, but it will also have become evident that not just any content of thought will lead to it, but only a content that has been evolved in the manner described.

The path that has been indicated here leads, in the first place, to what may be called imaginative cognition. It is the first stage of higher cognition. Knowledge that rests upon sense-perception and upon the working over of the sense-perceptions through the intellect bound to the senses may be called, in the sense of spiritual science, "objective cognition." Beyond this lie the higher stages of knowledge, the first of which is imaginative cognition. The expression "imaginative" may call forth doubts in those who think "imagination" stands only for unreal imaginings, that is, a visualization of something that has no corresponding reality. In spiritual science, however, "imaginative" cognition is to be conceived as something coming into existence through a supersensible state of consciousness of the soul. What is perceived in this state are spiritual facts and beings to which the senses have no access. Because this state is awakened in the soul by meditating on symbols or "imaginations," the world of this higher state of consciousness may be named the "imaginative" world, and the knowledge corresponding to it "imaginative" cognition. "Imaginative," therefore, means something which is "real" in a different sense from the facts and beings of physical sense-perception. The content of the visualizations that fill imaginative experience is of no importance, but of utmost importance is the soul faculty which is developed through this experience.

An obvious objection to the employment of the characterized symbolic visualizations is that their fashioning corresponds to a dreamlike thinking and to arbitrary imagining and therefore can bring forth only doubtful results. In regard to the symbols that lie at the foundation of true spiritual training, doubts of this character are unjustified. For the symbols are chosen in such a way that their connection with outer sense reality may be entirely disregarded and their value sought merely in the force with which they affect the soul when the latter withdraws all attention from the outer world, when it suppresses all impressions of the senses, and shuts out all thoughts that it may cherish as a result of outer stimuli. The process of meditation is best illustrated by a comparison with the state of sleep. On the one hand it resembles the latter, on the other it is the complete opposite. It is a sleep that represents, in regard to everyday consciousness, a higher waking state. The important point is that through concentration upon the visualization or picture in question the soul is compelled to draw forth much stronger powers from its own depths than it employs in everyday life or in everyday cognition. Its inner activity is thereby enhanced. It liberates itself from the bodily nature just as it does during sleep, but it does not, as in the latter case, pass over into unconsciousness, but becomes conscious of a world that it has not previously experienced. Although this soul state may be compared with sleep in regard to the liberation from the body, yet it may be described as an enhanced waking state when compared with everyday waking consciousness. Through this the soul experiences itself in its true inner, independent nature, while in the everyday waking state it becomes conscious of itself only through the help of the body because of the weaker unfolding of its forces in that state, and does not, therefore, experience itself, but is only aware of the picture that, like a reflection, the body (or properly speaking its processes) sketches for it.

The symbols that are constructed in the above described manner do, by their very nature, not yet relate to anything real in the spiritual world. They serve the purpose of detaching the human soul from sense-perception and from the brain instrument to which the intellect is bound at the outset. This detachment cannot occur in man prior to his feeling the following: I now visualize something by means of forces in connection with which my senses and my brain do not serve me as instruments. The first thing that the human being experiences on this path is such a liberation from the physical organs. He may then say to himself, "My consciousness is not extinguished when I disregard the sense-perceptions and ordinary intellectual thinking; I can lift myself out of them and then feel myself as a being alongside the one I

was previously." This is the first purely spiritual experience: the observation of a soul-spirit ego being. This, as a new self, has lifted itself out of the self that is only bound to the physical senses and the physical intellect. If without meditation the pupil had released himself from the world of the senses and intellect, he would have sunk into the "nothingness" of unconsciousness. The soul-spirit being, naturally, existed before meditation had taken place, but it did not yet have any organs of observing the spiritual world. It was somewhat similar to a physical body without eyes to see, or ears to hear. The force that was employed in meditation first has fashioned the soul-spirit organs out of the previously unorganized soul-spirit nature. The individual beholds first, therefore, what he has created. Thus, the first experience is, in a certain sense, self-perception. It belongs to the essence of spiritual training that the soul, through the practice of self-education, is at this point of its development fully conscious of the fact that at first it perceives itself in the world of pictures—imaginations—which appear as a result of the exercises described. Although these pictures appear as living in a new world, the soul must recognize that they are, at the outset, nothing but the reflection of its own being, strengthened through the exercises, and it must not only recognize this with proper discretion, but it must also have developed such a power of will that it can extinguish, can eliminate these pictures from consciousness at any time. The soul must be able to act within these pictures completely free and fully aware. This belongs to true spiritual training at this stage. If the soul were not able to do this it would be in the same circumstances, in the sphere of spiritual experience, in which a soul would find itself in the physical world, were its eyes fettered to the object upon which they gaze, powerless to withdraw them. Only one group of inner imaginative experiences constitutes an exception to this possibility of extinction. These experiences are not to be extinguished at this stage of spiritual training. They correspond to the kernel of the soul's own being, and the student of the spiritual recognizes in these pictures what, in himself, passes through repeated earth lives as his fundamental being. At this point the sensing of repeated earth lives becomes a real experience. In regard to everything else the independence of the experiences mentioned must rule, and only after having acquired the ability to bring about this extinction does the student approach the true external spiritual world. In place of what has been extinguished, something else appears that is recognized as spiritual reality. The student feels how he grows in his soul from the undefined into the defined. From the self-perception he then must proceed to an observation of an outer world of soul and spirit. This takes place when the student arranges his inner experiences in the sense that will be further indicated here.

In the beginning the soul of the student of the spiritual is weak in regard to everything that is to be perceived in the spiritual world. He will have to employ great inner energy in order to hold fast in meditation to the symbols or other visualizations that he has fashioned from the stimuli of the world of the senses. If, however, he wishes besides this to attain real observation in a higher world, he must be able not only to hold fast to these visualizations, but he must also, after he has done this, be able to sojourn in a state in which no stimuli of the sensory world act upon the soul, but in which also the visualized imaginations themselves, characterized above, are extirpated from consciousness. What has been formed through meditation can only then appear in consciousness. It is important now that sufficient inner soul power be present in order really to perceive spiritually what has been formed through meditation, so that it may not elude the attention. This is, however, always the case with but weakly developed inner energy. What is thus constructed in the beginning as a soul-spirit organism and what is to be taken hold of by the student in self-perception is delicate and fleeting, and the disturbances of the outer world of the senses and its after-effects of memory are great, however much we may endeavor to hold them back. Not only the disturbances that we observe come into question here, but much more, indeed, those of which we are not conscious at all in everyday life.—The very nature of the human being, however, makes possible a state of transition in this regard. What the soul at the beginning cannot achieve in the waking state on account of the disturbances of the physical world, is possible in the state of sleep. Whoever surrenders to meditation will, by proper attention, become aware of something in sleep. He will feel that during sleep he does not "fall into a complete slumber," but that at times his soul is active in a certain way while sleeping. In such states the natural processes hold back the influences of the outer world that the waking soul is not yet able to prevent by means of its own power. If, however, the exercises of meditation have already been effective, the soul frees itself during sleep from unconsciousness and feels the world of soul and spirit. This may happen in a twofold

way. It may be clear to the human being during sleep that now he is in another world; or he may have the memory on awaking that he has been in another world. To the first belongs, indeed, greater inner energy than to the second. Therefore the latter will be more frequent for the beginner in spiritual training. By degrees this may go so far that the pupil feels on waking that he has been in another world during the whole sleep period, from which he has emerged on waking, and his memory of the beings and facts of this other world will become ever more definite. Something has taken place for the student of the spiritual in one form or another that may be called the continuity of consciousness. (The continuity of consciousness during sleep.) It is not at all meant by this, however, that man is always conscious during sleep. Much, however, has already been gained in the continuity of consciousness if the human being, who otherwise sleeps like ordinary man, has at certain times during sleep intervals in which he can consciously behold a world of soul and spirit, or if, after waking, he can look back again in memory upon such brief states of consciousness. It should not be forgotten, however, that what is described here may be only understood as a transitional state. It is good to pass through this state in the course of training, but one should certainly not believe that a conclusive perception in regard to the world of soul and spirit should be derived from it. The soul is uncertain in this state and cannot yet depend upon what it perceives. But through such experiences it gathers more and more power in order to succeed, also while awake, in warding off the disturbing influences of the physical outer and inner worlds, and thus to acquire the faculty of soul-spirit observation when impressions no longer come through the senses, when the intellect bound to the physical brain is silent, and when consciousness is freed even from the visualizations of meditation by means of which we have only prepared ourselves for spiritual perception.—Whatever is revealed by spiritual science in this or that form should never originate from any other soul-spirit observation than from one that has been made during the state of complete wakefulness.

Two soul experiences are important in the process of spiritual training. Through the one, man may say to himself, “Although I now disregard all the impressions the outer physical world may offer, nevertheless, I do not look into myself as though at a being in whom all activity is extinguished, but I look at one who is conscious of himself in a world of which I know nothing as long as I only permit myself to be stimulated by sense impressions and the ordinary impressions of the intellect.” At this moment the soul has the feeling that it has given birth, in the manner described above, to a new being in itself as the kernel of its soul nature, and this being possesses characteristics quite different from those that previously existed in the soul. The other experience consists in now having the old being like a second alongside the new. What, up to the present, the student knew as enclosing him becomes something that now confronts him, in a certain sense. He feels himself at times outside of what he had otherwise called his own being, his ego. It is as though he now lived in full consciousness in two egos. One of these is the being he has known up to the present. The other stands, like a being newly born, above it. The student feels how the first ego attains a certain independence of the second, just as the body of the human being has a certain independence of the first ego.—This experience is of great significance. For through it the human being knows what it means to live in the world that he strives to reach through training.

The second, the new-born ego, may now be trained to perceive within the spiritual world. There may be developed in this ego what, for the spiritual world, has the same significance the sense organs possess for the sensory-physical world. If this development has advanced to the necessary stage, then the human being will not only feel himself as a new-born ego, but he will now perceive spiritual facts and spiritual beings in his environment, just as he perceives the physical world through the physical senses. This is a third significant experience. In order completely to find his way about at this stage of spiritual training the human being must realize that, with the strengthening of soul powers, self-love and egotism will appear to a degree quite unknown to everyday soul-life. It would be a misunderstanding if someone were to believe that at this point only ordinary self-love is meant. This self-love increases at this stage of development to such a degree that it assumes the appearance of a nature force within the human soul, and in order to vanquish this strong egotism a rigorous strengthening of the will is necessary. This egotism is not produced by spiritual training; it is always present; it only comes to consciousness through spiritual experience. The training of the will must go

hand in hand with the other spiritual training. A strong inclination exists to feel enraptured in the world that we have created for ourselves, and we must, in the manner described above, be able to extinguish, as it were, what we have striven to create with such great effort. In the imaginative world that has thus been reached the student must extinguish himself. Against this however, the strongest impulses of egotism wage war.—The belief may easily arise that the exercises of spiritual training are something external, disregarding the moral evolution of the soul. It must be said concerning this that the moral force that is necessary for the indicated victory over egotism cannot be attained unless the moral condition of the soul is brought to a corresponding level. Progress in spiritual training is not thinkable without a corresponding moral progress. Without moral force the described victory over egotism is not possible. All talk about true spiritual training not being at the same time moral training does not conform to facts. Only the person who does not know such an experience can make the following objection by asking, “How are we to know that we are dealing with realities and not with mere visions, hallucinations, and so forth, when we believe we have spiritual perceptions?”—The facts are such, however, that the student who has reached the characterized stage by proper training is just as able to distinguish his own visualization from spiritual reality as a man with a healthy mind is able to distinguish the thought of a hot piece of iron from an actual one that he touches with his hand. Healthy experience, and nothing else, shows the difference. In the spiritual world also, life itself is the touchstone. Just as we know that in the sense world the mental picture of a piece of iron, be it thought ever so hot, will not burn the fingers, the trained spiritual student knows whether or not he experiences a spiritual fact only in his imaginings or whether real facts or beings make an impression upon his awakened spiritual organs of perception. The general rules that we must observe during spiritual training in order not to fall victim to illusions in this regard will be described later.

It is of greatest importance that the student of the spiritual has acquired a quite definite soul state when he becomes conscious of a new-born ego. For through his ego the human being attains to control of his sensations, feelings, thoughts, instincts, passions, and desires. Perception and thought cannot be left to themselves in the soul. They must be regulated through attentive thinking. It is the ego that employs these laws of thinking and through them brings order into the life of visualization and thought. It is similar with desires, instincts, inclinations, and passions. The ethical principles become guides of these soul powers. Through moral judgment the ego becomes the guide of the soul in this realm. If the human being now draws a higher ego out of his ordinary ego, the latter becomes independent in a certain sense. From this ego just as much of living force is withdrawn as is bestowed upon the higher ego. Let us suppose, however, the case in which the human being has not yet developed a sufficient ability and firmness in the laws of thought and in his power of judgment, and he wishes to give birth to his higher ego at this stage of development. He will be able to leave behind for his everyday ego only so much thought power as he has previously developed. If the measure of regulated thinking is too small, then there will appear a disordered, confused, fantastic thinking and judgment in the ordinary ego that has become independent. Because the new-born ego can only be weak in such a personality, the disturbed lower ego will gain domination over supersensible perception, and man will not show equilibrium in his power of judgment in observing the supersensible world. If he had developed sufficient ability in logical thinking, he would be able, without fear, to permit the ordinary ego to have its independence.—This is also true in the domain of the ethical. If the human being has not attained firmness in moral judgment, if he has not gained sufficient control over his inclinations, instincts, and passions, then he will make his ordinary ego independent in a state in which these soul powers act. It may happen that the human being in describing the knowledge he has experienced in the supersensible is not governed by the same high sense of truth that guides him in what he brings to his consciousness in the physical outer world. With such a demoralized sense of truth, he might believe anything to be spiritual reality that in truth is only his own fantastic imagining. Into this sense of truth there must act firmness of ethical judgment, certainty of character, keenness of conscience, which are developed in the lower, first ego, before the higher, second ego becomes active for the purpose of supersensible cognition.—What is said here must not discourage training, but it must be taken very seriously.

Anyone who has the strong will to do what brings the first ego to inner certainty in the exercise of its functions need not recoil from the liberation of his second ego, brought about through spiritual training

for the sake of supersensible cognition. But he must keep in mind that self-deception has great power over the human being when it is a question of his feeling himself “mature” enough for some step. In the spiritual training described here, man attains such a development of his thought life that it is impossible for him to encounter the dangers of going astray, often presumed to be inevitable. This development of thought acts in such a way that all necessary inner experiences appear, but that they occur in the soul without being accompanied by damaging aberrations of fantasy. Without corresponding thought development the experiences may call forth a profound uncertainty in the soul. The method stressed here causes the experiences to appear in such a way that the student becomes completely familiar with them, just as he becomes familiar with the perceptions of the physical world in a healthy soul state. Through the development of thought life he becomes, as it were, an observer of what he experiences in himself, while, without this thought life, he stands heedless within the experience.

In a factual training certain qualities are mentioned that the student who wishes to find his way into the higher worlds should acquire through practice. These are, above all, control of the soul over its train of thought, over its will, and its feelings. The way in which this control is to be acquired through practice has a twofold purpose. On the one hand, the soul is to be imbued with firmness, certainty, and equilibrium to such a degree that it preserves these qualities, although from its being a second ego is born. On the other hand, this second ego is to be furnished with strength and inner consistency of character.

What is necessary for the thinking of man in spiritual training is, above all, objectivity. In the physical-sensory world, life is the human ego's great teacher of objectivity. Were the soul to let thoughts wander about aimlessly, it would be immediately compelled to let itself be corrected by life if it did not wish to come into conflict with it. The soul must think according to the course of the facts of life. If now the human being turns his attention away from the physical-sensory world, he lacks the compulsory correction of the latter. If his thinking is then unable to be its own corrective, it must become irrational. Therefore the thinking of the student of the spiritual must be trained in such a manner that it is able to give to itself direction and goal. Thinking must be its own instructor in inner firmness and the capacity to hold the attention strictly to one object. For this reason, suitable “thought exercises” are not to be undertaken with unfamiliar and complicated objects, but with those that are simple and familiar. Anyone who is able for months at a time to concentrate his thoughts daily at least for five minutes upon an ordinary object (for example a needle, a pencil, or any other simple object), and during this time to exclude all thoughts that have no bearing on the subject, has achieved a great deal in this regard. (We may contemplate a new object daily, or the same one for several days.) Also, the one who considers himself a thinker as a result of scientific training should not disdain to prepare himself for spiritual training in this manner. For if for a certain length of time we fasten our thoughts upon an object that is well known to us, we can be sure that we think in conformity with facts. If we ask ourselves what a pencil is composed of, how its materials are prepared, how they are brought together afterward, when pencils were invented, and so forth, we then conform our thoughts more to reality than if we reflect upon the origin of man, or upon the nature of life. Through simple thought exercises we acquire greater ability for factual thinking concerning the Saturn, Sun, and Moon evolutions than through complicated and learned ideas. For in the first place it is not at all a question of thinking about this or that, but of thinking factually by means of inner force. If we have schooled ourselves in regard to factuality by a physical-sensory process, easily surveyed, then thought becomes accustomed to function in accordance with facts even though it does not feel itself controlled by the physical world of the senses and its laws, and we rid ourselves of the habit of letting our thoughts wander without relation to facts.

The soul must become a ruler in the sphere of the will as it must be in the world of thought. In the physical-sensory world, it is life itself that appears as the ruler. It emphasizes this or that need of the human being, and the will feels itself impelled to satisfy these needs. In higher training man must become accustomed to obey his own commands strictly. He who becomes accustomed to this will be

less and less inclined to desire the non-essential. Dissatisfaction and instability in the life of will rest upon the desire for things the realization of which we cannot conceive clearly. Such dissatisfaction may bring the entire mental life into disorder when a higher ego is about to emerge from the soul. It is a good practice if one gives oneself for months, at a certain time of the day, the following command: Today, at this definite time, I shall perform this or that action. One then gradually becomes able to determine the time for this action and the nature of the thing to be done so as to permit its being carried out with great exactness. Thus one lifts oneself above the damaging attitude of mind found in, "I should like this, I want that," in which we do not at all consider the possibility of its accomplishment. A great personality—Goethe—lets a seeress say, "Him I love who desires the impossible."2 And Goethe himself says, "To live in the idea means to treat the impossible as though it were possible."3 Such expressions must not be used as objections to what is presented here. For the demand of Goethe and his seeress, Manto, can only be fulfilled by someone who has trained himself to desire what is possible, in order then to be able, through his strong will, to treat the "impossible" so that it is transformed through his will into the possible.

In regard to the world of feeling the soul should attain for spiritual training a certain degree of calmness. It is necessary for that purpose that the soul become ruler over expressions of joy and sorrow, of pleasure and pain. It is just in regard to the acquiring of this ability that much prejudice may result. One might imagine that one would become dull and without sympathy in regard to one's fellowmen if one should not feel joy with the joyful and with the painful, pain. Yet this is not the point in question. With the joyful the soul should rejoice, with sadness it should feel pain. But it should acquire the ability to control the expression of joy and sorrow, of pleasure and pain. If one endeavors to do this, one will soon notice that one does not become less sensitive, but on the contrary more receptive to all that is joyous and sorrowful in one's environment than one was previously. To be sure, if one wishes to acquire the ability with which we are concerned here, one must strictly observe oneself for a long period of time. One must see to it that one is able fully to sympathize with joy and sorrow without losing one's self-control so that one gives way to an involuntary expression of one's feelings. It is not the justified pain that one should suppress, but involuntary weeping; not the horror of an evil action, but the blind rage of anger; not attention to danger, but fruitless fear, and so forth.—Only through such practice does the student of the spiritual attain the tranquility of mind that is necessary to prevent the soul at the birth of the higher ego, and, above all, during its activity, from leading a second, abnormal life like a sort of Doppelganger—soul double—along side this higher ego. It is just in regard to these things that one should not surrender oneself to any sort of self-deception. It may appear to many a one that he already possesses a certain equanimity in ordinary life and therefore does not need this exercise. It is just such a person who doubly needs it. It may be quite possible to be calm when confronting the things of ordinary life, but when one ascends into a higher world, the lack of equilibrium that heretofore was only suppressed may assert itself all the more. It must be grasped that for spiritual training what one already appeared to possess previously is of less importance than the need to practice, according to exact rules, what one lacks. Although this sentence appears contradictory, it is, nevertheless, correct. Even though life has taught us this or that, the abilities we have acquired by ourselves serve the cause of spiritual training. If life has brought us excitability, we should break ourselves of the habit; if life has brought us complacency, then we should through self-education arouse ourselves to such a degree that the expression of the soul corresponds to the impression received. Anyone who never laughs about anything has just as little control of his life as someone who, without any control whatever, is continually given to laughter.

For the control of thought and feeling there is a further means of education in the acquirement of the faculty that we may call positiveness. There is a beautiful legend that tells of how the Christ Jesus, accompanied by some other persons, passed by a dead dog lying on the roadside. While the others turned aside from the hideous spectacle, the Christ Jesus spoke admiringly of the animal's beautiful teeth. One can school oneself in order to attain the attitude of soul toward the world shown by this legend. The erroneous, the bad, the ugly should not prevent the soul from finding the true, the good, and the beautiful wherever it is present. This positiveness should not be confused with non-criticism, with the arbitrary closing of the eyes to the bad, the false, and the inferior. If you admire the "beautiful

teeth" of a dead animal, you also see the decaying corpse. But this corpse does not prevent your seeing the beautiful teeth. One cannot consider the bad good and the false true, but it is possible to attain the ability not to be deterred by evil from seeing good, and by error from seeing truth.

Thought linked with will undergoes a certain maturing if we permit ourselves never to be robbed by previous experiences of the unbiased receptivity for new experiences. For the student of the spiritual the following thought should entirely lose its meaning, "I have never heard that, I do not believe that." It should be his aim, during specific periods of time, to learn something new on every occasion from everything and everybody. From every breath of air, from every leaf, from the babbling of children one can learn something if one is prepared to bring to one's aid a certain point of view that one has not made use of up to the present. It will, however, be easily possible in regard to such an ability to go wide of the mark. One should not in any way disregard, at any particular stage of life, one's previous experiences. One should judge what one experiences in the present by one's experiences of the past. This is placed upon one scale of the balance; upon the other, however, must be placed the inclination of the student continually to experience the new. Above all, there must be faith in the possibility that new experiences may contradict the old.

Thus we have named five capacities of the soul that the student must make his own by correct training: Control of the direction of thought; control of the impulses of will; calmness in joy and sorrow; positiveness in judging the world; impartiality in our attitude toward life. Anyone who has employed certain consecutive periods of time for the purpose of acquiring these capacities will still be subject to the necessity of bringing them into harmonious concord in his soul. He will be under the necessity of practicing them simultaneously, in pairs, or three and one, and so forth, in order to bring about harmony.

The exercises just characterized are indicated by the methods of spiritual training because by being conscientiously carried out they not only effect in the student what has been designated above as a direct result, but indirectly much else follows, which is needed on the path to the spiritual worlds. Whoever carries out these exercises to a sufficient degree will encounter in the process many short comings and defects in his soul-life, and he will find precisely the means required by him for strengthening and safeguarding his intellectual life, his life of feeling, and his character. He will certainly have need of many other exercises, according to his abilities, his temperament, and character; such exercises will follow, however, when those named are sufficiently carried out. The student will indeed notice that the exercises described yield, indirectly and by degrees, what did not in the first place appear to be in them. If, for example, someone has too little self-confidence, he will be able to notice after a certain time that through the exercises the necessary self-confidence has developed. It is the same in regard to other soul characteristics. (Special and more detailed exercises may be found in my book, Knowledge of the Higher Worlds and Its Attainment.)—It is significant that the student of the spiritual be able to increase the indicated abilities to ever higher degrees. He must bring the control of thought and feeling to such a stage that the soul acquires the power of establishing periods of complete inner tranquility, during which the student holds back from his spirit and heart all that everyday outer life brings of joy and sorrow, of satisfaction and affliction, indeed, of duties and demands. During such periods only those things should enter the soul that the soul itself permits to enter during the state of meditation. In regard to this, a prejudice may easily arise. The opinion might develop that the student might become estranged from life and its duties if he withdraws from it in heart and spirit during certain periods of the day. In reality, however, this is not at all the case. Anyone who surrenders himself, in the manner described, to periods of inner tranquility and peace will, during these periods, engender so many and such strong forces for the duties of outer life that as a result he will not, indeed, perform his duties more poorly, but, certainly, in a better fashion.—It is of great benefit if in such periods the student detaches himself completely from the thoughts of his personal affairs, if he is able to elevate himself to what concerns not only himself but mankind in general. If he is able to fill his soul with the communications from the higher spiritual world and if they are able to arouse his interest to just as high a degree as is the case with personal troubles or affairs, then his soul

will gather from it fruit of special value.—Whoever, in this way, endeavors to regulate his soul-life will also attain the possibility of self-observation through which he observes his own affairs with the same tranquility as if they were those of others. The ability to behold one's own experiences, one's own joys and sorrows as though they were the joys and sorrows of others is a good preparation for spiritual training. One gradually attains the necessary degree of this quality if, after one has finished one's daily tasks, one permits the panorama of one's daily experiences to pass before the eyes of the spirit. One must see oneself in a picture within one's experiences; that is, one must observe oneself in one's daily life as though from outside. One attains a certain ability in such self-observation if one begins with the visualization of detached portions of this daily life. One then becomes increasingly clever and skillful in such retrospect, so that, after a longer period of practice, one will be able to form a complete picture within a brief span of time. This looking at one's experiences backward has a special value for spiritual training for the reason that it brings the soul to a point where it is able to release itself in thinking from the previous habit of merely following in thought the course of everyday events. In thought-retrospect one visualizes correctly, but one is not held to the sensory course of events. One needs this exercise to familiarize oneself with the spiritual world. Thought strengthens itself in this way in a healthy manner. It is therefore also good not only to review in retrospect one's daily life, but to retrace in reverse order, for instance, the course of a drama, a narrative, or a melody.—More and more it will become the ideal for the student to relate himself to the life events he encounters in such a way that, with inner certainty and soul tranquility, he allows them to approach him and does not judge them according to his soul condition, but according to their inner significance and their inner value. It is just by looking upon this ideal that he will create for himself the soul basis for the surrender of himself to the above described meditations on symbolic and other thoughts and feelings.

The conditions described here must be fulfilled, because supersensible experience is built upon the foundation on which one stands in everyday soul life before one enters the supersensible world. In a twofold manner all supersensible experience is dependent upon the starting point at which the soul stands before it enters into this world. Anyone who, from the beginning, does not consider making a healthy judgment the foundation of his spiritual training will develop in himself supersensible faculties with which he perceives the spiritual world inexactly and incorrectly. His spiritual organs of perception will, so to speak, unfold incorrectly. Just as one cannot see correctly in the sense world with eyes that are faulty and diseased, one cannot perceive correctly with spiritual organs that have not been constructed upon the foundation of a healthy capacity for judgment.—Whoever makes the start with an immoral soul condition elevates himself to the spiritual world in a way by which his spiritual perception becomes stupefied and clouded. He stands confronting the supersensible worlds like someone observing the sensory world in a stupor. Such a person will, to be sure, make no important statements. The spiritual observer in his state of stupor is, however, more awake than a human being in everyday consciousness. His assertions, therefore, will become errors in regard to the spiritual world.

The object of meditation on the previously characterized symbolic mental images and feelings is, correctly speaking, the development of the higher organs of perception within the human astral body. They are created from the substance of this astral body. These new organs of observation open up a new world, and in this new world man becomes acquainted with himself as a new ego. The new organs of observation are to be distinguished from the organs of the physical sense world through the fact of their being active organs. Whereas eyes and ears remain passive, permitting light and sound to act upon them, the soul-spirit organs of perception are continually active while perceiving and they seize upon their objects and facts, as it were, in full consciousness. This results in the feeling that soul-spirit cognition is the act of uniting with the corresponding facts, is really a “living within them.”—The soul-spirit organs that are being individually developed may, by way of comparison, be called “lotus flowers,” according to the forms which they present imaginatively to supersensible consciousness. (Granted, it must be clear that such a designation has nothing more to do with the case than the expression “chamber” has to do with the case when we speak of the “chamber of the heart.”) Through quite definite methods of inner meditation the astral body is affected in such a way that one or another of the soul-spirit organs, one or another of the “lotus flowers,” is formed. After all that has been described in this book it ought to be superfluous to accentuate the fact that these “organs of

observation” are not to be imagined as something that, in the mental representation of its sense-image, is a picture of its reality. These “organs” are supersensible and consist of a definitely formed soul activity; they exist only as far and as long as this soul activity is practiced. The existence of these organs in the human being produces nothing of a sensory character any more than human thinking produces some sort of a physical “vapor.” Whoever insists on visualizing the supersensory as something sensory becomes involved in misunderstandings. In spite of the superfluity of this remark, it is made here because again and again there are those who accept the supersensory as a fact, but who, in their thoughts, desire only what is sensory, and because again and again there appear opponents of supersensory cognition who believe that the spiritual researcher speaks of “lotus flowers” as though they were delicate, physical structures. Every correct meditation that is made in regard to imaginative cognition has its effect upon one or another organ. (In my book, Knowledge of the Higher Worlds and Its Attainment, certain methods of meditation, and exercises that affect one or another of the organs, are outlined.) Proper training sets up the several exercises of the student of the spiritual and arranges them to follow one another so that the organs are able to develop correspondingly, either singly, in groups, or consecutively. In connection with this development the spiritual student must have great patience and endurance. Anyone having only the measure of patience possessed, as a rule, by most human beings through the ordinary relationships of life will find that this does not suffice. For it takes a long time, often a very long time, before the organs are sufficiently developed to permit their employment by the spiritual student in perceiving the spiritual world. This is the moment when something occurs for him that may be called illumination, in contrast to the preparation or purification consisting of the exercises that develop the organs. (We speak of purification, because the corresponding exercises purify the student in a certain sphere of his inner life of all that springs only from the sensory world of observation.) It may happen that the student, even before his actual illumination occurs, may experience repeatedly “flashes of light” coming from a higher world. He should accept such experiences gratefully. Through them he can already become a witness for the spiritual world. But he should not waver if this does not occur during this period of preparation, which may perhaps seem to him altogether too long. If he exhibits any impatience whatever “because he does not yet see anything,” he has not yet gained the right attitude toward a higher world. This attitude can only be grasped by someone for whom the exercises performed in his training can be, as it were, an end in themselves. These exercises are, in truth, work performed on the soul-spirit nature, that is to say, on the student's own astral body, and although he “sees nothing,” he may “feel” that he is working on his soul-spirit nature. If, however, one forms a definite opinion right at the beginning of what one actually expects to “see,” one will not have this feeling. Then one will consider as nothing what in truth is of immeasurable significance. But one should be subtly observant of everything one experiences during the exercises and that is so fundamentally different from all experiences in the sense world. One will then certainly notice that one's astral body, upon which one is working, is not a neutral substance, but that in it there lives a totally different world of which one knows nothing in one's life of the senses. Higher beings are working upon the astral body, just as the outer physical-sensory world works upon the physical body, and one encounters this higher life in one's own astral body if one does not close oneself to it. If someone repeatedly says to himself, “I perceive nothing!” then, in most cases, he has imagined that spiritual perception must take place in this or that manner, and because he does not perceive what he imagines he should see, he says, “I see nothing!”

If the student has acquired the right attitude toward the exercises of spiritual training, they will constitute something for him that he loves more and more for its own sake. He then knows that through the practice itself he stands in a world of soul and spirit, and with patience and serenity he awaits what will result. This attitude may arise in the consciousness of the student most favorably in the following words, “I will do everything that is proper in the way of exercises, and I know that just as much will come to me at the proper time as is important for me. I do not demand it impatiently, but I am ever ready to receive it.” It is not valid to object that “the spiritual student must thus grope about in the dark, perhaps for an immeasurably long time; for he can only know clearly that he is on the right path in his exercises when the results appear.” It is untrue that only results can bring knowledge of the correctness of the exercises. If the student takes the right attitude toward them, he finds that the satisfaction he draws from the practice gives him the assurance that what he is doing is right; he does not have to wait

for the results. Correct practice in the sphere of spiritual training calls forth satisfaction that is not mere satisfaction, but knowledge that is to say, the knowledge that he is doing something which convinces him that he is making progress in the right direction. Every spiritual student may have this knowledge at every moment, provided he is subtly attentive to his experiences. If he does not employ this attention then the experiences escape him, as is the case with a pedestrian who, lost in thought, does not see the trees on both sides of the road, although he would see them were he to direct his attention to them.—It is not at all desirable that a result be hastened different from the one that must always occur from correct practice. For this result might easily be only the smallest part of what should actually appear. In regard to spiritual development a partial success is often the reason for a strong retardation of the complete success. The movement among such forms of spiritual life that correspond to the partial success dulls the sensitivity in regard to the influences of the forces that lead to higher stages of evolution, and what we may have gained by having "peered" into the spirit world is only an illusion, for this "peering" cannot furnish the truth, but only a mirage.

The psycho-spiritual organs, the lotus flowers, are fashioned so as to appear to supersensible consciousness, in the student undergoing training, as though located in the neighborhood of certain organs of the physical body. From among these soul organs the following will be mentioned here. First, the one that is felt between the eyebrows—the so-called two-petalled lotus flower; the one in the neighborhood of the larynx—the sixteen-petalled lotus flower; a third in the heart region—the twelve-petalled lotus flower; a fourth in the region of the solar plexus. Other similar organs appear in the neighborhood of other parts of the physical body. (The names "two-petalled" or "sixteen-petalled" may be used because the corresponding organs may be likened to flowers of a corresponding number of petals.)

One becomes conscious of the lotus flowers through the astral body. The moment one has developed one or another of these organs, one is aware of its existence. One feels that one can employ it and through its use really enter into a higher world. The impressions that one receives from that world still resemble in many ways those of the physical-sensory world. He who possesses imaginative cognition will be able to speak of the new, higher world in such a way that he designates the impressions as sensations of heat or cold, as perceptions of tones and words, as effects of light and color, for he experiences them as such. But he is aware that these perceptions in the imaginative world express something quite different from sense reality. He recognizes that behind them stand not physical material, but soul-spirit causes. If he experiences something like an impression of heat, he does not, for instance, ascribe it to a piece of hot iron, but he considers it the outflow of a soul process that, up to the present, he has only known in his inner soul-life. He knows that behind imaginative perceptions stand soul and spiritual things and processes just as behind physical perceptions stand material physical beings and facts.—Beside this similarity of the imaginative with the physical world there is, however, a significant difference. Certain phenomena in the physical world appear quite different in the imaginative world. In the former can be observed a continual growth and decay of things, an alternation of birth and death. In the imaginative world a continual transformation of one thing into another takes the place of these phenomena. One sees, for example, the decay of a plant in the physical world. In the imaginative world, in proportion to the withering of the plant the growth of another formation makes its appearance that is not perceptible physically and into which the decaying plant is gradually transformed. When the plant has disappeared, this formation stands completely developed in its place. Birth and death are ideas that lose their significance in the imaginative world. In their place appears the concept of transformation of one thing into another.—Because this is so, the truths about the being of man become accessible to imaginative cognition, truths that have been described in Chapter 2 of this book, entitled "The Essential Nature of Mankind." To physical-sensory perception only the processes of the physical body are perceptible. They occur in the "region of birth and death." The other members of human nature—life body, sentient body, and ego—come under the law of transformation, and perception of them is acquired through imaginative cognition. Whoever has advanced to this point perceives the releasing itself from the physical body of what at death continues to live on in another state of existence.

Development, however, does not stop with the imaginative world. The human being who might wish to stop in this world would perceive the beings undergoing transformation, but he would be unable to explain the processes of transformation; he would be unable to orientate himself in the newly attained world. The imaginative world is an unstable region. In it there exist everywhere constant motion and transformation; nowhere are there points of rest. Such points of rest are attained by man only when he has developed himself beyond the stage of imaginative cognition to the stage that may be called "cognition through inspiration."—It is not necessary that a person who seeks cognition of the supersensible world develop himself in such a way that he advance first to the possession of a full degree of imaginative cognition, and then only advance to "Inspiration." His exercises may be so arranged that what may lead to imagination and to inspiration proceeds hand in hand. He will then, after a certain time, enter a higher world in which he not only perceives, but in which he is able to orientate himself, and which he can interpret. To be sure, this progress will, as a rule, be of such a character that first of all some of the phenomena of the imaginative world manifest themselves to him; then after a time he will experience the feeling, "Now I am beginning to orientate myself."—The world of inspiration is, nevertheless, something quite new in comparison with the world of mere imagination. Through the latter one perceives the transformation of one process into another; through the former one learns to know the inner qualities of beings who transform themselves. Through imagination one learns to know the soul-expression of beings; through inspiration one penetrates into their inner spiritual nature. One recognizes above all a host of spiritual beings and discerns a great number of relationships between one being and another. One has to deal with a multitude of individual beings also in the physical-sensory world; in the world of inspiration, however, this multitude is of a different character. There each being has a quite definite relationship to others, not as in the physical world through external influences, but through its inner constitution. If we perceive a being in the world of inspiration, there is no evidence of an outer influence upon another being, which might be compared with the effect of one physical being upon another, but a relationship exists between two beings through their inner constitution. Let us compare this relationship with a relationship in the physical world, by selecting for comparison the relationship between the separate sounds or letters of a word. Take, for instance, the word "man." It is produced through the concordance of the sounds m-a-n. There is no impulse or other external influence passing over from the m to the a; both sounds act together within the whole through their inner constitution. Therefore observation in the world of inspiration may only be compared with reading,—and the beings in the world of inspiration act upon the observer like the letters of an alphabet, which he must learn to know and the interrelationships of which must unfold themselves to him like a supersensible script. Spiritual science, therefore, may call cognition through inspiration—speaking figuratively—the reading of secret or occult script.

How we may read by means of this occult script, and how we may communicate what is read, will now be made clear by means of the preceding chapters of this book itself. How the human being takes shape out of various members was described at the very outset. It was then shown how the cosmic being, within which the human being develops, passes through the various states of Saturn, Sun, Moon, and Earth. The perceptions through which one can, on the one hand, cognize the members of the human being and, on the other, the consecutive states of the Earth and its preceding transformations, disclose themselves to imaginative knowledge. It is, however, also necessary that it be known what relationships exist between the Saturn state and the human physical body, the Sun state and the ether body, and so forth. It must be shown that the germinal human physical body has come already into existence during the Saturn state, and that it has evolved further to its present form during the Sun, Moon, and Earth states. It was necessary to show also, for example, what transformations have taken place within the human being as a result of the separation of the sun from the Earth, and similarly through the separation of the moon. It was necessary also to describe the powers and beings who co-operated in order that such transformations could occur in humanity as are expressed in the transformations during the Atlantean period and also during the successive periods of the ancient Indian, the ancient Persian, the Egyptian cultures, and the subsequent periods of culture. The description of these relationships does not result from imaginative perception, but from cognition through inspiration, by reading the occult script. For this sort of "reading" the perceptions of imagination are like letter symbols or sounds. This "reading," however, is not only necessary for the

purpose of explaining what has just been described, but it would be impossible to understand the life course of the whole human being were it only perceived through imaginative cognition. One would perceive, indeed, how the soul-spiritual members are released at death from what remains in the physical world, but one would not understand the relationships between what happens to the human being after death and the preceding and succeeding states, were one unable to orientate oneself within the imaginatively perceived.. Without cognition through inspiration the imaginative world would remain like writing at which we stare but which we cannot read.

When the student of the spiritual advances from imagination to inspiration he soon sees how incorrect it would be to relinquish the understanding of the macrocosmic phenomena and to limit himself only to facts that, so to say, touch upon immediate human interests. Someone who is not initiated into these things might well say the following. “It appears to me only necessary to learn about the fate of the human soul after death; if I am told something about that, it will suffice; why does spiritual science wish to demonstrate such distant things as the Saturn or Sun state, and the sun and moon separation, and so forth?” Anyone properly informed about these things learns that real knowledge of what he wishes to know is never acquired without an understanding of what seems to him so unnecessary. A description of the human states after death remains completely unintelligible and worthless if man is unable to connect them with concepts that are derived from such remote matters. Even the simplest observation of the scientist of the supersensible makes his acquaintance with such things necessary. If, for example, a plant makes the transition from blossom to fruit, the human observer of the supersensible sees a transformation taking place in an astral being that during the period of flowering has overshadowed the plant from above and enclosed it like a cloud. Had the fructification not occurred, then this astral being would have made a transition into quite a different shape from the one it has assumed in consequence of fructification. Now one understands the entire process perceived by supersensible observation, if one has learned to understand its nature through the macrocosmic process through which the Earth and all its inhabitants have passed at the time of the sun separation. Before fructification, the plant is in a position similar to the entire Earth prior to the sun separation. After fructification, the plant blossom shows itself in a condition similar to the Earth after the sun had severed itself and the moon forces were still present in it. If one has made one's own the concepts that may be gained by studying the sun separation, one then understands adequately the meaning of the process of plant fructification. One will say that the plant is in a sun state before fructification, in a moon state after it. For it is a fact that even the smallest process in the world may be grasped only if we recognize that it constitutes a copy of macrocosmic processes. Otherwise its very nature remains unintelligible, just as Raphael's Madonna would remain unintelligible if nothing were to be seen but a small blue speck when the rest of the picture were covered up. Everything that occurs in the human being is a copy of macrocosmic processes that have to do with his existence. If one wishes to understand the observations of supersensible consciousness concerning the phenomena occurring between birth and death, and again between death and rebirth, one can do this if one has acquired the faculty of deciphering the imaginative observations through the concepts acquired by the study of the macrocosmic processes.—This study gives us the key to the comprehension of human life. Therefore, in the sense of spiritual science, observation of Saturn, Sun, and Moon is at the same time observation of man.

Through inspiration one acquires the knowledge of the relationships between the beings of the higher world. It is possible through a higher stage of cognition to understand the inner nature of these beings themselves. This stage of cognition may be designated intuitive cognition. (Intuition is a word misused in everyday life for an obscure, uncertain insight into a fact, that is, for a certain idea which at times agrees with truth but the justification of which is at the time not provable. What is meant here has naturally nothing to do with this sort of intuition. Intuition denotes here a cognition of the highest, most illuminating clarity, and, if one has it, one is conscious in the fullest sense of its justification.)—To have knowledge of a sense-being means to stand outside it and to judge it according to the external impression. To have knowledge of a spiritual being through intuition means to have become completely one with it, to have become united with its inner nature. Step by step the student of the spiritual ascends to such knowledge. Imagination leads him to sense the perceptions no longer as outer

characteristics of beings, but to recognize in them the outpouring of something psycho-spiritual; inspiration leads him further into the inner nature of beings. He learns through it to understand what these beings are to each other; with intuition he penetrates into the beings themselves.—The significance of intuition also may be shown by the descriptions given in this book. In the preceding chapters, not only the course of Saturn, Sun, and Moon evolutions was described, but it was told that beings participate in this development in the most varied ways. Thrones or Spirits of Will, Spirits of Wisdom, of Motion, and others were mentioned. In the Earth evolution mention was made of the spirits Lucifer and Ahriman. The construction of the cosmos was traced back to the beings who participate in it. What may be learned about these beings is won through intuitive cognition. This faculty is also necessary if one wishes to have a knowledge of the course of human life. What is released after death from the human bodily nature goes through various states in the subsequent period. The states directly after death might be described in some measure through imaginative cognition. What, however, takes place when man advances further into the period between death and rebirth would have to remain quite unintelligible to imaginative cognition, if inspiration did not come to the rescue. Only inspiration is able to discover what may be said about the life of man in the land of spirits after purification. Then something appears for which inspiration no longer suffices, where it reaches, so to say, the limits of understanding. There is a period in human evolution between death and rebirth when the being of man is accessible only to intuition. This part of the being of man, however, is always present in him; and if we wish to understand it according to its true inner nature, we must investigate it by means of intuition also in the period between birth and death. Whoever wished to fathom the nature of man by means of imagination and inspiration alone, would miss the innermost processes of his being that take place from incarnation to incarnation. Only intuitive cognition, therefore, makes possible an adequate research into repeated earth lives and into karma. The truth communicated about these processes must originate from research by means of intuitive cognition.—If man himself wishes to have a knowledge of his own inner being, he can only acquire this through intuition. By means of it he perceives what progresses in him from earth life to earth life.

Man is able to attain knowledge by means of inspiration and intuition only through soul-spirit exercises. They resemble those that have been described as meditation for the attainment of imagination. While, however, those exercises that lead to imagination are linked to the impressions of the sensory-physical world, this link must disappear more and more in the exercises for inspiration. In order to make clear to himself what has to happen there, let a person consider again the symbol of the rose cross. If he ponders upon this symbol he has an image before him, the parts of which have been taken from the impressions of the sense world: the black color of the cross, the roses, and so forth. The combining of these parts into a rose cross has not been taken from the physical sense world. If now the student of the spirit attempts to let the black cross and also the red roses as pictures of sense realities disappear entirely from his consciousness and only to retain in his soul the spiritual activity that has combined these parts, then he has a means for meditation that leads him by degrees to inspiration. One may place the following question before one's soul. What have I done inwardly in order to combine cross and rose into a symbol? What I have done—my own soul process—I wish to hold fast to; I let the picture itself, however, disappear from my consciousness. Then I wish to feel within me all that my soul has done in order to bring the image into existence, but I do not wish to hold the image itself; I wish to live quite inwardly within my own activity, which has created the image. Thus, I do not intend to meditate on an image, but to dwell in my own image-creating soul activity. Such meditation must be carried out in regard to many symbols. This then leads to cognition through inspiration. Another example would be the following. One meditates on the thought of a growing and decaying plant. One allows to arise in the soul the image of a slowly growing plant as it shoots up out of the seed, as it unfolds leaf on leaf, until it develops flower and fruit. Then again, one meditates on how it begins to fade until its complete dissolution. One acquires gradually by meditating on such an image a feeling of growth and decay for which the plant remains a mere symbol. From this feeling, if this exercise is continued with perseverance, there may arise the imagination of the transformation that underlies physical growth and decay. If one wishes, however, to attain the corresponding state of inspiration, one has to carry out the exercise differently. The student must recall his own soul activity that has gained the visualization of growth and decay from the image of the plant. He must now let the plant disappear

completely from consciousness and only meditate upon what he has himself done inwardly. Only through such exercises is it possible to ascend to inspiration. In the beginning it will not be entirely easy for the student of the spirit to comprehend completely how he should go about such an exercise. The reason for this is that the human being who is accustomed to have his inner life determined by outer impressions immediately finds himself uncertain and wavering when he has to unfold a soul-life that has discarded all connection with outer impressions. In a still higher degree than in the acquiring of imagination the student must be clear, in regard to these exercises that lead to inspiration, that he ought only to carry them out when he accompanies them with all those precautionary measures that can lead to safeguarding and strengthening of his power of discrimination, his life of feeling, and his character. If he takes these precautions, then he will have a twofold result. In the first place, he will not, through these exercises, lose the equilibrium of his personality during supersensible perception; secondly, he will at the same time gain the faculty of being able actually to carry out what is required in these exercises. He will maintain in regard to them that they are difficult only so long as he has not yet acquired a quite definite soul condition, quite definite feelings and sensations. He will soon gain understanding and also ability for the exercises, if in patience and perseverance he fosters in his soul such inner faculties as favor the unfolding of supersensible knowledge. If he grows accustomed to withdrawing into himself frequently in such a way that he is less concerned with brooding on himself than with quietly arranging and working over his life-experiences, he will gain much. He will see that his thoughts and feelings are enriched if he brings one life-experience into relationship with another. He will become aware to what a high degree he experiences something new not only by having new impressions and new experiences, but also by permitting the old to work in him. If he sets to work in such a way that he lets his experiences, indeed, even his acquired opinions, play back and forth as though he were not at all involved in them with his sympathies and antipathies, with his personal interests and feelings, he will prepare an especially good soil for the forces of supersensible cognition. He will develop, in truth, what may be called a rich inner life. The question of chief importance here, however, is equanimity and equilibrium of the soul qualities. Man is only too easily inclined, if he surrenders himself to a certain soul activity, to fall into one-sidedness. For example, if he becomes aware of the advantage of inner meditation and of dwelling in his own thought world, he may develop such an inclination toward it that he begins to shut himself off from the impressions of the outer world. This, however, leads to the withering and devastation of the inner life. Those go the farthest who preserve, alongside the ability to withdraw inwardly, an open receptivity to all impressions of the outer world. One need not think here merely of the so-called important impressions of life, but every man in every situation—even in the poorest surroundings—may have sufficient experiences if he only keeps his mind sufficiently receptive. One need not seek the experiences; they are present everywhere.—Of special importance also is the way experiences are transformed in the human soul. For example, somebody may discover that a person revered by him or others has this or that quality that may be viewed as a fault of character. Such an experience may cause the human being to meditate in a twofold manner. He may simply say to himself, “Now, that I have recognized this fault, I can no longer revere this person in the same way as formerly.” Or he may pose the following question to himself, “How does it happen that this revered person is afflicted with this fault? Should I not consider that this fault is not merely a fault, but something due to the circumstances of this person's life, perhaps even to his great capacities?” A human being posing this question to himself will perhaps arrive at the result that his reverence is not in the least to be decreased by the discovery of such a fault. He will have learned something every time he goes through such an experience; he will have added something to his understanding of life. It would, however, certainly be disastrous to the human being were he to let himself be misled by the merit of such a view of life to excuse everything he possibly can in people and things for whom he has a preference, or even to form the habit of disregarding all faults because it brings him advantage for his inner development. This will not be the case if he has the subjective impulse not merely to censure faults but to understand them; it will occur when this attitude is demanded by the case in question, regardless of the gain or loss to him who judges. It is entirely correct that one cannot learn through condemning faults, but only through understanding them. If, however, because of understanding, one should entirely exclude disapproval, one would not get very far either. Here also it is not a question of one-sidedness in either direction, but of equanimity and equilibrium of the soul powers.—It is especially so with a soul quality that is of great significance for

the development of the human being; this is what is called the feeling of reverence or devotion. Those who have developed this feeling in themselves or possess it from the outset through a fortunate gift of nature have an excellent basis for the forces of supersensible knowledge. The person who in childhood or youth has been able to look up with self-surrendering admiration to personalities as though to high ideals, possesses something at the foundation of his soul in which supersensible cognition thrives especially well. And whoever with mature judgment in later life looks upon the starry heavens and feels with wonder in complete surrender the revelation of exalted powers makes himself thus mature for knowledge of supersensible worlds. Something similar is the case with those who are able to admire the forces ruling in human life, and it is not of little importance if we, even as mature human beings, can have reverence to the highest degree for other men whose worth we divine or believe we know. Only where such reverence is present can the view into the higher world open up. The person who is unable to revere will in no way advance very far in his knowledge. Whoever does not wish to acknowledge anything in the world will find that the essential nature of things is closed to him.—The person, however, who permits himself to be misled, through an unrestrained feeling of reverence and surrender, to deaden in himself a healthy consciousness of self and self-confidence sins against the law of equanimity and equilibrium. The student will continually work on himself in order to make himself more and more mature; he is then justified in having confidence in his own personality and in having faith that its powers will continually increase. If he achieves correct feelings in this direction he may say to himself, “In me there lie hidden forces and I can draw them forth from my inner being. Therefore, when I see something that I must revere because it stands above me, I need not only revere it, but I may hope to develop myself to such a degree that I become similar to what I revere.”

The greater the capacity of a human being to direct his attention to certain processes of life with which his personal judgment is not, at the outset, familiar, the greater the possibility for him to lay the foundation for a development into the spiritual worlds. An example may make this clear. A man is in a certain situation in life where he may perform a certain deed or leave it undone. His judgment suggests to him: Do this! But there may be a certain inexplicable something in his feelings that holds him back from the deed. Now it may be that he does not pay any attention to this inexplicable something that seeks to restrain him, but simply performs the deed, according to his capacity to judge. Or he may surrender to the urge of this inexplicable something and leave the deed undone. If he then follows up the matter further it may become evident that evil would have been the result had he followed his judgment, but that by non-performance of the deed, a blessing has ensued. Such an experience may lead man's thoughts into a quite definite direction. He may say to himself, “Something lives in me that is a better guide than my present capacity of judgment. I must hold my mind open to this ,something in me that cannot at all be reached by the present degree of my capacity of judgment.” The soul is benefited to the highest degree when it directs its attention toward such occurrences in life. It then becomes aware, as though in a state of healthy premonition, that something exists in man that transcends his present ability to judge. Through such attention the human being directs his efforts toward an extension of soul-life, but here also it is possible that one-sidedness may result that is dangerous. Whoever were to form the habit of disregarding his judgment because his “premonitions” impel him to this or that, would become the plaything of all sorts of uncertain impulses, and from such a habit it is not a great distance to complete lack of judgment and superstition.—Any sort of superstition is fatal to the student of the spiritual. He acquires the possibility of penetrating in a true way into the regions of spiritual life only by guarding himself carefully against superstition, fantastic ideas, and day-dreaming. No one can enter the spirit world in the right way who is happy in experiencing something that “cannot be grasped by the human mind.” A preference for the “inexplicable” certainly makes no one a student of the spirit. He must completely abandon the notion that “a mystic is someone who presumes wherever it suits him something inexplicable and unfathomable in the world.” The student shows the proper feeling by acknowledging this existence of hidden forces and beings everywhere, but also by assuming that the uninvestigated may be investigated if the necessary powers are present.

There is a certain attitude of soul that is important for the student of the spirit at every stage of his development. This consists in not directing his desire for knowledge in a one-sided way by asking,

“How may this or that question be answered?” but by asking, “How do I develop this or that ability in myself?” If then by inner patient work in himself this or that faculty is developed, the answer to certain questions is received. Students of the spirit will always foster this attitude of soul. Through this they are led to work on themselves, to make themselves more and more mature, and to renounce the desire to force answers to certain questions. They will wait until such answers come to them.—If, however, they become one-sided here also, they will not advance properly. The student may also have the feeling at a certain point of his development that he, with the degree of his ability, can himself answer the most sublime questions. Here also equanimity and equilibrium play an important role in the attitude of soul.

Many more soul faculties could be described, the fostering and development of which are beneficial when the student strives by means of exercises to attain inspiration. In all of them, we should have to emphasize that equanimity and equilibrium are the soul faculties upon which everything depends. They prepare the understanding and the ability to carry out the exercises outlined for the purpose of acquiring inspiration.

The exercises for the attainment of intuition demand that the student cause not only the images, to which he has surrendered himself in acquiring imagination, to disappear from his consciousness, but also the life within his own soul activity into which he has immersed himself for the acquirement of inspiration. He should then literally retain nothing in his soul of previously known outer or inner experiences. Were there to be, however, nothing left in his consciousness after this discarding of outer and inner experiences, that is to say, were his consciousness then entirely to disappear and he to sink down into unconsciousness, this would then make it clear to him that he had not yet made himself mature enough to undertake exercises for intuition; he would then have to continue the exercises for imagination and inspiration. A time will surely come when the consciousness is not empty after the soul has discarded all inner and outer experiences, but when, after this discarding, something remains in consciousness as an effect, to which we then may surrender in meditation just as we had previously surrendered to what owes its existence to outer or inner impressions. This something is of a quite special character. It is, in contrast to all preceding experiences, something entirely new. When one experiences it one knows, “This I have not known before. It is a perception just as the real tone, heard by the ear, is a perception, but this something can only enter my consciousness through intuition, just as the tone can only enter my consciousness through the ear.” Through intuition man's impressions are stripped of the last trace of the sensory-physical; the spiritual world now begins to open itself to cognition in a form that no longer has anything in common with the qualities of the physical world of the senses.

Imaginative consciousness is attained through the development of the lotus flowers in the astral body. Through the exercises that are undertaken for acquiring inspiration and intuition, certain definite motions, forms, and currents appear in the human ether or life body that were not present previously. They are in fact the organs through which man adds to the scope of his faculties the “reading of the occult script,” and what lies beyond it. The changes in the ether body of a human being who has attained inspiration and intuition present themselves to supersensible cognition in the following manner. Somewhere in the neighborhood of the physical heart a new center becomes conscious in the ether body, which develops into an etheric organ. From this organ, movements and currents flow to the various members of the human body in the most manifold way. The most important of these currents flow to the lotus flowers, permeating them and their various petals, then proceeding outward, pouring themselves like radiations into external space. The more the human being is developed, the greater the sphere around him within which these radiations are perceptible. The center in the region of the heart does not, however, develop immediately at the start of correct training. It is first prepared. There appears, to begin with, a temporary center in the head; this then moves down into the neighborhood of the larynx and finally settles in the region of the physical heart. Were its development irregular, then the organ of which we have been speaking might immediately be formed in the neighborhood of the heart. In that case there would be danger that the student, instead of attaining quiet and factual supersensible perception, would become a visionary and fantast. As he develops further, the student

acquires the ability to free the currents and structures of his ether body from his physical body and to use them independently. In doing this, the lotus flowers serve him as organs through which he brings the ether body into motion. Before this occurs, however, special currents and radiations must have formed in the sphere of the ether body, enclosing it like a fine network and making it into a self-contained being. If that has happened, the movements and currents taking place in the ether body are able to come into unhindered contact with the outer world of soul and spirit and to unite with it, so that outer occurrences in the realm of soul and spirit and inner events in the human ether body flow into one another. If that happens, the moment has arrived when man perceives the world of inspiration consciously. This cognition occurs in a different way from cognition in the sensory-physical world. In the latter we gain perceptions through the senses and form from them mental images and concepts. This is not the case with the knowledge derived from inspiration. What one knows is immediately present in the act; there is no reflection after perception. What sensory-physical cognition gains only afterwards in concepts is, in inspiration, given simultaneously with perception. Man would therefore merge with the environment of soul and spirit and would not be able to distinguish himself from it had he not developed the above characterized network in the ether body.

If the exercises leading to intuition are carried out, their effect extends not only to the ether body, but right down into the supersensible forces of the physical body. One should not, however, think that in this way effects take place in the physical body that are accessible to everyday sensory observation. These are effects that only supersensory cognition can judge. They have nothing whatever to do with external cognition. They are the results of the maturity of consciousness, when the latter is able to have experiences in intuition, in spite of the fact that it has excluded all previously known outer and inner experiences.—The experiences of intuition are delicate, intimate, and subtle, and the human physical body is, at the present stage of its evolution, coarse in comparison. It offers therefore a strong hindrance to the success of intuition exercises. If these are continued with energy and persistence and with the requisite inner tranquility, the powerful hindrances of the physical body are finally overcome. The student notices this by the fact that gradually certain expressions of the physical body that formerly took place unconsciously now come under his control. He notices it also by the fact that for a short time he feels the need, for example, so to control the breath that it comes into a sort of concord or harmony with what the soul performs in the exercises or otherwise in inner meditation. The ideal of the development is that no exercises be made at all by means of the physical body itself, also no breathing exercises, but that everything that occurs in the physical body in this way should only come about as a consequence of pure intuition exercises.

If the student of the spirit ascends upon the path into the higher worlds of knowledge, he notices at a certain stage that the cohesion of the forces of his personality assumes a different form from the one in the physical-sensory world, where the ego effects a uniform co-operation of the soul forces, of thinking, feeling, and willing. These three soul forces stand always in a certain relationship to each other in the conditions of ordinary human life. One sees, for example, a certain object in the outer world. It pleases or displeases the soul. That is to say, of necessity the visualizing of a thing will be followed by a feeling of pleasure or displeasure. One may, perhaps, desire the object or have the impulse to alter it in one way or another. That is, the power of desire and will associate with visualizing and feeling.

That this co-ordination takes place is caused by the ego uniting visualizing (thinking), feeling, and willing and in this way bringing order into the forces of the personality. This healthy order would be interrupted if the ego were to prove powerless in this regard; if, for example, desire should elect to go a different way from feeling or thinking. A human being would not be in a healthy soul condition who might think that this or that is right, but who might want something of which he is convinced that it is not right. The case would be similar if someone did not want what pleases him, but rather what displeases him. The human being now notices that on the path to higher knowledge thinking, feeling, and willing do indeed separate and each assumes a certain independence. For example, a certain thought has no longer an inward urge toward a certain feeling and willing. The matter is as follows. In

thinking something may be perceived correctly, but in order to have any feeling or to come to a resolution of the will, we need again an independent impulse from ourselves. During supersensible perception thinking, feeling, and willing do not remain three forces that radiate from the common egocenter of the personality, but they become three independent entities, three personalities, as it were; one must now make one's own ego all the stronger, for it is not merely a matter of its bringing three forces into order, but of leading and directing three entities. This separation, however, must only exist during supersensible perception. Here again it becomes clear how important it is that the exercises for higher training be accompanied by those that give certainty and firmness to the power of judgment, and to the life of feeling and willing. For the person who does not bring these qualities with him into the higher world will soon see how the ego proves weak and unable to act as an orderly guide for thinking, feeling, and willing. If this weakness were present, the soul would be as though torn by three personalities in as many directions and its inner unity would cease. If, however, the development of the student proceeds in the right way the described transformation of forces signifies true progress; the ego remains master of the independent entities that now form its soul.—In the further course of this evolution the development continues. Thinking that has become independent stimulates the emergence of a special fourth soul-spirit being that may be described as a direct influx of currents into man, similar to thoughts. The entire cosmos then appears as a thought-structure confronting man as does the plant or animal world in the realm of the physical senses. Likewise, feeling and willing that have become independent stimulate two forces in the soul that act in it like independent beings. Still another seventh power and being appears that is similar to one's own ego itself.

This entire experience is connected with yet another. Before his entrance into the supersensible world, man knew thinking, feeling, and willing only as inner soul experiences. As soon as he enters the supersensible world he perceives objects that do not express the physical-sensory, but the psycho-spiritual. Behind the characteristics of the new world now perceived by him stand soul-spirit beings. These now stand before him as an outer world, just as in the physical realm stones, plants, and animals stood before his senses. The student of the spiritual can now perceive an important difference between the world of soul and spirit that reveals itself to him, and the world that he was accustomed to perceiving through his physical senses. A plant in the world of the senses remains just as it is, whatever the human soul may feel or think about it. With the images of the world of soul and spirit this is, at the outset, not the case. They alter according to what the human being feels or thinks. In this way he gives them form that depends upon his own nature. Let us imagine that a certain picture appears before man in the world of imagination. If, at first, he remains indifferent to it in his soul, it then shows itself in a certain form. At the moment, however, when pleasure or displeasure is felt in regard to the picture, it changes its form. The pictures therefore, in the first instance, express not only what they are, independent of man, but they reflect what man is himself. They are permeated through and through by his own nature. The latter spreads like a veil over the supersensible beings. Although real beings confront him, he does not see them, but instead, his own creation. Thus he may have something true before him and, nevertheless, see something false. Indeed, this is not only the case in regard to what man notices in himself as his own essential nature, but everything that is in him affects this world. He may have, for example, hidden inclinations that do not come into evidence in life because of his education and character; they affect the world of the soul and spirit, which takes on a peculiar coloring through the whole being of man, no matter whether he himself knows much about this being or not.—In order to be able to advance further from this stage of development it is necessary that man learn to distinguish between himself and the outer spiritual world. It is necessary that he learn to eliminate all the effects of himself upon his soul-spirit environment. This cannot be done otherwise than by acquiring a knowledge of what he himself carries into the new world. It is therefore important that he first possess true, thoroughly developed self-knowledge, in order to be able to have a clear perception of the surrounding world of soul and spirit. Now, certain facts of human development demand that such self-knowledge must take place quite naturally at the time of the entrance into the higher world. Man develops his ego, his self-consciousness in the everyday physical-sensory world. This ego now acts as a center of attraction for everything belonging to man. All his inclinations, sympathies, antipathies, passions, and opinions group themselves, as it were, around his ego, and this ego is also the point of attraction for what may be designated as the karma of man. If this ego were to be seen

unconcealed it would show that certain forms of destiny must still be encountered by it in this and in subsequent incarnations, according to the way it has lived in the preceding incarnations and has made this or that its own. Invested with all this, the ego must appear as the first image before the human soul when the latter ascends into the world of soul and spirit. This Doppelganger (double or twin likeness) of man must, according to a law of the spiritual world, emerge prior to everything else as his first impression in that world. One may easily make the law underlying this fact understandable if one considers the following. In the life of the physical senses man only perceives himself in so far as he experiences himself inwardly in his thinking, feeling, and willing. This, however, is an inner perception; it does not present itself to the human being like stones, plants, and animals. Also, man learns to know himself only partially through inner perception. He has something in himself that prevents his having more profound self-knowledge. This is an impulse to transform immediately a trait of character if he, as a result of self-knowledge, must admit to it and does not wish to deceive himself about himself.

If he does not follow this impulse, if he simply turns his attention away from himself, remaining what he is, then he, naturally, also deprives himself of the possibility of self-knowledge in the point in question. If man, however, penetrates into himself and confronts himself without deception with this or that trait, then he will either be in the position to improve the trait, or he will be incapable of doing so under the present circumstances of his life. In the latter case a feeling will creep over his soul that must be described as a feeling of shame. This is indeed the reaction of healthy human nature: it feels through self-knowledge various kinds of shame. This feeling has even in ordinary life a quite definite effect. The normally thinking human being will take care that what fills him, through himself, with this feeling does not become evident outwardly in effects, does not manifest in outer deeds. Shame is thus a force that impels man to conceal something in his inner being and not allow it to become outwardly perceptible. If we give this due consideration, we shall find it comprehensible that spiritual research ascribes much farther reaching effects to an inner soul experience that is closely related to the feeling of shame. This research finds that there is, concealed in the depths of the soul, a sort of hidden shame of which the human being is not conscious in physical-sensory life. This concealed feeling, however, acts in a similar manner to the feeling of shame in everyday life; it prevents the innermost nature of the human being from appearing before him in a perceptible picture. If this feeling were not present, the human being would perceive before him what he is in truth; his thoughts, feelings, and will would not only be experienced inwardly, but would be perceived outwardly just as stones, animals, and plants are perceived. This feeling is thus the concealer of man from himself, and at the same time it is the concealer of the entire world of soul and spirit. Owing to the fact that his inner nature is concealed from him, he is also not able to perceive that by means of which he should develop inner organs in order to cognize the world of soul and spirit; he is unable so to transform his nature that it may unfold spiritual organs of perception.—If, however, through correct training man strives to acquire these organs of perception, what he himself is appears to him as first impression. He perceives his Doppelganger, his double. This self-perception is not at all to be separated from the perception of the rest of the world of soul and spirit. In everyday life of the physical-sensory world, the feeling characterized acts so as constantly to close the door of the world of soul and spirit to the human being. Even the mere attempt to penetrate into this world causes the feeling of shame—which arises immediately, but of which we do not become conscious—to conceal the part of the world of soul and spirit that strives to appear. The exercises characterized open the door to this world. It is a fact, however, that this concealed feeling acts like a great benefactor of man. For all that man acquires of power of judgment, feeling-life, and character without spiritual-scientific training does not enable him to bear without further preparation the perception of his own being in its true form. He would lose through this perception all self-esteem, self-confidence, and self-consciousness. That this may not happen, we must take the necessary precautions which we do undertake, alongside the exercises for higher knowledge, in the fostering of a healthy power of judgment, feeling-life, and character. Through this regular training man learns to know so much of spiritual science—as though without intention—and, moreover, so many means for the attainment of self-knowledge and self-observation become clear to him as are necessary in order to encounter his Doppelganger bravely. The student then only sees in another form, as a picture of the imaginative world, what he has already learned in the physical world.

If he has first comprehended the law of karma properly in the physical world through his intellect, he will not be especially shaken when he now sees the beginnings of his destiny engraved in the image of his Doppelganger. If man has made himself acquainted through his power of judgment with the evolution of the cosmos and mankind and knows how, at a certain point of time of this evolution, the forces of Lucifer have penetrated into the human soul, he will bear it without difficulty when he becomes aware that the Luciferic beings with all their effects are contained within the image of his own nature.—We see from this how necessary it is that man does not demand entrance into the spiritual world before he has understood, through his ordinary power of judgment developed in the physical-sensory world, certain truths about the spiritual world. The knowledge given in this book prior to the discussion about “Cognition of the Higher Worlds” should have been acquired by the student of spiritual science by means of his ordinary power of thought in the regular course of development, before he has the desire himself to enter into supersensible worlds.

In a training in which no attention is paid to the certainty and firmness of the power of judgment, of the life of feeling and character, it may happen that the student encounters the higher world before he possesses the necessary inner faculties. In that case the encounter with his Doppelganger would depress him and lead to error. If, however, the encounter were entirely avoided—something that might indeed be possible—and man nevertheless were led into the supersensible world, he would then be just as little in the position to recognize that world in its true shape. For it would be quite impossible for him to distinguish between what he carries over as projections of himself into things and what they are in reality. This distinction is only possible if one perceives one's own being as an image in itself, and if, as a result of this distinction, everything that flows from one's own inner nature becomes detached from the environment.—For man's life in the physical-sensory world, the Doppelganger's effect is such that he becomes immediately invisible through the feeling of shame characterized when man approaches the world of soul and spirit. As a result of this, he conceals the entire latter world also. Like a “guardian” he stands there before that world, in order to deny entrance to those who are not truly capable of entering. He may therefore be called the “guardian of the threshold that lies before the world of soul and spirit.”—Besides the described encounter with the guardian at the entrance into the supersensible world, man also encounters him when passing through physical death, and in the course of life between death and a new birth the guardian discloses himself by degrees in the evolution of soul and spirit. There, however, the encounter cannot depress the human being, because he then has knowledge of worlds quite different from those he knows in the life between birth and death.

If, without encountering the “guardian of the threshold,” man were to enter the world of soul and spirit, he might fall prey to deception after deception. For he would never be able to distinguish between what he himself has carried over into that world and what in reality belongs to it. A proper training must lead the student of spiritual science into the realm of truth only, not into the realm of illusion. This training will of itself be of such a nature that the encounter must of necessity take place sometime. For it is one of the precautionary measures, indispensable for the observation of supersensible worlds, against the possibility of falling prey to deception and the fantastic.—It belongs to the most indispensable measures that every student of spiritual science must take, to work carefully on himself in order not to become a fantast, a human being who might succumb to possible deception and self-delusion. Where the advice for spiritual training is correctly followed, the sources that may bring deception are at the same time destroyed. Naturally, we cannot speak at length here of all the numerous details that have to be considered in regard to such precautionary measures. The important points can only be indicated. Deceptions that have to be considered here are derived from two sources. They originate in part from the coloring of reality through one's own soul nature. In ordinary life of the physical-sensory world there is comparatively little danger from this source of deception; for here the outer world continually impresses its own form sharply upon our observation, no matter how the observer wants to color it according to his own wishes and interests. As soon, however, as man enters the imaginative world, its pictures are transformed through such wishes and interests, and he has before him, like a reality, what he himself has formed, or at least has helped in forming. This source of deception is removed by the student's having learned to recognize, through his encounter with the “guardian of the threshold,” his own inner nature, which he might thus carry into the world of soul and spirit. The preparation that the

student of spiritual science undergoes before his entrance into the world of soul and spirit acts in such a way that he becomes accustomed to disregarding himself even when observing the physical-sensory world and to permitting the objects and processes to speak to him purely out of their own nature. If the student has thus prepared himself sufficiently, he can calmly await the encounter with the “guardian of the threshold.” This encounter will be the final test to determine whether he feels himself really in a position to disregard his own nature also when he confronts the world of soul and spirit.

Besides this source of delusion, there is still another. This comes into evidence when one misinterprets an impression made on one. A simple example of this sort of delusion in the physical sense-life is the delusion that arises when a man sits in a railway coach moving in a certain direction and believes the trees and other objects of perception are moving in the opposite direction, while actually it is he himself who is moving with the train. Although there are numerous cases where such delusions In the physical sense-world are more difficult to correct than the simple one quoted, still, it is easy to see that within this world one also finds the means of disposing of such delusions when, with sound judgment, one takes into consideration all that may possibly contribute to an adequate factual explanation. The matter is different, however, as soon as one penetrates into the realms of the supersensible. In the world of the senses facts are not altered as a result of human delusion; therefore it is possible, by means of unprejudiced observation, to rectify the delusion by means of the facts. In the supersensible world this is not immediately possible. If one wants to observe a supersensible process and approaches it with false judgment, one carries this judgment over into the process and it becomes so interwoven with the fact that it is impossible to distinguish the judgment from the fact. The error is then not within the human being and the correct fact outside him, but the error itself is made a component of the outer fact. It cannot, therefore, be rectified simply by an unbiased observation of the fact. We are here pointing to what may be a superabundant source of delusion and the fantastic for those who approach the supersensible world without proper preparation.—The student of the spiritual, besides acquiring the ability to exclude the delusions that arise through the coloring of supersensible world-phenomena with his own nature, must also acquire the ability to make the second indicated source of delusion ineffective. He can exclude what comes from himself if he has first recognized the image of his own Doppelganger. He will be able to exclude the second source of delusion if he acquires the ability to recognize, from the inner quality of a supersensible fact, whether it is reality or delusion. If the delusion were to appear exactly like the actual facts, then a distinction would not be possible. This, however, is not the case. Delusions of the supersensible world have qualities in themselves by which they are to be distinguished from realities, and it is important that the student of the spiritual know by which qualities he can recognize realities. Nothing is more self-evident than the fact that anyone ignorant of spiritual training may ask, “How is it at all possible to protect myself against delusion, when its sources are so numerous?” And he may continue to ask, “Is there any proof for the student of the spiritual against the fact that all his professed higher knowledge is not something based on mere delusion and autosuggestion?” Anyone who asks such questions does not realize that in true spiritual training, through the very manner of its occurrence, the sources of delusion are stopped up. In the first place, in preparing himself the true spiritual science student will acquire sufficient knowledge about what may cause delusion and autosuggestion, and thus be in a position to protect himself from them. He has, in this regard, more opportunity than any other human being to make himself prudent and capable in judgment on the path of life. Everything that he experiences causes him to disregard indefinite premonitions and suggestions. This training makes him as careful as possible. Besides this, all correct training leads first to concepts about great cosmic events, and thus to things that make necessary the exertion of sound judgment, which becomes, at the same time, more refined and acute. Only someone who might refuse to go into such distant realms and preferred to abide with “revelations” of a world near at hand might lose the strengthening of that sound judgment that gives him certainty in distinguishing between delusion and reality. All of this, however, is not yet the most important. That lies in the exercises themselves that are used in a correct spiritual training. These must be so arranged that the student is always consciously aware of what takes place in the soul during inner meditation. In order to bring about imagination, a symbol is first formed. In this symbol are still contained mental images of outer perceptions. The human being is not alone responsible for the content of these mental images; he does not make it himself. Thus he may delude himself in regard to

its origin; he may interpret its origin incorrectly. But the student of spiritual science removes this content from his consciousness when he advances to the exercises of inspiration. Here he contemplates his own soul activity only, which has formed the symbol. Here also error is still possible. Through education, learning, and through other means man has acquired the character of his soul activity. He cannot know everything about its origin. The student of spiritual science now removes even his own soul activity from his consciousness. If now anything remains in his consciousness, nothing is attached to it that cannot be surveyed. Nothing can intermingle with it that is not to be judged in regard to its whole content. In intuition, the student of spiritual science has thus a criterion enabling him to recognize how a clear reality of the world of soul and spirit is constituted. If he now applies the signs of soul and spirit-reality thus recognized to everything that comes under his observation, he is able to distinguish between illusion and reality. He may be certain that by employing this law he will remain protected from illusion in the supersensible world just as it cannot happen to him in the physical-sensory world to mistake an imaginary piece of hot iron for one that really burns. It is taken for granted that one only takes this attitude toward the knowledge one regards as one's own experiences in the supersensible worlds, and not toward what one receives as communications from other persons and that one comprehends with one's physical intellect and sound feeling for truth. The student of the spiritual will take pains to draw an exact line between what he has acquired in the one way and what he has acquired in the other. He will receive willingly, on the one hand, the communications about the higher worlds and seek to understand them by means of his capacity to judge. If on the other hand he states something as his own experience, his own observation, he will have tested whether this has confronted him with precisely the qualities he has learned to perceive by means of unerring intuition.

After the student of the spiritual has encountered the “guardian of the threshold,” further experiences await him as he ascends into supersensible worlds. First he will notice that an inner relationship exists between this “guardian of the threshold” and the soul-power that, in the above description, has resulted as the seventh, and has shaped itself into an independent principle. Indeed, this seventh principle is in a certain regard nothing else but the Doppelganger, the “guardian of the threshold” himself, and this principle sets the student of the spiritual a special task. He has to direct and lead with his newborn self what he is in his ordinary self and which appears to him in an image. A sort of battle against the Doppelganger will result. The latter will constantly strive for supremacy. To establish the right relationship to this Doppelganger and not permit him to do anything that is not under the influence of the newborn ego strengthens and fortifies man's powers.—In the higher world, self-knowledge is different, in a certain respect, from self-knowledge in the physical-sensory world. Whereas in the physical-sensory world self-knowledge appears only as an inner experience, the newborn self presents itself at once as an outer soul phenomenon. Man beholds his newborn self as another being standing before him, but he cannot perceive it completely. For whatever stage he may have reached upon the way into the supersensible worlds, there are always still higher stages. At these stages he will perceive ever more and more of his “higher self.” This “higher self” can thus only partially reveal itself to the student of the spiritual at any of these stages. The temptation is extremely great which overtakes the human being when he first becomes aware of some aspect of his “higher self,” to observe this “higher self,” so to speak, from the standpoint he has gained in the physical-sensory world. This temptation is even good and it must appear, if development is to proceed in the right way. We must observe what appears in the Doppelganger, the “guardian of the threshold,” and place it before the “higher self” in order to note the contrast between what we are and what we are to become. Through this observation the “guardian of the threshold” begins to take on quite a different form. He presents himself as an image of all the hindrances that the development of the higher self must encounter. The student will perceive what a load he must drag in the form of his ordinary self, and if he is not strong enough through his preparations to say, “I will not remain stationary here, but unceasingly strive to reach my higher self,” he will slacken his efforts and shrink back before what is in store for him. He has plunged into the world of soul and spirit, but now gives up his efforts. He becomes a prisoner of the form that, through the “guardian of the threshold,” now stands before the soul. What is important here is the fact that in this experience he does not have the feeling of being a prisoner. On the contrary, he believes he experiences something quite different. The form that the “guardian of the threshold” calls forth can be of such a nature that it causes the impression in the soul of the observer of having before him, in the

pictures that appear at this evolutionary stage, the entire compass of all imaginable worlds, of having attained the pinnacle of knowledge, with no need of striving further. Instead of feeling to be a prisoner he may feel himself as the immeasurably rich possessor of all the world mysteries. The fact that one can have such an experience that depicts the very opposite of the actual facts will, however, not astonish a person who keeps in mind the fact that, when he experiences this, he stands already in the world of soul and spirit and that it is a peculiarity of this world that events may present themselves in reverse order. This fact was pointed out earlier in this book when life after death was discussed.

The figure that one perceives at this stage of development shows the student of the spiritual something in addition to what appeared to him in the first instance as the "guardian of the threshold." In this Doppelganger all the peculiarities were perceived that the ordinary self of man has in consequence of the influence of the forces of Lucifer. Now, however, in the course of human evolution another power has entered the human soul through the influence of Lucifer. This is the power that was designated in an earlier section of this book as the power of Ahriman. It is the power that prevents the human being during physical sense-existence from perceiving the soul-spirit beings of the outer world lying behind the veil of the sensory. The form the human soul has assumed under the influence of this power is shown in a picture by the shape that emerges in the experience described.—The person who is adequately prepared for this experience will be able to interpret it correctly; very soon thereafter another form will appear that we may call the "greater guardian of the threshold" in contrast to the already described "lesser guardian." This greater guardian tells the student of the spiritual that he must not remain stationary at this stage but must energetically work on. He calls forth in the observer the consciousness that the world that is conquered becomes truth, and is not transformed into illusion, only if the work is continued in an adequate manner.—If, because of incorrect spiritual training, a person were to enter upon this experience unprepared, then, in the encounter with the "greater guardian of the threshold," something would pour into his soul that only can be compared to the "feeling of immeasurable horror," of "boundless fear."

Just as the student of the spiritual in his encounter with the "lesser guardian of the threshold" is afforded the possibility of testing whether or not he is protected against delusions arising from the intermingling of his own being with the supersensible world, so can he also test himself by the experiences that finally lead to the "greater guardian of the threshold" whether he is capable of mastering the delusions described above as coming from the second source. If he is able to withstand the gigantic illusion that has been conjured up before him—that the picture world he has gained is a rich possession, while in reality he is only a prisoner—if he is able to resist this delusion, he is then, during the progressing course of his development, guarded from mistaking illusion for reality.

The "guardian of the threshold" will assume, to a certain degree, an individual shape for each human being. The encounter with him corresponds indeed to the experience by which the personal character of the supersensible observations is overcome and through which the possibility is given of entering a region of experience that is free from personal coloring and applies to every human being.

If the student of the spiritual has had the above described experiences he is capable of distinguishing, within the surrounding world of soul and spirit, between himself and what lies outside him. He will then recognize that it is necessary to comprehend the cosmic process described in this book, in order to understand man and his life. Indeed, we understand the physical body only when we recognize how it has been fashioned during the Saturn, Sun, Moon, and Earth evolutions. We understand the ether body when we follow its formations through the Sun, Moon, and Earth evolutions. Moreover, we understand what at present is connected with the Earth evolution when we know how everything has unfolded itself step by step. Through spiritual training the student is placed in the position to recognize the relationship of everything that exists in the human being to corresponding facts and beings of the world outside him. For it is a fact that every member of the human organism stands in a relationship to the whole world surrounding it. In this book it has only been possible to indicate the facts in a sketchy outline. We must, however, consider that the human physical body, for example, was present during the

Saturn evolution only in its rudimentary beginnings. Its organs—the heart, the lungs, the brain—developed later out of these beginnings during the Sun, Moon, and Earth evolutions. The heart, lungs, and the other organs are thus related to the Sun, Moon, and Earth evolutions. It is quite the same with the members of the ether and soul body, the sentient soul, and the other principles. Man is fashioned from the entire surrounding world, and every part of him corresponds to a process or being of the outer world. At the corresponding stage of his development the student becomes acquainted with this relationship between his own being and the great world. We may designate this stage of cognition as the becoming aware of the correspondence between the lesser world, the microcosm, which is the human being himself, and the greater world, the macrocosm. If the student has struggled through to such a stage of knowledge, a new experience may occur for him. He begins to feel as though he were intergrown with the entire cosmic structure, in spite of the fact that he feels himself in his complete independence. This feeling is a merging with the entire cosmos, a becoming one with it, but without losing one's own essential being. This stage of development may be designated as the “becoming one with the macrocosm.” It is significant that this becoming one, this union, is not to be thought of as though through it the individual consciousness were to cease and the human being were to flow out into the universe, merging with it. Such a thought would be merely the expression of an opinion springing from the untrained power of judgment.—The stages of higher knowledge, in the sense of the process of initiation that has been described in this book, may now be enumerated as follows:

1. Study of spiritual science, in which one employs one's power of judgment gained in the physical-sensory world.
2. Acquiring imaginative knowledge.
3. Reading the occult script—corresponding to inspiration.
4. Living into the spiritual environment—corresponding to intuition.
5. Knowledge of the relationships between microcosm and macrocosm.
6. Union with the macrocosm.
7. Total experience of all previous experiences as a fundamental mood of the soul.

These stages need not be thought of as successive experiences. On the contrary, the training may proceed in such a way that, in accordance with the individuality of the student of the spiritual, he may have reached only a certain degree of perfection in a preceding stage when he begins exercises that correspond to a subsequent stage. It may well happen, for example, that the student has only gained a few imaginations with certainty, yet he already performs exercises leading to inspiration, intuition, or the cognition of the relationship between microcosm and macrocosm.

If the student of the spiritual has experienced intuition, he not only knows the images of the psycho-spiritual world, he cannot merely read their connections in the “occult script,” but he attains to knowledge of the spiritual beings themselves through whose co-operation the world, to which the human being belongs, comes into existence. In this way he learns to know himself in the form he possesses as a spiritual being in the world of soul and spirit. He has struggled through to a perception of his higher ego, and he has become aware of how he has to continue his efforts in order to control his Doppelganger, the “guardian of the threshold.” He has, however, also encountered the “greater guardian of the threshold,” who stands before him as an ever present exhorter to further effort. This “greater guardian” becomes the ideal toward which he strives. If this feeling emerges in the student of the spiritual, he has then acquired the possibility of recognizing who it is that stands there before him as the “greater guardian of the threshold.” To the perception of the student of the spiritual this guardian now transforms himself into the form of the Christ, whose Being and participation in Earth evolution has been made clear in the previous chapters of this book. The student is now initiated into the exalted mystery that is linked with the name of the Christ. The Christ shows Himself to the student as the “great ideal of man on earth.”—If thus through intuition the Christ is recognized in the spiritual world, what occurred historically on earth in the fourth post-Atlantean evolutionary epoch—the Greco-Latin epoch—also becomes comprehensible. The way in which, at that time, the exalted Sun Being, the Christ, has intervened in the Earth evolution and how he continues to work within this evolution

becomes the personally experienced knowledge of the student of the spiritual. It is thus a revelation of the meaning and significance of Earth evolution that the student receives through intuition.

The way to knowledge of the supersensible worlds, which is described here, is one that every human being can follow, no matter what the situation in which he may find himself within the present-day conditions of life. When describing such a path we must consider that the goal of knowledge and truth is the same in all ages of Earth evolution, but that the starting points of man have been different in different ages. If the human being wishes to tread the path to the spiritual world he cannot at present begin at the same starting point as, for example, the would-be initiate of ancient Egypt. Therefore, the exercises that were imposed upon the student of the spiritual of ancient Egypt cannot be carried out by the modern man without modification. Since that time, human souls have passed through various incarnations, and this advance from incarnation to incarnation is not without meaning and significance. The faculties and qualities of souls alter from incarnation to incarnation. Whoever considers human historical life, be it only superficially, is able to notice that since the twelfth and thirteenth centuries A.D. all life-conditions have changed when compared with previous centuries; that opinions, feelings, and also abilities of human beings have become different from what they were previously. The path to higher knowledge described here is eminently fit for souls who incarnate in the immediate present. It is one that places the point of departure for spiritual development just where the human being now stands in any situation presented by modern life.—Progressive evolution leads mankind in regard to the path to higher knowledge from period to period to ever changing forms, just as outer life changes its forms, and at all times a perfect harmony must prevail between outer life and initiation.
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This, too, presents itself as a vision to the intuitive mind, the third stage of supersensible cognition. In a wondrous harmony, we see before us what appears as the freedom of the individual earthly life, and what we feel as a necessity of destiny—a necessity that is not, however, a necessity of external nature, nor of the natural constitution of human life, but one that radiates from previous earthly lives. This does not make us unfree, any more than we become unfree by entering a new setting for our lives and being dependent on how this new setting is connected to the previous one—for example, when we migrate from Europe to America. It is our destiny, just as the ship carried us across; we enter a new setting but remain free, even though we have migrated from Europe to America. We can distinguish necessity from freedom as soon as we perceive this necessity in our repeated earthly lives and freedom in the individual earthly life. And looking up toward higher worlds gives us a human sense of security by showing us what the meaning of earthly life is. We are not merely seized by a longing for higher worlds —a longing we must, of course, also feel if we wish to stand firmly on earth—for the divine-spiritual is always within us, and we become unsteady in earthly life when we lack our connection to the divine-spiritual. But we do not become people who flee from the world or are alien to it through the true knowledge of the reality of higher worlds in the anthroposophical sense. We know that we must always descend back to Earth in order to gradually incorporate freedom into our human being. An awareness of freedom permeates us, even though we are able to discern the great question of destiny in a spiritual sense from the higher worlds, from the reality of these higher worlds.

I will first have to touch on the fundamental principles of the matter here. You will find more precise information in full detail in various books of mine, and I will also have to discuss further details here in the coming days. My books that discuss these details are, above all, *How Does One Attain Knowledge of the Higher Worlds?* and *Esoteric Science*. What constitutes decades of study can only be outlined here in principle through a few guidelines. The point is that the human power of thought is developed to a greater strength and intensity than it possesses in ordinary life and in conventional science. When one exerts a muscle particularly hard during work, the strength of that muscle is increased. What is done here with an external limb is carried out, quite systematically, by the spiritual researcher with regard to the powers of the soul. He places a clearly comprehensible idea or a clearly comprehensible complex of ideas at the center of his consciousness with full awareness and full free will, and he holds

his consciousness on such a clearly comprehensible idea for a time—some need longer, others shorter, depending on their abilities and their capacity for concentration.

I ask you to note that I am speaking of a manageable concept. This is extremely important. If we were to simply draw upon our usual store of memories for our meditation, for our mental exercise, we would not be able to manage. For what we draw upon from our store of thoughts contains many reminiscences and unconscious impressions of life that would then come into play if we were to engage in this mental exercise. Nothing from the unconscious must influence proper anthroposophical meditation. Everything must be manageable. Everything must be subject to full self-control. That is why it is sometimes required—and rightly so—that anyone who wishes to become a researcher in this anthroposophical spiritual science should turn to an experienced researcher and have exercises given to them by that person. When we practice such things—which we seek out in one way or another on our own, or when we have them given to us—they enter our consciousness as something new, just like a sensory experience we encounter, which does not arise from the depths of our soul but rather enters our soul as something new. It is not a matter of gaining something from the content of any such image, but rather that it enters our consciousness with the novelty of a sensory experience, and that we then dwell upon it with our soul forces. Just as we perform work with a muscle, so do we work with our soul forces when we dwell diligently on such an image with inner concentration. If we are careful to observe all the details I have described in my books regarding this practice, then we will not fall into any form of suggestion or autosuggestion, but we will undertake every single moment of such a mental exercise with our will fully engaged. After some time, however, we will sense how we are strengthening our inner spiritual power, how we are making it more intense. These exercises do not take much time on any given day, but they must be repeated over and over again. Some people need more time; others can achieve significant results in just a few months; and some need years. But in principle, the same thing applies in every case: that the powers of the soul—namely, the powers of thought—are strengthened from within through such exercises. And one finally reaches a point where one advances to what is called imaginative thinking.

I have called what develops there “imaginative thinking” because one gradually notices that thinking is emerging from the abstractness and intellectualism to which it is subject in ordinary life and in ordinary science: Pure inner thinking is gradually illuminated by a vividness and warmed by a liveliness that are entirely comparable to the vividness and liveliness we develop in response to external sensory impressions. It is extremely important to note this, for we all know that when we direct our attention to external sensory impressions, everything is intense; everything is saturated. We are wholly devoted to these external sensory impressions with our entire being. But when, after turning our attention away from external sensory impressions, we then turn to thinking in ordinary life and in ordinary science, this thinking is pale and lacks warmth. People rightly speak of the pallor of abstract thinking. And almost all thinking that we develop in ordinary life and in ordinary science is abstract. Only those thoughts that we develop in the moment when we are fully absorbed in external sensory reality are fully saturated.

However, one arrives at this liveliness, at this inner richness, through mere inner experience at first, when one engages in the kinds of thought exercises I have described. Then one truly comes to think in a pictorial, imaginative way. One must simply be aware that, at first, in this imaginative thinking, one has nothing before oneself or within oneself that already corresponds to any external spiritual reality. However, one gradually becomes aware of the real, objective significance of this imaginative thinking when one has the following inner experience.

You all know how, in a growing child, the brain gradually develops into the marvelous organ it eventually becomes over the course of a lifetime. One can certainly say: The brain is initially a malleable organ; it allows the formative forces of the soul to imprint themselves on its entire structure, its convolutions, and so on. This, of course, takes place during the first years of a child’s life. It comes to a halt at a certain point, which we reach through the ordinary natural development of the human being and through ordinary education. And with what we achieve in this way, we then seek to cope

with ordinary life and to make progress in ordinary science. But as we developed from year to year as children, we became more and more capable. This process of becoming increasingly capable is experienced anew when one strives for imaginative cognition. There one discovers that through the activity I have just described as a series of thought exercises, one is once again working on something within oneself—that one is working on something that is now plastic. But one also feels that what one is working on there—which, in the same way, I would say, is now being furrowed in a soul-spiritual sense as the physical brain was furrowed in childhood—is a supersensible, soul-spiritual aspect of the human being that stands apart from the physical body. And after some time, one feels that one can now relate quite differently to the outer and inner limits of knowledge. Precisely as a researcher of the spirit, one must agree with those who speak of such limits of knowledge. But one feels that one can now truly and gradually transcend these limits of knowledge through newly developed abilities.

When this inner experience, this inner realization has come—when you truly feel that you no longer need to remain confined to the sensory world, when you experience something through your imaginative thinking, through your living thinking, when you break through the veil of the senses, when you try to look into your inner self— you experience something that ordinary natural science does not experience, something that ordinary mysticism can only present to the soul in an illusory way; if you honestly experience this as the result of inner development, then you can be certain that you are on a path that can truly lead to higher worlds.

At first, there is nothing outwardly visible. One has merely strengthened the old forces, made them more intense. But one soon realizes that something essential, something important, is now taking place within one's consciousness. Gradually, one begins to experience something like an inner vision that spans one's entire life up to that point, from birth onward. Yes, this is the first supersensible reality one experiences: one's own inner life since birth presented as a clear, comprehensive tableau. And this clear, comprehensive tableau is expressed by the fact that one's thinking now stands in a different relationship to what one perceives externally than one's thinking previously stood in relation to external realities and inner experiences.

In everyday life, we develop our thinking. We reflect on things. Thoughts reside in the soul; they are subjective. The other is objective; the other is out there. We feel our thought processes as separate from what is out there. Now we have before us a panorama of our own inner life since birth. But I would like to say that thoughts enter into this fabric. One feels oneself to be within this fabric. One says to oneself: Only now are you truly beginning to grasp yourself. You must surrender your thoughts to that which objectively presents itself to your consciousness. — This even gives rise to a certain, I would say, painful experience, at least initially, for the anthroposophical spiritual researcher. The anthroposophical spiritual researcher must go through such painful experiences in various ways. He must not shy away from going through, in a certain sense, inner difficulties—and often pain. I will also have to speak about this today from a different perspective. But for now, what one initially experiences in relation to this tableau of life is that, in a kind of inner oppression, one senses one's own being. One does not perceive it with the ease with which one otherwise nurtures thoughts and ideas, or with which feelings, impulses of will, desires, and the like are usually present within us; rather, one perceives it as something that weighs heavily upon one. In short, it is precisely within this heaviness that one perceives reality. If one does not experience this heaviness, then one has merely a mental construct; one does not have reality. But by bringing into this sense of oppression everything that one previously had in the form of freely unfolding webs of thought, one is thereby protected from developing, through one's imaginative insight, things such as illusions, visions, or hallucinations.

This is something that is so often held against anthroposophical spiritual science. People say: Its exercises lead to nothing more than visions and hallucinations. It brings repressed nervous forces to the surface of consciousness, so to speak, and no one can prove the reality of what anthroposophical spiritual science speaks of as higher worlds. Anyone who considers even what I have already said today will sense that the path taken by anthroposophical spiritual science is the opposite of all those paths that lead to visions, hallucinations, or even mediumship. Everything that leads to mediumship,

hallucinations, or visions ultimately arises only from diseased physical organs that, in a sense, exhale their spiritual-psychic content in a pathological manner upward into consciousness. All of this lies below the level of sensory perception. In contrast, what develops as imaginative knowledge lies above ordinary sensory perception; it is formed precisely through objectivity, not through the diseased inner state.

It is therefore a complete misunderstanding to accuse what is characterized as the anthroposophical method of spiritual research of such pathology. On the contrary, by grasping—with complete freedom of consciousness—what I have described as imaginative knowledge, one comes to see through everything hallucinatory and everything mediumistic for what it is. No one will reject all such psychopathologies more strictly than precisely the person who has not pushed his or her soul further into the body, as the hallucinator does, but who has, through the efforts described, drawn his or her soul right out of the body—the person who has now, on the one hand, come to survey his or her own life back to the moment of birth in such a tableau.

From what I have just referred to as reality, one can see that one has now truly grasped not mere thoughts, but rather the living forces that have been working to build up our organism ever since we began our earthly life. What unfolds in this way as imagination is nothing other than the sum of the forces through which we grow—the sum of the forces that are also at work in our nutrition. That is why anthroposophical spiritual science calls that which is discovered in this way as a supersensible force at work within the human being the etheric body or body of formative forces. You see: in a completely systematic way, one discovers a higher aspect of the human being—that which, as a supersensible aspect, initially works to shape our earthly body. And the fact that, in what appears before you as a tableau, you do not move as you would in ordinary thoughts, but rather sense reality precisely in the oppressive feeling—this is how you realize: What you are seeing inwardly is the very same thing that is otherwise at work unconsciously in your organism.

What anthroposophical spiritual science refers to as the supersensible etheric or life body is not some fantastical construct. It is not the hypothetical “old life force” that science has rightly abandoned; it is something that emerges from a very real perception, something that becomes a reality for the heightened power of imagination that has been developed, just as the external sensory world is a reality. And it is not nebulous mystical speculations that lead us to this reality, but rather the strengthening and invigoration of our entirely normal faculty of thought, which is simply extended outward toward a free, purely spiritual-psychic “I.” This is what brings this first higher reality before our soul.

However, since, as earthly human beings, we initially see nothing more than our own living being unfolding in the sequence of time like a tableau, we must progress further along the path to the supersensible worlds. This happens when, through exercises, we awaken further powers that lie dormant within the soul. As you know, human life involves not only remembering—that is, retaining mental images—but also forgetting. In everyday life, to our regret, forgetting often comes easily to us. But precisely those who live deeply in their thoughts will know that thoughts can also torment us, and that it takes effort to suppress them entirely. This becomes a particularly great struggle when we meditate in the systematic way I have described, when we develop deep inner thinking. When we bring certain images to the center of our consciousness in this way and strengthen the powers of imagination, those images do not want to fade away immediately. They weigh on us. They can only be suppressed if we, in turn, practice this quite systematically. In a sense—if I may express myself somewhat paradoxically—we must artificially practice forgetting, suppressing the images that insist on being there.

Once again, I have described in detail in the books mentioned many exercises through which we can strengthen this power that suppresses mental images. Then, if we practice such exercises in suppressing mental images for a long time, we reach the point where we can completely empty our consciousness while fully awake. This is not as trivial a matter as one might ordinarily suppose. Most

people, at first, who are immersed in ordinary life, fall asleep after a while when they try to make their consciousness completely empty. Now, it is even more difficult to empty the consciousness if one has first filled it with intensified mental images through meditation. But one must practice this. And through this practice, one gradually arrives not only at suppressing individual images, not only at emptying one's consciousness of them, but through constant effort, one gradually succeeds in removing from consciousness the entire tableau of one's life up to this point, of which I have spoken. It is almost as if one's entire life were contained within—I would say—a space that has become time, or a time that has become space. The entire tableau of one's life up to this point lies before us. Through the exercises I have described, we gradually acquire the ability to erase this entire tableau from our consciousness; after having held this tableau, we learn to empty our consciousness and yet remain awake. This is a very important stage on the path to the reality of the higher worlds. For when we come to completely empty our consciousness in this way—after first having filled it with the tableau of our own life and with the vision of our etheric body—we do not find ourselves facing nothingness. Then we can indeed recognize that everything that constitutes the sensory world is no longer present around us—the sensory world is now just as absent from our surroundings as it is during deep, dreamless sleep—but a world we have not known until now emerges: a world of supersensory beings and supersensory processes. We discover this only after we have first removed the tableau of our own life from our consciousness. It is simply absurd, in the face of what emerges after these efforts, to speak of it as mere reminiscences of life or as possible illusions. Anyone who experiences this in reality knows—just as they know, when faced with external sensory reality, that they are indeed facing a reality—through direct experience that they are indeed facing such a reality.

The essential point in all of this, however, is that when a person becomes a hallucinationist—a visionary—he loses his ordinary consciousness. The hallucinationist lives within his hallucinations. His usual level-headedness is no longer present. The person who develops in the way I have described loses none of his common sense; he loses none of his usual level-headedness. Everything he had before remains with him, and he can always look back from the sight of the new worlds—the supersensible worlds—that now appear before him. Just as one looks back on one's memories, he can always look back to what he can incorporate into his consciousness in ordinary life and in ordinary science. Therefore, the person developing in this way can carry his conscious thinking—his thinking, which is entirely permeated by the will—into the entire perception of the supersensible world. He can speak about this supersensible world in an intellectual, rational manner, just as one otherwise speaks about the sensory world in ordinary science. Since he describes these higher worlds using ordinary intellect and the ordinary scientific method, anyone can follow him—even if they have not become a spiritual researcher or an active anthroposophist, but simply allow their common sense to exercise critical judgment. Because the anthroposophical researcher brings this common sense to bear on all knowledge of the higher worlds, one need not be a spiritual researcher to understand his communications. When one receives the communications of the spiritual researcher, they must be presented in such a way that common sense can follow them. This applies not only to imaginative thinking—through which, after all, only earthly life first presents itself to us—but it also applies up to the level of knowledge I have just spoken of, and which I have called "inspired knowledge" in my books.

Please do not take offense at such expressions. They do not imply anything superstitious or antiquated, but refer solely to what I am describing. I call it "inspired insight" because, just as air from the external world enters our respiratory system as a real entity, so too does the supersensible world now enter the ordinary soul world. As spiritual researchers devoted to such inspired insight, we find ourselves in the following situation. We begin with the ordinary state of the soul. Once we have first acquired the ability to empty our consciousness, we can—no matter where we are in time or space, or whatever we have in our consciousness—bring about the possibility of emptying our consciousness. From certain starting points, something of the nature and processes of the supersensible world then appears to us. This is like an inhalation, an inspiration. The spiritual world is breathed into the ordinary world. And in turn, we must have the strength to restore ordinary consciousness and to judge this spiritual world from the perspective of ordinary consciousness. It is a continuous exhalation and inhalation of the spiritual

world, a constant return to ordinary consciousness, that makes human beings fully level-headed even in the face of these spiritual worlds.

That the term “inspiration” is justified may become clear from something I would like to mention merely by way of comparison. Today’s spiritual researcher is not able to penetrate the supersensible higher worlds in the same way that peoples of earlier times—particularly in prehistoric times—were able to do. The manner in which Eastern peoples penetrated the higher worlds has been handed down and is still widely practiced today in Asia—albeit in a decadent form—as yoga, adapted to a different physical constitution and bodily structure. This is not something we in the West can adopt for our own benefit. That process occurs instinctively, unconsciously, whereas everything I have described takes place with full consciousness and with full will. Nevertheless, we can, in a certain sense, learn something from the way in which, in earlier, instinctive ages of human development, people sought to ascend to the higher worlds and their effects. In yoga exercises, the ancient Indian sought to regulate his breathing—not to breathe in the ordinary way, but in a regulated, orderly, or rather, reorganized manner—in a way that came to their conscious awareness, in which they were always present with their consciousness, whereas ordinary breathing takes place entirely unconsciously as a mere organic process. By experiencing this rhythm: inhaling—exhaling, inhaling—exhaling, the yoga student attuned himself to the rhythm of the world; and through the physical rhythm of breathing, he attuned himself to the spiritual rhythm of inhaling the spiritual worlds and exhaling the spiritual worlds, as I have just described as suitable for our Western civilization. One does indeed attune oneself to a rhythm. The existence that one otherwise has as an earthly existence can, in a sense, be continually inspired and re-inspired in relation to a supersensible, higher world. What is this supersensible, higher world?

Through imaginative contemplation, one has previously come to recognize that which works within one as the etheric or formative body during one’s earthly existence. This etheric or formative body has been suppressed. A new world has been discovered. To the extent that one lives in this new world, the sensory world is not present. It exists only as a memory, as I have explained. But in the new world that one discovers, one discovers a higher reality—the reality that now works through and permeates the etheric or formative body in the same way that this etheric or formative body permeates the physical body. Once again, anthroposophical spiritual science does not speak from a realm of fantasy, but from strictly systematic paths into the higher realities—from the human astral body, which is discovered in this way and which permeates the etheric or formative body, yet lives in other worlds. And when one examines the worlds in which this astral body lives together with the “I,” just as I live physically among sensory objects, one discovers the spiritual-soul world from which the human being has descended by connecting, through birth—or, let us say, through conception—with the physical matter provided by the father and mother. One discovers the eternal, immortal core of the human being through direct perception, which one has struggled to attain, and which can be verified by sound reason on the grounds I have cited.

Today, people take particular offense when one does not speak in general terms—as, for example, a pantheist might—of a vague spiritual world that permeates everything, but rather when one rises to a specific description of a spiritual -psychic world from which we have descended through birth into physical existence, and to which we ascend again by passing through the gate of death—a world we thus discover as reality, not through speculation, not through nebulous mystical feeling, but through strictly regulated intuition. People take offense when one describes these worlds, as I have done, for example, in my *The Secret Science*. I would like to make myself understood through a simple comparison to illustrate how these worlds can truly be described. When you look at ordinary recollection and ordinary memory, what do you experience there? You have gone through this or that in life. What is long past, what has long ceased to be an external reality, stands before you as an image in your memory. From this image, you reconstruct the experience for yourself. It has, so to speak, migrated from the external world into you and become part of your soul’s content. From the content of our souls, we reconstruct for ourselves at every moment the entire world of memory—the world of external experiences—in which we have become entangled. The inner world is grasped, taken in, and

comprehended in the life of the imagination, the life of the emotions, and the life of the will. By grasping the inner world, the outer world of experiences conjures itself before the soul. But what is grasped through imagination and inspiration?

One does not merely perceive what one has absorbed during one's earthly life; one perceives the whole human being. One learns to recognize how the body of formative forces works in all human organs and remains a unified whole throughout one's entire life. One learns to recognize how the astral body, in a spiritual-soul world prior to birth and conception, carries our eternal core of being, how it enters into us, and how it works within us. The human being becomes, so to speak, completely transparent. One learns to recognize one's physical body as an effect of the spiritual. Just as we look into our memories and reconstruct our earthly life, so too, when we now look deeper into our inner being—not merely grasping what we have spiritually and psychologically imbued within ourselves throughout our earthly life, but also understanding how we are structured within our organs, how our etheric body, our astral body, and our "I" are interwoven with this physical body— We can also project ourselves outward through contemplation, just as we do through memory, into our etheric body, into the great cosmic experiences, into the experiences of the world. For human beings have been present in everything that has unfolded spiritually, psychically, and physically in the world with which they are connected. If they look within themselves in the manner described, they can recognize through self-observation the events through which they have historically evolved, and the events through which the entire human being has developed within the cosmos.

Anyone who grasps the full significance of this idea will no longer find it strange that I have described in my *Secret Science* how human beings, in their original forms, were connected not only to the Earth but also to planetary worlds that preceded it as earlier metamorphoses of the Earth, and how, through what is inherent in human beings, can perceive that the Earth will in turn transform into other planetary states; how one can not only perceive this from the perspective of the human being, but how one can truly penetrate into higher worlds through it, and recognize the ordinary worlds—the worlds that extend around us as Earth-dwellers—as the effects of higher spiritual worlds, supersensible worlds. One need only familiarize oneself with all the efforts that anthroposophical spiritual science undergoes to arrive at these results. There is often a belief that what anthroposophical spiritual research presents about the reality of higher worlds is derived from mere whims, from subjective intellectual considerations, or even from fantasies. This is not the case. One must learn clinical research and astronomical research in detail. It is difficult. But what is attained in this way inwardly—I would say, through inner experimentation—in order to arrive at a vision of higher worlds, is even more difficult. It requires even greater dedication, greater care, greater inner conscientiousness, and greater methodical rigor. And what is described here in a serious and honest sense as spiritual science is far removed from what is commonly regarded as occultism, mysticism, and the like. Just as science stands in relation to superstition, so does this spiritual science stand in relation to popular occultism, which seeks to arrive at its insights through all manner of mediums or through all manner of amateurish collection of external, surprising facts. This particular form of modern superstition is most surely overcome by nothing other than serious and honest spiritual research, which develops its thoroughly conscientious methods.

And when a person has attained, in this way, inspired insight and thus a vision of the world they left behind at birth or at conception, and which they will enter again after death—when a person enters these worlds, they experience something inwardly that, when it appears as a reflection in ordinary consciousness—and everything supersensible does indeed appear in ordinary consciousness as very vague feelings or the like—seems to them to be pessimism. What the spiritual researcher experiences through inspired insight appears to him as pessimism. Why as pessimism? Because the spiritual researcher, in fact, upon entering these higher worlds, already feels something like deep pain, like all-encompassing deprivation. Now one must be armed and prepared—precisely through the exercises I describe in my books—to endure this pain with dignity and fortitude. What kind of pain is it, then? One learns to recognize this pain as a reality. This pain, which is actually an intense longing—it is nothing other than the experience of the force through which the soul passes from the spiritual worlds

into physical existence through birth. The soul experiences the final stages it undergoes—after having lived in the spiritual worlds—to descend into physical existence as a longing for the physical world. One experiences this longing as pain. And it is precisely the fact that one does not merely experience something abstractly and theoretically in spiritual science, but that one is fully immersed in spiritual science with one's whole being—with feeling and will—that constitutes the essence of this path into the higher worlds.

Theoretical speculation alone is not enough to embark on the anthroposophical path into the supersensible worlds. What must be lived through in the methods of this spiritual research requires moral preparation at every stage. And, fundamentally, there is no better preparation for the moral strengthening of the whole human being—body, soul, and spirit—than undergoing the exercises that must be undertaken to attain the reality of the supersensible worlds. They do not reveal themselves to the mere theorist. They reveal themselves only to those who commit their entire humanity to the task, who bring to life within their souls all the powers of good feeling, of a beautiful perception of the world, and of religious, devout immersion in the mysteries of the universe; who transform love for humanity and love for the world into forces of inner warmth; only such a person attains the moral fortitude necessary to advance in this way toward the reality of higher worlds. It is therefore acknowledged by some people that the exercises I describe for walking the spiritual-scientific path into the higher worlds have a moral aspect that is certainly worthy of recognition. But this is also admitted by those who then turn away and do not wish to participate in the true path of knowledge leading into the supersensible worlds. Yet it is only this path that, in contrast to the scientific yearning humanity has today—a yearning it has had before—leads into these higher worlds. And as one ascends through imagination and inspiration, one first enters into one's own self. But this own self must also surrender to the environment. I have already pointed out how thinking must, in a sense, flow out into the objective realm even during imagination. We take this thinking with us everywhere. We take the full clarity of thought with us wherever we discover the supersensible worlds. But we must also become aware of how our entire being must, in a sense, surrender to the reality of these supersensible worlds. But after inspiration—through the efforts we undergo, through the experiences we have—we come to feel our "I," the center of our being, with great intensity. And here we reach the point where we can recognize the harmony, the union, of the experience of freedom with the experience of natural necessity. In ordinary life, we are bound by this natural necessity. How keenly we feel that what lives in our impulses of will—even when it has worked its way up a little from the sinful toward the good—nevertheless arises from the subconscious depths of our soul life, from the instinctive and the impulsive. Just as we can hardly consciously grasp what we go through from falling asleep to waking up, so too can we hardly grasp what lives in our volitional impulses—and yet much of what ultimately plays a role in our conscious, responsible moral life is contained within them. But the person who has gone through inspiration and imagination also gains a strengthening of their "I" through the efforts they have undergone. They experience their "I" more intensely. They experience it, admittedly, as devoted—I would say, poured out—into the outer world, but they experience it in such a way that it is reflected back to them. And they are now no longer in a position to say, as a prejudiced scientific view tends to do: The same natural necessity that causes the stone to fall to the earth, that causes the stone to be warmed by the sun's rays, that is at work in electricity and magnetism, in acoustic and optical phenomena—this very same necessity is also at work when I act as a human being, when I develop my impulses of will as a human being. — And in conventional science and in everyday life, one cannot move beyond bitter doubts regarding this question.

On the one hand, there is human freedom, of which we are aware. It is believed that one must deny this freedom if one is, in the true sense, a modern scientific researcher and believes in the conservation of energy and matter. It is then believed that no human impulse of will, no human action, can arise out of free will, for human beings must be subject to natural necessity, just like all other beings in the realms of nature. But when one now has one's true "I"-being before oneself in a heightened form, one attains a kind of insight that is even higher than inspiration and imagination. I have called it true intuition, true immersion—but now into a spiritual reality. There, what anthroposophy calls repeated earthly lives is imbued with true meaning. What appears necessary in one's own actions and will reveals itself as the

result of previous earthly lives. The eternal core of the human being undergoes repeated earthly lives, interspersed with lives between death and new birth in spiritual-soul worlds. And one now comes to recognize: What extends from one life to the next is a necessary submission—not to external natural necessity, but to that necessity that runs through the repeated earthly lives—with regard to our "I" and its impulses of will. But with our thinking—which, as ordinary consciousness, does not initially grasp this necessity, which is drawn from this necessity, and which develops within the individual earthly existence as a free, senseless thinking, as I have described it in my *Philosophy of Freedom*—with this we have a foundation for our freedom. By striving, as human beings in our individual lives, toward such moral impulses that are grasped through free thinking, we become free human beings here on earth between birth and death. And what lives within us as necessity, what plays out as fate, is not a natural necessity; it extends through repeated earthly lives.

This, too, presents itself as a vision to the intuitive mind, the third stage of supersensible cognition. In a wondrous harmony, we see before us what appears as the freedom of the individual earthly life, and what we feel as a necessity of destiny—a necessity that is not, however, a necessity of external nature, nor of the natural constitution of human life, but one that radiates from previous earthly lives. This does not make us unfree, any more than we become unfree by entering a new setting for our lives and being dependent on how this new setting is connected to the previous one—for example, when we migrate from Europe to America. It is our destiny, just as the ship carried us across; we enter a new setting but remain free, even though we have migrated from Europe to America. We can distinguish necessity from freedom as soon as we perceive this necessity in our repeated earthly lives and freedom in the individual earthly life. And looking up toward higher worlds gives us a human sense of security by showing us what the meaning of earthly life is. We are not merely seized by a longing for higher worlds—a longing we must, of course, also feel if we wish to stand firmly on earth—for the divine-spiritual is always within us, and we become unsteady in earthly life when we lack our connection to the divine-spiritual. But we do not become people who flee from the world or are alien to it through the true knowledge of the reality of higher worlds in the anthroposophical sense. We know that we must always descend back to Earth in order to gradually incorporate freedom into our human being. An awareness of freedom permeates us, even though we are able to discern the great question of destiny in a spiritual sense from the higher worlds, from the reality of these higher worlds.
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But is the inner, true human being what we see with our physical eyes as a sleeping body lying in bed? Surely no one would claim that. Now, anyone who observes the transition from waking to sleeping with ordinary consciousness can, of course, perceive nothing other than that the physical body gradually passes into a motionless state. But the person who has developed their spiritual eye through the means just described perceives how the inner, spiritual, true human being rises up out of the physical body. Just as the outward appearance of the person falling asleep is different for the seer than for the ordinary person, who is capable of perceiving only with the physical eye, so too is the state of sleep itself fundamentally different for the two. While the non-clairvoyant person falls into unconsciousness, the seer remains conscious as he falls asleep, for he has developed in his soul body—which ascends from the resting physical body—sense organs for perceiving the spiritual world.

Let us now attempt to briefly characterize this spiritual world into which the person who has become clairvoyant ascends. At first, the perceptions they have are limited to the time when their physical body is asleep. With constant practice, however, they will reach the point where, at any moment of the day, as soon as they wish, they can shut off their physical senses and see spiritually without leaving their body. A great difference becomes immediately apparent when, for example, we look at this bouquet of roses with the eyes of a seer. We can then suddenly no longer say: "The bouquet of roses is in front of me; I am here and it is there"—as we can say in our normal waking state. In the spiritual world, the distinction of space—the "here" and "there"—completely loses its meaning, and our consciousness is no longer in front of the bouquet of roses, but inside it. In that world, spiritual consciousness feels itself in the essence, in the reality; the clairvoyant pours himself into the object he perceives. His inner

being, as it were, penetrates the skin of our physical body and becomes one with everything he beholds around him in the spiritual world. What, then, is that which pours out into the environment at night and feels bound within the confines of the physical body during the day? It is that which we summarize in the little word “I,” of which a person in normal daytime consciousness says: It lives in my body. - Clairvoyant consciousness perceives this “I” as pouring out into the entire external world that it can reach. We may ask: Where, then, is it? — To this there is only one answer: The seer’s “I” is, in essence, everywhere it perceives.

This path into the spiritual world is the same one that every non-clairvoyant takes when falling asleep, except that in doing so, they lose consciousness. Thus, each of us lives alternately while awake, confined within the physical body—the microcosm—and while asleep, expanded into the infinite and united with the great world around us—the macrocosm.

Why, then, we might ask, must we fall into unconsciousness? — The reason is that modern human beings are not yet ready for this, and their ego could not bear to consciously flow out into the universe. We can understand this process to some extent through a mental image: Imagine a large basin of water into which we drop a tiny drop of a colored liquid. There we see how the drop dissolves into the water surrounding it, and how it becomes increasingly invisible the farther it spreads. Human beings experience something similar in their “I,” which, like a droplet, must expand into the entire spiritual world. Modern human beings could not bear to consciously dissolve in this way and must pay for this acceptance into their spiritual home with a loss of consciousness. What would happen to them if, without occult preparation, they were to expand into the spiritual world while fully conscious? We can best visualize this by imagining the “I” endowed with only as much power as is necessary for limited perception on the physical plane. As it expands beyond the physical boundaries, it loses strength, just as a drop loses its consistency, and its perceptions would fade more and more the further it expands, until it would finally have the horrifying sensation of hovering over a bottomless abyss in the deepest darkness. We must conceive of the “I” not merely as a force, but as a feeling and sensing being, and can therefore form a faint mental image of the impression of being lost in nothingness. Therefore, one of the most important preparations for anyone who wishes to advance toward clairvoyant consciousness is to cultivate fearlessness, and it is an essential part of the spiritual researcher’s training that many opportunities be created for him to test his equanimity and steadfastness. A person who has not had a thousand and a thousand more opportunities to say to himself with a calm soul, in the face of events that would otherwise terrify others and make them turn pale: “I am facing the most terrible danger, but I know that my fear does not make my situation any safer—only courageous action does”—is not yet sufficiently prepared. In the ancient mysteries, of course, it happened that the initiate, even if his “I” had not yet attained full strength, was consciously led out into the macrocosm; however, the initiator had to be with him at all times to be able to help him in time. This type of clairvoyance, as it was achieved in the ancient mystery schools of Europe, is called ecstasy. This method is no longer suitable for our current stage of development, and it has been replaced by another, which we will now discuss. It is the Rosicrucian method.

As was just mentioned, in the ancient mysteries the student was under the supervision of his teacher, whose task was to prevent the emerging “I” from completely dissolving and falling into a state of powerlessness. This ecstatic absorption was achieved through the strictly regulated cultivation of certain feelings that one also experiences in everyday life. The ancient method was to link these feelings to those that people still experience today—albeit to a far lesser degree—during the changing of the seasons. For example, when the student stepped out into the fresh spring landscape and saw the young grass and the first flowers sprouting from the melting snow, when he saw all around him the reawakening from winter slumber, when he felt the frozen earth thawing beneath his feet and saw the dry, bare trees sprouting new buds under the awakening touch of warm sunlight, then he was to feel this reawakening life within himself and, in the deepest meditation, surrender to it with his whole soul.

Through constant repetition, he was then able to let this feeling swell to unimagined strength. “You must,” the initiator told him, “be able to kindle this joy, this confidence, and this vitality within yourself with such power and such vibrancy as the Earth itself would feel if it had consciousness.”

Likewise, in the fall, the student had to learn to feel melancholy; he had to let the withering of nature all around him take effect upon him; he had to feel how forests and meadows lose their leafy finery and how life withdraws into the bosom of the earth. Together with nature, he had to be able to mourn for her children. Likewise, he had to experience the other seasons—and especially the winter and summer solstices—deep within himself.

It may seem as though these are merely hidden aspects of everyday life, and yet this is not the case, for the esotericist—both of ancient times and today—must create these feelings deep within himself in a state of complete inner stillness, with all external impressions shut out. Those who had learned to feel in this way experienced, after prolonged practice—and this is still the case today—what was called in the ancient mysteries: “Beholding the Sun at Midnight.” - The Earth became transparent, and through its fading physical form one could see the spiritual reality underlying it; instead of the physical sun, one beheld the great spiritual sun, that primal, powerful Being of which the physical sun was merely the material body.

Faced with this overwhelming sight, however, the ego of the disciple—who had just regained his sight—was in danger of succumbing to faintness, and his guru, his teacher, had to stand by his side to help him. Today, the guru could no longer exert the same power over the student as in those days, since the relationship between teacher and student has changed, and modern human nature—as a result of a different upbringing—would be incapable, despite all good intentions and willing submission, of suppressing the rebellious forces within it.

In addition to this path of ecstasy, there was also the so-called mystical path to initiation. It consisted of the meditator delving ever deeper into his own inner self. Within himself, he then experienced what the ecstatic individual experienced upon stepping outside of himself. But this path, too, had its great dangers. While the ecstatic was threatened by the powerlessness of the dissolving ego, the mystic’s ego contracted within itself to unimaginable strength, and egoism swelled within him to monstrous proportions. “I want to be everything, I want to have everything”—that was the unbridled desire that possessed the ego.

How, then, did one bring about this deepening into oneself? Let us think of waking up. What happens then? The “I,” which was widely extended outward into the macrocosm, contracts and sinks into the physical bodies. If it were not for the external world, which sets a limit to this contraction through its impressions, one would indeed descend into one’s innermost being. What, then, is there to learn? One must learn to wake up without allowing external impressions to affect one. As a result, the “I” can concentrate unhindered within the innermost core of the human being. The experiences one then has amid egoistic desires that escalate into the boundless are what all mystics refer to as “temptation.” To avoid succumbing to this danger, virtue and love, humility, and devotion must therefore be developed to a high degree beforehand. Thus equipped, the meditator can calmly embark on this path. For the great mystics, the ego could no longer will of its own accord; they could no longer be themselves at all; they were able to surrender themselves unreservedly to Christ and allow him to think, feel, act, and will within them. Paul therefore says: “It is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me.”

“We also find this method in other ancient mysteries, such as the Egyptian ones; however, during the initiation, the guru was always present to protect the aspirant from egoistic forces from the outside.

The changing circumstances of our present era call for a new approach. Human beings have become more independent, and they must be provided with the necessary means to enter the path to the inner and higher worlds without the teacher’s direct intervention. The Rosicrucian initiation, as it is practiced

today, combines both methods, and this training—which leads to clairvoyance in the spiritual worlds—eliminates the dangers mentioned earlier, to which the ancient ecstatics and mystics were exposed.

Tomorrow we will go into this in more detail and describe how the Rosicrucian student develops spiritual organs of perception within his soul body to explore the spiritual foundation of the universe.

Yesterday, two paths were described for reaching the spiritual worlds: the mystical path and the path of ecstasy. At the same time, it was emphasized that the ancient methods of initiation are no longer appropriate for our time and that today's stage of development requires new means, which in turn will have to give way to other means in the future. From approximately the 12th to the 14th century, the Rosicrucian method became necessary, and it will gain even greater significance in the near future. Anyone who is engaged in the spiritual life and who pursues its ascent higher and higher from incarnation to incarnation knows that today's Spiritual Science is adapted to our circumstances, and that, after millennia, people will look back on it as something outdated. People will rely even more on fully conscious forces than they do today. As we have seen, modern humans receive these forces during sleep, when they are in an unconscious state. Gradually, in the course of evolution, this process will increasingly enter their consciousness and come under their will.

The ancient forms of initiation required a person to descend into his own inner self, which resulted in a strengthening of all egoistic forces and was a true temptation for the student. Everything within him—both the instincts that were still active and those he had already overcome—was brought to the surface in this process. For example, if immediately upon waking we shut off our senses to all the external impressions pressing upon us and immerse ourselves within, the true inner self would not reveal itself to our gaze at that moment; yet if we remained conscious, our sense of self would escalate into boundless egotism. In ecstasy, on the other hand, as we have seen, when a person consciously dissolves into the macrocosm, his ego grows ever weaker, and the student needs the support of a guru so that he does not fall into complete powerlessness.

The Rosicrucian initiation unites the two paths and provides the aspirant with the proper balance, which protects him from the dangers mentioned above and, at the same time, grants him enough independence that he no longer requires the supervision of an initiator. It first leads him into the inner world, to which it grants him access through the outer world—which the student must observe faithfully in all its forms. Everywhere, he must learn to discern the symbolic, until he realizes that the entire physical world is a parable. This is not to say that the botanist, the poet, or the painter sees incorrectly—they, too, see correctly—but for the Rosicrucian student, it is essential that he focus his attention on the symbolic aspect of form, since his purpose lies deeper than that of the other observers.

For example, when he sees a rose, he recognizes it as a symbol of life and says to himself: Clear green sap rises up through the stem, flowing from leaf to leaf, but at the top, in the bloom that crowns the plant, it transforms into the red sap of the rose. - Then he turns his gaze away from the flower and looks at the human being, thinking to himself: When I observe the plant next to the human being, it appears to me at first glance to be far lower in the scale of existence than the human; it has neither movement nor feelings nor consciousness. Human beings, too, are permeated by the red sap, yet they move freely wherever they wish; they perceive the outside world and experience its impressions as pleasure and pain, and are conscious of their own existence. The plant, however, has one advantage: it cannot err as humans do; chaste and pure, causing no harm to anyone, it simply goes about its existence. Red blood is the expression of a higher spirituality and stands above the green sap of the plant—which is symbolically colored red in the flower—yet blood is at the same time the bearer of desires, passions, errors, and faults. The rose may well be a subordinate being, but it serves as an ideal for humankind. One day, humankind will become master of itself, and its true self will rise above the everyday self. It will ennoble and purify itself, and its blood will become chaste and pure like the green sap of the plant. And I see this purified blood of the spiritualized human being symbolized in the red blood of the rose.

We must bring the lower part of ourselves under our control; we must master everything that stands in the way of our ascent and transform it into pure forces. In the symbol of the Rose Cross—the dead, black crossbeam upon which living roses bloom—we see ourselves. The dark wood represents our lower nature, which is subject to death and must be overcome; the red roses represent our higher nature, dedicated to life, which springs victoriously from the dying, impure substance.

The Rosicrucian should allow such symbols to influence him with all his might; he should seek them everywhere in the nature around him, form them in his mind, and meditate on them. In this mental image, what matters is not so much the truth as what is right—what is symbolically correct. Especially when meditating on the Rosicrucian symbol, one's entire being—one's whole heart and soul—must be engaged; it must permeate and ignite us as we contemplate the image of the transformation of our nature. The student must intensify this impression to such a degree and then repeat it constantly, so that it no longer fades from him and is carried over by his astral body into the spiritual world each evening. The Rosicrucian student then feels how the unconsciousness into which he previously fell during sleep gradually fades; it is as if a slow soul fire were kindled within him. He carries it within himself like a lamp that shines into the darkness of the night and reveals to him what was previously veiled by darkness. He has become a being of light in the beyond. A light-giving, active eye has opened within him, in contrast to the physical, passive eye, which has no light source within itself but perceives only through external light.

Once the Rosicrucian has trained himself in this way, he perceives external reality only where he can transform it into symbols that enable his inner self to convert into light the meditative abilities he has acquired.

In this way, the student's "I" is protected from becoming hardened in selfishness, as well as from powerlessness, and he enters the higher worlds without danger. To the proper degree, he acquires the strength of mysticism and employs it in ecstasy. Through serious practice, he eventually reaches the point where he beholds the sun at midnight, as it was called in the ancient occult schools—that is, he sees the spirit simultaneously behind the physical form.
GA118

GA145
We have seen that as the result of serious theosophical training, or esoteric occult development, changes come about in the four principal parts of the human being; and you may have observed that in the descriptions we have given the principal stress has been laid upon the inward change in these four parts of human nature, or the changes which are, to a certain extent, experienced inwardly. But we have to distinguish clearly between this change to be experienced inwardly, and the description of the outer changes manifest to the vision of the seer, which is, of course, quite different. In true esoteric development it is very important to know what takes place within man, and what is in front of him, when he goes through occult development. Interesting, also, although perhaps not so important, is the change outwardly visible to the seer. To sum up in a few words, we might say: that which is perceived inwardly as a sort of 'becoming more mobile' and 'becoming more independent' of the various parts of the physical body, manifests itself to the clairvoyant vision, which does not experience the changes in the physical body from within, but looks upon them from without, in such a manner that the physical body of a person undergoing occult development is seen to split up, to divide, in a certain sense; and because of this splitting-up, clairvoyant-vision feels it to be separating.

To clairvoyant vision the physical body of a person who is steadily advancing in occult development is actually seen to grow. And we may say that if at one time we meet a person who is undergoing a true occult development, that which the clairvoyant vision sees at a definite time as the physical body has a definite size; if we meet him again a few years later his physical body has grown; it has become decidedly larger. Thus there is such a thing as the growth of the physical body beyond the normal

physical size, but with this is connected the fact that it becomes more shadowy. Thus we notice that as the person develops, his physical body is seen to become larger and larger. It consists, however, of various parts, as it were, and these manifest themselves in what in occult life is called ‘Imagination.’ The physical body of a person undergoing occult development manifests more and more as a number of imaginations, of pictures which are in a sense inwardly alive and active, and are, or rather become, more and more interesting; for they are not just anything we please. When the person is beginning his development the pictures are not specially significant; and they are least so when the clairvoyant vision observes the body of a person who has not yet developed in occultism. In this latter case a number of pictures, a number of imaginations are perceived. To clairvoyant vision the physical substance disappears, and in its place appear imaginations: but these are so pressed together that instead of the pleasing inwardly shining aspect of a person engaged in occult development, they manifest as in an opaque substance.

Even, however, in the case of a person who is not yet developed they are to be seen, and indeed as parts and each part signifies something in the macrocosm. Essentially one can distinguish twelve parts, each of which is really a picture—a painting of one part of the great cosmos. When all twelve are assembled together, the impression is given that some unknown painter has produced miniature pictures of the macrocosm, twelve in number, and from these has formed the physical human body. Now, when the individual is engaged in occult development, this picture grows larger and larger, and also appears inwardly more and more pleasing, radiant from within. This is because, in the case of an individual not engaged in occult development, the macrocosm is only reflected in its physical aspect; but in the case of one undergoing an occult development the spiritual content more and more manifests itself; the pictures of the spiritual essence of the macrocosm are to be seen. Thus occult development also shows us that a person engaged in an occult development, from being merely a physical microcosm, becomes more and more a spiritual one, that is, he manifests within himself more and more, not merely the pictures of planets and suns, but of entities belonging to the Higher Hierarchies. That is the difference between persons engaged and others not engaged in occult development. The more a person presses forward in occult development the more exalted are the Hierarchies manifesting within him. And thus we learn the structure of the world, as it were, by clairvoyantly observing the physical human body.

The human etheric body of one who is not undergoing occult development manifests the progressive course of the world, that which follows consecutively in time; it shows how planets and suns, even the human civilisations on earth, and the individual human beings alter in the course of their incarnations, and how they appear in consecutive stages of growth. Thus the etheric body may truly be called a narrator; it recounts the story of the growth of the world. While the physical body of man is like a sum-total of pictures painted by an unknown artist, the etheric body proves to be a kind of story-teller who narrates in its own inner happenings the story of the world itself. And the more deeply a person is engaged in occult development, the wider the range of the stories. The etheric body of a person who has undergone comparatively little occult development manifests to the clairvoyant vision perhaps only a few generations which have preceded him in physical ancestry—for this development is still also shown in the etheric body of man. But the further a person carries his occult development, the more possible it becomes to see in his etheric body the various civilisations of humanity, the various incarnations of this or that individuality; yea, even to ascend to cosmic development and see the share of the Spirits of the Higher Hierarchies in it.

The astral body of man—which to ordinary observation can only be seen, as it were, through its inner reflection, through experiences of thought, will and feeling—becomes more and more an expression of the value of man, with respect to his essential entity in the cosmos. I want you to consider this description, this presentation, as being of very special significance. The astral body of a human being undergoing an occult development becomes more and more the expression of his value in the cosmos. In a previous lecture we showed how we discover that the astral body, in its original nature, is a sort of egotist, and that this has to be overcome in occult development, raising the personal interests to those

of the world. Observing the astral body of a person engaged in higher development one can see from it, according to whether it appears dark and dull or has an inner illumination, according to its revelation of itself in shrill dissonances or in harmonious melodious tones, whether the person in question has so conducted his development that he is still entangled in his personal interests, of which we have spoken, or whether he has really made the interests of the world his own. This is what can be seen from the astral body of a human personality engaged in higher development: when the development goes on in a true, occult, ethical manner, we see in him how wonderful man becomes through extending the horizon of his interests from those that are personal to those that are universally human, and into the common aims of the world. The astral body becomes more radiant, shines more and more like a radiant sun, as the human being learns to make the affairs of all humanity and the world his own.

The further the human being progresses in his development, the more the Self manifests the tendency to split up, to divide. It sends out, as it were, the contents of its consciousness, and these make 'messenger paths' in the world. If, for example, a human being wishes to learn to know a being belonging to the Hierarchy of the Angels, it is not sufficient for him to exercise the ordinary forces of perception; if he really wishes to know this being he must be able to transfer his consciousness; that is, he must be able to separate the forces of his Self and transpose a part of his self-consciousness into the being of the Angel. Whatever sort of being we wish to know, we can only do it by transposing our self-consciousness into this being. It is the impulse of the Self to go out of itself, to transpose itself into the other being and allow that which at first lived only in oneself to enter the life of the other being. At a lower stage in the development of the human being, at the stage of ordinary human existence, this manifests as a certain impulse to remove its consciousness out of itself; this can be seen in the need for sleep. And that which psychically drives man to sleep is exactly the same that in higher development directs the consciousness, not into the unconscious world of sleep, but into the consciousness of the Angels or the Spirits of Form or still Higher Hierarchies. Thus one might be paradoxical by inquiring: What does it imply when a man becomes acquainted with one of the Elohim, one of the Spirits of Form? It means that he has developed so far that he is able to sleep over into the consciousness of the Elohim and to awaken within the Elohim, possessing the consciousness of this Spirit of Form, of this spirit belonging to the Higher Hierarchies. This is recognition of a higher being: consciousness must be resigned as in sleep, but so resigned that by reason of the higher forces awakened within, it reawakens and radiates towards us as the consciousness of the higher being.

Thus, an astral body under true occult development becomes like a sun which radiates its world-interests; but when the Self is more highly developed it becomes like the planets which circle round the sun of the astral body, and which, in their circling through the world, meet other beings, and by means of this bring messages from them to the perceptive nature of man. Thus the astral body and the Self of a human being undergoing occult development present the picture of a sun—which is the astral body—surrounded by its planets—that are a number of multiplications of the Self, sent out into other beings in order that the student through that which his multiplied Self rays back to him from these other beings may know their nature.

The feeling we have when becoming acquainted with the inner nature of the members of the Higher Hierarchies (we learn to recognise their external being through the physical body and the etheric body; and to recognise them inwardly through the astral body and the Self, we come into communication, as it were, with these beings who belong to the Higher Hierarchies through the astral body and Self)—the feeling we have is as though we had to make our self in our astral body into a sun and to separate from oneself, a Self capable of active participation in the nature of the Hierarchy of the Angels; another Self which has that gift as regards the Hierarchy of the Archangels; and yet another Self which has the gift with regard to the Hierarchy of the Spirits of Form. A fourth Self participates in the nature of the Hierarchy of the Spirits of Motion, a fifth in that of the Hierarchy of the Spirits of Wisdom and of Will, a sixth Self or Ego in that of the Hierarchy of the Cherubim, and a seventh in that of the Hierarchy of the Seraphim. It is possible for a person, when he develops the four parts of his being and continues this development to a high stage, actually to attain to the experience we have just described. This is

possible; and in addition to this development of his Self in the manner I have just indicated, he can attain to a still higher development of his Self.

For through the separation of seven selves from the eighth Self, this eighth self, which remains behind, undergoes a higher development. Consider the matter in this way: We have the original Self of man, which is given to him before he undergoes occult development. He then undergoes this, and thereby sends forth from himself seven Selves. In order that the Self originally given him may be able to send forth seven Selves he has to exercise an inner force, the result of which is that the Self rises a stage higher. But now I want you to reflect that the process which I have described in its most extreme development, as it were, only comes about gradually. A person undergoing occult development does not, of course, at once become a perfect Sun in—the astral body, surrounded by the planets of his Selves, but he first attains to an imperfect Sun existence, and imperfect developments of his planetary Selves; all this takes place gradually. And, at the same time, the development of the ordinary Self into the Higher Self takes place slowly and gradually. When this development has reached a definite stage, when the Self has reached higher and higher attainment, then gradually comes the power to look back at former incarnations. This is the stage which gives one the power to look back to previous incarnations; it is the development of the Self beyond itself, the attainment of forces beyond itself, which give it at the same time power truly to understand higher Hierarchies. We might say that, to clairvoyant vision, a person, through occult development, with respect to his Self and his astral body, becomes star-like—similar to a starry system.
GA145

GA284
The Rose Cross initiation is born out of the necessity of the time. It also has seven levels.

The first is what is broadly called study; the second, the acquisition of imaginative knowledge; the third, the acquisition of occult writing; the fourth, the production of the philosopher's stone - that is the technical word for it -; the fifth, the correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm; the sixth, the absorption in the macrocosm; the seventh, beatitude. You must not imagine that each pupil has to pass through these stages in succession, so to speak; but the teacher must select from each chapter that which is suitable for each pupil according to his individuality. First each pupil must study, but then the material must often be organized in quite different ways. And now we will discuss it in detail.

Study in the sense of the Rosicrucians is not what is called study in ordinary life. In the sense of the Rosicrucians it is what should really be called: living in pure thought. What this means is not at all easy to grasp at the outset. Hegel, on the other hand, spent his whole life trying to teach the Germans what it means to live in pure thought. And ten years after his death, what Hegel contributed to the Germans' deepening had been completely forgotten. Today we have not yet reached the point where Hegel would be understood again. And yet his works would be a good means of showing what it means to live in pure, sensuality-free thought. The more recent philosophers, for example Eduard von Hartmann, deny altogether that we can form a thought that is not influenced by sensuality. They swore that nothing is in the intellect that was not in the senses. What is not of the senses is not real. If these words were true, there would be no mathematics. The Gnostics called the life of the spirit a “mathesis,” not because they imagined it to be mathematics, but because on the higher planes there is pure thinking and knowing, as there is in mathematics, in terms of forms, a thinking free of sensuality. This pure thinking does not proceed from objects, but flows from thought to thought. For those who want to immerse themselves in a completely sensuality-free thinking, I tried to write a book like my “Philosophy of Freedom”. It is not a personal work. It has come into being like an organism: it is a thought organism, and a guide to what is called study in the Rosicrucian sense. Certainly, many do not go through something like that. For most people who cannot undergo something like this, the simple Theosophical teaching is enough. It is sensual thought; no one can hear or see it. If you study Theosophy, it corresponds to the first stage of the Rosicrucian training. Theosophy is itself Rosicrucian

study if you pursue it in the right way. There is no need to lose yourself in philosophical heights. The humblest soul can immerse itself in it.

Imaginative knowledge is the second step in the Rose Cross initiation. It is achieved when a person learns to transform thought into image. This is a real fact. A man who knew about Rosicrucianism once uttered the words, “All that is transitory is but a parable!” Then one comes away from the physical plane. I would like to show you how this can be achieved by means of two examples. Take the three Logoi. Everything that has been mentioned so far as a study relates solely and exclusively to the physical plane. Only imaginative knowledge lifts us higher. If you describe the three logos schematically, if you speak of projections, then one can form an idea for the physical mind, even if you say that the second logo vibrates differently from the first. But all this is only for the consciousness of the mind. We cannot take with us to the higher planes anything that relates to three-dimensional space, but only that which is not conceived spatially. A “tone or color quality is indeed built into the space, but it is not spatial. The astral space is a flowing sea of color and light. There you will encounter on the astral plane what you have perceived here as a color quality and a tone quality. What is physical here in color and tone, you lift up to the higher planes; only we must purify and cleanse it in order to lift it up. Therefore, the teacher says: Take away the sensual quality for everything you want to see directly; imagine how a color stands out. Then that is the method for developing the imagination. And anyone who wants to achieve this level confronts the outside world in such a way that these isolated images present themselves in such a way that when one speaks, for example, of the three Logoi, one no longer perceives them as quantity but as quality. Then he feels the third Logos as something that resounds through the world – he feels it as sound; the second, insofar as it appears as an astral projection, as flooding light; and the first Logos as the aroma of the world, as an aroma flying through the world, purified to the most perfect purity. This is how the Rosicrucians felt everywhere. These are images, imaginations, not descriptions, for these come from the physical plane.

Another image, which presents us with a more mundane phenomenon, has been preserved in a wonderful myth, the myth of the Holy Grail. This is also an experience for the Rosicrucian disciple, which he perceives as a real fact of his inner soul life. The Master says to the disciple: “Take a look at the plant; it lives with the root in the ground, sends the stem upwards and has its calyx - that which produces a plant again - turned towards the sun. Even the more recent materialistic scholarship has again pointed out that if we compare the plant with the human being, we must compare the root with the head. The plant is, as it were, a human being turned upside down. Evolution consists in the image being reversed: what the plant opens up chastely before the world, is directed downwards in the human being. What the root is in the plant, striving towards the center of the earth, is directed upwards in the human being. In the human being, the head reaches out into the space of the sun. Between the two, on the inside, is the animal world, whose backbone is directed horizontally. Now the pupil was told: Imagine the plant, the animal and the human being and you have the world cross. The cross was the image of the evolution of the world beings up to the human being. The plant only produces when it is touched by the sunbeam, which was called the “holy lance of love”. When it is touched by this, it fulfills its task. Now imagine the human being with the Kama that has seized him; the lower organs must be purified and cleansed and must appear again at a higher level, so that in the course of evolution this chalice opens. When man has transformed himself, when he has purified this chalice, which the plant has at a primitive level, then he will have it in his hand again, that he will be touched by the holy lance of love – then he will have the purification of man in his hand – not only astral or etheric, but even physical. Thus evolution is imaginatively presented. Those who live in this way will have the astral plane revealed to them.

The third is the attainment of occult writing. It is not a writing like our present-day abstract writing. One appropriates the harmony of the qualities. The teacher says to the disciple: “If you ascend higher, until you attain knowledge of occult writing, you will hear what was called the harmony of the spheres in the Pythagorean school. This is a reality for the initiate, not a mere allegory. What today's science has to offer when it speaks of number systems is often as far removed from the harmony of the spheres

as if one wanted to describe a symphony as a wave motion in the air. The occult disciple learns to hear the sounds in the spiritual world. Goethe also knew about this when he said: “The sun resounds in the ancient manner in the brother spheres of song.” And in another place: “The new day is born sounding for spiritual ears.” What happens, what is audible to spiritual, not physical ears, are the events of the spiritual plan, are the harmonies of the spheres. And the signs of occult writing are real cosmic forces, and he who knows them feels the stream of cosmic forces in his organism down to the physical organism. I will give you only one example: four numbers. When I tell you, they are somewhat abstract; but if you were to perceive the music spiritually, you would perceive the relationship of the four lower human limbs. These numbers are: 1, 3, 7, 12. This is how the four lower limbs of human nature sound together harmoniously in the spiritual world. This is the secret of Pythagorean number theory: that it can be transformed into spiritual music.

The fourth is the creation of the philosopher's stone. Modern scholarship has turned it into a fairy tale. But in a way it is right, because if it were really as science imagines it, it would be a childish thing. But it is the highest goal to which man aspires. At the end of the eighteenth century, some of the Rosicrucian secrets were revealed. We find something there that we could say: People have heard something ringing there. We find a remarkable passage in a German newspaper! It says about the philosopher's stone: It exists. If you can recognize it in its full value, you possess the secret of immortality. Actually, the vast majority of people know it. Many have it in their hands every day. The man who wrote this had no idea what it was about, but he had received a message that contained something true. We need to consider nothing other than the process that maintains human beings cosmically in this present epoch: the breathing process. We breathe in and out. We breathe in the oxygen of the air and give back to the surrounding world the carbonic acid, a poisonous gas in which we could not live. The plant absorbs it continually, retains the coal from the carbonic acid and builds up its own body from it. But it gives the oxygen back to animals and humans. Thus, plant, animal and human form a whole, as far as we look at the breathing process. Today, humans need plants. The corpse of the plant as black coal, when you dig it out of the earth, or as a transparent diamond, is something we have within us; but we cannot use it. We have to give it to the plants as air for life. The plant builds its body out of carbonic acid itself. It can do something that man cannot yet do today, but will be able to do later. Imagine this process: the plant taking in carbonic acid and emitting oxygen – transferred to the inside of the human being... [gap in the text] Thus, by merging with the plant world and taking it into human nature, we build up within ourselves a pure, chaste body, as the plant does today. Man is on the way to becoming a being who can consciously carry this out; and then he will be able to develop within himself the chalice of the Holy Grail. The breathing process is not a closed one; it is in the process of becoming more perfect and of performing within man that which today takes place outside of man, and of transforming the human substance, which is permeated by Kama, into pure, chaste substance. This is real alchemy. Then man will have mastered alchemy, by means of which he will also learn to transform the cosmos. The symbol for this is the Holy Grail. We must not reject the lofty ideal because it is still millions of years away from us, but must be attained according to the principle: constant dripping wears away the stone. Thus, he who rhythmizes the breathing process will gradually achieve his goal. The philosopher's stone is coal, it is the substance for building the human body in the future. This process of transformation is alchemy in the Rosicrucian sense. Of course, the intimate instructions are given only from teacher to student.

The fifth, the correspondence of microcosm and macrocosm, is the learning of the correspondence of what we have within ourselves with the outer macrocosm. Paracelsus once said: “Let us look at the animals, plants and minerals - everything is in some way also in the human body. Man is like a confluence of everything that is also in nature outside. Nature is, as it were, the dismembered human being. Nature is like the letters, but the human being is the word that is composed of these letters. When this realization dawns on the consciousness, the student sees how the eye was formed from the light. The eye is formed by the light. Our organism emerged from another that did not yet have eyes; but the light brought forth the eye. This state of consciousness has long since ceased to exist. Man today knows nothing more about it, but the seer on the astral plane sees it. There you get to know again what is weaving within the cosmos as in your own nature. Then you get to know the cosmos through

your individual limbs: from the eye the light, from the ears the sound, and the other as it can only be given from the teacher to the disciple.

When a person has come so far that he has learned the correspondence between microcosm and macrocosm, then he can ascend to the sixth: to merging with the macrocosm. Then you have a relationship of friendship with every thing in nature. There is then something like a loving relationship with every being in nature, something like what remains in the love between man and woman. The sunflower appears different, the violet different, the lion and the tiger different, this and that different. The whole cosmos appears as differentiated as love between man and woman. Our inner being flows from the inside out, and this is connected with a transformation of the heart: the etheric and astral bodies transform the heart so that it becomes an arbitrary muscle. Here, the occult teaching, if it perfects itself even more, will spread light. Today, the heart is a crux for physiologists. It is an involuntary muscle, but in terms of its striation it is an arbitrary muscle; for it is transversely striated. All voluntary muscles are transversely striated, while the involuntary muscles are longitudinally striated. The heart is transversely striated because it is on the way to becoming an arbitrary muscle. Today it is endowed with the potential to become one. If in the future man is able to create from the spirituality of the cosmos, he will be able to move the heart as he is able to move the hand today. And so I could give you a hundred and a hundred examples where occult science sheds light on what physical science cannot unravel.

When man gradually attains this personal, intimate relationship with the whole of his environment, when he no longer has to use the physical powers of the brain, then, the teacher says, he can only understand what the Rosicrucian calls divinity, where the independence of man is preserved, but the highest is felt.

I have only been able to sketch out a few ideas today; but the Rosicrucian training has much to give here. Much can also be objected to; one can point out the dangers that can arise in the process. Only one thing can be pointed out: if a person does not strive towards the ideal out of egoism, but feels integrated, if he does not feel the urge for development as a desire but as a duty, if he wants to be a servant of evolution, if he purifies everything that needs to be purified, then there is no danger at all. And the Rosicrucian training in particular will also bring about a moral purification. The disciple must have the intention of merging his soul completely in the pure thought, for the pure thought is a mighty moral purification. Then he is prepared for the six steps.

All striving for occult development must proceed under the principle of conquest, which Goethe also expressed in one place. Only when we have conquered ourselves may we develop higher. This must become our fundamental ideal, for conquest is the fundamental ideal of the Rosicrucians:

From the fetters that bind all beings,
The man who overcomes himself is free!
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When man recognizes himself as a spiritual being in this All-Spirit, he can feel the meaning of the words from the Rosicrucian saying: “In the Holy Spirit I shall be reborn,” for as a new being he stands face to face with his earlier self, a being that must first acquire the qualities and abilities it needs in this spiritual life, just as a child must learn to use its bodily organs in the physical world. And again, this spiritual being must experience within itself the three spiritual powers that reveal themselves in the cosmic evolution as feeling, thinking, and willing, as love, wisdom, and power. Just as the child first learns to stand and then to walk, so must man learn to find direction and path in the spiritual world. This can only be acquired through feeling, by lovingly confronting everything. Then he must learn to recognize the truth by learning to understand the world wisdom that resounds in him, by allowing the sounds from the spiritual world to resound within him and intuiting their meaning, just as a child learns

to understand language. Then he gradually learns to recognize true life in the spirit by experiencing within himself a center from which his own impulses of will and life emanate, so that he can reveal himself in speech and in his being. Therefore, Christ Jesus speaks the words: “I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.” No one can penetrate to the true spiritual source of all being, to the Father, if he has not developed these three powers in his spirit and combines them in the right way.

The development of man is represented in the symbol that belongs to the deeply significant Rosicrucian motto, in the black cross with the red roses. Man feels this symbol as something living, in which live and weave the spiritual forces that have built it up just as he is born out of the Godhead. But then he knows that further development of his soul is possible through the exertion of his own powers. He knows that not only must his blood become pure like the red sap of the roses, but that the black cross must also be transformed by purifying his nature of the veil and growing beyond the merely personal when he surrenders himself to something infinitely greater. Then he dies in Christ, and before his soul the dark, black cross is transformed into a luminous, radiant cross. The red roses expand into an infinite circle as the soul becomes more and more at home in the macrocosm until it perceives itself as this circle. In the all-embracing macrocosm, the human being then experiences himself in a new existence.

Then, in a mysterious way, the colors of the symbolum change, the roses turn green, the cross turns white. The soul can only sense the full significance by feeling the power that streams towards it. As if from higher spiritual spheres, the soul beholds and recognizes this holy symbol. It appears strict and powerful, as an invitation to constant work, so that the great ideal may one day be attained, which every single person can realize when they are reborn in the Holy Spirit.
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